Serve and Protect

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29716032.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

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Alternate Universe, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Street Gang, Gangs, catradora, Illustrated, Illustrated Fic

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Serve and Protect

by MaggieDerrick

Summary

******AUTHOR'S NOTE: THIS STORY CONTAINS MATURE SUBJECT MATTER THAT SOME READERS MAY FIND DISTURBING.** *Please read the content warnings for each chapter before reading. Reader discretion is advised.***

Adora and her best friend Catra have been working for the notorious Horde gang for as long as they can remember. Picking pockets for a living may not be a great way to grow up, but it's better than living on the streets without protection. But when she's promoted to Force Captain and becomes a full-fledged member of the gang, Adora realizes the Horde is far worse than she ever could have imagined.

If she wants to escape this dangerous world of crime, Adora will need to work with a group of vigilantes to bring down the Horde and expose the corruption within Etheria's police force. But when Catra chooses to stay with the gang, Adora must figure out if she can serve the greater good while protecting the people she loves, or risk losing it all.

Story by: Henar Torinos and Iria Abella (@ilikeyoucatradora on IG)
Illustrations by: Henar Torinos
Written by: Maggie Derrick

Notes

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- Though not explicit, this story is not recommended for younger readers.

- Translation into Español available: Servir y Proteger by MaggieDerrick

Chapter 1

Adora and Catra stood outside the west entrance of the public market and went over the rules one more time.

"You know the drill," Adora said, watching as the busy Saturday crowd milled around them like a school of fish. "We have half an hour to get from one side of the market to the other. Whoever has the most money when we finish wins."

"And whoever loses buys burgers," Catra added. She laced her fingers and pushed her palms forward, popping her knuckles with a satisfying crackle. "There's a good crowd today, plenty of bougie tourists."

Adora nodded. "Yup. Should make for a good haul."

Catra snorted a laugh and prodded one of her sharp, dark-painted fingernails into Adora's ribs. "Whatever. I'm still gonna kick your ass."

Swatting Catra's hand, Adora wriggled out of poking range. "We'll see. You ready?"

"Always."

They lifted their eyes in unison to the old iron clock that stood in the center of the market district's courtyard. The hands read 10:52.

"Perfect," Adora said. "We'll be finished just in time for you to buy me lunch."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Whatever. See you on the other side, princess."

Together, they pushed through the doors and immediately split up. Flashing Catra a parting grin, Adora took the left side of the wide, bustling building. Back when the city was young, the public

market was a humble place for farmers, bakers, butchers, and fishers to sell their products — a grocery store long before grocery stores were a thing. These days, those stalls were still there—the best place to buy fresh fish and cheese and produce without having to travel outside of the city limits—but they were crammed alongside stands selling artisan goods at exorbitant prices. What was once a rough and gritty part of town had since been transformed into a trendy tourist destination. Visitors from around the world browsed the public market stalls alongside well-off locals who liked pretending to be "of the people" on weekends.

Adora and Catra belonged to neither of those social groups. In fact, having lived most of their lives on the streets, they didn't have much business being there at all. But the type of people who shopped at the public market did so with plenty of money in their pockets, and that made it the friends' favorite place to make some cash of their own.

As she moved through the crowded floor, Adora would occasionally catch sight of Catra prowling along her side of the building. A flash of her long, dark hair, the glint of her mismatched eyes — Catra's strength in this game was her speed. Adora on the other hand, preferred to be strategic when choosing her prey. When it came to pilfering wallets, she was after quality, not quantity.

Not that she could blame Catra for wanting to make quick work of the job at hand. Being white, Adora blended in, even with her dirty face and clothes. She could afford to take her time. Catra on the other hand, with her warm brown skin, was a magnet for police attention, especially in a place like this. This was just one more injustice in the long, unfair story of Catra's life. It was safer for her to get in and out as fast as possible.

But Adora had another reason for being slow and steady with her process. After all, with speed came mistakes, and she couldn't afford to make those anymore. She had turned eighteen earlier that year, which meant getting caught with her hand in a stranger's purse wouldn't just mean a trip to the police station and

a firm reprimand from Captain Angella: it would mean criminal charges in adult court. Just thinking about it made Adora shudder.

So, she chose her marks thoughtfully. She sought out the distracted crowds of tourists crammed around high-end artisan jewelry stalls and well-dressed older couples shopping for truffle oil. She'd watch for people with too much money and not enough common sense to flash their overstuffed wallets, then follow them from one stall to another until the right opportunity presented itself. After years of picking pockets, her sleight of hand skills were unmatched. She would swoop in like a shadow, unburdening those same shoppers from their cash and disappear into the swarms of people before anyone even realized she'd been there.

Adora found herself at the east doors with a couple minutes to spare. Still, when she glanced around, she found Catra already leaning against the wall waiting for her.

"Took you long enough," Catra said with a laugh. Adora made a face at her and pushed through the doors into the late-morning sunshine. They kept their gait casual and unassuming — they knew better than to draw attention to themselves. Only after they turned a corner around one of the many low studio buildings that made up the market district did they break into a sprint.

Adora laughed, pumping her arms and breathing hard as she raced Catra to a small park a couple streets over. As they closed in on the park's entrance, Adora leapt forward and slapped the outstretched paw of one of the twin stone lions that stood guard on either side of the path.



“I win!” she crowed, thrusting her fists into the air victoriously.

“Only because I was weighed down by my massive score,” Catra said, hitching a thumb over her shoulder at her backpack. Adora snorted a laugh and gave Catra a playful shove. They giggled, walking side by side to their favorite tree. It was set back from the path, far from the benches and playground, making it the ideal place to count their winnings away from other people. Adora

pulled her own backpack off her shoulders and tossed it into the grass. She dropped down beside it with a *whump*.

"Got you a present," Catra said, digging through her bag. She pulled out something wrapped in a paper napkin and tossed it into Adora's lap. Adora peeled back the napkin to find one of her favorite cookies: thick shortbread slathered in sugary icing and stuffed with fresh jam.

"You spoil me," Adora teased as Catra flopped down beside her. She took a huge bite and groaned appreciatively.

Catra grinned at her. "You're such an idiot. Come on — show me what you got."

They emptied their bags of their spoils and started counting. As expected, Catra had collected more wallets than Adora. But when they were finished counting the cash inside, Adora had beat Catra by a long shot.

"Oh, come on!" Catra slumped back against the tree trunk, crossing her arms with a frown. "I scored, like, five more wallets than you!"

"That's because you always pick shitty marks," Adora replied, gathering her earnings into a neat stack and shoving the wad of cash into her front pocket. "Now, I believe you owe me lunch."

Grumbling, Catra crammed her earnings into her sock. Together they wiped the wallets down, removing their fingerprints before dumping them down a storm drain for good measure.

The sun was setting by the time the pair made their way home that evening. Of course, "home" was a generous way to describe the old warehouse where Adora, Catra, and the rest of the gang spent their nights, but it was all they had. Once upon a time the building housed a shoe factory, but when the company folded the building didn't sell. It stood vacant for decades until the Horde found it and turned it into a barracks of sorts for its younger members.

Catra rapped a complicated pattern of knocks onto one of the rusted steel doors. A moment later, the door opened a sliver — just wide enough for whomever was on the other side to peer out and confirm who was requesting access.

"It's us, Kyle," Catra grumbled, banging the meaty side of her fist against the door hard enough to make the young man on the other side yelp with surprise. "Open up!"

The old door groaned noisily as Kyle—a fellow youth member of the street gang known as the Horde—hauled it open. Adora and Catra slid inside. Now that the work day was over, most of the kids were clustered on the mismatched and threadbare sofas and chairs that made up the common space in the middle of the warehouse floor. Their jokes and laughter echoed throughout the vast space, drifting up like ghosts among the exposed steel beams and out into the night through grimy, cracked windows. Someone had already lit a bonfire in the old oil drum in the middle, and it cast long shadows across the room.

"I can't wait to get off my feet," Catra said, eyeing an empty armchair by the fire.

"Not so fast."

A velvety voice drifted from the darkness, making both girls jump with. Adora pressed a hand to her racing heart and mentally chastised herself. Even after all these years, she still hadn't gotten used to the way Shadow Weaver seemed to materialize out of nowhere.

Dark hair, scarred face, sallow eyes — Shadow Weaver emerged from the gloom like a monster in a nightmare. But, even though she certainly earned that kind of reputation, she was the closest thing to a mother Adora and the rest of the Horde kids had. Adora and Catra stood at attention, as was expected of them. Shadow Weaver unfurled her long, thin fingers toward them without speaking. The girls knew what to do: they riffled through their clothes, pulled out the wads of cash they'd stolen earlier that day,

and handed it all over. They stood quietly as Shadow Weaver counted their score.

"*Tch*," she hissed through her teeth. "This is a pathetic sum, even for you, Catra."

Catra flinched back and cast her gaze toward the floor. Out of the corner of her eye, Adora saw her friend bite her lip in an attempt to stop herself from saying something she'd regret. So, Adora cleared her throat instead.

"It was just an unlucky day," she said with a false brightness. "Catra actually hit way more marks than I did, they just—"

"Do not make excuses for her, Adora." Shadow Weaver cut her off. "If she didn't want to be a disappointment, she would simply try harder. Isn't that right, Catra?"

Scowling, Catra rubbed at the scars on her forearm absently. "Yes, Shadow Weaver."

Shadow Weaver waved her hand, dismissively. "You are excused, Catra. Adora, walk with me."

Adora looked to Catra, who shrugged before turning on her heel and stalking toward the fire.

"Leave her to sulk," Shadow Weaver said. She held a hand out and motioned for Adora to join her. "We have something to discuss."

Falling into step at Shadow Weaver's side, Adora followed her across the floor and up the stairs to what had once been offices. These rooms now served as sleeping quarters for the younger Horde members, and were the only place where a person could find a modicum of privacy in the entire building.

"I think it may be time to put some distance between yourself and Catra," Shadow Weaver said, gazing out over the railings and

down at her young charges. “I’m worried she will hold you back from your full potential.”

“What?” Adora was taken aback. She knew Shadow Weaver wasn’t Catra’s biggest fan, but this was an extreme reaction to a poor day’s earnings. Suddenly she regretted making Catra buy them lunch with some of the money she’d stolen. “She just had a bad day. Besides, she’s my best friend! I’m not going to—”

“Adora, you are the brightest recruit the Horde has ever seen,” Shadow Weaver spoke over her. “You have a promising future within our ranks — I can see you rising quickly.”

Adora blinked. “Really?”

“Yes.” Shadow Weaver turned to face her at last. She laid her palms against Adora’s cheeks and cradled her face with something that almost felt like tenderness. “But to do that, you must remain focused. You can’t afford to become complacent, especially now that you’re eighteen.”

“I won’t, Shadow Weaver,” Adora said. A hopeful sense of pride bubbled up inside of her. “I’m still just as committed to the Horde as I’ve always been, I promise. I won’t let you down.”

For a few long moments, Shadow Weaver didn’t say anything. She regarded Adora with intensity, searching her blue eyes for something only she could see. Adora didn’t dare blink, let alone look away. She swallowed hard and returned her mentor’s stare without flinching.

At last, Shadow Weaver sighed. “Of course you won’t. Which is why I think you’re ready.”

She released Adora’s face and breezed away, leaving Adora to scramble after her.

“Really?” Adora breathed. She couldn’t believe what she was hearing. “Are you serious?”

Shadow Weaver glanced back over her shoulder. The flickering firelight below caught on her eyes, making them glow in the dimness.

“Very serious. It’s time to earn your promotion, Adora.”

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

*[**AUTHOR'S NOTE:** This chapter contains mature subject matter, including depictions of blood and violence. Please see the specific content warnings at the end of that chapter]*

"Holy shit!" Catra cried. "Are you fucking serious?"

"Shh!" Adora hissed, pressing a finger to her lips. "Keep your voice down!"

"Uh, you just told me you're being promoted, and you expect me *not* to make a big deal about it? C'mon, Adora — it's like you don't know me at all." Without warning, Catra leapt at her. Had Adora not been anticipating such a reaction, it would have sent them both crashing backwards. Instead, she caught Catra in her arms and laughed.

"I know you well enough to know you were going to jump me, so that's got to count for something." She whirled Catra around before setting her back on her feet. "Anyway, let's not get ahead of ourselves. I haven't been promoted yet — I still have to earn it."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Oh, please. You and I both know you're Shadow Weaver's golden girl. There's no way she is not going to give it to you." Grinning, she grabbed Adora's hand. "Which is why I have a surprise for you. C'mon!"

She pulled Adora toward the staircase, and together they climbed it up onto the roof. Technically they weren't supposed to be up there, but that had never stopped them before. Years earlier, Adora picked the lock to give Catra a place to hide after a particularly violent beating at Shadow Weaver's hand. Since then, the roof had become their secret place — the only spot in the

entire building where they could be perfectly alone and escape their bleak lives, even if just for a little while.

Night had fully settled over the city now. The starless sky was heavy with gloom that reflected a neon glow from the lights below. Adora always found it beautiful in a strange way, though to be fair, she had no point of reference. This was the only view she'd ever really known. She followed Catra to the corner where they liked to sit — it had a decent view of the harbor, and they liked to watch the ships glide across the water on their way to port.

"I don't mean to be a killjoy," Adora said, grinning, "but I've been up here before. Kind of a shitty surprise."

"Just sit down, dummy," Catra replied.

Adora did as she was told. She watched in obedient silence as Catra rifled through the inner pocket of her old baseball jacket– the one she'd been wearing since she was a kid–and pulled out a small box, thin and square.

"This is for you," Catra said, handing it to Adora.

Blinking, Adora tried to play down her surprise. "Two presents in one day? What's gotten into you?"

"Stop being a dork and just open it."

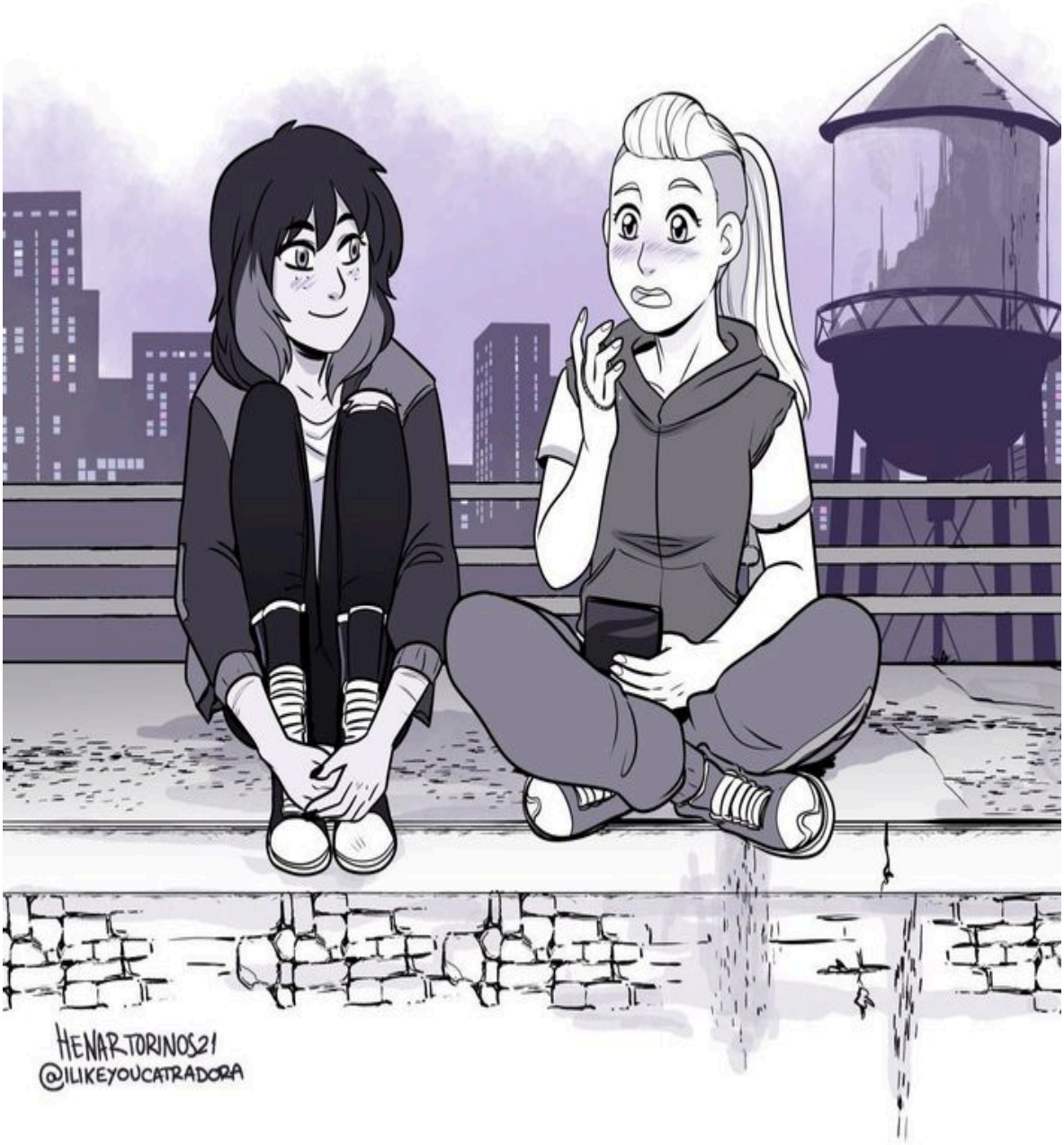
Again, Adora did as Catra demanded. Carefully, she pulled the lid off the box to reveal a beautiful golden bracelet.

"Catra," she gasped. "This is—"

"The bracelet you liked from that jewelry store on 6th avenue, yeah."

"How did you manage to steal this?" Adora was agog. "The security at that place is intense!"

"I didn't steal it!" Catra balked. "I bought it. I even got it engraved, see?" She pointed to the flat gold panel at the middle of the bracelet, the one held on either end by short lengths of chain. Adora lifted the bracelet and squinted in the dim light. The inscription read simply, *Hey, Adora.*



“Catra, this is amazing,” Adora said, wiping away the tears that pooled at the corners of her eyes. She had never received a gift like this before — she had never owned anything so extravagant, let alone something that hadn’t been stolen first. The fact that Catra had bought it for her made it even more special. “But I don’t understand. How did you pay for this? It was so expensive!”

Shifting awkwardly, Catra rubbed at the back of her neck. “Let’s just say there’s a reason my scores have been a bit lower than usual for the last few months. I knew you’d be getting promoted eventually, so I started saving the day you went all heart-eyes when you spotted this thing in the store window.”

Adora’s eyes grew wide. “You’ve been skimming? Catra, if Shadow Weaver finds out—”

“She won’t. Just don’t let her see it,” Catra said, laying a hand on Adora’s shoulder. She gave her a toothy, reassuring smile. “Besides, it’s not every day your best friend gets a major promotion. You’ve been busting your ass for years, Adora — I thought you deserved something nice.” She gestured vaguely. “Y’know, to celebrate or whatever.”

Sniffling, Adora wrapped her friend in a tight and unrelenting hug. “You’re the best, Catra.”

Catra huffed a laugh. “Oh, I know. Here, let me help you put it on.”

Adora held her wrist out while Catra unlatched the bracelet’s clasp. The feeling of Catra’s fingertips brushing against her skin made Adora bite her lip to hide her smile.

“There,” Catra said, sitting back when her work was done. “What do you think?”

“I love it,” Adora replied, turning her hand to admire her treasure. “Thank you so much, Catra.”

“Don’t get sappy on me, now.” Catra jumped to her feet and reached back for Adora. “You still have a job to do, remember? Now go earn that promotion or I’m returning that thing first thing tomorrow.”

With a snort of laughter, Adora took Catra’s hand and let her haul her to her feet. They darted back across the roof to the staircase door, their hands still firmly clasped together.

“Any idea what you have to do tonight?” Catra whispered as they crept back down the stairs.

“Nope,” Adora replied, a thrill racing through her at the thought of her mystery mission. “All I know is I’ve gotta meet one of the squadrons down at the docks in an hour.”

They slid back out onto the ground floor and eased the staircase door closed behind them. Catra rounded on Adora, her eyes sparkling with excitement. “I’m so jealous. I wish I could go with you.”

“Don’t worry,” Adora grinned. “I’ll tell you all about it when you get back.”

They hurried to the main doors and didn’t bother to wake Kyle, who was curled on a dilapidated armchair and dozing through the rest of his sentry duty. Adora cracked the door just enough to slip outside. She looked back at Catra and flashed her a thumbs-up, her new bracelet rattling on her wrist.

“Good luck, dummy,” Catra said, winking.

Adora winked back. “That’s soon-to-be Force Captain Dummy to you!” she replied, then took off into the night.

*

The air was cooler down by the water, and Adora couldn’t help but shiver as she made her way to the old storehouse where she’d been told to meet the other Horde squad. A fog was drifting in off

the harbor, casting an eerie haze over the few street lights that actually worked in this district. Adora ran her fingers over her bracelet as she cut her way down an alley — the weight of it on her wrist helped soothe her nerves.

Up ahead, a figure leaned against one of the squat storage buildings, silhouetted in the dark and smoking a pungent cigarette.

"Nice night for a swim," Adora said firmly, speaking the code that would grant her passage.

The figure flicked their cigarette to the ground and snuffed it out under the toe of their boot. "If you insist," they replied, their voice low and gravelly.

They turned and opened the door they'd been slouching in front of. The yellow light from inside illuminated the gangster's face — it was Grizzlor, a high-ranking Commander in the Horde gang. Adora's stomach twisted: she was running with the big kids now. Wordlessly, Grizzlor tipped his head toward the threshold and Adora took her cue to enter.

The inside the storehouse was sparse. Only a chair sat in the middle of the room beneath a buzzing bare bulb. On the walls hung an assortment of heavy metal tools. The windows were boarded up tight.

"Well, well. Look who's finally earning her stripes," came a voice from the shadows. Adora glanced to the corner of the room, where she found the rest of the squadron lurking. Force Captain Octavia stepped forward, a sneer playing at her lips. Her one good eye glared, the other was covered by a thick leather eye patch. "It's about damn time."

Adora let the comment slide and answered instead with a nod. Octavia had been promoted a few years earlier, but only because she was older. She'd been a constant source of torment to Adora

and Catra growing up, but Adora knew better than to let that resentment cloud her judgement tonight.

"So, what's the plan?" Adora asked, staring Octavia down with an unflinching gaze.

Octavia crossed her arms and looked Adora over. "We're bringing one of our contacts in for a little chat." From the corner, the rest of the squad snickered darkly. "It seems he's done some damage to one of the Horde's boats while he was ferrying some product."

"What kind of damage?" Adora asked.

"That's none of your business, *Cadet* ," Octavia snapped.

"None of that, Force Captain," Grizzlor said, stepping between them. "Adora's here because Hordak thinks she's ready."

Scoffing, Octavia relented. "Fine. The jackass set the boat on fire. Our job is to figure out if the pyrotechnics were intentional or not. And, y'know, to make sure it never happens again." She cracked her knuckles to punctuate her point.

Adora's skin prickled at the insinuation. She swallowed hard but kept her expression unphased. "So, what do you need me to do?"

"When the contact arrives, we're going to need you to stand guard at the door," Octavia replied. "Just to make sure no one interrupts our conversation. Understood?"

That's it? Adora thought. *Guard duty?* She was confused — this assignment hardly felt like a worthy test of her mettle. But it wasn't her job to question orders, so she nodded once more. "Got it."

As if on cue, the door flew open with a bang. Adora whirled around to see two hulking Horde members dragging a bound and hooded figure between them. The prisoner struggled, but it was no use — whoever was under that hood was completely overpowered.

Ice trickled through Adora's veins as she watched the gangsters throw the figure down into the waiting chair. They tied him firmly in place before finally removing the hood, revealing a head of mussed brown hair. The person slumped forward, their face obscured. Octavia reached forward, gripped the hair with her fingers, and used it to pull their head back.

Only then did Adora recognize him as Seahawk, a local boat captain the Horde had somehow gotten onto their payroll. She had never worked with him personally, but she'd seen his face around. He was usually a boisterous man, with a slick mustache and weeks worth of stories to tell. But now his mirth was gone. His dark, frightened eyes darted around the room. A filthy rag had been crammed in his mouth as a gag. Adora looked down at her feet just so she wouldn't have to look at his terrified face any longer.

A heavy hand settled on Adora's shoulder, making her jump. She looked up to find Grizzlor looking down at her. He hitched a thumb toward the door, and she hurried to take her post.

"Now remember: nobody else has business here tonight," he said once Adora was outside. His wide shoulders filled the doorframe. "If anyone tries to get in, we expect you to take care of them. You stay here until I come for you, go it?"

"Yes, sir." Adora replied, saluting her superior officer the way she'd been taught.

Grunting, Grizzlor slammed the door shut. Adora heard a deadbolt slide into place, and only then did she panic.

Oh fuck , she thought. *Are they gonna torture that guy? Kill him?*

Adora had spent her entire life in the Horde, and she'd been put to work young. But while she'd long since come to terms with the fact that their organization wasn't working for the greater good, this was the first time she'd ever seen anything like this. Up until now, her work had involved mostly petty crimes: pick-pocketing,

breaking and entering, thievery fit for a common criminal. At worst, she'd been assigned to deliver drugs or pick up payments. At best, she'd been a simple messenger. Sure, she'd been taught to fight—they all had—but she'd always assumed that was just for her safety. After all, there had been more than a few occasions where she'd been forced to use her fists to get out of trouble.

But this was something different altogether. The voices from inside were muffled, but Adora could still hear the sickening sound of impact. She knew what flesh sounded like when it was struck — she'd lived that nightmare first hand more times than she could count. She could even hear Seahawk's desperate sobs and howls of pain, and the sounds made her stomach turn.

It was impossible to tell how long she stood out there, guarding a door in that deserted alleyway. At some point, a fine drizzle started to fall, and Adora shivered as her clothes grew damp. The tortured wailing droned on until at last Adora grew numb to it. All the while, she stood at her post, fidgeting with her bracelet for company.

When the door finally opened, Adora was soaked through. She peered up, her eyes straining against the light after so much time in the dark.

"C'mon in," Octavia said, standing aside to make room.

Warily, Adora shuffled inside. Under the light, Grizzlor stood with his back to her, blocking her view of Seahawk. The sailor had been quiet for a while now.

"She's ready for you," Octavia told him, motioning toward Adora.

Grizzlor looked over his shoulder with a sharp glare. Then he waved for Adora to join him. "Over here, Cadet."

Her stomach dropped.

She inched forward and Seahawk came into view. He was a ghost of his former self — his handsome face was battered and bruised,

swollen nearly beyond recognition. There was so much blood that Adora couldn't even tell where it was coming from. Watery trails streaked down his cheeks from where tears had washed some of the crimson mess away.

"Time to earn your big promotion, Cadet," Octavia said with a laugh.

Adora trembled. "What do you mean?"

"You didn't think you were going to become a Force Captain by watching a door all night, did you?"

Of course not , Adora thought grimly.

Grizzlor turned to her, a bloody metal pipe clenched in his fist. He held it out to Adora. "We saved the last strike for you, Cadet. Make it count."

"I…" Adora stared down at the pipe. She felt lightheaded. "You want me to—"

"Hit him, yes," Octavia cut in, sounding bored. "And you've gotta mean in — there's no room for cowards in the Horde."

Slowly, as if being directed by some invisible hand, Adora took the pipe. It was heavier than it looked, and that made what she had to do so much worse. She twisted her hands around the clean end and took a deep, shaky breath. Without thinking, she lifted her eyes, and her gaze locked with what little of Seahawk's eyes were still visible through the swelling. The meager contents of Adora's stomach rolled as Seahawk shook his head, quick, jerking movements that pleaded for mercy.

Again, Grizzlor's hands closed over Adora's shoulders.

"Hordak is expecting us to report back on your performance tonight, Cadet," he said. "Do not disappoint him," His grip tightened, and Adora knew it was meant as a threat.

So she swallowed the bile rising in her throat, and she lifted the pipe over her shoulder like a baseball bat.

"Please…" Seahawk whimpered, sending fresh blood spilling over her split lip.

I'm so sorry , Adora thought.

She brought the pipe down with every ounce of strength she could muster. The sick sound of metal splitting flesh and hitting bone filled her ears like a scream. Warm blood splattered with the force of the swing and sprayed across Adora's face. She froze, horrified.

Octavia's laughter boomed throughout the room. Seahawk's head fell forward, his chin against his chest.

"Oh my God," Adora breathed, swaying dangerously. She was vaguely aware of someone sliding the pipe from her hands. A hand pressed into her back and steered her toward the door and back outside. The cold damp air was like a slap to her face, bringing her back to her senses.

Adora whirled around. Grizzlor gazed down at her, impassive.

"Is— is he dead?" she asked, her voice a frantic whisper that still managed to echo through the deserted alley. "Did I kill him?"

By way of answer, Grizzlor took Adora's hand and pressed something small and hard into her palm.

"Bring this to the Witch," he said gruffly, referring to Shadow Weaver by her crude code name. "Good work tonight. I'll see you in the streets, Force Captain."

Adora gaped after him as he retreated back into the storehouse and slammed the door behind him. Alone again, Adora lifted her hand and cautiously opened her fingers.

A fresh wave of nausea nearly brought her to her knees.

There, in the middle of Adora’s quivering palm, sat a single, bloody tooth.

Chapter End Notes

Content warnings:
- Seahawk is bound to a chair and beaten; off-page
- Adora sees Seahawk after he's received a severe beating; on-page, blood
- Adora is forced to hit Seahawk with a lead pipe; on-page, blood
- Adora is given a bloody tooth to prove she passed her initiation; on-page, blood

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

*[**AUTHOR'S NOTE:** This chapter contains mature subject matter, including blood, physical abuse/torture. Please see the bottom of the chapter for specific content warnings.]*

Adora kept her stride calm and purposeful until she was certain no one was following her. Then, once the storehouse was out of sight, she took off running. She sped through the street, her lungs searing with exertion until nausea forced her to stop. Adora doubled over and vomited into the gutter.

When her stomach was finally empty, Adora straightened up. She lifted her hand to wipe the sick from her mouth, only to find it covered in blood. Her head spun. All she wanted to do was get home.

Eventually she made it, shuddering with cold and damp and shock. She tapped out the secret pattern and the door creaked open. Rogelio was on sentry duty now, and despite his towering stature, he still looked startled to find Adora standing there, covered in blood. He opened his mouth, but she cut him off.

"I don't want to talk about it," she said, pushing past him into the building.

It was quiet inside, and mercifully void of any other people. Adora dashed to the bathroom, flipped on the light, and locked the door behind her. She did a double take whens he caught sight of her reflection — somehow, she looked even worse than she felt.

Adora crammed the tooth into her pocket and peeled off her shirt. She rinsed her clothes with cold water, hoping the blood wouldn't set, then went to work on herself. She was in the middle of rubbing her face raw when she heard a knock at the door.

“Adora?” Catra’s voice came from the hallway.

For a moment, Adora considered ignoring her. She was a mess—a frantic, teary mess—and she didn’t want Catra to see her this way. But she knew perfectly well there was no such thing as ignoring Catra, so she reached out and unlatched the door.

Catra took that as the invitation it was and opened the door.

“What are you doing? I’ve been wait—” Catra stopped dead in her tracks. Her eyes went wide as they raked over Adora, who stood wet and trembling in her pants and bra in the middle of the bathroom. “Are you okay?”

“I, uh…” Adora’s mind churned for a reasonable answer. No, she wasn’t okay, but to say so would feel like admitting defeat.

Catra slipped inside and shut the door behind her. “Adora, whose blood in your hair?”

“Shit, shit…” Adora hissed, wheeling back around to the sink. She yanked the elastic out of her ponytail and proceeded to dunk her head under the tap.

“Adora, what the hell is going on?” Catra asked. Adora felt a soft towel drape over her shoulders. “What happened out there?”

Turning off the tap, Adora pulled the towel over her head and gave her hair a rub. It didn’t seem to matter how much she washed or scrubbed — she still didn’t feel clean. She gave up, and turned to Catra instead.

“The squad beat some shit of some guy tonight.
Like, *really* fucked him up,” Adora said, too ashamed to look Catra in the eyes. “At first they just had me stand guard outside, but then…” she hesitated and ran a shaky hand through her wet hair, “they made me hit him. Hard, with a pipe.”

Catra let out a low whistle. “Damn. So, is that it then? Are you a Force Captain now?”

Adora blinked back at her. “Catra, didn’t you hear what I just said? I had to beat some dude with a *lead pipe*. I think I might have killed him! How are you so calm about this?”

Tipping her head, Catra regarded Adora like a strange animal she’d never seen before. “Adora, you realize the Horde is a *gang*, right? We’re the bad guys. I’m sure what you had to do was awful but… what did you think was going to happen?”

“I don’t know!” Adora cried, throwing her hands in the air. “I thought they would make me organize a drug run or go undercover or…” She slumped back against the counter and trailed off.

A few tense moments passed between them. The rhythmic dripping of the faucet was the only sound.

Catra cleared her throat. “Are you going to be okay?”

“I don’t know,” Adora croaked, dragging her hand down her face. “I thought this was what I wanted, but not…” She looked to Catra, who stared back, her expression was tight. Adora wished she would just tell her everything was going to be alright. “Are you really okay with this? What we’re doing?”

Sighing, Catra perched herself on the counter beside Adora. “Not really. But what choice do we have?”

Adora closed her eyes and let her head rest on Catra’s shoulder. She hadn’t realized how exhausted she was. Catra’s hand slid into hers and squeezed it tight.

“Maybe it’s just one of those things that gets easier over time,” Catra whispered.

Adora wasn’t sure if that prospect made her feel better or worse.

That night, with Catra curled into her side, Adora laid awake. She was so tired, but her brain apparently didn’t get the memo. Catra’s words played over and over in Adora’s mind.

What choice do we have?

Adora could think of one.

She and Catra weren't even 10 years old when they got their first mugshot. They had been picked up for shoplifting when they attempted to smuggle some food from a bodega. It had been days since their last meal, and they were still $13 shy of making their quota. Adora had been scared during her first ride in a police car. She wondered if she and Catra were going to jail. She worried what Shadow Weaver would say when she found out.

But that was also the day they met then-Sargeant Angella Brightmoon. She was patient, with a kind smile and a gentle voice — the complete opposite of every adult Adora had met in the Horde. Catra was wary, but Adora liked her.

And, it seemed, Angella liked them too. From that point on, every time the girls landed themselves in the police precinct, Angella made sure she was the officer to handle their case. Though she pretended to be annoyed, Angella ensured Adora and Catra were fed and kept warm and comfortable.

This alone would have been incentive enough for them to get arrested more often, had it not been for the eventual consequences.

Because the fact was, Adora and Catra were minors. By law, they were considered wards of the state, which meant every time the two of them wound up in police custody, Angella was obligated to contact their social worker: Shadow Weaver.

And whenever Shadow Weaver received a call informing her that her charges were back in police custody, well… it never ended well for Adora and Catra.

One day, during yet another routine booking, Angella sat the girls down in her office and closed the door. Adora took Catra's hand, and together they waited for their punishment. Even at their

young ages, they knew all too well that nothing good could last, and Angella had been too good for too long.

Angella sat behind her desk and smiled softly.

"Girls, can I ask you a question?"

"Nope," Catra answered immediately. "We don't have to talk to you."

"Catra!" Adora hissed. She knew that's what they had been coached to say to the police, but she didn't like being rude to Angella.

"You're right, Catra. You don't have to talk to me," Angella said, unshakable as always. "How about I talk to *you*, instead? Would that be alright?"

Adora and Catra exchanged anxious glances.

"Do you know what the police motto is?" Angella pointed to a crest that hung on the wall behind her desk. "It's 'To Serve And Protect'. That means it's my job to make sure you're protected. If anything is wrong at home—if someone is, say, hurting you, or making you feel unsafe—my colleagues and I will protect you. You know that, right?"

Catra's tiny fingers burrowed tightly into Adora's hand. Angella sat back in her chair and waited. In that moment, every part of Adora wanted to break — to tell Angella exactly what was waiting for them once Shadow Weaver got them back to the warehouse.

But she also knew that what was waiting for them could never be as bad as what would happen if they tried to leave — if they tried selling Shadow Weaver out to the police. It didn't help that the police force was about as corrupt as the Horde, what with a bunch of them being on Hordak's payroll. Adora knew that the protection Angella was offering could only extend so far. By the end of the day, one of the dirty cops would get word back to Shadow

Weaver, and Adora and Catra would be worse off than where they started.

So instead, Adora put on her brightest smile. “Thanks, Officer Angella. We’ll keep that in mind.”

That conversation was years ago, but even as Angella rose through the ranks, she made it clear that the offer still stood. It had been a while since Adora’s last visit to the precinct, but she’d heard from the other street kids that Angella had been promoted to Chief. As she laid there in the dark, listening to Catra’s soft snores, Adora wondered what would happen if she tried to take Angella up on her offer now.

At some point Adora must have drifted off, because the next thing she knew, Lonnie was calling her name.

“Geeze, Adora! Are you dead?” Lonnie pulled the sheets off bed, earning an indignant squeak from Catra. “Get up already!”

“Lonnie, get the fuck out of here!” Catra snapped, hurling her pillow at Lonnie’s head.

“Listen, I don’t give a shit if you stay in bed, but Adora’s got to get up,” Lonnie said. “Shadow Weaver is here and she’s looking for you.”

Adora sat up with a gasp. Her hand flew to her hip — the tooth was still in her pocket.

“Okay, Lonnie. I’m coming. Just give me a sec to get dressed.”

As Lonnie retreated, Adora scrambled off the mattress and dug around for a clean-ish shirt to wear. Catra sat up and rubbed her eyes.

“What’s the big rush?” she groaned.

“Shadow Weaver probably wants to talk about last night,” Adora explained, pulling her hair into a ponytail and she hunted for her

boots. That woke Catra up in a hurry.

“Give me your hand, dummy.” Catra unfastened the bracelet from Adora’s wrist and handed it back to her.

“Right, good catch,” Adora said. She crammed the contraband jewelry deep in her pocket and out of sight.

Moments later, the pair scrambled down the rickety metal stairs to the main floor of the warehouse. Shadow Weaver stood by the door in her crisp blazer and pencil skirt, glaring around the room as the other kids worked on their morning chores. It had been years since she’d lost her social worker’s license, but that hadn’t stopped her from dressing the part.

Adora was smoothing the wrinkles from her clothes when Catra gave her a subtle nudge.

“Knock ‘em dead,” Catra whispered.

“Thanks,” Adora smiled.

While Catra hung back, Adora hurried to her mentor’s side.

“Good morning, Shadow Weaver,” she said with a salute.

“Adora,” Shadow Weaver drawled with a brightness that didn’t suit her in the slightest. “I understand you are officially a member of the Horde’s ranks.” She held out her hand expectantly.

“Right,” Adora said. She fished for the tooth.

“I heard everything went according to plan last night,” Shadow Weaver prattled on. “I knew you wouldn’t disappoint me.”

“Thank you,” Adora replied, smiling sheepishly. “I learned from the best.”

She pulled the tooth from her pocket, trying not to think about the blood that stained the white enamel.

Something metallic clattered at her feet. Shadow Weaver's eyes dropped and Adora froze.

The world slowed to an agonizing crawl as Shadow Weaver stooped to pick up the source of the sound. It was Adora's gold bracelet – she must have accidentally pulled it free from her pocket when she received the tooth.

"What is this?" Shadow Weaver demanded. All the false nicety from her voice was gone now. Adora looked down to where Catra's gift glinted in Shadow Weaver's hand.

"Oh, it's uh, a bracelet."

Shadow Weaver glowered darkly. "I can see that. Where did you get this little trinket?"

"I found it," Adora lied, her mind racing for a plausible explanation. "It was in one of the purses I stole yesterday."

Humming thoughtfully, Shadow Weaver turned the bracelet over. "And you thought it would be better on your wrist than in the Horde's coffers, did you? It looks expen—"

Her gaze landed on the inscription. Adora's heart sank as Shadow Weaver lifted her eyes to hers — they were swimming with rage. Without warning, Shadow Weaver's empty hand shot forward and caught Adora's forearm with a vice-like grip.

"Come with me," she snapped, wrenching Adora after her as she stormed across the floor to the common area.

Catra was lounging on one of the threadbare sofas, listening to the other kids talk, when she spotted them. When she saw the horrified look on Adora's face, she scampered to her feet.

"You," Shadow Weaver growled as she bore down on Catra. She thrust her hand into the air so everyone could see the bracelet dangling from her curled fingers. "Where did you get this?"

“I told you,” Adora tried again, “I found it.”

Shadow Weaver’s face snapped back to her. “Do you honestly expect me to believe you *found* an expensive piece of jewelry that just so happened to have your best friend’s little catch phrase engraved into it?”

Terrified, Adora’s mouth worked wordlessly. Shadow Weaver gave her a violent shake, getting right into her face.

“Do not lie to me, Adora!” she shouted.

“It was me!” Catra cried, lurching forward protectively. “It was me, I gave it to her.”

That was all Shadow Weaver needed to hear. Releasing Adora’s arm, she stalked up to Catra until she nearly stepped on her toes.

“Where did it come from?” she asked, her words clipped and dangerous.

Catra licked her lips. She held Shadow Weaver’s fiery glare, but she didn’t say anything either. Adora didn’t know what was worse: on one hand, refusing to answer Shadow Weaver was a terrible idea. On the other hand, the truth wasn’t much better.

When it became clear that Catra planned to stay silent, Shadow Weaver stepped back with a sniff.

“Remove your jacket,” she said curtly. Catra pressed her lips into a tight line. She hesitated. Then she did as she was told.

Adora shook her head. “Shadow Weaver, please—”

Shadow Weaver rounded on her like a viper. “Are you going to tell me the truth?”

“I…” Adora’s eyes flicked to Catra, who gave a quick, nearly imperceptible shake of her head.

Don't.

So Adora shrank back.

"I didn't think so," Shadow Weaver said. "If you're not going to tell me what I want to know, be quiet."

She turned to the empty wooden crate that the kids used as a coffee table and set down the bracelet and the expensive purse that hung at her side. From the bag, she pulled a small switchblade and flipped it open. She held out a hand toward Catra.

"Give me your arm."

Everyone in the room held their breath. All activity stopped as the other kids froze to watch with morbid curiosity. Catra held her head high. She lifted her arm and let Shadow Weaver grab hold of her roughly. Shadow Weaver pressed the blade to the already-scarred skin of Catra's upper arm.

"Where did you get the bracelet, Catra?" She demanded in an eerily calm voice. She waited a beat. When Catra refused to answer, Shadow Weaver slashed the knife across her skin.

Catra hissed a sharp breath between her gritted teeth. She swallowed hard, and kept her eyes trained across the room. The gathered crowd winced.

Shadow Weaver moved the knife an inch below the first cut. "I asked you a question, Cadet."

Again, Catra said nothing, and again, Shadow Weaver carved another line.

Adora pressed her hands to her mouth to smother her sobs. She wanted to intercede—to protect her friend—but she knew that would just make things worse.

More silence, another cut. Catra grunted with each slice and bit her lip to keep it from trembling. Blood flowed down her arm and dripped onto the concrete floor.

The knife was just above Catra’s elbow now.

“Answer my question, Catra,” Shadow Weaver said. This time, she dragged the knife slowly and pressed it deeper into Catra’s flesh. At last, Catra’s resolve broke, and she cried out.

“I found it!”

Shadow Weaver clicked her tongue. “Wrong answer.”

“Come on, Catra,” Adora pleaded. She couldn’t stand to watch this much longer.

“Fine!” Catra's face was twisted in pain. Sweat beaded at her brow. “I bought it!”

“Fascinating,” Shadow Weaver replied, pressing the blade into the muscle of Catra’s forearm. “And where, pray tell, did you get the money?”

Catra’s breaths were short and shallow as she braced herself for the next cut. Again, Shadow Weaver took her time, and this time Catra sobbed.

“Did you steal from your earnings, Catra?” Shadow Weaver asked, her voice low.

Tears leaked from Catra’s eyes and trailed down her face. She nodded, ever so slightly.

Shadow Weaver pressed the blade harder. “Use your words.”

“Yes,” Catra shouted. “Yes, I stole the money.”

That should have been enough — Shadow Weaver had her answer.

But with Shadow Weaver, *enough* was never sufficient when it came to making a point. With vicious speed, she took a fistful of Catra's hair and dragged her over to the crate. She swept it clear with one arm, then shoved Catra down onto it, face first.

Adora lunged forward, throwing herself down on top of Catra. "Shadow Weaver, please stop! It's my fault! I told her I liked the bracelet and—"

Shadow Weaver didn't give Adora a chance to finish. She grabbed Adora by the arm and threw her down onto the couch, where she landed in a heap on Lonnie and Kyle's laps. Panting hard, Shadow Weaver pointed at Rogelio.

"You — bring me the lash," she snapped. Rogelio leapt to his feet, and she turned her attention to Lonnie and Kyle. "Keep her there with you. Do not let her go."

Rogelio raced frantically across the warehouse floor and Lonnie and Kyle wrapped their arms around Adora. She could feel them trembling. Catra turned her face to look at Adora.

It's okay, she mouthed.

But it wasn't okay — nothing about what was happening was okay.

When Rogelio returned with the lash—a length of thick, flat leather—Shadow Weaver snatched it from his hands and brandished it over her head like the weapon it was.

"Let this be a lesson to you all," she shouted, her voice carrying across the hushed and cowering crowd. "The Horde will not tolerate treachery. We are your *family*. We provide you with everything you need. Do not disgrace us by taking our generosity for granted. Do I make myself clear?"

"Yes, Shadow Weaver," the chorus of Cadets replied in unison.

Still bent over the crate, Catra took a breath and clutched the edges so tightly that her knuckles turned white. She knew what was coming — she'd suffered this punishment before. Shadow Weaver tugged up the hem of Catra'd ratty old T-shirt to expose the skin of her back, already striped with long horizontal scars.

"I'm so sorry, Catra," Adora wept, straining against the hold her friends had on her.

Catra gave her a weak smile, then she closed her eyes.

"Enough," Shadow Weaver snarled. She brought the lash down with cruel force, and the sound of it splitting Catra's skin filled the otherwise silent warehouse.

Again and again, Shadow Weaver whipped at Catra's back. It didn't take long for Catra's defiant silence to break. She screamed through the rest of her punishment, sobbing shamelessing after each strike. All the while, Adora wailed and struggled, powerless to save the most important person in her world.

Though it was only minutes, the ordeal seemed to take hours. When Shadow Weaver finally decided she'd made her point, she threw the lash at whichever kid was standing closest. She was panting from exertion, and she took a moment to smooth back her hair and straighten her blazer before turning to the couch.

"You three," she snapped, gesturing at Rogelio, Lonnie, and Kyle, "get this embarrassment out of my sight."

As soon as Adora felt her friends relax their grip, she dove forward and reached for Catra's hand. But before she could reach her, Shadow Weaver snatched Adora's arm and hauled her back to her feet.

"Come with me. Now." Shadow Weaver said. She pulled Adora to the far side of the warehouse floor, away from the other cadets. All the while, Adora twisted to look back over her shoulder. She watched miserably as Rogelio and Lonnie helped Catra to her feet

and led her gingerly to the stairs. Kyle gathered Catra's abandoned jacket and scampered after them.

Shadow Weaver whirled Adora around and shoved her backwards into the wall.

"I expected better from you, Adora," Shadow Weaver snarled. "How could you let something like this happen? Perhaps insisting on your promotion to Force Captain was a mistake."

"No," Adora said, even though she was starting to think the same thing. "It won't happen again, I promise."

Sighing, Shadow Weaver's stance softened ever so slightly. "What did I tell you about that girl, Adora? She is a poor influence. She is distracting you from your potential."

Adora stood her ground. She lifted her chin and met her mentor's gaze. "I won't let anything like this happen again. You have my word." Her words were firm.

Shadow Weaver laid her hand to Adora's cheek. It was a gesture that should have been tender and caring, but Adora knew better than that.

"Do not disappoint me like this again," Shadow Weaver said. She waited until Adora nodded before turning away. "Now, I have business to attend to. You will receive your next assignment tomorrow. Until then, keep your head down."

Adora waited, her back pressed to the wall, until Shadow Weaver slipped through the warehouse door. As soon as she heard the latch slide shut, she ran across the floor and darted up the stairs two at a time. She found Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio loitering in the hallway outside the dormitories.

"There you are," Lonnie said, breathing a sigh of relief.

"Where is she?" Adora asked. "How is she?"

“She’s in there,” Kyle replied, gesturing to the closed door behind them. He was clutching the first aid kit to his chest. “But she won’t let us anywhere near her.”

“Of course she won’t.” Adora took the first aid kit. Lonnie handed her some towels and Rogelio gave her the bucket of hot water he was holding. “Thanks, guys. I’ll take it from here.”

As Lonnie and Rogelio started down the hall, Kyle hung back.

“Here, Adora,” he whispered as he tucked something into her already-full hands.

It was the bracelet.

“Kyle, how did you—”

“Shadow Weaver knocked in onto the floor with everything else,” he said with a smile. “I noticed it when I grabbed Catra’s jacket. Thought you might want it back.”

Adora swallowed down the lump in her throat. “Thank you.”

Once Kyle was gone, Adora toed the dormitory door open. The only light in the room drifted through a single window that had been draped with a grimy sheet.

“Catra? It’s me.”

“Leave me alone.” Catra’s voice drifted weakly from the darkness.

Adora shuffled inside anyway and used her hip to bump the door closed. “I will, if that’s what you want. But we’ve got to get you cleaned up first, okay?”

Catra grunted, but she didn’t tell Adora to go fuck herself, so Adora took it as a win. She crossed the room and set the supplies down next to the mattress she and Catra shared. Then she turned on a small lamp and used the light to survey the damage. Catra

lay on her stomach, her shirt cast aside in a bloody lump on the floor. She had her face turned toward the wall.

"Just leave the stuff there," she mumbled. "I'll do it."

"Come on, Catra," Adora begged. "Please let me help."

A moment of silence stretched between them. Finally, in a tiny, defeated voice, Catra whispered, "Okay."

Adora went to work, cleaning and bandaging Catra's many wounds with a gentle hand. Catra didn't speak, and Adora didn't push her. When she finished, Adora hauled all the supplies back to where they belonged, then returned to the dorm. She tiptoed across the room and sank down at Catra's side.

"Can I stay here with you?" she asked quietly. She heard Catra take a shaky breath.

"Sure."

Adora laid down on her side beside Catra, who still had her face turned away. For a while, they simply lay together without speaking. Then, Adora lifted her hand and ran her fingers softly through Catra's hair. Catra flinched at the initial touch, but relaxed quickly.

"Is this okay?" Adora asked. "I'll stop if you want."

"I don't mind."

Finally, just as Adora started to drift off to sleep, Catra turned her head to face her. The whites of her dual-colored eyes were red, the flesh around them swollen from crying. Her soft cheeks were streaked with tears.

"I'm so sorry," Adora whispered.

"I knew what I was getting myself into," Catra replied, her voice hoarse. "It's fine."

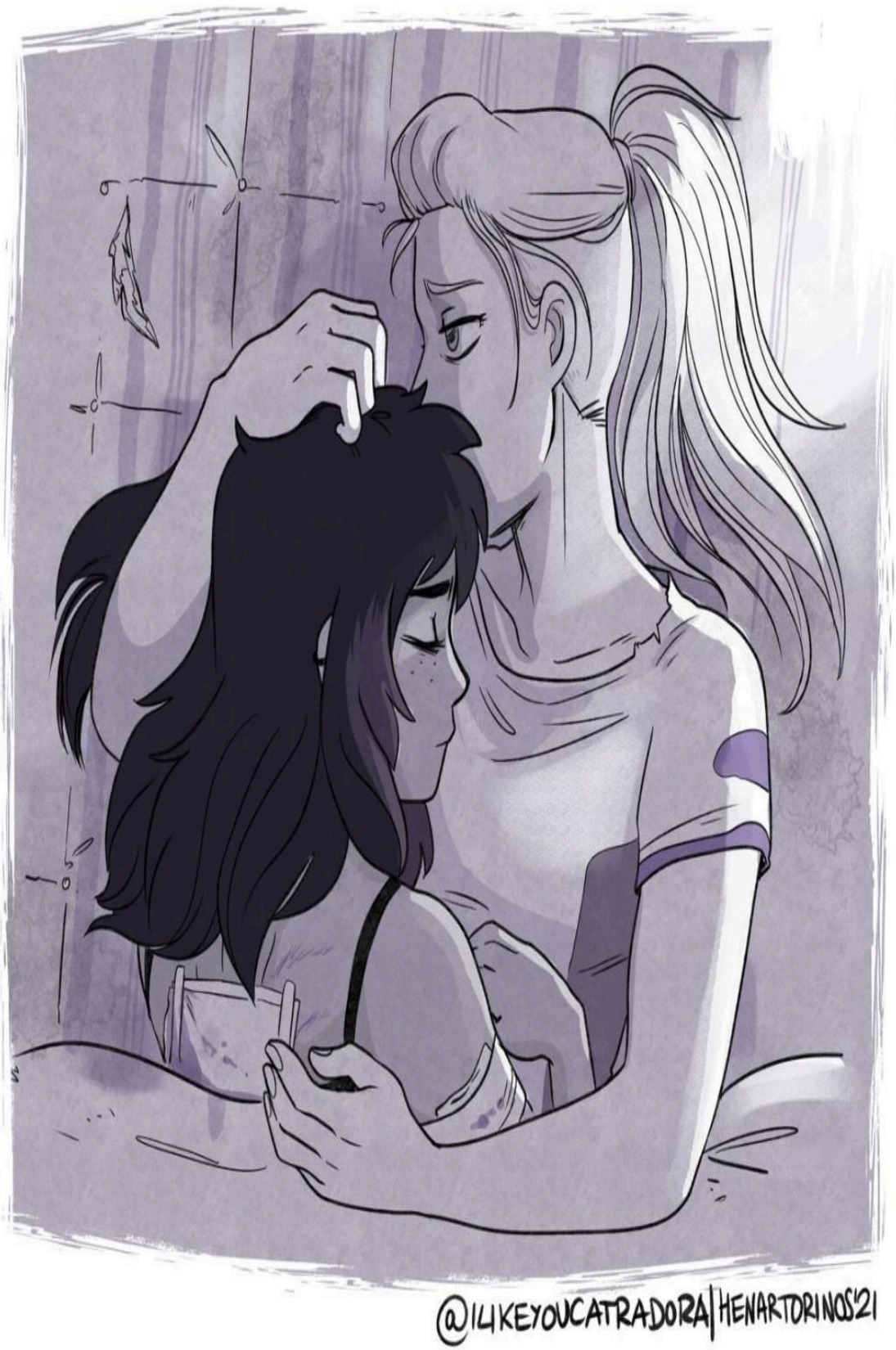
“No, it’s not.” Adora searched Catra’s face in the dim light. “Can I hold you for a little while?”

Catra closed her eyes. “Yes, please.”

So, Adora tugged the sheet up and snuggled in close so Catra didn’t have to move. Catra nuzzled her face into the crook of Adora’s neck, and Adora continued stroking her hair until at last, her best friend fell asleep in her arms.

It was then, in the dark of barracks and with the events of the last 12 hours swirling through her mind, that Adora’s resolve crystalized into a plan. She pressed her face into Catra’s hair and held her close.

“Don’t worry, Catra,” she whispered. “I’m going to get us out of here.”



Chapter End Notes

CONTENT WARNINGS:
- Adora vomits in a gutter; on-page
- Adora washes blood off herself in the bathroom; on-page
- Shadow Weaver repeatedly cuts Catra's arm in an attempt to make her confess; on-page
- Shadow Weaver whips Catra's back as a form of punishment; on-page

Chapter 4

Chief Angella Brightmoon paced the length of her office with her phone pressed to her ear.

"I understand," she said. "Thank you, Mermista. Please keep me posted on his condition."

She hung up with a sigh, and placed the phone gently on her desk. In truth, she wanted to throw it — she wanted to hurl it across the room and watch it shatter against the wall. But an outburst like that wouldn't help her. It wouldn't help the precinct she was trying to run, and it certainly wouldn't help her undercover officer, laid up and barely stable in the hospital's ICU.

So, instead of throwing her phone, Angella took a breath. She laid her palms against the smooth surface of her desk and dropped her head. Her long hair slid forward, framing her face like a curtain that hid her frustration and exhaustion from the world.

In the privacy of her own mind, Angella felt as though the walls were closing in. Dismantling the most dangerous gang in Etheria was her life's work. But after years of chasing after the Horde, she felt further away from that goal than she had as a fresh-faced beat cop.

Nothing she did seemed to make a difference. For every raid her officers planned, the gang always seemed to be one step ahead. If she planted an undercover officer within their ranks, the gang inevitably found them out. For every investigation she launched, her witnesses and informants either vanished or wound up dead before she could make any progress. Bringing the Horde down was a noble cause, but the stakes had never been higher. And now, with one of her best undercover officers clinging to life, Chief Angella Brightmoon couldn't help but wonder if this was all worth it.

She sank into her chair, crushed under the elephantine weight of her mission, and flipped open the folder on her desk. Inside she found the photos of Detective Seahawk's injuries. He had sustained a brutal beating, and the result was a nightmarish mix of split flesh and fresh blood, deep bruises and missing teeth. Somehow he had survived, and what's more, he hadn't blown his cover either. Angella forced herself to stare at the carnage until all of her doubts subsided.

This was the kind of horror that came naturally to the Horde. She knew this — she had witnessed it first hand. The only way to stop it was to put an end to the gang once and for all. Angella couldn't stop now. So she added Detective Seahawk to her long list of reasons to keep fighting, and closed the folder.

As she slid the folder into her filing cabinet, a knock sounded at Angella's door.

"Come in," she called.

The door opened to reveal one of her officers, his hulking figure filling the doorframe. He stood with his uniform jacket draped over his forearm.

"Sargeant Lashor," Angella said, her eyes darting to the clock on the wall. "Are you heading home? I thought you'd be gone by now."

"I was on my way, ma'am," the sergeant replied gruffly. "But I ran into these two in the parking lot." He stepped aside and Angella sighed.

"Thanks, Sarge," quipped Glimmer, Angella's only child, as she breezed into the office. "We've got it from here." Glimmer's best friend, Bow, hurried in behind her. Sergeant Lashor raised an eyebrow at his superior officer, who waved him off.

"Have a lovely evening, Sergeant," she said. "I'll see you at the briefing meeting in the morning."

Once the sergeant took his leave, Angella turned her attention to her daughter. “Glimmer, what are you—”

“How is he, Mom?” Glimmer said, cutting her off. “Is Seahawk going to be okay?”

Angella jerked back with surprise. “How did you know about that?”

By way of answer, Glimmer raised an eyebrow.

Of course, Angella thought darkly. *My vigilante daughter somehow has better connections than I do*.

“We heard he was beaten pretty badly,” Bow said, shifting anxiously in the corner. “Is he going to make it?”

Sensing there was no point in being secretive, Angella sighed. “I believe so. But he has a long road of recovery ahead of him.”

“Was he made?” Bow asked, referring to Seahawk’s undercover status as a contract courier for the Horde’s illegal drug smuggling operations.

“No, he went off book and tried to destroy one of the Horde’s payloads by setting fire to the ship he was piloting.” Angella shook her head. “Despite the interrogation, he insisted the fire was an accident. They let him live, which makes me think they believe him, but I’m not willing to risk it. Detective Seahawk is out of the field for the foreseeable future.”

Glimmer growled and paced the office, looking much like her mother a few minutes earlier. “I hate this! It feels like no matter what we do, the Horde is always one step ahead of us. There’s got to be a way to take them down!”

Angella got to her feet. “There is no ‘us’ in this equation, Glimmer. You know perfectly well this is police business.”

“But Mom—” Glimmer tried to argue, but her mother cut her off with a stern glare.

“The Horde is dangerous, Glimmer,” Angella said through gritted teeth.

“Don’t you think I know that?” Glimmer threw her hands up in frustration. “That’s why we should work together on this.”

“We will not work with vigilantes on an official police investigation.” Angella was losing patience. “How many times must we have this conversation?”

Glimmer stormed up to her mother’s desk and slammed her open palms against the surface hard enough to knock over a framed photo. “Would you still be saying no to the help if I wasn’t your daughter?”

Before Angella could snap back, another knock came at the door. She groaned against the headache rising behind her eyes.

“Come in,” she shouted, perhaps a touch more forcefully than she normally would.

This time it was one of the precinct’s newer beat cops who opened the door. They glanced around the room and cleared their throat. “Sorry for interrupting, ma’am. You have a visitor.”

The young constable motioned over their shoulder and Angella’s eyes widened. Seated on a bench down the hallway was a familiar face — one she hadn’t seen in years, but one she thought of every day.

“Adora?” Angella rounded her desk. “What is she in for?”



“She hasn’t been booked for anything, ma’am,” the constable said. “She says she needs to speak with you — she says it’s important.”

Angella nodded. “Send her in.”

Glimmer and Bow exchanged curious glances.

“Mom, what’s going on?”

“Glimmer, Bow, I’m afraid I need to ask you both to leave,” Angella said without taking her eyes off the young woman down the hall. The constable was speaking to her, gesturing to Angella’s office. Adora turned her icy blue eyes toward her, and Angella felt her breath hitch. Something felt wrong. “We can continue this conversation when I get home this evening.”

She could tell her diplomacy took Glimmer off guard. It was a peace offering made in exchange for compliance. Angella didn't want her only daughter around for whatever was about to happen next.

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Adora stepped into Chief Brightmoon's office and looked around. It was far more spacious than the last one Adora had been in. But of course it was — Angella had been promoted since Adora's last involuntary visit to the precinct. But the crest on the wall was the same, with its 'Serve and Protect' motto emblazoned in a scrolling banner that stretched across its center. Adora gazed up at it and hoped those words still rang true.

"Please close the door behind you," Angella said.

It was then that Adora realized they weren't alone. She turned her head to find two teens staring curiously back at her. One she recognized from the photos Angella kept on her desk. The girl was older now, but her wild pink and purple hair was hard to forget. Hovering at her side was a boy that Adora had never seen before. When he flashed a smile at her, she could tell it was genuine.

Angella made a point of loudly clearing her throat, and the teens jumped into action. They filed past Adora, neither bothering to hide their curiosity as they gaped openly at her. She watched them slip into the hallway and pull the door shut.

"Adora," Angella said, her voice still as soft and warm as Adora remembered. "It's been so long. Is it too much to hope that means you've been staying out of trouble?"

Adora replied with a bark of laughter, and Angella sighed.

"I figured as much." She gestured to an empty chair. "Please, sit."

But there was too much nervous energy thrumming through Adora's body to let her do that. She folded her arms and shifted. "Thanks, but I'll stand."

A tension filled the air as Adora and Chief Brightmoon stared one another down. Angella licked her lips.

"What brings you in, Adora? Are you alright?"

Adora pulled in a shaky breath. Despite having practiced this conversation in her head for hours—first as she lay sleepless with Catra in her arms, and then as she made her way to the precinct, moving carefully so as not to be seen—her mind went blank. Years of conditioning had taught Adora to never be honest with the police. Coming to Angella willingly went against everything Adora knew, and her sense of self preservation was doing everything it could to keep her silent.

But Angella was no stranger to difficult conversations with unwilling participants. She sat on the edge of her desk and waited in patient silence.

Finally, Adora swallowed. She pushed through.

"Serve and Protect," she said. "That's your motto, right?"

Angella tipped her head curiously. "It is."

"You once told me that if I ever needed your help, you'd be there for me. Is that still true?"

At this, Angella got back to her feet. Her expression was impassive, but Adora could tell she had her complete and undivided attention.

"What do you need, Adora?" Angella asked, speaking slowly.

Adora's reply came as a whisper. "I need out."

"I'm glad to hear that," Angella said, and Adora could tell she meant it. "But why the change of heart after all this time?"

The memory of Catra in Shadow Weaver's grip flashed through Adora's mind. In a split-second, she saw Catra's bleeding skin and

heard her agonized screams. If Adora stood still for too long, she swore she could still feel Catra trembling in her arms.

"I can't be part of what they're doing. Not anymore, not after what I…" She paused, took a breath. "Not after what I've seen."

Angella's gaze narrowed. She searched Adora's face. "How can I help?"

"The Horde doesn't just let people leave" Adora said. Her heart was pounding. Every word that spilled from her mouth felt like an unforgivable betrayal to the only world she knew. "Not alive, anyway. The only way I can be free of the Horde is if there is no more Horde, period."

"Adora," Angella was breathless. "What are you saying?"

Adora knew the game Angella was playing — Etheria's police chief was a smart woman, and she knew exactly what Adora was getting at. She just wanted to hear her say it.

"I'm willing to help you take down the Horde," she said. She watched Angella's eyes light up, but she cut her off before she could say anything. "But on one condition."

Angella nodded, and Adora assumed she must have known this was coming. "Go on."

"No matter what happens, you have to promise me that Catra will be safe. If she ends up arrested or in danger because of this, I walk, and I take everything I know with me."

Whatever Angella was expecting, the look of surprise that flickered across her face told Adora that this wasn't it. She could see the police chief considering the offer, no doubt running through the variables in her mind.

"I can help you," Adora pressed. "I can lead you right to them and you could arrest all of the top players at once. It would be over."

“I hear what you’re saying, Adora. I really do,” Angella said, raising her hands as if in surrender. “But it’s not that easy. There are a lot of things to consider and protocols to follow if we want to bring these criminals to justice. I want to help you, but we can’t just rush in without a plan.”

Adora bristled. She was irritated — she hadn’t expected to have to sell Angella on this idea.

“Then let’s make a plan” she snapped, feeling desperate. “What do you need?”

“For starters: time,” Angella said. Her gaze was apologetic. “If we’re going to do this, we need to do it right. And we need evidence — something concrete that can be used to build a credible case against the Horde.”

“I’m right here!” Adora shouted. “I can tell you everything you need.”

But Angella shook her head. “Your testimony will be crucial, there’s no denying that. But it would still be your word against the defense in court. If we’re going to dismantle this gang, we need to be able to put the leaders away for good, and to do that we need more than just your word.”

Though Adora didn’t want to admit it, she knew Angella was right. She considered her options.

“Send me undercover,” she said. “I can be your informant.”

“Absolutely not.”

“Why not?” Adora was angry now. “I know cops do shit like that all the time!”

Angella pinned Adora under a stony gaze. Her soft smile hardened into a scowl. “Adora, one of my top undercover agents was just beaten within an inch of his life. He is a trained professional, and

he almost died at the hands of the Horde. I am not willing to put you in that kind of danger."

This stuck Adora like a punch to the gut. She felt deflated, as though the air had been forced from her lungs. She thought of Seahawk's bloodied face, his pleading eyes. In an instant, she was back in that boarded up shack, a gore-covered lead pipe heavy in her hands. Shame curdled in the pit of her stomach. She said nothing.

"I can make a push to get you into witness protection," Angella offered. "We can keep you safe."

"What about Catra?"

Angella shifted. "Until Catra's of legal age, the best I can do is get her into the foster system. We can keep her safe, but she can't go with you."

Fresh, hot anger surged through Adora.

"Not a fucking chance," she spat. "You and I both know the system can't keep her safe. Do you think we would have chosen to live on the streets if it could?" Adora sneered at Chief Brightmoon, torn between disgust and disappointment. "If that's the best you can do, then forget it. I'll find my own way to end this."

She whirled around, turning her back on Angella, who called after her. But Adora was too upset. She felt betrayed and foolish. She was also on the verge of tears, and the last thing she wanted to do was cry in front of the chief of police. So she threw open the door and slammed it shut behind her. She stormed down the hall, ignoring the curious glances of the constables who were just settling in for the night shift. With a violent shove, she pushed through the doors and out of the precinct.

Adora was halfway across the parking lot when she heard the doors clatter behind her. She figured Angella was following her, so

she didn’t slow down. But when a voice called after her, it wasn’t Angella’s at all.

“Adora, wait up!”

Curious, Adora glanced over her shoulder and found the two teens from earlier scampering after her.

“What do you want?” she snapped, eyeing them warily.

“To help,” the girl from Angella’s photos said. “You want to take down the Horde? Well, so do we.”

Adora glanced back and forth, skeptically taking the pair in. “Were you eavesdropping?”

The boy cringed. “Chief Brightmoon is Glimmer’s mom,” he explained, motioning to his friend. “Eavesdropping makes up, like, half of their communication. I’m Bow, by the way.”

“Riiiight,” Adora folded her arms and took a step back. “And what makes you two think you can help me?”

Glimmer, a girl short in stature but shimmering with a ferocity even Adora could see, drew herself up tall. She lifted her chin. “I understand if you don’t trust us, but I promise we’re on the same side here.” She held out her hand. “If evidence is what my mom needs, we can help you get it.”

Adora looked down at Glimmer’s outstretched hand. Then she turned on her heel and started walking.

“You’re right, I don’t trust you,” she called back over her shoulder. “But I am willing to hear you out. Let’s find somewhere private so you can explain what the hell you’re up to.”

Chapter 5

It was the chill that woke Catra up, and it struck her as odd. Even though the dorms were drafty, Catra rarely had reason to notice. Sharing a mattress with Adora had always been enough to keep her warm, even on the chilliest of nights.

She forced her eyes open. Diluted light drifted through the grimy window, and by its angle, Catra could tell that it was already late in the morning. Confused, she turned her head, much to the protest of her sore body. The dorm was completely empty, and Adora's spot on the bed was cold. Everyone must have decided to let her sleep in.

The cuts on her skin stung as Catra gingerly pulled herself up to sit. She sucked in a sharp breath and gritted her teeth against the pain. It took her a few more minutes to get off the mattress, bracing her weight against the wall as she rose to her feet.

"¡Jueputa!" she hissed miserably. It was going to be a long, excruciating day.

Catra glanced around for something to wear. To her surprise, she found her t-shirt draped over the radiator. Adora must have washed it — the thin fabric was still a bit damp under Catra's fingers, but the deep red splotches of blood were now nothing more than faded rust-colored stains that blended in with the rest.

"That idiot," Catra mumbled under her breath. "Why bother washing the blood out of this old rag when it's just going to get dirty again?"

Nonetheless, she smiled and slowly got to work shimmying into the shirt. Once she was dressed Catra made her way downstairs. There were still a few kids loitering on the main floor of the warehouse, but most of them were already gone for the day, off to pick pockets and steal what they could until the sun went

down. Catra was debating how much she could reasonably score in her current condition when Kyle scurried up to her.

"Hey, Catra," he said, holding out a stale, nearly rock-hard muffin . "How are you feeling?"

"Fantastic," Catra replied. She snatched the pastry and crammed it into her pocket for later. "Do you know where Adora is?"

Kyle shook his head. "She was gone by the time I woke up. She didn't tell you where she was going?" He sounded surprised, and that made Catra bristle.

"She's probably off doing Force Captain shit," she muttered, looking away.

"Totally," Kyle agreed with a nod. "Anyway, we all thought you'd prefer to stay home today, so we volunteered you for chores."

Again, Catra felt herself get defensive. Sure, she was in pain, but she didn't need everyone else acknowledging it. She hated when the other kids babied her, almost as much as she hated when they picked on her. Either way, it made her feel weak and useless.

But she didn't complain. At least being stuck inside all day meant she would be there when Adora got back.

Catra was given sentry duty, which suited her just fine. She carefully lowered herself into the chair by the door and fidgeted, trying to find a position that was comfortable. It was boring as hell, but it beat having to mop the expansive warehouse floor or worse — latrine duty. She was about halfway through gnawing on her aged breakfast muffin when someone knocked the pattern into the door.

"Finally," Catra muttered. She'd spent her entire shift thinking of something sarcastic and biting to say to Adora for not telling her where she was going. Getting to her feet as quickly as her injuries allowed, Catra unlatched the door and pulled it open.

Her mouth was open, but the words died on her tongue when she realized it wasn't Adora waiting for her on the other side: it was Shadow Weaver.

"Leave it to you to completely disregard protocol," Shadow Weaver snarled by way of greeting. She gestured to the spyhole in the door that Catra had failed to use, and Catra shrank guiltily into herself. She had been so sure it was Adora outside that double-checking hadn't even crossed her mind.

With a click of her tongue, Shadow Weaver strode inside, leaving Catra behind without another word. Shame burned in Catra's chest — not at having screwed up, but for the fact that despite how much she hated Shadow Weaver, a part of her still wanted the miserable old woman to like her. And, given that Shadow Weaver had never shown Catra an ounce of appreciation, Catra felt that way a lot.

Grumbling to herself, Catra pushed the door closed and set the latch. She stayed standing, arms crossed, and watched Shadow Weaver storm around the warehouse as she did her inspections. Shadow Weaver barked a few orders at Kyle, berated another kid on their sweeping technique, and then climbed the stairs to the offices before disappearing into the dormitories.

That's weird, Catra thought. *She never goes in there*.

A couple minutes later, Shadow Weaver returned to the stairs. She looked more agitated than usual, and when her eyes narrowed on Catra from across the room, Catra's stomach dropped.

"Where is she?" Shadow Weaver demanded as she crossed the floor.

"Where's who?" Catra replied.

"Don't play dumb with me. You two are close. She wouldn't go anywhere without telling you, so where is she?"

Catra blinked. If Shadow Weaver was looking for Adora, then meant Adora wasn't on a Force Captain mission after all. And if Adora wasn't on a mission, then where was she? Was she in some kind of trouble? Catra's mind raced, trying to come up with a plausible lie to buy both her and Adora a bit of time.

If that moron isn't dead already, I'm gonna kill her myself, Catra thought.

She cleared her throat, but before she could say anything, someone knocked the pattern into the door again. Catra turned, and this time she made a point to peer through the spyhole. Adora stood on the other side, completely out of breath. Catra let out a sigh of relief and opened the door.

Adora slid inside and immediately froze as she came face to face with Shadow Weaver. She looked to Catra, who shrugged imperceptibly.

"Where have you been?" Shadow Weaver asked. She stared Adora down, as if she could see her thoughts if she just glared hard enough.

"I was out for a run," Adora replied. She flashed a dazzling smile, and Catra had to bite her tongue to keep from scoffing. "I figured I should step up my fitness game now that I'm Force Captain."

Catra knew Adora. She knew her so well that she could tell when she was lying. Adora was a terrible actor, and Catra knew there wasn't a hint of truth in her story. But Shadow Weaver didn't know Adora—not really—which meant she didn't find Adora's morning run excuse to be as implausible as Catra knew it to be.

"Your dedication is duly noted, Adora," Shadow Weaver said, her words dripping with a sense of pride that Catra has never heard directed at herself. "But we have business to discuss. Come with me."

Shadow Weaver turned and made her way over to the seating area. Catra knew there was no way Shadow Weaver would

actually sit on the filthy sofas, just like she knew the only reason Shadow Weaver was choosing that part of the warehouse to talk was so Catra wouldn't be able to listen in.

Before she followed, Adora looked to Catra. "How are you feeling?"

Catra ignored the question and raised one of her eyebrows instead. "Out for a run, Adora? Seriously?"

"Seriously!" Adora replied. "I gotta go talk to Shadow Weaver, okay? I'll be right back."

She darted away before Catra could say another word. Scowling, Catra dropped back into her chair. She winced at the sharp sting of her wounds, but she didn't care about being gentle with herself anymore. She slumped low, sulking as she watched Shadow Weaver and Adora talk about things she wasn't special enough to know about, all the while wondering why her best friend was lying to her for the first time in their lives.


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Adora's heart was still racing as she stood across from Shadow Weaver and received her next assignment. She could feel Catra's eyes boring into her from across the room, and she felt terrible about lying to her. But if the Rebellion's plan was going to work, she was going to have to keep Catra in the dark a little while longer. Adora just had to keep reminding herself that this was for the greater good, and that Catra would appreciate the secrecy once this was all over.

"Hordak was impressed with your performance during your initiation," Shadow Weaver said. Adora had to fight the urge to grimace. Any leader who was impressed by someone's ability to maim another person was not someone wanted to follow.

"Now that you've been promoted, it is time for you to learn how our business operates," Shadow Weaver continued.

"The business?"

Shadow Weaver nodded. "There's much more to the Horde than you know. Ours is an enterprising organization. As Force Captain, part of your job will be in keeping things running smoothly."

Adora couldn't believe her luck, and she couldn't wait to tell Glimmer and Bow the good news.

After their conversation in the parking lot, Adora had led the pair of vigilantes to a 24 hour diner in a part of town she knew the Horde didn't spend much time in. Despite this, she still raised her hood and sank low in her booth seat — the last thing she needed was to be spotted by someone who could rat her out.

"Okay, talk," she'd asked, casting her eyes surreptitiously around the room. There were only a handful of other patrons at this late hour, and they were all preoccupied with their own thoughts. She didn't recognize anyone, which made her feel a bit safer, but not by much.

"Wow, are you always this friendly or are you making an exception just for us?" Glimmer deadpanned.

"I don't think you understand the danger I'm putting myself in here," Adora hissed, trying to keep her voice low. "So excuse me if I'm a little tense."

Glimmer narrowed her eyes into a cutting glare. "Oh, we understand perfectly. You're not the only person here who knows what the Horde is capable of."

Adora folded her arms and propped them on the laminate table top. She matched Glimmer's glare with one of her own. "Oh, yeah? Did you grow up in the Horde too? Have you been working for them for basically your entire life? Because I don't remember seeing you around the streets."

"No," Glimmer replied, leaning closer across the table. "But the Horde did kill my dad, so maybe save your sob story for someone who cares."

"Hi there!" Bow chirped loudly, breaking the tension between the girls. Adora looked up to see a waitress hovering beside their table. If the bored expression on her face was any indication, this whispered argument was hardly the strangest thing she'd witnessed on the job.

"What can I get ya, kids?" she asked.

Adora slumped lower and looked out the window while the others placed their orders. She turned over Glimmer's confession in her mind. She had no idea who Glimmer's dad had been, but after what she'd been part of, she didn't doubt the Horde's involvement in his death.

Once the waitress left, Adora turned back to the others. "I'm listening."

Glimmer sat back in her seat and drummed her fingers across the table top.

"I was young when it happened," she said. "My dad was a detective, but what he really wanted was to run for mayor. He believed he could make a difference in this city, and he ran his entire campaign on a promise to get rid of the Horde." Glimmer slid her violet eyes back to Adora. "As you can imagine, that didn't go over very well with your boss."

Adora had never actually met the Horde's "boss", the ruthless man known only as Hordak, but Glimmer didn't need to know that. She kept her expression impassive.

"The Horde threatened Dad—threatened our whole family—but he refused to back down," Glimmer continued. "And then, when it looked like the election was as good as his, he was murdered. That's the reason why my mom joined the force, and it's the same reason I'm joining the academy as I'm old enough. We're going to finish what my dad started."

Just then, the waitress shuffled back to the table and set down three large plates of burgers and fries. Adora stiffened.

"I didn't order this," she said once the waitress was out of earshot again.

"I ordered it for you," Bow replied, reaching for the ketchup.

"I can't pay for this." Adora twisted in her seat and tried to flag the waitress down. "Send it back."

"What?" Bow laughed. "No! We're not going to make you sit there and watch us eat."

Adora scowled at him. "I don't want your charity."

But Bow shook his head. "It's not charity. It's a gift, and one I'm happy to give. And if you don't want to accept that, consider it payment for your time instead."

Though Adora wanted to keep arguing, the aroma wafting from the food in front of her was hard to ignore. She dropped her eyes

to the plate, and her stomach let out a low grumble. This was the first time in her life she'd been offered a real hot meal. It smelled incredible. Adora looked down at herself and wondered what Bow and Glimmer saw when they looked at her. Did she look as underfed as she felt? Was her poverty that obvious?

Not wanting to seem too eager, she plucked a single fry from the plate and took a bite. It was so delicious that Adora thought she might cry. Before she knew it, she was shoveling food in her mouth almost as fast as she could swallow it. She saw Bow and Glimmer share a quick, knowing glance, but neither said anything about it, and for that Adora was grateful.

"So how exactly are you planning to stop the Horde?" she asked through a mouthful of burger.

"You heard my mom," Glimmer said. "Her hands are tied. The police have to follow protocol in order to get anything done."

"Well, the good ones do, anyway," Bow muttered. At this, Adora cocked her head, and he elaborated. "Etheria's police force is crawling with dirty cops. We're pretty sure there's a mole or two who keep feeding intel to the Horde."

Glimmer lifted an eyebrow. "You wouldn't happen to know anything about that, would you?"

Adora swallowed her food and resisted the urge to be sarcastic. If these two were serious about wanting to help, she needed to learn how to play nice. "Sort of. I know the Horde's got friends in high places, but I don't know who they are."

It felt strange to talk about the Horde as if they were something outside of herself — as if she hadn't been complicit in their crimes, however naively, her entire life. But if she was going to go through with this, she couldn't afford to be sentimental. She needed to create some distance if she had any hope of surviving her own treason.

"Yeah, well those dirty cops keep Angella so busy trying to deal with police corruption, she barely has time to focus on the real problem," Bow explained.

"Which is where the Rebellion comes in," Glimmer said. "Vigilantes don't need to follow the same rules as the cops."

Adora nodded. "Right. So what's the plan?"

A mischievous smile crept across Glimmer's face. Her eyes sparkled as she leaned forward. "We need proof of what the Horde is doing. Not just rumors and talk — hard, tangible proof that my mom can use to issue some warrants."

"Like what exactly?" Adora asked.

"With you on the inside, it could be anything," Bow said. "Documents, photos. Heck, if you can get a video or a recording, we'd be set!"

Adora took a deep breath. What they were talking about was serious business. The Horde took their privacy very seriously. If she managed to leak any of the things Bow was describing, there'd be no coming back from her betrayal.

But if that was all it would take...

"Okay," Adora said. "I'll do it, but on one condition: we have to keep my friend safe. Before anything goes sideways, we have to get her out of there, and I'm not going to do anything that puts her in harm's way. Got it?"

Again, Glimmer and Bow turned to one another. They shared a look that seemed to convey an entire conversation — so much so that Adora felt like she was eavesdropping. Then, they turned their gaze back to her and smiled.

"Of course," Glimmer said. "We get it. Whatever happens, we'll keep your friend safe."

Adora thought about Catra—about the two of them finally being free of the Horde—and her heart ached with want. Now, standing in the dismal warehouse she called home, Adora glanced over her shoulder. Catra was staring back at her, those mismatched eyes watching intently. Adora smiled at her, then turned her attention back to Shadow Weaver.

"I can't wait to get started," she said, holding her head up high.

This seemed to be exactly what Shadow Weaver wanted to hear. A hint of a smile tugged at the corners of her scarred lips.

"Excellent," she drawled. "Follow me — we've got important work to do."

Chapter 6

Shadow Weaver kept a tight grip on Adora's shoulder as she steered her back to the door. Catra got to her feet, and Adora could see from the twitch of her brows that Catra was fighting to hide how much she was hurting. Adora reached out for her hand, but Shadow Weaver yanked her away.

"Not now, Adora," Shadow weaver snapped. She jutted her chin at Catra. "Door. Now."

Sulking, Catra did as she was told. She unlatched the heavy metal door and pulled it open before stepping aside to let them through. Shadow Weaver pushed Adora forward without so much a word of thanks.

"I'll see you tonight, okay?" Adora told Catra as she was shoved out the door and back into the dazzling midday sun. If Catra said anything in reply, Adora wasn't given the chance to hear it. Shadow Weaver led her down the sidewalk at a brisk pace. Only once they heard the warehouse door creak closed and the latch fall into place did Shadow Weaver release her merciless grip.

"Here we are," She said, gesturing tot a sleek black car with tinted windows that was parked at the curb. "Get in."

Adora hurried to obey, crawling into the back and fumbling with the seatbelt. A woman sat in the driver's seat — someone Adora had never seen before but assumed was one of their own based on the insignia emblazoned on the arm of her jacket. The driver didn't acknowledge her, so Adora followed her lead and said nothing either. Shadow Weaver slid into the car and sat straight-backed at Adora's side. Once she was settled, she nodded to the driver, and they were off.

Compared to the cop cars Adora had ridden in, this vehicle felt like a luxury experience. The clean, plush leather seats and carefully detailed cabin made her acutely aware of how filthy she was by

comparison. Feeling suddenly self-conscious, Adora shifted her gaze out the window and watched the city slip by.

A short drive later, the car pulled into a garage called Prime Auto Repair. Wordlessly, Shadow Weaver got out and Adora followed, offering a small wave to the driver, who dutifully ignored her. Adora couldn't help but stare, taking everything in as she hurried to keep up with Shadow Weaver's quick strides. All around them, mechanics worked on cars and trucks in a series of vehicle bays, doing oil changes and digging around under hoods. None of them batted an eye as Shadow Weaver breezed from the car to a door at the back of the garage with Adora following in her wake.

The door led to a hallway that felt like stepping into another building entirely. Unlike the warehouse Adora called home, this building was well-lit and in much better repair. Through yet another door, they entered a large room that was bustling with activity. The set-up reminded Adora of the bullpen at the police precinct, with a collection of tables set up around the floor. Full-fledged members of the Horde sat at a set of monitors that displayed a collage of security camera feeds. Others stood clustered together around maps and schematic drawings, holding discussions in low tones. Adora was in awe. Her heart tripped over itself as she imagined what kind of damning information this place held. If being Force Captain gave her access to a treasure trove like this, bringing down the Horde might be easier than she thought.

"This is the Horde's headquarters," Shadow Weaver explained, gesturing to the work happening around them. "In time, you'll become familiar with all aspects of our operations."

"Where do you want me to start?" Adora asked. "I could start training on the computers, or maybe you need someone to sort through the records? I'm ready for anything."

Shadow Weaver paused at another door on the opposite side of the bullpen and looked back at her. "Like I said, you'll learn it all in due time. But I have a different assignment for you today."

She pushed through the door and motioned for Adora to follow. Inside was a sort of antechamber, with one wall made almost entirely of glass that looked into another room. A man stood with his back to them, his focus trained on whatever was happening through the window.

"Sir," Shadow Weaver said. There was a reverence to her voice that Adora had never heard before, and it put her on edge. "Force Captain Adora is ready to receive her first assignment."

Slowly, as if it pained him to pull his attention from the window, the man turned. Adora's breath hitched and she froze in place. Though she'd never met him before, she knew exactly who this man was.

Hordak took her in with a studious stare. His eyes were dark and ringed with shadows. Intricate black tattoos crawled across his pronounced cheekbones and up his neck, spilling over his jawline and chin. Adora had to remind herself to breathe.

"And she's as good as you say?" Hordak said in a deep velvety voice that took Adora completely by surprise.

"Better," Shadow Weaver insisted.

"Excellent." Hordak turned back to the window, and Shadow Weaver had to steer Adora to join him.

Through the glass, Adora saw a laboratory of sorts. Long metal tables stretched across the room, littered with smoking beakers, industrial sized bottles of various fluids, and piles of wires and circuit boards. In the middle of all this clutter was a single figure: a lone woman with long lavender hair that she wore in twin ponytails at the top of her head. Her face was covered by a gas mask that gave her an unsettling apocalyptic vibe. A white rat with blood-red eyes sat perched on the woman's shoulder as she worked.

Hordak rapped the glass with his knuckles, and the woman's head snapped up. She waved enthusiastically before skipping to the

door and joining them in the antechamber.

“Hiiii!” The woman lifted her mask and grinned brightly at Adora. “Oooh, you’re new!”

“Entrapta, this is our newest Force Captain,” Shadow Weaver explained, shoving Adora forward. “She’ll be assisting you moving forward.”

Entrapta let out a high-pitched squeal. She leapt forward and took Adora’s hand, shaking it vigorously. “How exciting! What’s your name?”

“I’m Adora.”

“Great! I’m Entrapta, and this is Hordak.” She clutched his arm, and for a split second Adora feared for Entrapta’s life. This hardly seemed like the respectful behavior they were taught to show Hordak in the unlikely event they ever got to meet him. But rather than get angry, Hordak actually smiled down at Entrapta fondly. “Oh! And this little lady is Emily.”


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Entrapta scooped the white rat from her shoulder and held it out to Adora, who flinched back involuntarily. Emily the rat blinked her beady red eyes and quirked her whiskers curiously.

"Um, hi, Emily," Adora said, giving the rat a gentle pat for good measure. "It's, uh, nice to meet you both."

"Isn't she cute?" Entrapta cooed, nuzzling Emily against her cheek before depositing her back on her shoulder. "I rescued her from the university labs. Now she gets to *do* science instead of *be* science!"

Hordak laid a hand on Entrapta's rat-free shoulder and addressed Adora for the first time since she walked into the room. "Entrapta is responsible for the development and manufacturing of our product," he said proudly.

Adora's eyes flicked back to the window as the pieces clicked into place in her mind. This was where the drugs she'd spent years running came from.

"Wait, you make all of it yourself?" Adora asked. Given how much product was on the streets, she had a hard time believing it all came from one person.

"Yep!" Entrapta beamed. "The recipe is pretty tricky, so I don't trust anyone else to work on the production side of things. It slows things down, but it's better than risking a bad batch. But that's okay, because now I have you!"

Uh oh, Adora thought, her stomach dropping to her toes. She was a lot of things, but a scientist wasn't one of them.

Shadow Weaver must have read the apprehension on Adora's face, because she stepped in to elaborate.

"Entrapta has been developing a way to mass synthesize our product in order to speed up production."

Out of the corner of her eye, Adora could see the way Entrapta was almost vibrating with excitement.

"I've been working with really common tech—the kind of stuff you find in old household electronics like cell phones and TVs and stuff—to create a device that can produce four times as much product as I can on my own," Entrapta explained. She spoke so fast that Adora almost felt dizzy. "The only problem is that I only get a couple uses out of the device before it burns out, so I need a lot of tech for the rebuilds."

Shadow Weaver nodded. "That is where you come in, Adora. Your assignment is to mobilize the children to collect tech for Entrapta's work."

Adora fought to hide her disappointment. This assignment was barely a step above what she'd been doing before. It looked like she was going to have to play the long game if she wanted to earn access to the types of documents that would help the Rebellion's case against the Horde.

"No problem," she said. "We'll have you rolling in tech in no time."

"Yay!" Entrapta exclaimed. She dug into one of her deep overall pockets and pulled out a folded, grease-stained piece of paper. "Here's a list of everything I need. This is going to be great!"

With that, Shadow Weaver thanked Hordak for his time and ushered Adora back into the bullpen.

"I don't care how you get the tech," Shadow Weaver explained as she walked them back through the headquarters. "You can salvage scrap yards or rob every big box store in the city, just make sure you keep Hordak's little pet flush with everything she needs. I'll leave the strategy to you, but just make sure no one gets caught. Do you understand?"

"Yes, Shadow Weaver."

They were back at the main doors. Shadow Weaver stood aside, indicating that Adora was free to go.

"Oh, and one more thing," Shadow Weaver said just as Adora reached for the door. "After you've briefed the children, collect your things. The car will pick you up at nine o'clock."

Adora turned to her in surprise. "My things? What do you mean?"

Shadow Weaver tipped her head and gave her a look that hovered somewhere between puzzled and amused.

"Force Captains don't live at the warehouse with the street urchins, Adora. You'll be moving into your new accommodations tonight." She pushed the door open and shoved Adora outside. "Remember: nine o'clock. Don't be late."

Adora was too stunned to respond. The door slammed shut, leaving her standing alone on the sidewalk with Entrapta's list still clutched in her hand. She felt stupid — *of course* she was going to have to move. None of the other kids who got promoted stayed in the warehouse. What did she think was going to happen?

She thought about the mattress she and Catra shared, about the warmth and comfort of falling asleep next to her best friend every night since they were little. What would Catra say when she found out Adora had to leave?

She glanced down at the paper. Even though it was light as a feather, it felt heavy with the weight of everything it represented.

Adora gave her head a shake.

"Just be patient," she told herself as she crammed the list into her pocket and set off down the street.

"It'll all be worth it in the end."

Chapter 7

Adora stood in the middle of the warehouse floor, surrounded by the small army of kids and teens she called friends. A low buzz of curious whispers and excited energy filled the room, as everyone waited for the last of their members to gather. Adora shot a quick glance to Catra, who stood at her side, and got a lopsided grin in return. This was Adora's first big assignment as Force Captain, and everyone was excited for her.

"Okay, everyone. Listen up," she shouted over the din. Immediately the crowd fell silent and attentive. "Hordak has given us a special task. Moving forward, everyone will be rotating assignments. Half of you will continue with collecting funds—" this was the way Shadow Weaver described the low-level work the kids did day in and day out, as if they were out on the street fundraising instead of picking pockets and panhandling for cash "—the other half will be working with me to collect materials for the Horde."

She went through the list of items Entrapta gave her: microwaves, cell phones, TVs, computers, DVD players. The things didn't even need to work: it was the parts they needed. Next, Adora unfurled a large map of the city. She pointed out key targets, such as salvage yards and recycling centers, and specific big box stores, bodegas and gas stations — places she knew carried electronic equipment but didn't necessarily have the greatest security (or at least had security that was easy enough to sneak past).

Once everyone had their assignments for the day, the group split up and took off around the city. While the others stole and scavenged, Adora and Catra wandered the streets, looking for different targets she may have missed. It made Adora feel strange and uneasy to not be doing the grunt work of this assignment — the wandering made her feel like a slacker. But she and Catra hadn't had a chance to talk since Shadow Weaver's thrashing the day before, and Adora knew she wasn't going to have many more

opportunities to be alone with her best friend until she was able to go through with her plan.

As if Catra could read Adora's mind (Which sometimes Adora seriously thought she could.) she turned to Adora with a frown.

"So where were you really this morning?"

Adora's stomach dropped. Of course Catra didn't believe the lie; she always could see right through her. "I told you, I went for a run."

Catra stopped dead in the middle of the sidewalk and crossed her arms. "Why are you lying to me, Adora?"

"I'm not," Adora said with a sigh. She knew this conversation would happen eventually, and she'd spent most of the night rehearsing what she'd say when Catra finally called her out. "This whole Force Captain thing is a lot more intense than I expected and I don't want to screw it up. I just… I don't want to give Shadow Weaver any reason to doubt me." She lifted her eyes to meet Catra's gaze. "I don't want to give her a reason to take my failings out on you again."

Whatever Catra had been expecting Adora to say, it didn't seem to be that. She blinked in surprise, and for a split second, her stony veneer fell away.

"You know how Shadow Weaver is," Catra said, the edge to her words slightly dulled now. She shrugged. "She'll always find a reason to be mad at me."

"That doesn't make it right," Adora replied.

She reached out her hand, and after a moment's hesitation, Catra took it. Hand in hand, they resumed wandering down the street. For a minute, Adora thought she was out of the woods.

But Catra had always been smarter than that.

“What aren’t you telling me?” Catra asked after a moment of silence.

That I’m working as a double agent with a group of vigilantes to bring down the only family we’ve ever known? Adora thought miserably. As terrible as that truth was, she would have preferred it if that’s what she had to say next.

“Shadow Weaver is making me move out of the warehouse.”

Again, Catra froze. “She what?”

Nodding, Adora continued. “She said now that I'm an official member of the Horde, I can’t stay with the rest of the kids anymore.”

She felt Catra bristle at being lumped in with the kids. Being among the eldest of the junior Horde members was a tricky place to be — no longer a child, but not quite a full fledged part of the gang. Even though Adora had been 18 for months now, this was the first time the age divide between her and Catra had mattered.

“Where is she taking you?” Catra asked.

“I’m not sure,” Adora confessed.

“When?”

“Tonight. Nine o’clock.”

Behind those mismatched eyes, Adora could see the wheels of Catra’s mind turning. She held her breath, waiting for the outburst, waiting for Catra’s indignant rage to bubble over. But instead, Catra deflated. At that moment, she looked so small.

“Hey, it’s okay.” Adora rushed to overcorrect. “Sure, it’ll be different, but we’re still going to see each other every day.”

Catra shook her head. The watery threat of tears made her eyes glisten in the sun. “No we won’t. You’re going to be busy with

your Force Captain shit and you'll start coming around the warehouse less and less until eventually—"

"No," Adora said firmly. She took Catra's other hand and held them both tightly between her own. "That's not going to happen to us. I won't let it."

It was so rare for Catra to show weakness. Catra worked hard to keep her vulnerabilities hidden — there was no safety in being soft on the streets. So, when a single tear fell from Catra's lashes, it broke Adora's heart.

"You promise?" Catra asked in a tiny voice.

Adora smiled. "I promise."

As if to seal the deal, Adora pulled Catra into a hug, careful to mind her wounds. She felt Catra melt into her, and in that moment, everything felt right.


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“When I come back to the warehouse tomorrow, I’ll give you the address of my new place,” Adora said with a bright smile. “We can have sleepovers until you get promoted! You can even help me decorate the place.”

Catra barked a laugh. In the blink of an eye, she was back to her old self; a cheeky smile and mischief glinting in her blue and yellow eyes. “You’ll regret making that offer after I draw all over your walls.”

Relieved, Adora smiled. “Challenge accepted.”

*

Adora was out on the curb with five minutes to spare. She fidgeted, adjusted the straps of the backpack filled with her things. It was heavier than usual, but not by much; it turned out everything she owned didn’t amount to much. Her stomach was tight with a combination of excitement and trepidation.

She was alone. Catra claimed she had chores to do, but Adora knew better than that. Catra just didn’t want to watch her leave, and Adora couldn’t blame her.

The car pulled up at nine o’clock exactly. Swallowing hard, Adora climbed in the backseat. The driver was the same woman as before, and this time she actually nodded to Adora in the rearview mirror. Adora took that as a good sign. Or, at least not a bad one.

As the car set off down the street, Adora turned in her seat to watch the warehouse—the place she’d called home for most of her life—shrink behind her. It was only as the car made a left turn, in the split second before the warehouse disappeared from view completely, that Adora thought to look up. There she found Catra, perched on the edge of the roof, watching the car. There was too much distance for Adora to make out her expression, and even though she was sure Catra couldn’t see her, she waved anyway. The whole thing felt like a dream.

The driver brought them from the industrial district to the same seedy part of town where the Horde's garage was. They pulled down an alleyway to the backside of an older building that once upon a time must have been a five story hotel. Now however, it was clear the building had seen better days. The whitewash paint that covered the stone walls was grimy and peeling. Bedsheets and shower curtains hung over the windows that weren't broken. A pair of people sat out on the fire escape, talking and smoking. Their conversation ceased for a moment as they eyed the car warily.

A heavy metal door opened with a squeak of protest from its rusty hinges. Octavia slouched against the doorframe.

"You comin' or what?" she called. The pair on the fire escape chuckled. Adora jumped, uncertain of how long she'd been sitting there gawking. She gathered her backpack and booted open the door.

"Thanks for the ride," she murmured to the driver.

"See you around," the driver replied.

Buoyed by this meager victory, Adora scampered after Octavia, who led her up the stairs.

"Technically, the Horde owns this place," Octavia explained, "but we rent some of the rooms out to make a bit of extra cash. Lots of drifters and stuff, so be sure to lock your door and guard your shit."

She led them all the way to the fifth floor and hustled Adora through the door that led to a hallway lined with a handful of doors and some worn down carpeting. Adora kept her backpack clutched close against her chest.

"This floor is for Horde members only, so if you see any drifters up here, kick their ass out," Octavia continued without looking back. She pointed at a door in the center of the hall as they passed. "Shared bathroom. You're the new kid, so you shower last. And

this—" she paused outside another door and gestured to it like it was some kind of game show prize "—is you."

Octavia pushed the door open and waved Adora in. On the other side was an incredibly modest room; four plain and peeling walls, with a metal framed twin bed pushed up against one of them and a tiny set of drawers against another. It was likely only a bit bigger than a jail cell, but it had a window that let in yellow light from the streetlamp outside.

"This is all for me?" Adora asked as she turned in place, taking the room in.

"Eh, it's not much," Octavia said with a shrug. "But it's better than sharing a mattress on the floor with a room full of snoring kids, right? Here ya' go." She flipped something small into the air, and Adora caught it with one hand. It was a single key. Adora turned it over, stunned.

"Anyway, I've got shit to do." Octavia turned, waving over her shoulder as she left the room. "Welcome home, kid."

And with that, Adora was alone in her brand new room. She closed the door and, as per Octavia's warning, locked it immediately. Satisfied with her security, Adora shuffled back to the bed—her own bed, all to herself—and sat down carefully. She cast her gaze around the room once more. No, it was nothing special at all. But it was all hers. Smiling, she wondered what Catra might do with those big empty walls.

Though it wasn't late, Adora was exhausted. She was also completely alone, and without any company or means to entertain herself, she decided to call it a night. Backpack in tow, Adora brushed her teeth and washed her face in the shared bathroom. She reveled in the simple extravagance of warm running water, and briefly debated taking her shower now so as to avoid the rush in the morning. But that would mean leaving her stuff unoccupied, and she wasn't quite ready for that yet, so she slipped back to her room, locked the door, and crawled into bed.

Despite the sound of vehicles driving by and people talking on the street below, Adora found the quiet of her new room unnerving. She tossed and turned, unable to find comfort in a room that wasn't crowded with her friends. Her bed felt cold and entirely too big without Catra in it, and eventually Adora had to drag her backpack under the covers just so she could have something familiar to hold on to. She rooted around in her pocket until her fingers found what she needed. In the window light, Adora held up the bracelet. She ran her thumb over the engraved words, and in her mind she heard Catra speaking them so clearly that she may as well have been there in the room too.

Hey, Adora.

She put the bracelet back on and found comfort in its weight. Only then, with this vestige of her best friend against her skin, was she finally able to sleep.

Chapter 8

It was still dark when Adora left her new room the following morning. In a couple hours, she'd have to head back to the warehouse to pass out scavenging assignments for the day. But first, she had a meeting to attend.

Double checking the address she'd scrawled on a piece of diner napkin, Adora frowned and pushed into a small artisanal cafe. Inside, she spotted Glimmer and Bow already standing in line. From behind the counter, the baristas shot her dirty looks. Adora could feel them judging her worn clothes — it was like they could tell she wasn't there to buy anything just by looking at her. Feeling out of place, Adora hung back and waited for Glimmer and Bow to notice her.

After picking up their orders, Glimmer and Bow turned, and Glimmer's eyes widened with delight when they landed on Adora.

"You came!" she exclaimed, hurrying across the room with a coffee cup in one hand and a bagged pastry in the other. "Are you hungry? I got an extra muffin just in case."

"And I got you this," Bow said, handing a steaming paper cup to Adora.

"You guys really have to stop buying me stuff," Adora grumbled, though she took the breakfast anyway.

"Never," Bow replied, looking rather pleased with himself. "Friends take care of each other, Adora."

Adora blinked, surprised to hear Bow referring to her as a friend. She looked between him and Glimmer, who was smiling just as fondly. Cheeks flushing, Adora finally let herself smile.

"Okay, fine," she conceded.

“Oh, that reminds me!” Glimmer said. She tossed her backpack onto a chair and rooted through it, cursing under her breath about the amount of junk she was carrying around. Finally she pulled out a cell phone, a phone card, and charging cable, and handed them to Adora who instantly recoiled. “Before you say anything, this isn’t charity. I just upgraded my phone, so I’m giving you my old one.”

“It’s still too much, Glimmer,” Adora protested.

“How else are we going to stay in touch with each other?” Glimmer huffed, thrusting the phone closer.

Adora shook her head. “Why can’t we just keep meeting up before you guys go to school?”

“What if something important happens between meetings?” Bow insisted. He took the phone from Glimmer and slid it into Adora’s pocket. “Besides, you can use this to record conversations or take photos from inside the Horde.”

This made sense to Adora, and so at last, she relented. She took the cable from Glimmer with a sigh and crammed it into her bag.

“Thanks,” she mumbled.

“Great!” Glimmer grinned in a way that told Adora that this was a girl used to getting her way. “Our numbers are already programmed on the phone, and we’ve added you to our group chat.”

Seeing her confusion, Bow leaned in and whispered in Adora’s ear, “I’ll show you how it works later if you want.”

With that settled, the trio set off toward Glimmer and Bow’s high school. Between bites of her muffin, Adora filled them in on everything that had happened since they last spoke at the diner.

“Wow, this Entrapta person sounds brilliant,” Bow said, clearly in awe. “To have figured out a way to repurpose household tech to

mass produce drugs is really clever."

"Do you think you'd be able to get a video of that lab?" Glimmer asked. "That would be huge!"

Adora considered this for a moment. If Angella could see what was happening in that lab—if she had concrete proof—there's no way she wouldn't be able to act. But when she imagined getting that proof, Adora couldn't help but imagine what would happen to her if she got caught, and that terrified her.

"Are you okay?" Bow asked, cutting through her morbid imaginings. "You look really pale all of a sudden."

"Getting that video won't be easy," Adora said with a grimace. "I agree that it's the best shot we've got, but—"

"It's dangerous." Glimmer cut her off. She laid a hand on Adora's shoulder and smiled. "And that makes it scary. We get it."

"We can be strategic about this," Bow chimed in. "You don't have to rush in there and put yourself in harm's way. We'll start slow, do a bit of reconnaissance, and we'll come up with a plan together, okay?"

As much as Adora wanted this whole terrible mess to be over, she couldn't deny that not being pressured to produce results was comforting. Her shoulders sagged with relief. "Okay. Yeah, that sounds good."

Glimmer threw an arm around Adora's shoulder and hugged her tight. "And don't forget — now we're just a text message away! If you need us for anything, let us know and we'll be there."

"Right." Bow nodded and closed in to hug Adora from her Glimmer-free side. "We're all in this together."

Adora couldn't help but laugh. She barely knew these two, but already they felt like old friends.

“Thanks guys. I’m headed to the salvage yard today with some of my crew. If anything comes up, I’ll let you know.”

*

Later that day, Adora waved Catra, Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle through a gap in the fencing around a salvage yard on the edge of town. Even though the place was open to the public, they had no intention of paying for the junk they would no doubt find in the miles of scrap, so they figured it was better to stay out of sight as much as possible.

Kyle pulled a wagon along behind him, its plastic wheels trundling over the uneven, packed dirt. The team split up, picking their way down either side of one of the many rows of discarded contraptions. They worked in relative silence under the hot midday sun, picking through the piles of detritus and castoffs.

“I honestly don’t understand how any of this shit is supposed to help make drugs,” Catra grumbles as she turned a smashed video game system over in her hands.

“Me neither,” Adora admitted. She wiped the sweat from her brow with the back of her hand. “But I guess that’s why she’s the scientist and we’re not.”

This elicited a weak laugh from Catra, followed by a quiet grunt. Adora looked back over her shoulder to find Catra seated on an overturned refrigerator, her breaths coming quick and shallow.

“What’s wrong?” Adora asked as she scampered down from the junk pile.

“Nothing,” Catra replied, wincing her way back to her feet. “It’s just hot out, that’s all.” She walked away and unceremoniously tossed the gaming system into Kyle’s wagon. When she turned back, Adora was waiting for her with her hands on her hips.

“Nice try,” Adora said. She tipped Catra’s face up by the chin and studied her features. Catra was flushed, that much was clear, but

Adora doubted very much that it had anything to do with the heat. Under the redness of her cheeks, Catra's brown skin had taken on a sallow pallor. Though Catra tried to pull away, Adora pressed a hand to her forehead.

"Catra, you're burning up!"

"I told you, it's hot out!" Catra growled.

But Adora shook her head. "This isn't just the heat, you have a fever. Why didn't you tell me you were sick?"

Catra managed to wriggle away, but she didn't get far before she needed to sink back down. She sat on the ground and took a few breaths before answering. "Because I'm not!"

"Well, something's wrong." Adora crouched down in front of her friend. Not wanting to draw attention from the others, she kept her voice low. "How are your cuts? Have you been keeping them clean?"

The way Catra avoided her gaze told Adora everything she needed to know.

"Catra!" she hissed. "You know how important it is to keep open wounds clean! You probably have an infection!"

"What was I supposed to do?' Catra snapped back. "We used up the last of the bandages, and you know Shadow Weaver hasn't dropped off a new bar of soap in weeks."

Gently, Adora helped Catra to her feet. Inside, her heart was hammering. She felt ashamed to have left her best friend in such terrible shape, especially knowing it was her fault that Catra was in this condition in the first place.

"Hey, guys," Adora called to the others. Their heads poked up like groundhogs peeking up in various parts of their respective junk piles. "Are you good here without us? We need to go check on the other teams."

Lonnie raised an eyebrow, a knowing smirk trailing across her lips. “Whatever you say, boss.”

Ignoring the insinuation, Adora steered Catra out of the salvage yard and down the road to where they could catch a bus. Catra leaned her face against the cool window while they rode. Adora watched fretfully as her friend’s slow, shallow breaths fogged the glass in tiny puffs.

When they finally arrived at the old hotel, Adora offered to carry Catra up the stairs. Catra responded with a sneer and started up the stairs on her own, leaving Adora to scamper after her.

“This is it, huh?” Catra croaked once they reached the Horde’s floor.

“Yes, but the grand tour is going to have to wait.” Adora took her by the hand and led her down the hall. “Come on.”

She led them to the shared bathroom and, after checking to see if anyone else was there, locked the door behind them.

“Okay, let me see.” Adora said.

Begrudgingly, Catra shrugged out of her jacket, exposing the grubby bandages on her arm. Adora groaned at the sight of them, splotched with dried blood and the hardened yellow ooze of plasma.

“Don’t say a word,” Catra growled between gritted teeth. “I don’t want to hear it.”

Adora helped Catra out of her shirt. The gauze pads on Catra’s back were in much the same condition. But even with the dressings in place, Adora spotted the culprit right away: the angry red of inflamed skin rimmed the edge of one of the bandages.

“Yep, that’s definitely infected,” Adora said with a sigh. She reached into one of the showers and turned on the water, testing it until it ran warm. Then she grabbed a bar of soap and pressed

it into Catra's hands. "Okay, take a shower and wash up. I'll go find a first aid kit or something."

She was out the door before Catra could argue.

Adora went from door to door, knocking until someone finally answered. She didn't recognize the Force Captain who opened the door, but she figured there'd be time to introduce herself later.

"Hey, do we have a first aid kit or anything like that?"

The Force Captain replied with a bark of laughter before slamming the door shut in her face. Undeterred, Adora tried a few more doors, but it seemed as though everyone else was out for the day.

"Okay, fine," she muttered to herself. "I'll figure something else out."

She hurried to her room, where she retrieved the towel she'd hung to dry on the single hook on the back of her door. Then she returned to the bathroom, where she gathered Catra's discarded clothes while she waited for her to finish. When the water turned off, she stuck her hand behind the shower curtain with the towel. A moment later, Catra emerged. She looked marginally better, with her skin glowing from the water's heat. But Adora could tell by the glazed look in her eyes that Catra was still feeling terrible.

"I can't remember the last time I showered in hot water," Catra said, pushing her wet hair from her face. "You're really moving up in the world, monita."

Adora smiled — for some reason she didn't mind as much when Catra teased her in Spanish. She ushered Catra across the hall, the pair of them darting into Adora's room so as not to be seen.

"Do you have this room all to yourself?" Catra gawked.

"Yep."

"Damn, maybe I want to be a Force Captain after all."

Laughing, Adora tossed Catra's clothes at her and turned around so she could change.

"How are you feeling now?" she asked, listening to the sound of rustling and the odd grunt as Catra gingerly pulled her clothes back on.

"Meh," Catra replied.

"So you still feel like shit then," Adora said.

"I didn't say that."

"You didn't have to." Figuring Catra was finished, Adora turned back around. "I know you, remember?"

Catra was dressed from the waist down, but she was struggling with her bra. She stood facing away, giving Adora a clear view of the mangled flesh of her back. Most of the cuts seemed to be healing fine, but one was most certainly infected. Cleaning it probably helped, but Adora doubted it would be enough.

Without being asked, Adora gently tugged the straps of Catra's bra and slid the hooks into place.

"I had it," Catra grumbled.

"Sure you did," Adora replied. She turned Catra to face her and checked her temperature again. "Catra, you need to rest."

She could tell from Catra's glare that she wanted to argue. The fact that she didn't told Adora that the fever was much worse than Catra was willing to let on.

"Here, why don't you take a nap?" She motioned to her bed. "I'll find some medicine."

Catra's mismatched eyes darted to the bed, and Adora could see her stubbornness wavering. There were few things Catra loved more than a good nap.

"Shadow Weaver will be pissed if she finds out I'm not out working," Catra said.

"She'd be even more pissed if you wound up in the hospital and the Horde had to foot the bill." Adora led her to the bed and pulled back the neatly made blankets. "Let me worry about Shadow Weaver. You just focus on feeling better, okay?"

With a sigh of defeat, Catra crawled under the covers. Adora tucked her in and waited, crouched beside the bed until she heard her friend's breathing change. When she was certain Catra was asleep, she slipped from the room and locked the door.

Adora paced the hallway. She was contemplating finding a pharmacy she could steal supplies from, when her pocket buzzed. With a yelp of surprise, Adora pulled out her phone and found a message from Glimmer waiting for her in a chat labeled "Best Friends Squad".

Hey! Just checking in!

An idea ignited in Adora's mind. It took her a minute or two to figure out how to maneuver the phone's features, but eventually she was able to tap back a reply.

Not great. My friend is really sick.

Bow replied almost instantly. *Oh no! What's wrong?*

Infected wound, Adora wrote. *She needs meds. Any chance either of you can help me?*

The next response took a bit longer. Adora wondered if the pair of them were actually sitting side by side as they messaged her. She was just starting to wonder if her message hadn't gone through properly when a reply from Glimmer popped up.

We'll see what we can do. Can you meet us at the park around 4?

*

Adora waited, leaning against one of the stone lions and casting anxious glances at the clock on her phone. She was a bit early (She was always early.) but the wait was killing her all the same. Her foot bounced as she scanned the faces that streamed by; home-bound business folk and students who seemed to look right through her. Finally, she caught a flash of pink hair, a brown arm waving, and she exhaled.

"You're early," Bow said when she and Glimmer sidled up beside her.

"Catra's still sleeping," Adora replied. "Sitting around worrying about her wasn't doing me any good."

Glimmer wrapped her arms around her and squeezed. "I'm sorry, Adora. That must be scary. What happened to her?"

The memory of Shadow Weaver's rage and the sound of Catra's cries rushed back to Adora in a split-second, replaying so vividly in her mind that she could have sworn she was transported back to that very moment.

"Adora?" Bow's concerned voice broke the spell. "Are you okay? You kind of zoned out there."

She gave her head a shake. "Sorry, it's a long story."

Glimmer and Bow gave each other a troubled glance, but neither pressed the matter further.

"Well, hopefully this helps," Glimmer said, holding up a shopping bag. She rifled through it, holding each item one at a time. "We've got some antibiotic ointment, acetaminophen, hydrogen peroxide, fresh bandages, and I even threw in the last of my antibiotics from when I got my wisdom teeth out!"

Bow recoiled. "Glimmer! You're supposed to finish those!"

"It's fine," Glimmer said, waving him off. "I'm obviously not dead. And now they can be put to good use." She handed the bag to

Adora. “Here — I hope this helps.”

The gratitude Adora felt in that moment was so overwhelming she thought she might burst into tears.

“This is amazing, you guys,” she said, her voice cracking ever so slightly. “Seriously, I can’t thank you enough.”

“We’re happy to help.” Bow smiled.

Adora pulled them both into a group hug and held them tight.

Just then, the warning chirp of police sirens sounded from the street. Instinctively, Adora jumped back. Her eyes snapped to a police cruise that idled at the curb and her blood ran cold. An officer peered out through the rolled-down window and gave a small nod.

Glimmer whipped around and planted her fists on her hips. “Sarge! Don’t scare me like that!”

The officer chuckled. “Oh, come on. You gotta admit, it was kind of funny.”

“You know this guy?” Adora murmured under her breath.

“That’s Sargeant Lashor,” Bow explained, keeping his voice low. “He works with Glimmer’s mom.”

“I was just passing by when I spotted you,” the Sargeant explained. He leaned across the seats so he could get a better look at the three of them, and his sharp gaze made Adora shrink back involuntarily. “Couldn’t resist given’ ya the gears. Do you need a lift? I can drop everyone off before I head back to the station.”

Glimmer glanced back at Adora, her expression questioning. “Do you want us to take you anywhere?”

Not in a cop car, Adora thought. *And definitely not with that creep*. Perhaps it was her natural distrust of the police talking, but this Lashor guy made her feel uneasy.

"You go ahead," she said, forcing a smile. "I'm not too far from here. Thanks again for the supplies — I'll let you know how it goes."

"You sure?" the Sergeant asked. "I don't mind."

Taking a step back, Adora shook her head. "I'm good, thanks."

"Suit yourself." Sergeant Lashor winked as a toothy grin slid across his face. "Stay safe out there, kid."


HENARTORINOS
@ILIKEYOUCATRADORA

Chapter 9

It was still dark out when Catra slipped out from beneath Adora's arm. In stealthy silence, she collected her boots and the bag full of supplies—the same one Adora had come home with the night before and danced around where she'd procured the things inside—and crept from the room. She pulled her boots on in the stairwell then shoved out the back door and into the striking cool of early morning.

She knew she should have been grateful for Adora's help. It had only been a handful of hours since Adora disinfected her wounds and wrapped her in fresh dressings, fed her medicine and soup and waited by her side until the fever broke. Adora had always taken care of her that way.

And, perhaps, that was the problem.

A strange mix of shame and resentment bubbled at Catra's core. Adora's doting, combined with the fact that Catra always seemed to need it, left Catra feeling useless and small. But Catra wasn't useless. She wasn't weak or incompetent. She was just tired of being treated like she was, no matter how noble the intentions behind it were.

It was a long walk back to the warehouse, and the sun was rising by the time Catra trudged up to the door. Some kid she barely spoke to let her in without asking where she'd been, and Catra appreciated not having to snap at them about it being none of their damn business. Rather than return to the dorms, she made her way up to the roof and nestled into the corner where she and Adora had spent so many hours together over the years. She perched on the edge and wondered what Adora would think when she woke up and realized Catra was already gone.

With nothing better to do, Catra rifled through the bag of medical supplies. However Adora had gotten the stuff, she'd certainly hit the motherload. Everything was brand name—none of that

generic, store-brand bullshit—and there was enough of everything to last for quite a while. Catra was debating keeping this stuff for herself rather than adding it to the warehouse first aid kit when she noticed the small yellow bottle at the bottom of the bag. It was the one thing that didn't look like it had come off a shelf.

Catra turned it over in her hand, watching the four remaining capsules slide around. Her eyes scanned the label.

"Who the fuck is Glimmer Brightmoon, and how did Adora get her antibiotics?" Catra asked herself. The name sparked a note of recognition in her mind, but she couldn't quite place it.



The sound of a car door slamming stole her attention. Quietly, Catra crept to the other edge of the roof and peered over. Shadow Weaver had just arrived for one of her inspections. Catra sneered at her.

Just then, a second car pulled up behind the sleek black one that shuttled Shadow Weaver around the city: it was a cop car. Catra's eyes grew wide. She ducked low so she'd be harder to spot and watched with morbid curiosity as the police officer rose from the car and walked up to Shadow Weaver, almost as if he knew her. Catra could see Shadow Weaver's posture stiffen, and could tell from her body language that she was giving the cop shit for something, rather than the other way around. Their voices reached the rooftop, but their words were lost to the wind.

Catra narrowed her eyes at the police officer. She'd seen him around before. In fact, he was one of the only officers on the Etherian police force who didn't give her and Adora a hard time whenever he spotted them panhandling or being places they probably shouldn't have been. But she *had* seen him, and every time she spotted him, he'd just be watching them. If ever she accidentally caught his eye, he'd wink at her, or flash a creepy smile that left her skin crawling. She didn't need to know the guy to know she didn't trust him.

Then again, she felt that way about all cops, so perhaps that wasn't saying very much.

Whatever was happening down on the street escalated. Shadow Weaver was obviously pissed. Her entire body was rigid, her bony hands clenched into fists at her side. For his part, the officer simply shrugged. After a moment, Shadow Weaver seemed to calm down. She nodded, then waved off the cop as if he were nothing more than an annoying mosquito. Much to Catra's surprise, the officer did as he was told and retreated back to his car. Shadow Weaver watched him drive away, then turned back to the warehouse. Catra took this as her cue to leave.

She stashed the bag of medical supplies in the stairwell before hurrying out onto the main floor. Most of the other kids were up now, groggily readying themselves for the day. Catra strode in, hands in her pockets, doing her best to act as if everything was normal. No, she hadn't spent her night in a Force Captain's

quarters. No, she hadn't just witnessed a strange rendezvous between their boss and a police officer. Everything was normal.

But even without looking, Catra could feel Shadow Weaver's eyes on her. Against her better judgement, she looked over her shoulder and spotted the woman storming across the room, making a beeline straight for her. Catra's blood ran cold.

For fuck's sake, Catra thought, swallowing against the dread that rose like bile in her throat. *What now?*

Shadow Weaver stopped a few paces away. Without speaking, she sized Catra up from head to toe. The disdain in her gaze was unmistakable, but there was something else there too. Something Catra couldn't quite place.

Finally, Shadow Weaver stabbed a sharp finger in Catra's direction. Catra flinched.

"Gather your things," Shadow Weaver growled. "You're coming with me."

*

When Adora arrived at the Horde's garage headquarters that morning, she was actually grateful to find Entrapta waiting for her with a long list of tasks that needed attention. The mountain of work was a welcome distraction from the complicated feelings she'd been wrestling with since waking up alone.

It's not that it was unlike Catra to slink off, but for some reason, Adora had expected her to stay — or at least say goodbye before heading back to the warehouse. She was both hurt and worried, but there wasn't much she could do about it now.

"I can't believe how much amazing stuff you and your team found!" Entrapta exclaimed as they circled the impressive pile of technological junk that sat in the middle of the floor. "I'll be able to do a lot of great work with this!"

"Glad to hear it," Adora said, buoyed by the validation of a job well done. "What do you need now?"

Entrapta smiled apologetically. "I need your help sorting through everything. I need to know what still works and what's just scrap. I'd do it myself, but Hordak wants to maximize my time in the lab."

"No problem." Adora nodded genially, though on the inside she couldn't help but feel irritated. This kind of grunt work was hardly befitting of a Force Captain, and sorting through old microwaves and discarded laptops wasn't the kind of hard-hitting evidence the Rebellion needed to build a case against the Horde. But whining about it wouldn't help either, so she plastered on a smile instead. "I'll have this taken care of in no time."

"Thanks, Adora. I really appreciate it!" Entrapta gave her an enthusiastic thumbs-up. "Come find me when you're done!"

As she watched the sweetheart mad scientist retreat to her lab, Adora was suddenly struck with the realization that she'd just missed the perfect opportunity to make a recording. She was going to have to get a lot better at making use of her new phone. After a quick glance around to ensure no one was watching, she turned her back to the security camera and snapped a few quick photos of the pile of junk, then got to work.

The work was tedious and the pile sizable, but soon Adora lost herself to the mindlessness of it all. She worked diligently, making thorough records of the items that worked and stacking them neatly by item type. Just because it was a boring job didn't mean she wasn't going to do her best at it.

She was about halfway through when she heard the door that led from the main garage slam open. Shadow Weaver blew into the room, and Adora did a double-take when she realized that Catra was following in her wake. Her backpack hung over the shoulder of her good arm, and she glanced around the room warily. When her gaze met Adora's, Catra perked up.

Adora gestured with her hands and mouthed the words, *what's going on?*

Catra only had time to shrug before she was ushered through the second set of doors.

It was nearly impossible to concentrate after that. The care Adora had given to her task earlier was derailed as she kept glancing at the door, waiting for something to happen. Her mind was racing: had Shadow Weaver found out that Catra had ditched work the day before? Was Catra in trouble? What was happening back there?

After what felt like an eternity, the door swung open again. This time, Shadow Weaver and Catra were joined by Hordak, who looked as disinterested as always. He talked to Shadow Weaver as the three of them strode across the room, back toward the garage. Catra was between them, her face turning back and forth between Shadow Weaver and Hordak, listening as they spoke over her. Adora tried to catch her eye, but it was no use; they pushed through the door that led to the garage, and Adora was left to wonder.

The rest of her day passed in distraction. Every so often, Adora reached for her phone, only to remember that she couldn't just text Catra the way she could with Glimmer and Bow. By the time Entrapta sent Adora home at the end of the day, Adora was almost sick with worry. This was something she did often: working herself up to the point of nausea. But in this case, she felt justified. Why had Shadow Weaver brought Catra to HQ? What was going on?

As soon as was off duty, Adora headed straight for the warehouse. She hammered the pattern onto the door and bounced in place with nervous energy until the door finally swung open.

"Adora?" Lonnie watched with wide-eyed surprise as Adora hurried inside. "What are you doing here?"

“Hey, Lonnie,” Adora replied. She was out of breath from running most of the way. “Is Catra here?”

Kyle and Rogelio, who had clearly been sitting around keeping Lonnie company on her sentry duty, shared a startled glance.

“We thought she was with you,” Kyle said.

“With me?” Adora’s stomach dropped.

Lonnie folded her arms. Though her body language was tough, the furrow of her brow gave away a hint of concern. “Yeah. Shadow Weaver picked her up this morning. Made her take all of her stuff and everything. We haven’t seen her since.”

“You don’t think they kicked her out, do you?” Kyle fretted. Rogelio laid a reassuring hand on his small friend’s shoulder but said nothing.

Even though alarm bells were screaming in her mind, Adora fought to keep expression calm and impassive.

“No, I’m sure it’s nothing like that,” Adora said, though she hardly believed it herself. “I’m sure Shadow Weaver just had a job for her and she hasn’t finished yet.”

She made a flimsy excuse about needing to be somewhere and said goodnight to her friends. As soon as the warehouse door closed behind her, Adora took off in a mad sprint. She funneled her panicked energy into her run, letting the fire in her lungs and the pounding of her feet calm her nerves as her mind swirled with worst case scenarios.

Adora couldn’t help catastrophizing. She knew Shadow Weaver didn’t like Catra. What if, with Adora promoted and away from the warehouse, she’d finally done something about it? What if Kyle was right, and Catra had been ousted from the Horde? If she had, that could only mean one thing, and it was the worst thing Adora could imagine.

With no idea of what to do next, Adora headed back to the hotel. Maybe, she reasoned, one of the other Force Captains would know how to get a hold of Shadow Weaver. She was almost in tears by the time she spilled from the staircase onto her floor. Weak with exhaustion and worry, Adora staggered to her room to compose herself in private before continuing her search. Collapsing onto her bed, Adora finally let herself cry. She sobbed into her pillow, exorcising her fear like a demon.

She still had her face buried into that comforting softness when she heard a knock at the door. This was hardly a good time, and Adora had half a mind to ignore the visitor altogether. But the knocking was insistent, so Adora wiped her eyes, stomped across the room, and yanked the door open with a scowl.

Everything happened at once. Before she could give the incessant knocker a piece of her mind, the person on the other side of the door spoke first.

"Hey, Adora."

Chapter 10

Catra stood in the hallway, bracing herself against the doorframe with her forearm. A teasing smile played across her lips at the sight of Adora's face.

"Geeze, don't look so happy to see me," Catra said.

Adora launched forward and wrapped her in a hug. "Where have you been? What happened today? Are you okay?"

"Woah, woah!" Catra squirmed out of Adora's embrace. "Relax. What's gotten into you?"

"Are you serious?" Adora couldn't seem to keep her voice down. "First, you left without saying goodbye this morning, then you showed up at headquarters with Shadow Weaver, and then nobody knew where you were! I was worried she kicked you out or something."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Why would you think that?"

"Because Shadow Weaver's crazy!"

At this, Catra let out a squeaky laugh. "Okay, you're not wrong there. But, no, I wasn't kicked out. I mean, obviously, because I'm still alive."

This was the source of so much of Adora's worry. As she'd explained to Angella, leaving the Horde wasn't as simple as handing in your resignation. Once you were in, you were in for life. And if you weren't in—be it by your choice or theirs—the Horde would make sure you didn't have a chance to tell anyone what you knew about their operations.

Adora gave Catra a shove and wiped away the tears that still clung to her lashes. "Well, I know that now. Are you going to tell me what's going on or not?"

By way of reply, Catra held up a small key. For a split-second, Adora thought it was her own room key, and that perhaps Catra lifted it from her pocket during their embrace. But a quick pat of her pocket showed the key still safe where it had been stowed, which meant…

"Did Shadow Weaver give you your own room?" Adora squawked. "Like, here?"

"Yup." Catra grinned. "And that's not all. Guess who got a promotion?"

"Shadow Weaver made you a Force Captain?" Adora shouted in disbelief. It was impossible to hide her shock.

"Damn right she did!" Catra tugged Adora from her room and led her down the hall to a door at the very far end. Using her key, she unlocked the door to reveal the room she had been given. Adora gaped in disbelief. The room was a touch bigger than her own — not by much, but enough so that Adora noticed. And, because it was a corner unit, the room boasted two windows, one of which Catra bounded to and threw open. She leaned against the window pane and stuck her face out into the evening air.

"Isn't this awesome?" she said, smiling back at Adora over her shoulder. She looked genuinely delighted by her unexpected good fortune, and perhaps under different circumstances, Adora would have been just as happy for her. Instead, she strode across the room and pulled Catra away from the window.

"What did they make you do?" she asked in a hushed voice.

Catra tipped her head. "What do you mean?"

"For your initiation," Adora pressed.

"Oh, nothing yet." Catra shrugged. "Shadow Weaver said they'll wait until I turn 18. Did you know I'm the youngest Force Captain *ever*?"

Something bloomed in Adora's chest, and she didn't like it at all. It was an ugly and petty, and it was stopping her from feeling as proud of Catra as she knew she should have.

"I don't get it," she blurted. "What happened? Why did they suddenly decide to promote you out of the blue before you're even of age?"

At this, Catra recoiled. Her bright smile twisted into a scowl, and Adora realized she'd hit a nerve.

"Why does it matter?" Catra snapped defensively. "Isn't this what we always planned? Both of us moving up in the ranks of the Horde together?" She crossed her arms and looked away, clearly stung. "Geeze, Adora. I thought you'd be more excited about this."

"I am! I swear, I just…" Adora let out a sigh and rubbed her eyes. "I'm sorry, Catra, Five minutes ago I was having a full-blown panic attack because I thought Shadow Weaver had done something terrible to you. I think I'm just in shock." She put on her widest smile and reached for Catra's hand. "But I'm glad you're okay and I am excited about your promotion, I swear. I just wish I'd seen it coming — I didn't have a chance to get you anything to celebrate."

Catra's rigid posture softened. At last, she laid her hand in Adora's waiting palm. "Eh, whatever. I'm just glad to be out of that dump. Just try to save some hot water for my showers and we'll call it even."

That night, Adora slept in Catra's bed. Despite having their own rooms, they both slept better when the other was close. Streetlight streamed in from the dual windows, and Adora used it to watch Catra sleep. That ugly feeling still coiled inside of her like a snake waiting to strike. If she was being honest with herself, she was jealous. Jealous that Catra, who never really seemed to care about getting promoted, was made Force Captain so early. It was a privilege Adora had worked hard for.

She hated herself for feeling this way. Catra was her best friend — her entire world. She should have been happy for her without having to force it, and the fact that she did have to force it left her feeling ashamed.

But there was more to it than that: something about this whole set-up didn't feel right. As she laid there, watching the gentle rise and fall of Catra's breathing, Adora couldn't help but wonder what she was missing.

*

Adora was feeling a bit better by the following morning. She was happy to wake up with Catra again, and the familiarity of their old morning routines—teasing and laughing as they brushed their teeth and got ready for the day—was actually comforting.

They walked to the garage together, hurrying under dark clouds in hopes of beating the impending rain. The first few drops splattered the sidewalk just as the girls arrived, giggling under their hoods and shoving one another in what had turned into a race. Because Adora could tell that Catra was still recovering from her infection scare, she let her win.

By now, the people who worked in the garage were used to seeing Adora around. They jutted their chins and nodded as she strode across the floor. She caught herself standing a little taller, holding her head a little higher, finally feeling like the full-fledged member of the Horde that she was. Catra stayed pinned to Adora's side. She clocked each face in the room with a wary, scrutinizing glare, as if daring any of them to make trouble for her.

"Relax," Adora whispered to her. "You're supposed to be here."

"I know," Catra muttered back. "I'm just making sure they know it too."

In the back room, they found Shadow Weaver, Hordak, and Entrapta together, deep in conversation. Curiosity burned at Adora's core. With her hand in her pocket, she felt for her phone

and wondered how successful she'd be if she tried to maneuver to the voice memo app without looking. She made a mental note to practice the technique later when she was alone.

Entrapta's magenta eyes spotted Adora, and her face lit up.

"Adora!" she cried, her voice filling the entire room. As she waved, Shadow Weaver and Hordak turned. Adora smiled through her disappointment, releasing her grip on her phone.

I guess I won't be recording that conversation, she thought.

"So glad you're here," Entrapta said. She raised the tablet that she always seemed to have on hand, and opened a long list of bulleted items. "We've got a lot to get through today." Her eyes flicked to Catra. "Oh. You're new."

Catra opened her mouth—no doubt to make some kind of sarcastic remark—but Hordak cut her off.

"This is our newest Force Captain," he said without looking at her. "We need to be ready to manage the increased output once your machines are fully operational."

Shadow Weaver nodded. "Catra has been promoted to assist with preparations."

This seemed to satisfy Entrapta, who somehow managed to smile even wider. "Oooh, fun!"

Adora pressed her lips into a tight line. She had been so caught up in her jealousy the night before that she hadn't even considered this perfectly logical explanation for Catra's promotion. The smoldering embers of shame she'd fought to tamp down reignited into a new blaze. She smiled at Catra by way of an apology that her friend didn't even realize she was owed.

"So, what are we working on?" Catra asked, leaning in to get a better look at the task on Entrapta's tablet.

“Oh, those aren’t for you,” Shadow Weaver said. There was a hint of something devious in her voice that made Adora shudder involuntarily. “For your first assignment, you’ll be assisting with our records.”

“Seriously?” Catra whined. “An office job?”

Adora jabbed her in the ribs with her elbow. Taking the hint, Catra shrank back.

“Thank you, Shadow Weaver,” Catra grumbled.

Meanwhile, Adora was buzzing. That office job was the one she needed to be doing. Her mind raced at the kinds of documents Catra was about to have access to; the treasure trove of damning evidence that would be at her sharp-nailed fingertips. For the first time since deciding to take down the Horde, Adora considered reading Catra in on her plan. They’d get a lot more done if they worked together.

But, no. The less Catra knew about what Adora was planning, the safer she’d be in the long run. Adora was just going to have to find another way to get her hands on incriminating material herself.

As Shadow Weaver beckoned for Catra to follow, Adora grabbed her best friend’s hand and gave it a squeeze.

“I’m proud of you,” she whispered.

Catra smiled. “Gracias, monita.”

*

The girls didn’t see each other for the rest of the day. Adora spent most of it curled over a workbench, carefully extracting key components from the tech she’d sorted. By the time she was finally allowed to go home, the sun had set and Catra was apparently long gone. Adora trudged home, her back and neck

aching after the many hours hunched in the same position. She made a mental note to ask Entrapta how she managed.

She schlepped up the hotel stairs and down the hall to her room. The floor was busier at this time of day, with loud music and raucous laughter sounding from every other room. Some doors were open, and Force Captains drifted from room to room visiting with one another as if they were on an indoor bar crawl. Adora shuffled past all of it, unlocked her own door and flopped face-first onto the bed.

Though it wasn't her intention to fall asleep, fully clothed with her backpack still on, she must have dozed off. The next thing she knew, a smoky voice whispered in her ear.

"Hey, Adora."

With a shriek of surprise, Adora scrambled up to sit while Catra sat cackling on the mattress beside her.

"What the hell, Catra?" Adora snapped, giving her friend a shove. "You scared the shit out of me!"

"I know!" Catra was still laughing. "It was amazing!" She wiped away the stray tears that had pooled in the corners of her eyes and steadied her breath. "How long have you been home? I've been waiting for you."

Still groggy, Adora almost reached for her phone to check the time. She caught herself at the last second, and turned the gesture into an awkward stretch instead.

"Not long," she said through a yawn.

"Have you eaten yet?"

"You know I haven't."

Grinning, Catra reached off the bed and picked something off the floor: two cups of instant ramen.

They were the same brand as the cup Adora had with her on that fateful night she and Catra met for the first time.

It was the first hot meal she'd had since running away from her foster home. Eager to enjoy it in peace, Adora—so small and alone—slipped into an alley and settled next to a discarded box to eat. She was lifting that first, tantalizing bite to her lips when she heard a low growl coming from somewhere over her shoulder. It sounded like an animal, and for a split-second, Adora thought she was going to have to fight off a raccoon or rat for her dinner. But when she dared look back, she found instead a small face peering over the edge of the box: cheeks smeared with dirt and freckles, a wild mane of knotted brown hair, and dual-colored eyes that darted between her and the ramen clutched in her hands.

It took a bit of coaxing to lure the small girl out. For starters, she didn't seem to speak English, instead grumbling in Spanish under her breath as she eyed Adora with suspicion. But Adora could also tell she was wary — life on the streets would do that to a person. Eventually, the girl's hunger won out, and soon the pair was huddled side by side. Adora shared her ramen, and Catra shared her box. They had been inseparable ever since.

Adora gasped at the sight of those twin cups in Catra's hands.

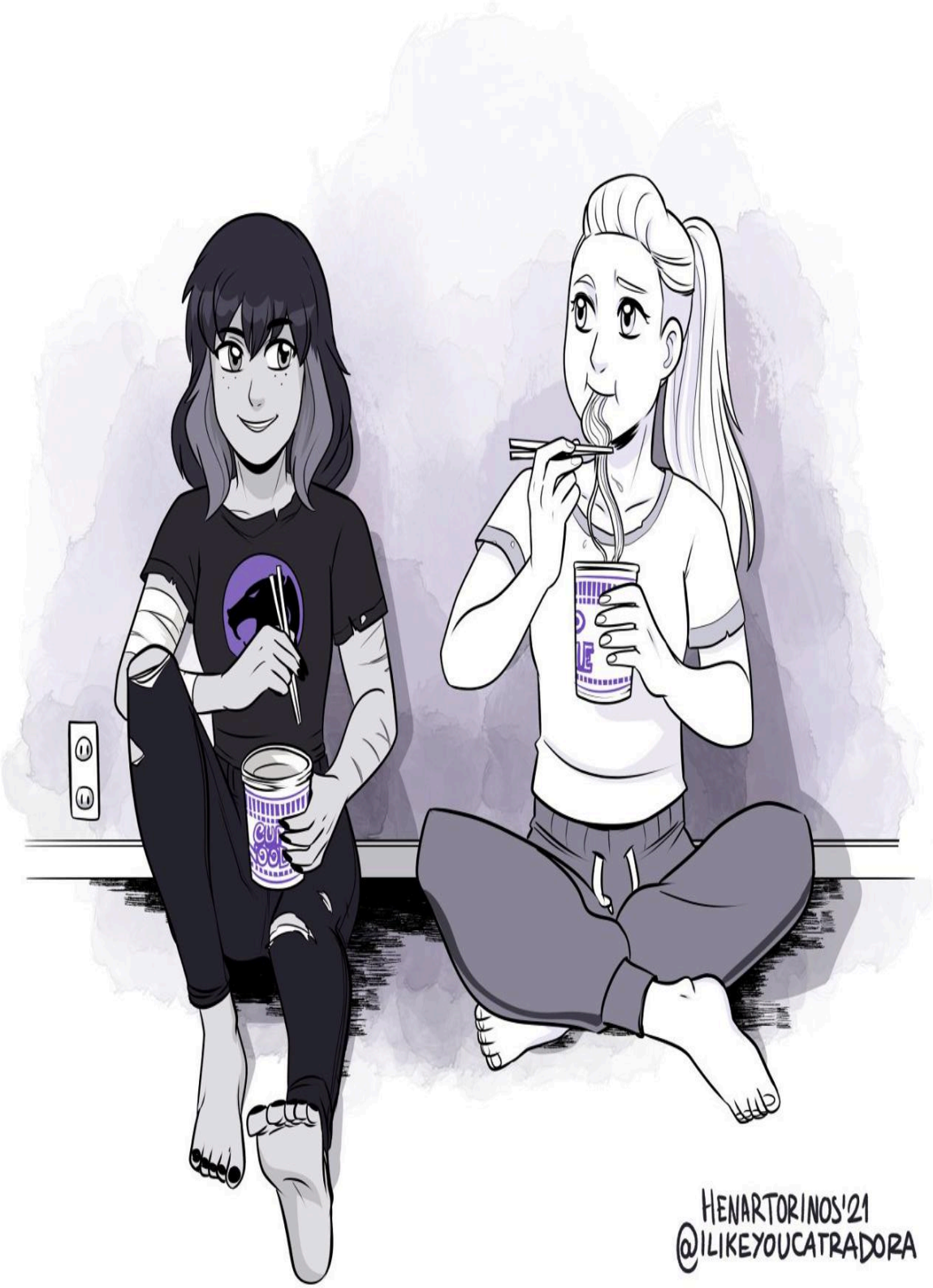
"Yes!" she cried, so happy she thought she might cry. "Where did you get them? Did you get paid already?"

This was one of the other perks of being a Force Captain: not only did you get your own room, but the Horde actually started paying you too. It wasn't much—typically just enough to keep oneself fed—but it was better than having to beg and steal all of the time.

Catra rolled her eyes. "No, dummy. You really think Shadow Weaver would pay me on my first day? I lifted these from a bodega. C'mon, let's get some water."

Without a kettle, the girls had to rely on hot water from the tap. But when you spent your entire life going without, something as

simple as instant ramen in hot tap water was a sweet luxury. Just like their first night together, Adora and Catra settled side by side on the floor and ate like queens.



“So?” Adora said through a mouthful. “How was your first day as a Force Captain? Tell me everything.”

Catra swallowed and wiped her mouth with the back of her hand. “Honestly? Boring as fuck. I spent the whole day sorting through files and shredding old shit.” She lifted her hand and regarded her fingertips darkly. “I have so many papercuts.”

Adora hummed thoughtfully, choosing her words carefully. “I didn’t even realize the Horde kept records of stuff.”

“Oh, yeah,” Catra replied. “You should see the room I was working in. There are literally bankers boxes piled to the ceiling. That place would go up like a box of matches if there was ever a fire.”

“Wow. Did you read any of it?”

Catra’s brow furrowed. She averted her eyes down into her cup and took a moment before answering. “Yeah.”

Adora waited, but Catra didn’t elaborate. She pressed. “Well? What did you see?”

“I, uh, can’t tell you,” Catra replied, her gaze still stubborning trained on her ramen.

This took Adora aback. “What do you mean?”

“Shadow Weaver told me I’m not supposed to talk about anything I read when I’m working with the records. I mean, technically I’m not supposed to be reading any of it, but of course I’m gonna. But, yeah, I’m supposed to keep the details under wraps from everyone.” At last she met Adora’s gaze. “Even from you.”

Adora didn’t know what to say. Her mouth hung open in surprise. It wasn’t like Catra to listen to anyone, especially not Shadow Weaver. But more surprising than that was the fact that Catra was keeping anything from her at all. They usually told each other everything.

Of course, that wasn't true anymore. The weight of the phone in Adora's pocket was reminder enough of that. So she swallowed her pride and smiled.

"That's okay. I get it."

Catra shrugged. "For what it's worth, you're not missing anything. I haven't come across anything exciting. I'd much rather be doing what you're doing."

"Maybe if we ask real nice, Shadow Weaver will let us switch jobs for a day," Adora said, half-joking. "Y'know, just to keep things fresh."

"I wouldn't hold my breath," Catra laughed.

There didn't seem to be much to say after that. The girls ate the rest of their ramen in silence, each lost in thoughts they couldn't share.

BONUS!


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Chapter 11

It was cold inside the storage unit the Horde used to house their records. Something about the lack of natural light and concrete walls, coupled with the miserable weather outside, made the place feel like a tomb. Catra huddled deeper into her jacket for warmth and mindlessly thumbed her way through a stack of papers under the lamplight.

She wasn't lying when she told Adora that she hadn't come across anything interesting yet. Most of the files she'd sorted through so far were ancient, sometimes older than she was. Everything was dusty and boring — nothing more than page after page of invoices or accounting documents filled with line items she couldn't decipher. Shadow Weaver had given her vague parameters of things to look for and instructions of what to do from there. Files of a certain date and older went in one pile, and newer files were to be sorted by type. Clearly whoever was responsible for putting everything in this storage unit in the first place didn't give a shit about maintaining any sense of order.

What Catra really wanted to find was a stack of personnel files in among the chaos. She doubted there'd be anything recent in a place like this, but it would make for fun reading. Or maybe she'd find some payroll details that would give her a sense of how much she could make as a Force Captain. If she knew how much others were making, she'd know how much to demand from Shadow Weaver when the time was right. That was information Catra didn't mind sharing with Adora — after all, the more money they were making, the better off they'd be. As for the rest of it, she couldn't imagine Adora would find the details in this mountain of documents any more interesting than she did.

This is what Catra was thinking about when she heard the distinct clicking of high-heels approaching outside. She had just enough time to sit up straight and act like she'd been hard at work before the metal door was rolled up. Shadow Weaver stood, back-lit by the angry fluorescent lighting of the building's hallway. Her

silhouette loomed like a ghost, and Catra caught herself shrinking back involuntarily.

A look of surprise flitted across Shadow Weaver's mangled features.

"You're early," she said.

Catra shrugged. "New job, new me, I guess."

With a click of her tongue, Shadow Weaver used the hand that wasn't clutching a coffee cup to pull the door closed. "I highly doubt that."

Before Catra had a chance to feel bad about herself, Shadow Weaver set the cup down on the desk beside her. She then fished a small brown paper-wrapped parcel from her purse and wordlessly set it down next to the cup before breezing away to survey the stacks Catra had sorted the day before.

It took a moment before Catra could think of something to say.

"Are… Are these for me?" she asked cautiously.

Shadow Weaver shot her a withering glance over her shoulder before returning to the stacks.

"No, Catra. I brought breakfast for the roaches." Her words dripped with sarcasm.

Though it still felt like a trap, Catra carefully peeled back the corner of the brown paper. Inside the parcel was a peanut butter sandwich. This was, without question, the nicest thing Shadow Weaver had ever done for her.

"Thanks," she muttered, still flabbergasted by the gesture.

Shadow Weaver ignored her.

“Are these the financial statements from the last five years?” She gestured to a particular stack of documents and files.

Catra nodded. “What I’ve found so far, anyway.”

“How many boxes did you make it through yesterday?”

“Uh…” Catra glanced over at the stack of discarded boxes. “Six?”

“You need to work faster than that,” Shadow Weaver replied as she gathered the stack of financial statements. “At this rate, you’ll be at this for months. Make it ten boxes today.”

The idea of slogging through ten boxes in one day made Catra want to scream, but she didn’t dare complain. “Yes, Shadow Weaver.”

Before taking her leave, Shadow Weaver paused. “You haven’t spoken to anyone about what you’ve seen in these files, have you?”

“Of course not,” Catra replied.

“Not even Adora?”

“No.”

Shadow Weaver’s eyes narrowed. She regarded Catra in silence for a moment.

“Did she ask?”

Something about this question felt dangerous. Yesterday, when Shadow Weaver had sat Catra down and explained the assignment, she had been very particular about Adora.

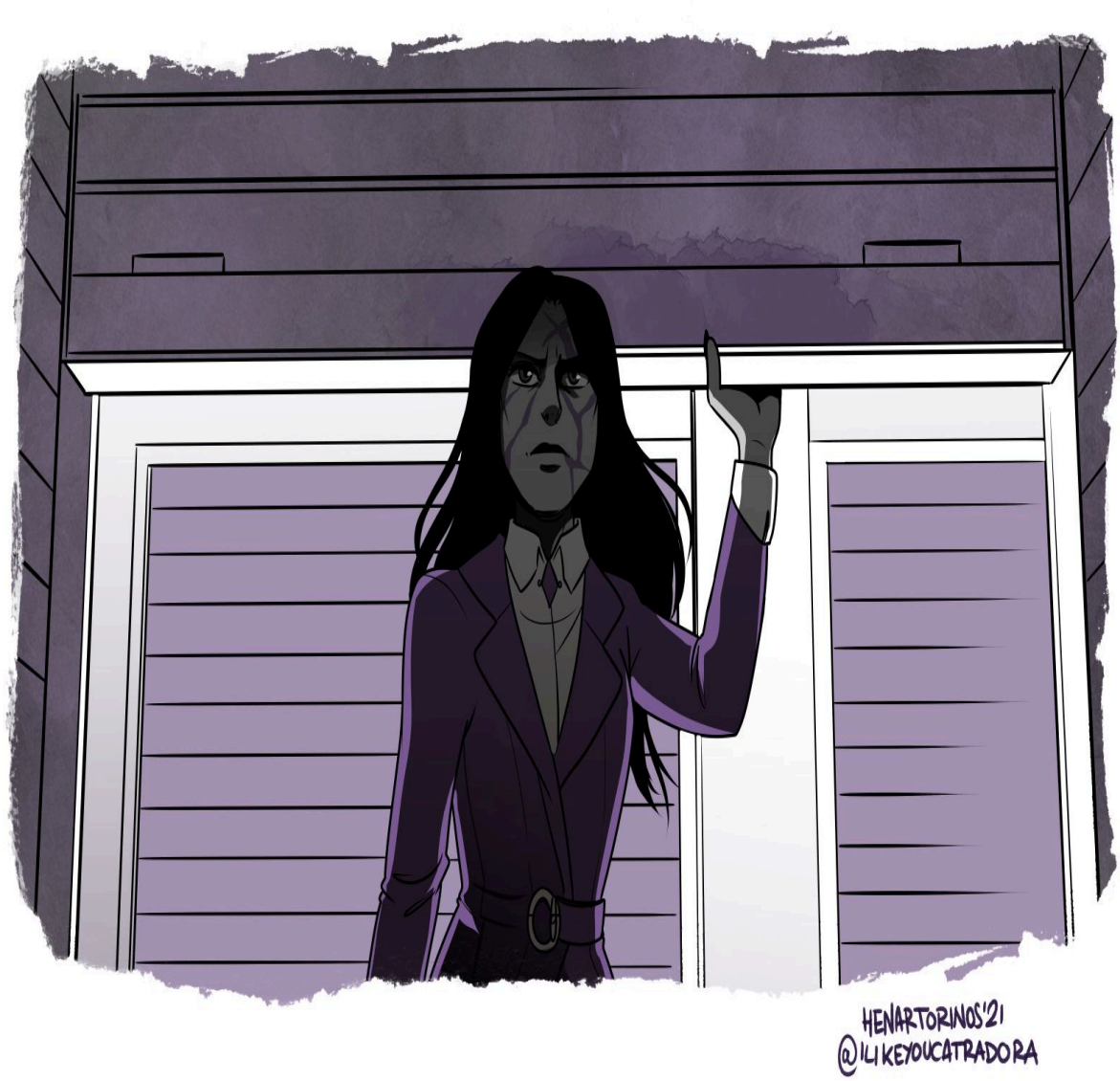
“You may find she wants to know the details of your work,” Shadow Weaver had cautioned. “She may pry more than usual. If you value your life, you will not say a word to her. Do you understand?”

Catra hadn't taken this vague threat very seriously at the time. She knew the Horde treated even the slightest whiff of betrayal with impunity (She was sporting the scars to prove it, after all.). And, of course, Adora did ask. Except now, with Shadow Weaver's words echoing in her mind, Catra found Adora's curiosity unsettling.

So, she lied. She shook her head and said, "This is Adora we're talking about. She knows better than that."

Shadow Weaver sniffed and pulled the unit door open.

"That's what I thought too," she said, before shutting Catra back into her tomb.



As the days passed, Adora and Catra fell into a predictable rhythm. Every morning they woke and walked to the garage together. In her mind, Adora liked to pretend they were just a normal pair of roommates, heading off to work their day jobs before returning home. Of course, in this fantasy, those day jobs were totally legal, and the home they shared was a cute apartment in the city instead of tiny gang-owned rooms in a run-down hotel.

A girl could dream.

Each day, they were split up. Catra would be spirited away to the Horde's record room—some mysterious place Adora still knew frustratingly little about—while Adora joined Entrapta in the lab.

Despite barely understanding half of what she was talking about, Adora actually enjoyed spending time with Entrapta. She'd become her unwitting lab partner, holding technical components in place while Entrapa soldered them together, or running to fetch tools based on description alone. It wasn't the most glamorous assignment, but Adora knew it could have been worse.

Perhaps the most interesting thing about being Entrapta's lab partner was how close it put Adora to Hordak. Growing up in the Horde, Hordak was the stuff of legend. He was whispered about like a ghost story around a campfire, and threats of his wrath were used to keep the kids in line. He ruled over the Horde with calculating precision. He was said to be as brilliant as he was merciless. All her life, Adora had been secretly terrified of him.

But now, Adora wasn't sure how she felt about him. She didn't doubt for a moment that he was the ruthless gang leader everyone said he was — on more than one occasion, Adora bore witness to his rage as he lashed out at people who disappointed him in one way or another. But when it came to Entrapta, the lion that was Hordak became a lamb. Adora watched in curious silence as he doted on his little scientist. He would listen to her explain her work in rapt attention, nodding and asking thoughtful questions that filled Entrapta with excitement. The pair would fall

into deep theoretical discussions about things Adora couldn't even pretend to understand, and so she'd sit quietly on her stool and watch the pair of them talk and pore over whatever Entrapta was showing him on the screen of her tablet.

And sometimes, when Entrapta was buried so deep in her work that she completely blocked the rest of the world out, Hordak would simply watch her. At first, Adora found it unnerving the way he studied Entrapta's single-minded focus. But there was a tenderness to his gaze that he seemed to reserve only for Entrapta, and as Adora watched this strange ritual of devotion play out between the two of them, she realized that perhaps she was in the right job after all.

I don't know if something's going on between them or what, Adora texted the group chat one evening as she waited for Catra to meet up with her at their usual spot. *But Entrapta's obviously important to Hordak.*

*Well, she *does* manufacture the Horde's most lucrative product*, Glimmer replied. *If I were him, I'd want to keep her close too.*

Adora wasn't sure how to explain what she was witnessing day in and day out. *It's more than that. I think he actually cares about her.*

So what's your plan? Bow asked. *Do you think you can use this to your advantage?*

Maybe, Adora replied. *Like, if they're close, maybe Entrapta knows something that could be helpful to us.*

Glimmer messaged back instantly. *That would be amazing*, followed by, *If you do get her to talk DON'T FORGET TO RECORD IT. The photos you've been sending are great, but without context, they're just pictures of stolen appliances and sciencey stuff.*

What about your friend? Bow added. *How is she doing in all of this?*

Yeah, has she told you anything useful yet?

Glimmer that's not what I meant.

Adora sighed. Ever since Catra's health scare, Glimmer and Bow had become endearingly invested in her wellbeing; like she was an interesting character in a story they were reading. Adora had told them about Catra's unexpected promotion, and lamented the fact that she wasn't willing to share the details of what she was working on.

No, and I'm not going to push it, Adora wrote. *I don't want to put her in an awkward position.*

All this talk of Catra brought Adora back to the present. She checked the time: it was getting late.

"What is taking her so long?" Adora muttered to herself. She glanced around the dark and mostly empty street. The days were getting colder, and Adora was shivering against the chill.

She didn't find Catra, but she did notice something else. A police cruiser idled quietly at the curb across the street, just out of the circle of light cast by the street lamp. Adora stiffened. How long had it been there? Whoever was inside was nothing more than a silhouette. Still, Adora could feel the cop inside watching her, and that lingering, invisible stare made her shiver for a whole different reason.

You're not doing anything wrong, she thought to herself as she slid her phone into her pocket and out of sight. *Relax.*

But it was always hard to relax with a cop nearby. Not for the first time, Adora wished Catra had a phone so she could call her and see what was taking her so long. She wasn't sure how much longer she could stand there under surveillance.

She was in the middle of contemplating stealing a phone for Catra when she heard running footsteps approaching up the sidewalk.

Heart rate racing, Adora whirled around just as Catra emerged from the gloom.

“Hey, Adora!” Catra called, waving as she approached. “Shadow Weaver kept me late.”

At that same moment, the cop car pulled back onto the street and drove away. Catra jumped at the sudden movement.

“Was that a cop?” she asked, watching the car recede over her shoulder.

“Yeah,” Adora replied. She kept her eyes on the car as she looped her arm with Catra’s and tugged her away. “They’ve just been sitting there watching me. Honestly, I was getting creeped out.”

There was something strange in the way Catra looked at her then — something guarded and uncertain. For a moment, it looked like she was going to say something, but then she shook her head and smiled.

“Fuck ‘em,” she said. “Let’s go home.”

Chapter 12

The following day, Adora decided to put her plan into action. She was determined to finally get some useful evidence to share with the Rebellion.

She loitered quietly in the corner of the lab, making herself look busy while Entrapta and Hordak whispered sweet sciency nothings to one another by the door. With her back to them, Adora found a discrete spot to set up her phone so that the camera had a perfect shot of the room. She piled things around it to keep it both upright and out of sight — odds and ends she knew Entrapta rarely used. Once she was satisfied with her set-up, she reached around and hit record. Now all she had to do was wait.

Hordak didn't stick around for much longer. He wished Entrapta a productive day and took his leave. Even though Adora wished she could have captured more of their conversation, she knew she had recorded at least a minute or two of both him and Entrapta together. That, she could only assume, would be a huge win.

"Today's a big day!" Entrapta chirped as she circled around her work bench. Grinning wide, she scooped Emily the rat from her shoulder and placed her lovingly on the table. "Are you ready?"

Adora hesitated for a moment. "Are you talking to me or Emily?"

Entrapta laughed. "Both of you! Today's the day we test out our new prototype. If my calculations are correct—and they are—we're about to manufacture three days worth of product in one morning!"

"Wow," Adora breathed, taking her place across from Entrapta. Emily scurried over and Adora scratched her behind the ears. "That's amazing."

"It sure is!" Entrapta was almost dancing with excitement. "I'm going to prepare the ingredients. Can you finish clearing off my

work station, please?"

"You got it."

Adora worked quickly, eager to get to the good part. She cleared her throat and tried to act natural. "Would you mind talking through the steps? I know I don't really understand all this science stuff, but I'm trying to learn."

Entrapta beamed over the plastic tub of beakers she was carrying to the workstation. "Of course! I'd never deny a curious mind from science!"

A twinge of guilt pulled at Adora's insides. Entrapta was so kind and genuine, it almost hurt to play her like this. In the back of her mind, Adora wondered how someone so smart and sweet ever got messed up with a gang like the Horde.

As Entrapta arranged her equipment and pulled on her safety gear, she prattled through every step of her process with breathless enthusiasm. She described the various chemical compounds she combined to produce the Horde's proprietary designer drug, known on the streets as Runestone.

"Have you ever tried it?" Adora asked. This was a question born more of her own curiosity than for reconnaissance purposes. For all the years she'd spent running the drug all over the city, she herself had never tried it. Something about the drug's regular users—the intensity of their lows after the highs, and the desperate way they'd do anything for it—told her it wasn't something she wanted to mess with.

"Oh, no," Entrapta replied, pulling her gas mask down over her face. "Runestone is highly addictive. I prefer to keep my mind clear for the sake of my work. Mask, please!"

Adora did as she was told, pulling on the spare mask she'd been given, as well as the intense set of safety gloves. She stood across from Entrapta, careful not to block the camera's view. Entrapta

got to work, carefully measuring and mixing various compounds and heating the resulting substance over a burner.

"Here comes the fun part!" she said, and Adora could tell by the tone of her voice that she really believed it. "Usually it takes hours for this chemical compound to synthesize. But with my device, we'll be able to cut down that processing time dramatically!"

The two of them worked together to lift one of the prototypes from its shelf and carried it to the bench. It was a bulky contraption, built into the chassis of an old printer. Entrapta pulled open one of the drawers previously used to hold paper. In the rebuild, they had lined it with a copper-based coating. Adora had spent days mining the stolen junk for copper components specifically for this purpose, and she felt a strange swell of pride to see her hard work fulfill its purpose. Of course, that pride was quickly replaced by guilt when she remembered that the purpose was to create highly addictive street drugs, but she pushed that down with the rest of her complicated feelings and focused on the task at hand.

At Entrapta's instruction, Adora helped her carefully transfer the compound from its beaker to the copper-lined drawer. It was a delicate process, what with the compound itself being so unstable. Sweat beaded on Adora's brow beneath her mask, her stomach tight with nerves. But the transfer was successful, and after gently sliding the drawer closed, Entrapta fired up the machine and sat back triumphantly.

"And now we wait!" she announced, gloved hands planted firmly on her hips. Emily poked her head out of the pocket of Entrapta's overalls and gave an excited squeak. "I'm going to sanitize the equipment — would you mind tidying up the rest of the lab? We've got about an hour before the test batch is ready, so you can take a break when you're done."

"No problem," Adora said brightly. She helped Entrapta gather the various beakers and tubes back into the tub before pulling off her mask. Once Entrapta left the room, Adora hurried back to the

corner and retrieved her phone. She stopped the recording and used her finger to trace over the tracking bar of the video, double checking that she had captured everything.

There, flashing across the screen in rapid motion, was the whole process from start to finish. Adora's heart hammered in her chest. Not wanting to waste another moment, she opened the Rebellion group chat and sent Glimmer and Bow a message.

I GOT IT!!! she wrote.

After an agonizing few minutes, Glimmer replied. *Got what?*

The evidence we've been waiting for. Adora attached the video and hit send. She waited.

And she waited.

A notification popped up that said the attachment failed to send.

Meanwhile, Glimmer texted: *???*

I can't get the video to send, Adora lamented.

It's probably too big, Bow offered. *Try uploading it to the cloud and send us the link instead.*

Adora paused. Her mind buzzed with white noise. She tipped her head back and frowned, wondering what the hell Bow was talking about.

The cloud??

She's not gonna know what that means Bow, Glimmer wrote.

Oh, right :(Bow replied. *Let's see, how can I explain this…*

Adora glanced over her shoulder. This was taking too long.

Guys, I don't think I have time for a tech lesson right now. I can't get caught with this phone.

How about we meet up tonight? Glimmer offered. *You can show us what you got and we'll show you how to upload files.*

Relieved to have a plan, Adora replied, *Perfect. Stone lions at 8?*

You bet!! Glimmer agreed.

Adora slid her phone back into the safety of her pocket. A wide grin pulled at her lips. Things were finally starting to come together.

*

Catra dumped an armful of documents into the oil drum and wiped her brow. Maybe Adora had been onto something when she talked about needing to get in better shape now that she was Force Captain. This job involved a lot more heavy lifting than Catra had anticipated.

With a grunt, she picked up the heavy red jerrycan at her feet and poured gasoline into the drum. The foul-smelling fuel splashed over the discarded paperwork, making Catra's stomach turn. Knowing her luck, she'd probably smell like gas for days after this.

Once the papers were saturated, Catra stepped back and pulled a book of matches from her pocket.

"Here goes nothin'," she muttered as she struck one of the matches and watched it flare to life. With a deft flick of her flingers, she sent the match soaring directly into the open oil drum. Its delicate contents immediately burst into flames that reached furiously skyward. Catra took another step back just to save herself from the intense heat of the inferno.

For a while, she stood alone, watching the fire burn. It was oddly calming, and the warmth was a welcome comfort against the early autumn chill. The sound of footsteps approaching made Catra turn.

"Is that everything?" Shadow Weaver asked, surveying the blaze.

“Yup,” Catra replied. She folded her arms. “I still don’t know why you had me spend all that time sorting through those files if you were just gonna have me destroy them though.”

“The information in those files was sensitive. We couldn’t risk them falling into the wrong hands.”

Catra couldn’t help but scoff. “Sounds a little paranoid, but okay.”

For a few long moments, Shadow Weaver said nothing. She simply stared into the flames. Catra glanced up, watching the fire light play across the scars that crisscrossed the old woman’s face.

As a child, back before she knew better, those scars had terrified Catra. Shadow Weaver never spoke of them, but there were plenty of rumors that floated through the Horde about how she got them. Though each story was a little different, they all came back to the same thing: Shadow Weaver had done something to cross the Horde, and now she forever wore the evidence of her failure for all to see. Those scars were a warning to them all; the price of wronging the Horde was steep.

“Hordak recognizes your hard work,” Shadow Weaver said at last, still gazing at the blazing oil drum. Flecks of charred paper drifted through the air, making the scene look like some post-apocalyptic fallout. “As do I.”

“Oh.” Catra shifted. She still wasn’t used to being on the receiving end of Shadow Weaver’s praise and good graces, no matter how modest the gestures were. She wasn’t sure how to react. “Thanks.”

“This is why I have a new assignment for you.” At last, Shadow Weaver pulled her gaze from the fire and trained it on Catra. “It’s important, and it’s something only you can do.”

A thrill raced up Catra’s spine. If she’d known slogging through paperwork was all it would take to finally get the chance to prove herself as worthy, Catra would have done it years ago. She

straightened up and turned so she could face Shadow Weaver head-on.

“I’m ready.”

Shadow Weaver lifted her hand and placed it against Catra’s cheek. Instinctively, Catra flinched. But the gesture was tender, and it captured her attention completely.

“I need you to listen to me, Catra,” Shadow Weaver said, her voice urgent. “Because you’re not going to like what I’m about to tell you.”

Catra smirked. “Try me.”

A pause hung between them as Shadow Weaver searched Catra’s face, her own expression impassive.

Then she spoke.

“Adora is a traitor.”

Catra blinked. In a way, she felt like she was still waiting for Shadow Weaver to say something, because there was no way she’d actually uttered those four words. Catra reasoned that she must have blacked out, or maybe the overwhelming funk of burning gasoline was playing tricks on her mind. She gaped up at Shadow Weaver.

“What?”

“Surely you’ve noticed,” Shadow Weaver continued. “The way she pries for information, her hesitance.”

“No.” Catra shook her head. She laughed—seriously laughed—right in Shadow Weaver’s face. “That’s just Adora being Adora. She’s just trying to get a feel for this whole Force Captain thing. Adora would never—”

“Our sources say she’s working with the police.” Shadow Weaver cocked her head. “That she has been for some time.”

Blood rushed in Catra’s ears. No. There had to be some mistake. Someone was trying to sewer Adora — planting false information to get her into trouble. That had to be what was happening, because Adora would never—

“They’re wrong,” Catra insisted with absolute certainty.

Shadow Weaver said nothing. She pulled back and folded her hands neatly. She waited, letting the silence hang between them.

Catra faltered. “I’m telling you, they’re wrong. If you’re asking me to spill on Adora, you’re going to be disappointed, because there’s nothing to say. Don’t you think I’d know if she was working with the cops?”

“Poor child,” Shadow Weaver said with a condescending click of her tongue. “Adora really hasn’t told you, has she? And to think the two of you used to be so close.”

This cut through Catra like a knife. The world around her seemed to spin, and for a split-second, she thought she might black out for real this time. Little things started to click in her mind: Adora’s early morning run, the disappointment on her face when Catra wouldn’t tell her what was on the documents she was sorting, the strange bottle of antibiotics with the name ‘Glimmer Brightmoon’ on the label.

She pulled in a deep, smoke-filled breath.

Brightmoon.

The same family name as Etheria’s chief of police.

“If you’re so certain, then you’ll have no qualms with proving me wrong,” Shadow Weaver said, her smooth voice cutting through Catra’s roaring inner panic. “Your assignment is to find out what she’s up to.”

Catra lifted her eyes. She could feel them watering, the threat of tears quivering along her lash line. “I can’t do that.”

Shadow Weaver placed a finger beneath Catra’s chin and used it to tip her face upward.

“I know it hurts, Catra. I know you don’t want to believe me.” She closed her other hand around Catra’s arm—the same one she’d carved up only a couple weeks earlier—and squeezed. With her grip, she pulled Catra closer and bent down to whisper in her ear. “But if she has been deceiving you, wouldn’t you want to know?”

The question careened through Catra’s brain as if it had been shouted at her. Would she want to know? She couldn’t fathom a reality in which Adora did something so reckless — a reality in which she kept something so important from her.

Shadow Weaver straightened up and dusted some of the floating ash from her jacket.

“Remember, Catra: the Horde is your family. Family does not betray one another. If I’m wrong, then we have nothing to worry about.” She stepped around Catra, then glanced back. “But if I’m right, I trust you to do the right thing.”

I trust you. How long had Catra wanted to hear those words?

“Don’t forget to douse the embers before you leave for the day,” Shadow Weaver called over her shoulder as she strode away. “We don’t want to burn the whole city down, now do we?”

Catra wasn’t sure how long she stood there, staring into the flames and fists clenched at her sides, thinking that maybe everything would be better if she did exactly that.


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Chapter 13

Catra didn't remember the walk home. One minute she was pouring buckets of water over the smoldering remains of her illegal bonfire, and the next she was trudging down the hallway to her room. She stopped at Adora's door. She stared at it without blinking, her mind filled with white noise.

As if possessed, her hand seemed to lift of its own accord. She knocked. There was a shuffling on the other side of the door, followed by the sound of the deadbolt sliding. Adora yanked the door open and her face split into a wide and warm smile.

"There you are!" she said brightly. Her eyes scanned Catra's face and her brows furrowed. "Yikes, what happened to you?"

This broke the spell. Catra blinked. "Huh?"

Adora laughed and laid her hands on either side of Catra's face. "You're filthy and you reek of gasoline. What is this?"

She wiped her thumbs across Catra's cheeks, and time seemed to slow to a crawl. Catra's skin crackled with an invisible electricity under Adora's touch. She wondered if she could feel it. And when Adora pulled her hands back, Catra felt herself aching to pull them back.

"Is this… soot?" Adora asked, examining the smudge on her thumbs. "Did Shadow Weaver have you cleaning chimneys today or what?"

Catra blinked. She wiped a hand down her face and saw that it came back smeared with black ash. It hadn't occurred to her that she'd been wearing the evidence of her day's work.

"Oh, yeah. I was burning stuff today."

"Really?" Adora's interest seemed immediately piqued. "What?"

It was an innocent enough question. Under different circumstances, Catra wouldn't have thought twice about it. Hell, she would have asked the same thing.

But now, with Shadow Weaver's warning echoing in her mind, the question made Catra's stomach drop. She swallowed drily.

"Just trash," she lied. Her heart pounded. "I guess it's easier to burn it than haul it down to the dump like normal people."

Adora smirked. "Yeah, well, there's nothing normal about the Horde, is there?"

"I guess not," Catra mumbled. She stared at her hand to avoid looking at Adora. She felt sick.

"Hey, princess," Octavia called from down the hall. She was standing by the bathroom door, wrapped in a towel and dripping water all over the worn carpet. "You're up."

Adora responded with a nod, then turned her attention back to Catra. "Wanna switch? I don't mind showering last if you want to get cleaned up."

A flood of warmth flooded Catra from the bottom up, buoying her spirits just enough to drown out the doubt. Of course Adora was willing to give up her claim to what little hot water remained — that's who she was. Adora was good and caring and there was no way in hell she was double-crossing the Horde. Catra knew Adora would never hurt her like that. Shadow Weaver was just going to have to deal with the fact that her source fed her bad intel.

"Nah, I can wait," Catra replied with a smile. "You go ahead."

"If you insist!" Adora grabbed her towel from the back of her door. "I'll make it quick — I actually have another quick assignment tonight, but I want to hang out a bit before I have to leave. You can chill in my room if you want."

The nagging uncertainty surfaced yet again. Catra felt her conviction falter. She waved it off and covered it with one of her practiced cheeky grins as she pushed her way into the room.

"I'm gonna rub my sooty face all over your pillow."

Adora laughed. "Please don't."

Catra watched her disappear behind the door. She sank to the floor with a sigh and considered the situation. There was nothing inherently suspicious about an evening assignment; it's not like being a Force Captain was a 9 to 5 job.

As she wrestled with the nagging in her mind, a strange sound caught Catra's attention. It was a light muffled buzz. She looked to the bed, where the sound seemed to be coming from, and her eyes caught on Adora's backpack, which had been shoved underneath. A dim glow emanated from the gaping zipper. Without thinking, Catra reached for it.

It was a phone.

Catra's stomach dropped.

She probably stole it from the junk pile in Entrapta's lab, she reasoned with herself as she turned the sleek device over in her hands. When she righted it, the phone's screen lit up to reveal a waiting text message.

From: Glimmer

Bow's going to pick me up in 20 minutes. See you soon!

Immediately, Catra's mind snapped to the bottle of antibiotics. The name 'Glimmer Brightmoon' felt like it was being screamed at her.

Catra felt dizzy.

"No," she murmured, her hands shaking. "No, no, no…" She tried to open the phone, but it asked for a password. Catra wracked her

brain. She tapped in Adora's favorite number: the full numeric date of the day she and Catra were brought into the Horde.

The phone flashed to the home screen.

Having messed around with phones before—usually the ones she stole from the pockets and purses of unassuming morons—Catra had a pretty decent idea of how to work this one. She navigated to the messaging app. There was only one conversation open — a group chat with this Glimmer and someone else named Bow. Catra scrolled back and read through from the beginning.

The blood in her veins turned to ice. Panic rose from the pit of her stomach. When she got to the part about the video, she closed the messenger and found the camera roll. There were dozens of photos, mostly of the junk they'd collected for Entrapta, but also some of the lab and the back room of Horde HQ. But there was one, right in the middle of everything else, of Catra. In it, she was fast asleep on Adora's pillow.

Catra shook her head and blinked back tears as she swiped away from the photo. The video she was looking for was the most recent file, and it was huge. Knowing she didn't have time to watch the whole thing, Catra swiped over the tracking bar to get a sense of what she was missing. Adora must have recorded it in secret; frame after frame of her and Entrapta making Runestone flashed across the screen. The whole process was captured, from start to finish.

The phone felt radioactive in Catra's hands.

Heart racing, she found the settings app and frantically tapped around until she found what she was looking for.

Are you sure you want to restore to factory settings? The phone asked.

Catra didn't think twice. She tapped 'yes' and watched the screen turn a blinding white.

Only after the damage was done did she stop to wonder what she was doing.

Shadow Weaver was right: Adora was a traitor. What was she hoping to achieve by erasing the phone? Was she protecting Adora from herself? Or was she protecting the Horde from Adora?

Inside, Catra felt like a battlefield on which rage and betrayal fought for dominance. The clash ripped a hole in her heart.

She returned the phone to the backpack and kicked the whole thing back under the bed. Her mind raced, wondering what to do next.

Just then, the door swung open. Adora slid into the room, her cheeks flushed from the shower and her long blonde hair hanging damp and loose around her shoulders.

"I don't think hot showers will ever stop being amazing," Adora said as she gave her hair one last scrub before hanging her towel up to dry. Catra used this momentary distraction to compose herself. She slouched back, propped herself on her elbows, and did her best to look unaffected.

"I'm sure I'd be horny for them too if you ever left me any hot water," she said, hoping Adora couldn't sense the slight tremble in her voice.

"Oh, please! I don't take that long."

With an air of indifference, Catra asked, "So, what's the assignment you're running tonight?"

Adora, who was busy pulling her hair back into her trademark ponytail, grinned mischievously. "You're not the only one who has to keep her work secret."

No shit, Catra thought bitterly.

“Actually, now that you mention it, I should probably head out.” Adora chewed her bottom lip. “I guess I did take too long in the shower after all.”

Catra didn’t respond. She didn’t even react when Adora turned on that dazzling smile of hers. Adora dropped into a crouch in front of her.

“I shouldn’t be long,” she said. “Do you think you’ll still be up when I get back?”

“It’s not even 8 o’clock yet,” Catra replied. She was having to fight to keep from snapping. “Of course I’ll still be awake.”

This seemed to appease Adora. She reached beneath the bed and pulled out her backpack. For a heartstopping moment, Catra held her breath, fearful that Adora might realize the bag had been disturbed or, worse still, that she might reach for the phone.

Instead, Adora slung the backpack over her shoulders and stood back up. She held her hand out to Catra. “Cool! Do you want to hang in here or—”

“Nah, I’m going to clean up,” Catra said, cutting her off. She ignored Adora’s hand and stood up on her own. Adora’s smile faltered, and for a split-second, her expression brought Catra a savage sense of satisfaction. Plastering on a fake smile of her own, Catra raised her sooty hands and wiggled her fingers. “I am filthy, after all.”

She followed Adora out into the hall, waving over her shoulder as she pretended to head to her room to retrieve her towel. When she reached her door, Catra lingered and waited for Adora to disappear down the stairwell. She counted to three and took a deep, steadying breath before dashing down the hall to follow her.

Years of pickpocketing and stealing had gifted Catra with the ability to slip through the world unnoticed. With her hood raised and her fists buried deep in her pockets, Catra slinked through the shadows and followed Adora from a safe distance. She kept her

steps light as they wound deeper into the city, out of the gritty neighborhoods they called home and into the more polished streets where proper, everyday people lived. Catra wove through the window shoppers and the clusters of people who loitered outside of restaurants, waiting for a table or smoking cigarettes. All the while, she kept Adora firmly in her sights. Wherever she was going, Catra was determined to follow.

It only took a few blocks for Catra to realize what their destination was: the park.

Their park.

A fresh flare of anger scorched her insides at the thought of Adora turning one of their favorite spots into a meeting place for her shady business. Sure enough, as they approached the stone lions Catra spotted a pair of people waiting. She knew the short girl with the pink hair was Glimmer right away: she looked so much like her mother, Chief Angella Brightmoon. At her side stood a boy with flawless dark skin and a toned set of abs peeking out beneath the cropped top he wore beneath an open jacket.

Any hope that this was all just a big misunderstanding evaporated as Catra watched Adora break into a sprint to reach the pair. When they spotted her, they opened their arms wide and pulled Adora into a hug. The rage at Catra's core threatened to burn her alive.

The three were so consumed with one another that Catra was able to slink along the park's stone fence without detection. She pressed herself into the shadows and crept closer, inch by careful inch. Soon, she was close enough to hear what they were saying.

"It actually worked?" the boy asked, a note of awe in his voice. "She was seriously able to use scrap parts to build a device for synthesizing Runestone? That's… that's amazing!"

Glimmer clicked her tongue disapprovingly. "Bow! She's a criminal making dangerous drugs! You shouldn't be impressed by that."

“I’m impressed by the technology,” Bow said defensively, “not what it’s used for.”

“If you’re into tech, you’re going to love this video.” Adora shrugged off her backpack and swung it around to her front. “I asked Entrapta a ton of questions and she answered all of them. I didn’t understand most of what she was saying, but maybe it’ll make sense to you.”

She unzipped the bag and rifled around. Catra held her breath as she watched Adora pull out the phone.

There was a moment of silence. Catra could see confusion settling across Adora’s brow in the pristine white glow of the phone’s set-up screen.

“Adora?” Glimmer said. “What’s wrong?”

“I don’t know,” Adora replied. She turned the phone to the others. “What does this mean? Is it broken?”

A manic sort of delight spilled from Catra’s heart. She watched Glimmer and Bow’s faces fall.

“Adora, why did you reset the phone?” Bow asked. His words came out slowly.

“Reset?” Adora turned the phone back around and blinked at the screen. “What does that mean?”

“It means it’s been wiped clean!” Glimmer wailed. She grabbed the phone from Adora’s hands and tapped on the screen. “It’s been completely restarted — it’s basically brand new again.”

The color drained from Adora’s face. “What? No. How does that happen? Can we undo it?”

“Dammit,” Bow hissed, leaning over Glimmer’s shoulder to get a better look. “I knew I should have set up the cloud earlier. How could I be so stupid?”

“I don’t understand.” Adora’s voice was flush with panic now. “I didn’t do anything — I haven’t even touched it since I texted you guys earlier.”

“Maybe it glitched somehow?” Bow asked, though it was clear from his tone that even he knew it was unlikely.

Glimmer’s expression was stony. “Adora, did anyone else have access to this phone?”

Adora shook her head. “No one knows I have it, and I almost always have it on me.”

“Almost?” Glimmer pressed.

“Well, I don’t shower with it, obviously,” Adora replied. “But it’s not like I leave it out in the open. I keep it in my bag under my bed in my…” She trailed off. Her eyes grew wide as she stared into the darkness of the park.

Catra could see it on her face: she knew.

“No,” Adora whispered. “She wouldn’t.”

Catra stepped out of the shadows. “You sure about that?”

Adora whipped around. Glimmer and Bow jumped. Catra glared.

“Hey, Adora.”

“Catra?” Adora looked like she’d seen a ghost. “What are you doing here?”

“No, Adora — what are *you* doing here?” Catra’s eyes snapped to the others. “And more importantly, what are you doing here with *them*?”

Adora took a cautious step toward her. Catra could see the way Adora’s hands trembled as she reached for her.

“Catra, listen to me. I can explain.”

“Explain what?” Catra snapped, her voice filling the quiet street. “Explain how you’ve been lying to me this whole fucking time? That you’re feeding Horde secrets to the cops?”

Something wild and unbidden was taking over. Every fiber of Catra’s being burned. A scream was building in her chest, working its way up her throat.

Adora stared firmly into Catra’s eyes. “I’m doing this for us, Catra. You’ve got to believe me.”

“I don’t have to *do* anything,” Catra shouted, making the trio flinch. “And don’t fucking stand there and lie to me, either.”

“I’m not—”

But Catra didn’t want to hear Adora’s excuses. She couldn’t. All of the hurt and anger she had been wrestling to keep under control erupted.

Catra screamed.


HENARTORINOS'21
@ILIKEYOUCATRADORA

It was a shrill and feral sound that cut through the evening. Adora stumbled back, fear painted plainly across her face.

Then, just as Catra's scream faded, the sound was replaced by a sudden cacophony of new ones. An engine revved and tires screeched as a car skidding up to the curb. Shouting voices and thunderous footsteps came up behind Catra. She froze as bodies pushed past her: Force Captains.

"Shit!" Adora cried, shoving Glimmer and Bow toward the park entrance. "We have to go, now!"

The three of them took off running and the small gang of Force Captains followed. Catra stood rooted in place, numb and bewildered by what was happening around her.

Before Adora disappeared, she glanced back over her shoulder. Catra caught her eyes, just a quick flash of ice blue and betrayal, and then she was gone.

Catra didn't realize she was crying until she felt hot tears fall from her lashes and trace their way down her face.

A hand curled around Catra's shoulder. She jumped with a gasp and looked up to find Shadow Weaver standing at her side.

"You followed me?" she asked. Her voice came out small and childlike, and left her feeling ashamed.

"We had to know," Shadow Weaver replied. Her eyes were trained on the darkened park, cold and unblinking. Catra followed her gaze and wondered what would happen if those Force Captains managed to catch up with Adora.

And then, in a startling moment of clarity, Catra realized she didn't care.

"Well, now you know," she said, angrily wiping away her tears. "Adora is a traitor."

“Indeed.” Shadow Weaver paused. She looked down at Catra and studied her with an expression that was hard to decipher. “Come with me, Force Captain Catra, We have a lot to discuss.”

Chapter 14

It was warm in Glimmer's basement, but Adora couldn't stop shivering. The adrenaline that had fueled their escape was slowly filtering out of her system, leaving her feeling weak and nauseous. Bow gently draped a soft blanket over her shoulders, and the gesture tugged her mind back to reality.

"I'm so sorry," she whispered. "I had no idea I was being followed. I was careless and stupid—"

"Adora, it's okay." Glimmer kneeled on the floor and took Adora's trembling hands in her own. "We got away. We're safe. Everything's okay."

Adora shook her head. "No, it's not okay. I put you guys in danger. I lost the video and screwed up the whole plan."

"Well, you shouldn't blame yourself for that part," Bow said. Adora understood what he was implying: Catra.

It was Catra who reset the phone, and Catra who blew their cover. Adora dropped her head into her hands so the others couldn't see the tears welling in her eyes.

"I can't believe she would do something like this," she said. "I knew she'd be upset when she found out I was lying to her, but I thought she'd at least let me explain before..."

"Before she ratted you out," Glimmer finished the thought that Adora couldn't bring herself to say out loud. "I'm so sorry, Adora."

Bow draped his arm around her. "Me too. I know she means a lot to you."

That was the understatement of the century. Catra didn't mean a lot to Adora, she meant *everything*.

Adora thought to the phone, still blank and useless at the bottom of her backpack, and her heart ached. She had wanted to take pictures of Catra so badly; to capture images of her beautiful smile and striking eyes. Adora had craved little mementos she could peek at while they were working apart. It had surprised her how much she missed Catra during those long days in Entrapta's lab.

But taking those pictures would have meant admitting that she had a phone, so Adora had resorted to the next best thing. One night after Catra fell asleep, Adora snapped a single photo. In it, Catra looked so peaceful, her head resting on Adora's pillow surrounded by the mess of her unruly hair. There was no smile or mismatched eyes, but the photo had captured one of Adora's favorite views: waking up with Catra at her side.

Maybe that had been the moment Adora realized the truth about what Catra really meant to her. In the quiet moments after taking the picture, Adora reached out and brushed some of Catra's hair off her face with a feather-light touch. Her fingers had lingered on Catra's warm cheek, and for a split second, Adora entertained the notion of leaning in and planting a soft kiss in that very same spot.

Because that's what Catra meant to her.

And now, just like the picture, Catra was gone.


HENARTORINOS'21

Adora could almost feel the fissure in her heart, and the pain was overwhelming. Just drawing in a breath was excruciating. A strangled sob escaped her lips, and the tears came at last. She wept shamelessly as Glimmer and Bow watched on.

"I ruined it," Adora choked through her sobs. "I've lost everything."

"No you haven't." Glimmer tugged Adora's hands away from her face so she could look her in the eyes. "You have us."

Bow leaned in and smiled. "Yeah. We're not turning our backs on you, Adora."

"But I'm no good to you anymore," Adora said. "I can't go back to the Horde to get information for you. Hell, I can't go back to the Horde at all." The gravity of her own words struck so hard that it took her breath away. "Oh my god, I can't go back to the Horde. What do I do now? Where do I go?" The octave of her voice rose with her panic.

"Take a breath, Adora," Bow insisted, massaging slow circles into her shoulders. "It doesn't matter that you can't go undercover anymore — you're our friend."

"Exactly." Glimmer nodded. "You can stay here with me. We have plenty of room."

Adora blinked. "Here? Like, in your *house*?"

"Of course! What, did you think we would just leave you to fend for yourself?" Glimmer's eyes sparkled as she spoke.

"But, what about your mom?" Adora thought about Angella — she couldn't imagine the chief of police would be too pleased about having an ex-gangster living in her basement.

But Glimmer seemed nonplussed as she waved her hand dismissively. "We'll worry about that later. Besides, this house is

huge and she's barely home — I'll bet we could go months before she even realized you're here."

Bow pinned her with a stern look. "But you're *not* going to wait for months before you tell her because that would be incredibly irresponsible."

"One thing at a time. Bow."

Their banter was enough to bring a weak smile to Adora's face. She wiped away her tears and took a deep breath.

"Thank you. I really appreciate—"

Before she could finish speaking, Adora was enveloped in a tight group hug. She let her friends comfort her and savored the rare sense of safety that came with being held tight.

Eventually, the trio pulled apart and sat back.

"I don't know about you guys, but all that running for our lives made me hungry," Bow said as he stood from the couch. "I'm thinking cookies? Or maybe pancakes?"

"Yesss," Glimmer replied. "And I'll go get one of the guest rooms set up for you, Adora." She got to her feet and dusted off the seat of her pants. "You just sit tight and relax."

Adora didn't have the energy to do more than nod. She watched her friends scamper off their errands and pulled the blanket tighter around her shoulders. Alone with her thoughts, Adora's mind wandered back to Catra. The memory of Catra's furious and broken scream played through her mind on a loop, and it broke her heart all over again. But it didn't hurt as much as the truth: that the person Adora loved most in this world had betrayed her without a second thought.

After everything Adora had done to keep her safe, Catra had still chosen the Horde. She wondered if things would have been different had she just let Catra in on the plan from the beginning.

But perhaps it wouldn't have mattered; maybe Catra's loyalty to the gang was stronger than Adora's. Maybe Catra just didn't care about Adora the way Adora cared for her.

That thought alone was almost enough to bring on a fresh onslaught of tears. Adora pressed her palms against her eyes and took a few steadying breaths.

"Now what?" she wondered aloud.

She sat, lost in thought, until Glimmer came back into the room.

"C'mon," Glimmer said softly as she took Adora by the hand and led her toward the stairs. "Let's go watch Bow bake. My mom won't be home for another hour or two, so we should take advantage of having the house to ourselves while we still can."

Being in Angella Brightmoon's house felt like a dream. As she let Glimmer lead her to this kitchen, Adora stared at the many photos that adorned the walls. Photos of Glimmer through the years, from a wide-eyed toddler dressed in frills to a scrappy pre-teen in a softball uniform posing with a championship trophy. It was all so foreign to Adora: the kind of childhood a kid like her could have only dreamed of. And there, interspersed with photos of Glimmer, were pictures of Angella—all smiles in her civilian clothes—posing happily with her daughter and a handsome man with long dark hair and a warm smile.

Adora's stomach dropped at the sight of him. Without thinking, she froze in front of one photo in particular. In it, Glimmer was probably about 8 or 9 and she sat on her father's lap, beaming up at him. He in turn smiled down at his daughter with such obvious love and pride, his arms wrapped around her in a way that promised to protect her from the world.

Except he couldn't even protect himself — the Horde had made sure of it.

"Adora?" Glimmer's voice pierced through the fog of Adora's thoughts. "Are you okay?"

“I hate them,” Adora replied, her voice nothing more than a whisper.

Glimmer frowned. “Who?”

“The Horde.” Adora pulled her stinging eyes away from the photo and looked instead to her friend. “All they do is take and destroy. They don’t care who they hurt along the way, and I hate them for it.” She paused and swallowed the lump in her throat. “I know I screwed everything up. I know things are different now. But I haven’t changed my mind. I still want to help you bring them down, if you’ll have me.”

A wide smile slid across Glimmer’s lips.

“I was hoping you’d say that.” She pulled Adora away from the photos and toward the kitchen. “Now, come on — it’s time for cookies and a strategy session.”

*

Catra sat silently in the back seat of Shadow Weaver’s chauffeured car. Her thoughts were nothing but static, her body completely numb. Every time her mind tried to replay what had just happened, Catra forced the thoughts away; she wasn’t ready to face it. So she focused on the buzzing static in her ears instead and let it drown everything else out.

At her side, she could feel Shadow Weaver watching her. If she was waiting for Catra to make the first move—to speak or perhaps cry—she was going to be disappointed.

A phone rang. The sound triggered a flood of ice cold fear that spilled from Catra’s core. She tensed as her mind snapped back to the phone in Adora’s backpack. It was as if the device, and what it had meant for her and Adora, was haunting her.

But this wasn’t a trick of Catra’s traumatized mind — a phone was actually ringing. Shadow Weaver pulled her own top-of-the-line

model from her bag and stared at the called I.D. She hesitated and took a moment to compose herself before answering the call.

“Sir,” she said.

The phone wasn’t on speaker, but Catra could still hear Hordak’s voice coming through loud and clear.

“I understand you mobilized our Force Captains this evening.”

“That is correct, sir.” Shadow Weaver stared straight ahead as she spoke. Catra could tell from her rigid posture that Shadow Weaver probably would have preferred to be alone for this conversation. Curious as she was, Catra turned her head to look out the window and pretended she wasn’t eavesdropping.

“And?” Hordak pressed. “What was so important that you needed to launch an unauthorized operation?”

Shadow Weaver took a breath. In the reflection of the window, Catra could almost see the wheels turning in her head.

“One of our Force Captains has abandoned her post,” Shadow Weaver said slowly. “We were attempting to apprehend her.”

“Were you successful?”

There was an uncomfortable beat of silence.

“No sir.”

Hordak let the moment hang.

“I see,” he said at last. “Who is it?”

“Adora, sir,” Shadow Weaver replied. “But rest assured, we will find her and bring her back to—”

“No,” Hordak cut her off. “The Horde does not reinstate deserters. Your Force Captains will find her and deal with the problem, just like we do with anyone who defects.”

Catra gripped her thigh to keep herself from reacting. Hordak had just ordered Adora's execution, and he didn't even know the whole story. She wondered what he would do if he knew Adora hadn't just abandoned the Horde, but was actually working against them.

She stole a surreptitious glance at Shadow Weaver, who looked genuinely distressed.

"But, sir," Shadow Weaver said. "Adora is the finest Force Captain the Horde has seen in years. I've been preparing her to be my second in command since she was a girl. We need her."

"Do not argue with me, Shadow Weaver," Hordak barked over her, loud enough that even Catra flinched. "You have Catra. If you need someone to assist with your work, use her. She is nearly of age, is she not?"

Shadow Weaver cut Catra a hateful glare. "Yes, sir. She will be eighteen next week."

"Good. Arrange her initiation. She will be your second in command. In the meantime, find the deserter and make sure she is dealt with accordingly. Do I make myself clear?"

Scowling, Shadow Weaver nodded. "Yes, sir."

Without another word, Hordak ended the call. Shadow Weaver gripped the phone so tightly that Catra wouldn't have been surprised if it crumpled like paper in her hand.

"Congratulations," Shadow Weaver snarled without looking at her. "It looks as though you managed to fail your way to the top."

Had the circumstances been different, Catra would have been stung by the backhanded compliment. But tonight, she was already too broken for Shadow Weaver's cruelty to hurt her.

Instead, she slumped back against the seat and went back to staring out the window, and let the static fill her mind once more.

Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

[**CONTENT WARNING** This chapter deals with mature subject matter that may be triggering, particularly to survivors of physical and sexual assault, and police violence. Please see the end of the chapter for specific content warnings and take care when reading. Reader discretion is advised.]

In days after her world fell apart, the only real human interaction Catra had was an interrogation. Instead of returning to the old hotel, Shadow Weaver brought Catra to headquarters and ushered her into a dark and cramped office.

"If ever there was a time in your sorry excuse of a life to be truthful, it's now," Shadow Weaver spat after more than an hour of fruitless back and forth.

"I *am* being truthful," Catra snapped back. She was exhausted and her nerves were frayed. All she wanted to do was go home and cry in private. "You already know Adora kept me in the dark — what do you want me to say?"

Shadow Weaver paced in the small space in front of Catra's chair. Whatever process she used to tame her long black hair seemed to have given up; it seems to be growing wilder by the minute. "You two are close. Surely she said *something*."

"Listen, I'm just as pissed off about it as you are." Catra folded her arms and sank back in her seat. "I guess she let us both down."

"Then did you see something? Anything that would indicate what kind of information she was feeding to the authorities."

Catra gritted her teeth. She dug her fingertips into her thighs hard enough to hurt, like a warning to herself not to say something she might regret.

"No. Nothing. I had absolutely no idea what she was up to."

A moment passed between them. Shadow Weaver stared Catra down with a cold and calculating glare. At last, she let out a frustrated sigh.

"Fine. Then we're done here."

Catra was officially benched until her initiation, which meant no Horde assignments until her birthday the following week. That suited her just fine. She had no interest in doing anything but sulking and crying in private. Shadow Weaver sent her home with strict instructions to not tell a soul about Adora working with the police.

"Adora's indiscretion will be dealt with discretely," Shadow Weaver explained when Catra asked why.

But Catra wasn't stupid — if anything, Shadow Weaver probably didn't want Hordak to know that her protege had turned out to be a traitor.

And so, Catra spent the days between Adora's defection and her initiation alone in her room. From her bed, she watched the sun trace its way across the sky in an endless loop. She rose only to eat, use the bathroom, and snarl at anyone who dared so much as glance her way. No one knocked on her door, and no one thought to check in on her. But that wasn't a surprise. After all, there was nobody left to care.

By the time her eighteenth birthday arrived, Catra felt transformed. It was as if she'd gone into her isolation a wounded and heartbroken caterpillar and emerged a butterfly with wings made of pure spite and rage. If there was such a thing as a butterfly with sharp teeth and venom in its veins, Catra would be that one.

She awoke late with the midday sun streaming in from a crack between the curtains. Grumbling, Catra rolled out of bed and decided her birthday was as good a day as any to finally take a shower. (In her misery, she hadn't exactly made personal hygiene a priority.) Snatching her towel, Catra yanked her door open and nearly tripped on a paper shopping bag that had been placed at the threshold.

"What the fuck?" she muttered as she picked the bag up. A folded note was taped to the side. For a split second, Catra forgot everything that had happened, and her hopeful heart leapt at the thought that maybe—just maybe—the package was a birthday gift from Adora.

But, no. The tight scrawl on the note was unmistakably that of Shadow Weaver.

Change out of those rags, it read. *Meet Grizzlor out back at 9 p.m. for your assignment*.

Her assignment — she'd almost forgotten that it was initiation day.

Curious, Catra closed the door and took the package to her bed. She wasn't sure what she expected, but it certainly wasn't what she found inside. Folded neatly at the bottom were brand new clothes — like, from a store new, as opposed to the cast-offs and hand-me-downs Catra was used to. Wide-eyed, she turned the items over in her hands. There was a pair of crisp burgundy jeans, distressed in a way that was obviously intentional, unlike the ones she wore now that were filled with holes born from wear and tear. Next was a backless red top that was far more revealing than anything Catra would have picked for herself, as well as a studded belt.

But the best piece by far was a new leather jacket, emblazoned with the Horde's symbol in blood red on the back. Catra trailed her fingertips reverently across the design, and for the first time, she finally felt like she belonged.

Eager to try everything on, Catra darted to the bathroom, took a quick shower and then hurried back. She pulled on her new clothes and then doubled back to the bathroom just so she could get a look at herself in the mirrors. Her reflection startled her. She felt like a completely different person. Gone was the sloppy, rough-around-the-edges teenager she'd been. In her place stood a woman, confident and powerful. Catra turned so she could see herself from different angles and marvelled at the difference properly-fitted clothes made. She looked good, and she liked it.

"Oh, man," Catra laughed, admiring the way the jeans hugged her hips, "Adora's gonna freak when she sees—"

She froze mid-sentence. Just like that, all of her excitement faded. The anger and heartbreak of Adora's betrayal came rushing back in an instant. Catra studied her scowling face in the mirror and adjusted the sleeves of her jacket.

"Whatever. I don't need her, and I'm going to prove it," she told her reflection. That would be her new mantra — she just needed to repeat it until she actually believed it.

Catra spent the rest of the day anxiously whiling away the hours until it was time to go. Her stomach was tied up in knots as her mind flitted between possible scenarios. She thought about Adora's initiation, and how she'd been forced to beat a guy with a lead pipe. Catra looked down at her hands and imagined the weight of a weapon in them. She was no stranger to violence, and if her initiation required it, Catra knew she could hold her own if she had to. But knowing that did little to calm her nerves.

"Just chill," she whispered to herself as she made her way down the stairs that evening. "Whatever they want you to do, you can handle it."

She pushed out into the chilly night air and found Grizzlor, a gruff and exceptionally hairy high-ranking Force Captain who had been around as long as Catra could remember, waiting. He stood leaning against a beat-up old car, arms crossed and looking bored.

But when he spotted Catra making her way toward him, his lips curled into a smirk.

"You ready for your big night, sweetheart?" he asked, looking her over shamelessly.

Catra wasn't used to being looked at that way, and it made her skin crawl. She was suddenly very aware of the low neckline on her new top. But she wasn't about to let some creep get to her, so she kept her head held high as she circled the car and paused at the passenger door.

"My name is Catra. Call me 'sweetheart' again and I'll scratch your fucking eyes out."

A look of surprise flickered across Grizzlor's face. Then he threw his head back and let out a deep guffaw. "I like your style, kid. Let's get this show on the road, shall we?"

They drove without speaking, letting the classic rock station on the radio fill the silence. Catra kept a close watch on the street signs as they passed and drew a mental map in her head. The car wove through the streets before eventually turning onto a main thoroughfare that took them to the outskirts of the city where the tall buildings gave way to strip malls and boring chain restaurants. Catra was just about to ask where they were going when Grizzlor flicked on the turn signal and pulled into the pothole-ridden parking lot of an old motel.

It wasn't the sketchiest motel Catra had ever seen, but that didn't mean it was nice. She peered up at the ancient faded sign that boasted amenities like "color TVs" and "air conditioned rooms" and, to Catra's amusement, "hourly rates". The neon "vacancy" sign flickered intermittently. The "no" that preceded it looked like it had never been turned on.

"This place is a dump," Catra said, wrinkling her nose. "What are we doing here?"

"This is where we're meeting the others." Grizzlor pulled up to door #11 and turned off the engine. Snatching his phone off the dashboard, he tapped out a quick text with his thick thumbs and hit send. Only then did he turn to Catra. "You know how this works, right?"

Catra didn't answer. Outside of what Adora told her about her own initiation, Catra knew very little about what was supposed to happen. Suddenly she found herself wishing she hadn't brushed Adora off when she found her scrubbing blood out of her hair in the warehouse bathroom. But saying that she wasn't sure what to expect felt like admitting weakness, and that's the last thing Catra wanted, so she stared back at the commander and tried to look bored.

"Tonight's the night you show us if the Horde can trust you," Grizzlor continued, his expression hard and serious. "You're either with us or you're not."

This made Catra bristle. Involuntarily, her face twisted into a deep scowl as she thought again about Adora's initiation. Adora, who had done everything she was told and still wound up betraying the Horde. If proving one's loyalty was the purpose of these initiations, clearly the system was broken. Catra wanted to point this out—to argue that she had already chosen the Horde at the detriment of everything else—but she knew it wouldn't matter.

"Yeah, yeah, I get it," she replied with a roll of her eyes. "Do as I'm told, don't ask questions, get some blood on my hands, blah, blah, blah. Are we doing this or not?"

Grizzlor replied with a huff of laughter. He got out of the car and Catra followed suit, hurrying to match his long strides. They stopped at the room door and Grizzlor rapped a morse code-like knock with his knuckles. A shuffling came from inside the room as the pinpoint light coming through the peephole shifted. Catra heard the chain lock slide and the deadbolt unlock. The door opened. Inside was another member of the gang — one Catra had

seen working under hoods in the Horde's garage, but never spoken with. She didn't even know his name.

His eyes flicked down to her and he nodded.

Grizzlor pushed through the door and Catra followed, cutting a dangerous glare at the other gangster as she slid into the room.

"Where is he?" Grizzlor asked.

"Should be here in a sec," the gangster replied. Even so, he dutifully relocked the door and waited.

Catra cracked her knuckles as she looked around the small, outdated room. It was in similar shape to the old hotel she now called home, with worn and discoloured carpets and ugly wallpaper everywhere. Water rings stained the nightstand on which a single, shadeless steel lamp sat. The bedding looked cheap and scratchy. The only thing in the room that obviously wasn't supposed to be there was a tripod that was set up in the narrow space between the bed and the dresser, blocking the path to the bathroom. A video camera was perched on top. Catra raised an eyebrow and pointed to it.

"What's that for?" she asked.

Grizzlor walked over to the camera and started messing around with it. "Gotta be able to prove to the boss that you passed the test."

Before Catra could ask what exactly that test would entail, another patterned knock came from outside. She rolled her shoulders and took a few deep breaths as the other gangster did his job of checking the peephole and unlocking the door.

You've hit people before, she thought to herself to calm her nerves. *Just pretend whoever this sucker is called you 'sweetheart' and kick his ass*.

The gangster pulled open the door, but his broad shoulders blocked Catra's view.

"Hey, man," he said as he stepped aside. "Come in."

Catra's stomach dropped. She recognized the man who walked in right away: it was the cop she'd seen talking to Shadow Weaver. The same one she often caught lurking, keeping an eye on her and Adora. Her mind raced.

Holy shit. Are they gonna make me kill a cop?

She wondered what he had done to earn what was coming to him. Dirty cops were important to the Horde — it was so much easier to stay in business if you had friends in high places who were willing to look the other way. This guy must have really fucked up if Hordak wanted to teach one of their VIPs a lesson.

The other gangsters greeted him like an old friend, pulling one another into those weird, one-armed, back-slapping bro hugs. Catra hoped she wouldn't be expected to do the same. The idea of hugging a cop—even a dirty one—made her skin crawl.

"Damn, Lashor," Grizzlor said. "I guess you're really earning your keep these days."

A shit-eating grin cut across Lashor's face as he shrugged out of his jacket and tossed it onto a nearby chair. "I fed the Witch some pretty solid intel recently."

Grizzlor laughed. "Oh, I know. I was pulled in to help look for the little traitor."

"What do you mean?" Lashor asked. "Did she get away?"

"For now. We'll find her."

Catra's heart hammered as the pieces clicked into place.

Lashor let out a whistle. "Shit, that sucks. I'll keep an eye out and —"

"You," Catra choked. The men in the room stopped talking and turned to her in unison. For the first time, Lashor seemed to realize she was there. His eyes lit up at the sight of her. "You're the one who told Shadow Weaver about Adora."

Smirking, Lashor glanced at Grizzlor. "This her?"

"Sure is." Grizzlor snapped his fingers at the other gangster, who fished something that looked like a black knitted cap from his jacket pocket. He handed it to Lashor. "You'll wanna wear this."

Lashor's eyes flicked to the video camera. "Right. Got it."

Heart racing, Catra clenched and released her grip a few times, stretching out her fingers and rolling her wrists as she warmed-up for carnage. She wasn't sure what Grizzlor was playing at — perhaps all this buddy talk was his way of luring the cop into a false sense of security. All she knew for certain was that she was going to take great pleasure in hurting this man.

She watched silently as Lashor pulled the knitted cap over his head. It turned out it wasn't a cap at all — it was a ski mask, the type that covered all but the eyes and mouth. When he smiled at her, his white teeth seemed to glow menacingly against the dark mask. He looked like he had just stepped out of a nightmare.

Somewhere in the back of Catra's mind, alarm bells began to ring.

Grizzlor shot her a look as he stepped around her and back to the video camera. "Remember what we talked about: this is your chance to prove your loyalty to the Horde." Catra blinked into the camera lens as static filled her mind. Something wasn't right. Grizzlor turned and looked her square in the eyes. "Give him what he wants and don't ask questions. It'll be over soon."

He hit record.

Before Catra could react, Grizzlor turned her around to face Lashor's nightmare smile. In a swift motion, he pulled her jacket off her shoulders and down her arms, leaving her standing in her revealing new top, skin and scars on full display.

No, she thought. *No, this isn't how it was supposed to go*.

She stood rooted in place, frozen in disbelief as Lashor stepped up to her. Her mind screamed for her to run, but her body wouldn't listen. She was trapped.

Lashor gripped her chin and tipped her face back to get a better look at her.

"Mmm, very nice," he said in a low growl.

Don't touch me, Catra thought. She wanted to scream, but her body betrayed her. Frantically, she looked at Grizzlor. But if he could see the desperation in her eyes, he ignored it.

This can't be happening.

With his hands on her hips, Lashor navigated Catra backwards until her legs hit the bed. He shoved her back, knocking her down onto the mattress. She scrambled to sit back up. Every inch of her trembled.

"You want us to step out?" the gangster asked. "Give you kids a bit of privacy?"

"Doesn't matter to me," Lashor replied without looking away from Catra's wide-eyed, horrified gaze. He reached down and unbuckled his belt. "I don't mind performing for an audience. What about you, sweetheart?"

Sweetheart.

The word was like the launch code to a nuclear bomb. And just like a bomb, Catra exploded.

All the fear and rage that was boiling at her core erupted in a wild scream. In the split-second that Lashor hesitated, Catra leaned back and drove her heel between his legs, hard.

Lashor doubled over, and Catra didn't hesitate. She landed a right hook to his jaw and then pulled her elbow back, cracking it against his temple. He crumpled to his knees in front of her. The shouting of the others filled the small room, and Catra looked up just in time to see the gangster launch himself at her.

Catra saw red.

The moment his hands clenched around her shoulders, Catra dug her sharp nails deep into his hands. She tore mercilessly at his flesh and aimed kick after kick to his legs and knees. In his desperate attempt to keep his groin out of her range, the gangster loosened his grip just enough that Catra was able to surge forward and ram her forehead into the bridge of his nose. She felt the delicate cartilage shatter as warm blood from his broken face splattered against hers.

She managed to land a few solid blows to the gangster's face before she felt a hand grip her hair. Catra shrieked as she was yanked back.

"You fucking bitch!" Lashor screamed into her face. "I'm gonna—"

He didn't have a chance to finish that thought. Catra's hands shot forward. She tore at his ski mask until she found what she was looking for. With the fingers of one hand, she gripped the lump of his ear and pulled. She dug the thumb of her other hand into his eye. With a howl of pain, Lashor released his hold on her hair, and Catra took the opportunity to snatch the lamp from the bedside table. She yanked it from the wall, its cord snapping from the base with a satisfying *pop*. Wielding its heavy base like a weapon, she brought it down hard, connecting with whatever part of Lashor was closest. Again and again she struck, until the dirty cop wasn't fighting back anymore.



Catra turned her wild eyes to the gangster she'd left slumped against the wall. He let out a startled yelp as she charged at him,

the bloody lamp raised over her head like a baseball bat. She swung hard, narrowly missing him as he scrambled out of the way and drove a deep hole into the wall instead.

White hot adrenaline pumped through every fibre of Catra's being. Chest heaving, she wrenched the lamp from the wall. She was ready to destroy everyone and everything in her path. But before she could make another move, something hit the back of her neck and sent a wave of excruciating pain pulsing through her body. A storm of electricity raced beneath her skin and seized her muscles into tight knots.

The shock ended as abruptly as it began, but the damage was done. Catra swayed dangerously on her feet. As the edges of her vision grew dark, she saw Grizzlor, pale-faced and breathing hard, step back with a stun gun in his hand.

Catra's legs gave out beneath her. She hit the ground, and the world went black.

Chapter End Notes

Content warnings:

- For her initiation, Catra is unknowingly offered to Lashor, who attempts to sexually assault her. There is no nudity or sexual contact, and his attempt is unsuccessful.

- Catra attacks both Lashor and another Horde gangster. The attack includes kicking, punching, scratching, gouging and bludgeoning. Mentions of blood.

- Grizzlor uses a stun gun on Catra.

Chapter 16

Somewhere on the edge of her consciousness, Catra could hear talking.

Whoever it was, they sounded far away; muffled as if underwater. She couldn't make out what they were saying, she only knew they were out there somewhere, drifting through the darkness.

Moment by moment, that darkness receded, until at last Catra realized she was awake. Her body felt heavy as a stone, and her side was aching. It took her another minute to realize she was laying on the ground. With her eyes still closed, she struggled through the fog in her mind, trying to pin down the last thing she remembered.

Then she heard a knock.

A door squeaked open.

"Thank you for coming, sir," said a gruff voice. "I know you don't like to be disturbed in the evenings, but I thought you'd want to see this."

Grizzlor.

Catra's eyes snapped open. From her vantage point, all she could see was the grubby carpet of the motel floor.

Everything came back to her in a flash.

There were footsteps. Someone gasped.

A primitive part of Catra's brain took over.

Fight, it told her. *Survive*.

Despite the persistent ache that made her limbs feel like they were filled with concrete, she tried to get to her feet. As she rose,

her wrist snagged on something hard and cold, and she stumbled back onto her knees. Catra looked at her hand, coated in dried smears of blood, and found the polished metal of a handcuff encircling her wrist. Its other end was fastened around one of the bed's legs. From where she was crouched she could see a slumped figure on the floor, surrounded by a pool of dark blood.

Catra cried out and scrambled back yet again. This time she settled for sitting up as much as her restraint would allow.

"What have you done?"

That voice.

Catra's head snapped toward the motel door and her blood ran cold. There stood both Shadow Weaver and Hordak. For his part, Hordak looked impassive. He stepped toward Lashor's body and nudged him with his toe. The dirty cop let out a low groan.

"Only *you* could manage to mishandle a perfectly simple initiation in such spectacular fashion," Shadow Weaver fumed. Her venomous green eyes seemed to emanate contempt, and all Catra could do was gape wordlessly back at her. Seething, Shadow Weaver turned to Hordak. "I told you she wasn't—"

Hordak silenced her with a wave of his hand. His eyes swept the room, lingering on Grizzlor's partner who sat in a chair with a bloody towel pressed to his face, then on the blood-covered lamp on the floor and the crater in the drywall.

And then, those eyes landed on Catra.

"You did this?" he asked. There was a note of incredulity behind his words that made Catra hesitate. She couldn't tell if it was a question she was expected to answer.

Grizzlor stepped forward and offered the video camera. "Here, sir."

Hordak took the camera and pressed play. The sound from its tiny speakers told Catra that he was rewatching the footage of what

she had done. Her blood ran cold. There would be no denying it now.

While Hordak and Shadow Weaver stared at the camera's screen, Catra watched them closely. Shadow Weaver was furious, which wasn't a surprise. But Hordak didn't seem to share his second-in-command's righteous indignation. As the video played out, his dark eyebrows crept up. Catra couldn't tell if it was a look of disgust or surprise. Either way, she knew she was as good as dead.

When the video ended, Hordak handed the camera back to Grizzlor. Every set of eyes turned to Catra in unison. She knew what they saw when they looked at her: a trembling, bloody, defiant problem.

If these were going to be her last moments on Earth, Catra figured she would make them count.

"I'm not sorry," she proclaimed. Her voice was hoarse and her throat felt raw, but she said it with as much conviction as she could muster.

Shadow Weaver made a move toward her, but Hordak shot her a stern look and she backed off. He turned to Grizzlor. "Unlock her cuffs."

Grizzlor hesitated. Rather than get too close to Catra, he opted to toss the key to her instead. Her hand was shaking so violently that it took her a moment to fit it into the cuff that secured her to the bed. When at last it clicked open, Catra scrambled to her feet and rubbed at the angry red circle around her wrist. She glanced between Hordak and Shadow Weaver like a wary, cornered animal.

The sight of Shadow Weaver made Catra's stomach turn. She was the one who organized this initiation. She knew what she would be forcing Catra into. While it was never a secret that Shadow Weaver didn't like her, Catra didn't realize how deeply that hatred

ran. Now, Catra didn't just know it: the feeling was unquestionably mutual.

"Come here," Hordak said, pointing to the space in front of him. Catra did as she was told. She rolled her shoulders back and held her head high, unwilling to let them see just how scared she really was. Hordak looked her over, his expression inscrutable as always. It drove Catra crazy that she couldn't read him the way she could with others — it was nearly impossible to tell what he was thinking behind that stony facade.

"It seems you've done some significant damage to our asset," Hordak said without inflection.

Catra swallowed the bile that rose in her throat and steadied her gaze. "He got what was coming to him."

She hated how weak her voice sounded at that moment.

Hordak tipped his head thoughtfully. "In fact, you managed to incapacitate two grown men single handedly. It might have been three had Grizzlor not come prepared. How long have you been with us?"

Catra licked her lips. "Pretty much my whole life."

"And yet you're still just as ungrateful as ever," Shadow Weaver snarled. Her hands were balled into tight fists at her side. She probably wanted to wrap one of them around Catra's neck and squeeze the life out of her herself. "We hand you the opportunity to join our ranks—to prove yourself to the Horde—and you couldn't even do that."

For a split second, Catra considered snapping back — considered reminding Shadow Weaver exactly what she'd given up for the Horde. But Hordak didn't give her the chance.

"On the contrary," he said, stroking his chin with his tattooed fingers. "I think she's proven herself quite admirably."

Neither Catra nor Shadow Weaver saw that coming. Catra blinked in surprise, while Shadow Weaver floundered.

"But, sir! Lashor is—"

"Lashor isn't the only cop on the Etheria Police Force at our beck and call," he said, pinning Shadow Weaver with a look so menacing that even someone as cruel as her couldn't help but flinch back. He turned his attention back to Catra, gesturing to Lashor's crumpled body at their feet. "Could you fight like that again?"

Is this a trap? Catra wondered.

"If I had to," she replied.

"Let me rephrase," Hordak pressed. "Can I expect the same level of performance from you in service of the Horde?"

"What?" Shadow Weaver balked, and the sound of her dismay sent a vicious smile creeping across Catra's face. She looked at Shadow Weaver, and held her wide eyes with her own as she answered.

"Absolutely."

This seemed to be exactly what Hordak wanted to hear. The corner of his lips curled in the closest thing to a smile Catra had ever seen from him. "Excellent. I'm placing you on my personal security team."

Shadow Weaver's entire body went rigid, and Catra had to fight the impulse to laugh right in her face. Hordak turned to Grizzlor and the wounded gangster and gestured around the room. "Take care of this mess."

Grizzlor responded with a nod. He stooped over and plucked Catra's leather jacket off the floor. Before handing it back to her, he even dusted it off.

"Welcome to the Horde, Catra," he said.

After a long, silent ride back to the hotel in the back of Hordak's full-sized, luxury SUV, it took every ounce of strength Catra had left to drag herself up the stairs to her floor. Now that the danger had passed, her legs felt as though they weighed a thousand pounds and she was certain she could sleep for days if only she had the time. She made her way down the hall in a daze, her jacket still clutched in her arms. The other Force Captains who loitered in doorways chatting with one another fell silent as she passed. No one said a word.

Exhausted as she was, Catra stopped at the bathroom before going to bed. She closed her eyes as she stepped up to one of the sinks and braced herself for what she would see reflected back at her in the mirror.

It didn't work. The sight of her face, splattered in blood and streaked with tears, made her sob. Trembling, she looked down at her hands. The dried blood of her assailants was stained halfway up her forearms and cracked at the crease of her split knuckles. The skin of her wrist still bore the angry red circle from where she'd been bound by the handcuff.

The nausea came on fast — so much so that she didn't even have time to make a run for the toilet. She vomited into the sink.

Catra didn't even bother to undress as she stepped into a shower stall and turned on the water. She scrubbed her hair, her face, her hands. She rinsed the splotches of blood on her new top and jeans, grateful that the shades of red and burgundy would help hide whatever she couldn't wash out. Maybe, she thought darkly, that had been Shadow Weaver's idea all along.

When she finally retreated to her room, Catra wrung her clothes out the window and draped them over the radiator to dry. She crawled weakly beneath her covers and curled into a tight ball.

Alone in her room and in all the world, Catra cried herself to sleep.

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Catra was not looking forward to returning to the garage the next morning. Her clothes were still damp when she tugged them on, and her eyes were rimmed with dark circles. She was exhausted, she was miserable, and she was nervous.

Nervous about facing other Horde members, who no doubt had heard about what happened in that motel. Nervous about what would be expected of her as a member of Hordak's personal security detail.

She fretted about it the entire walk. Her mind raced as she trudged through the morning chill.

For a brief moment, thoughts of Adora invaded her mind, and it took Catra by surprise. She hadn't thought of Adora once since getting into Grizzlor's car the night before. It seemed there was no room for Adora in this new, dangerous life Catra was living, and that suited her just fine.

"So much for always being there to protect me," Catra muttered under her breath. But before she could sink deeper into self-pity, she gave her head a shake. "Whatever. Obviously I don't need her. I can handle myself just fine on my own."

When she arrived at the garage, Catra kept her eyes trained forward as she stormed through the bays. As she walked, she pretended she couldn't see the other Horde members who stood around talking over steaming paper cups of coffee before setting up for another day of work. Their conversation fell away as catra passed. There was no teasing, no jeering or cruel jokes at her expense. Catra wasn't sure if that was a good thing or not.

She was a few strides from the door that led to the back when it suddenly swung open. Catra stopped short, taken aback by the towering woman who filled the doorway. She was all muscle, with

broad shoulders and intricate red tattoos that raced up both of her forearms. All of this was at odds with the excited expression on her face. The woman's dark eyes lit up at the sight of Catra, to whom she offered a wide and warm smile.

"Are you Catra?" the woman asked, her voice booming through the garage.

Catra took a step back. "Who's ask—"

Before she could finish speaking, the woman swooped forward and gathered Catra into a tight hug that lifted her off her feet.

"Oh, wow! This is so exciting!" the woman said brightly. "Welcome to the team!"

"What are you doing?" Catra shrieked, struggling against the stranger's formidable grip. "Put me down!"

This seemed to snap the woman to her senses. She set Catra down with a sheepish laugh.

"Sorry about that," she said. "I guess I should have warned you that I'm a hugger."

Catra held her hands up between them in an attempt to ward the rogue-hugger off. "You think? A normal person would at least introduce themself first."

"Oh! Duh, right! My name's Scorpia. I'm your new partner!"

"My *what*?" Catra hissed. "I don't need a partner."

At this, Scorpia laughed. It wasn't a mean laugh — clearly she thought something was genuinely funny.

"Trust me, when you're part of Hordak's personal security team you definitely need a partner." Scorpia beamed down at Catra. "Which is why I'm so glad you're here! It's been a while since my

last partner, well, y'know..." She dragged a finger across her throat and Catra's stomach sank.

"But I'm not worried about you," Scorpia continued. As she spoke, she opened the door and gestured for Catra to follow. "I hear you're quite a force to be reckoned with. Small but mighty, right? Oh, man. We are gonna make *quite* the team."

With a resigned sigh, Catra fell into step beside her. As she tuned out her new partner's seemingly endless chatter, Catra couldn't help but wonder,

What the hell have I gotten myself into?


HENARTORNOS'21
@ILIKEYOUCATRADORA

Chapter 17

Catra let out a loud, miserable groan.

"I thought we were supposed to be on Hordak's personal security team," she grumbled.

Scorpia laughed. "We are!"

"Then why have we spent the entire day babysitting Doctor Frankenstein over there?" Catra gestured to the window that separated the small antechamber from Entrapta's lab. As if on cue, Entrapta let out a peal of maniacal laughter from behind her gas mask. The pitch made Catra wince.

"Entrapta recently made a huge breakthrough in her work with Runestone," Scorpia said. She smiled warmly as she watched Entrapta work. "And when you consider that Runestone is one of the Horde's biggest money-makers, it makes sense that Hordak wants to make sure she has protection." She paused and quickly glanced around the room before leaning in and whispering, "And between you and me, I also think he might also have a bit of a crush on her."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Gross."

Folding her arms, Catra leaned back against the window and scowled down at the floor. So far being a Force Captain was just as disappointing as everything else in her life.

The pair stood in silence for a while. Only the sounds of Entrapta's tinkering, punctuated by the occasional giggle, filled the space between them.

"Do you want to talk about it?" Scorpia asked. Despite being much softer than usual, Scorpia's voice still surprised Catra enough to make her jump.

"Talk about what?" Catra snapped.

Scorpia wasn't looking at her. She still gazed through the window into the lab, but her smile had faded. "About your initiation. I know they can be pretty rough. I just figured you might wanna—"

"I don't," Catra said, cutting her off. She pulled her jacket tighter around herself as if she might be able to disappear into it completely.

There was another beat of silence, then Scorpia spoke again.

"Was it the motel?"

Catra's breath caught in her throat. Her heart hammered so hard she thought it might burst through her chest. "How do you know about that?"

"All Horde initiations are awful, but that one…" Scorpia trailed off. She gave her head a shake and smiled softly down at her partner. "You just seem pretty unhappy."

"Yeah, well, get used to it," Catra replied, turning away so Scorpia wouldn't see the way her cheeks burned. "And I don't need your pity, either. There's no way in hell I was going to let anyone do that to me. I beat the shit out of that fucking creep *and* one of the pricks who set me up."

The sound of Scorpia's reverent gasp made Catra glance back at her.

"Oh, wow!" Scorpia said, her face alight with awe. "I'd heard that you single handedly took out a couple guys, but I didn't realize that's how it happened. You're amazing!"

Catra didn't know how to take that. She shifted awkwardly and dug at the floor with the toe of her boot.

"What's the point of the initiations anyway?" She asked.

Scorpia hummed thoughtfully. "Well, they say it's to prove your loyalty to the gang."

Catra scoffed. “I literally grew up in the Horde — isn’t the fact that I’m still here proof enough?”

“Like I said, they *say* it’s to prove your loyalty, but there’s more to it than that,” Scorpia said. “There’s a reason they wait until you’re 18 to do it.”

“What do you mean?”

“Every initiation is recorded,” Scorpia explained. “They wait until members turn 18, and then they make them do something illegal on camera. Murder, assault, sex work, money laundering — anything that would get a person into a ton of trouble if they got caught doing it.”

The weight of what she was saying hit Catra like a punch to the gut. Her mind flashed to the tripod and video camera in the motel room — the one that wound up saving her in the end. “It’s blackmail.”

“Yup.” Scorpia shrugged. “That way if a person ever tries to double-cross the Horde, we have something to use against them.”

This made Catra stand up straight. “Wait, seriously?”

Scorpia blinked down at her. “I mean, what else would it be for?”

Catra thought back to Adora’s initiation. She didn’t remember Adora saying anything about a video camera. Then again, maybe she hadn’t seen it.

“Are you sure every initiation gets recorded?” Catra pressed. Scorpia nodded. “Where do videos get stored?”

“As far as I know, the only person who has access to them is Shadow Weaver,” Scorpia replied. “Which is probably for the best, right? We wouldn’t want too many people having access to stuff like that.”

Catra's mind spun. It had been more than a week since Adora betrayed the Horde, and so far no one had been able to track her down. If Scorpia was right, that meant the Horde had video proof of Adora assaulting a man.

And yet, Shadow Weaver hadn't used it.

Shadow Weaver, who was more than willing to subject Catra to a debasing initiation, but didn't seem willing to go after Adora in any meaningful way.

That bitch, Catra thought bitterly. *What the hell is she up to?*

Whatever it was, Catra wasn't going to let her get away with it.

*

Though Adora hadn't believed her at the time, Glimmer wasn't kidding when she said Angella wouldn't even realize there was an unexpected guest living under her roof.

For the first few days after her escape from the Horde, Adora barely left the room Glimmer gave her. She didn't dare touch anything — she didn't even sleep in the clean, soft bed that stood invitingly in the middle of the room. Instead, she spent the nights sleeping on the floor on the other side of it, where she wouldn't be seen should Angella suddenly walk in. When the sun rose, Adora stared at the ceiling, listening to the sound of Glimmer and Angella getting ready for their days. Even after they left, Adora would wait for at least half an hour before creeping out and dashing to the bathroom.

But after a while, Adora realized Glimmer was right; the house was so big, and Angella was rarely home. Slowly, Adora got braver. She started actually sleeping in her bed and wandering upstairs to make herself something to eat instead of waiting for Glimmer to sneak food down to her.

The sprawling house, with all of its underused space, struck Adora as a waste. She thought about the warehouse where she'd spent

her childhood sharing a single room with half a dozen other kids.

"Imagine how many street kids I'd be able to give a safe place to stay if I had a house this big," Adora muttered to herself as she wandered the halls.

Sometimes she spent the day in Glimmer's room, reading her way through her friend's impressive collection of spy thrillers and action novels while she waited for her to come home from school. Often Adora would catch herself gazing at the many photos of Glimmer and Bow that adorned the walls.

She couldn't look at those photos for very long though. The sight of Glimmer and Bow—who, as Adora was learning, had been friends for most of their lives—smiling and laughing through the years of their friendship, made Adora think of Catra. And thinking about Catra broke her heart all over again.

Adora had been hiding out for more than a week when her eyes found the calendar hanging on the kitchen wall. She had missed Catra's birthday for the first time ever. Her fingers traced the number 28 on the page. Catra would be 18 now — a legal adult in the eyes of the law. Adora wondered if she'd been initiated yet. She hoped it hadn't been as awful as her own had been.

"How could I have been so wrong about you?" Adora murmured. In the countless hours she spent alone, she'd developed a habit of talking to Catra in her mind. They'd never spent this much time apart before, and not talking to Catra just felt wrong. But so did the fact that Catra had turned on her. Adora couldn't fathom what she'd done to make her best friend betray her the way she had. "All I wanted was to keep you safe."

That afternoon, Adora found herself restless. She tried working out using the impressive home gym Angella kept in yet another room in the basement. A long run on the treadmill and a few sets of free weights helped to curb Adora's anxious energy, but it was a sorry replacement for what Adora really needed. She hadn't stepped foot outside since the night she arrived — it was just too

risky. But after days upon days of being cooped up inside, even the Brightmoon's opulent home was starting to feel like a prison.

Eager for a distraction, Adora flopped onto the plush living room couch and turned on the large wall-mounted TV. She flipped mindlessly through the channels until a familiar face caught her eye. It was Angella, who stood behind a podium covered in microphones and recording devices. Adora turned up the volume.

"In response to the recent influx of Runestone in Etheria, the E.P.D. has established a special task force dedicated to identifying the source," she said, speaking confidently to a crowd of reporters. One of them raised their hand.

"There is a growing sense of concern throughout the community that the E.P.D. isn't doing enough. What do you have to say to the citizens who have been vocally criticizing the police's handling of the Runestone epidemic?"

Angella grimaced. She looked tired. Dark circles rimmed her eyes. "I understand everyone's frustration, but rest assured, we are working around the clock to do our part. However, as I've said on numerous occasions, this issue won't be solved by making a few arrests. There are larger issues at play here, and I am urging Mayor Prime to declare a state of emergency so that the city can access the resources needed to address the problem holistically."

This response brought on a flurry of follow-up questions from the audience of reporters, who shouted over each other as they vied for Angella's attention. Adora's eyes dropped to the news ticker that traced its way across the bottom of the screen.

Runestone-related deaths on the rise, it read. *Local hospitals report record cases of overdoses as massive supply of Runestone floods city streets*.

Adora's stomach dropped.

"No," she whispered to herself as the world around her started to spin. "No, no, no…"

The guilt was overwhelming. Adora knew exactly where this wave of Runestone was coming from.

"What have I done?" she moaned. "I never should have helped Entrapta with those stupid machines." She dropped her head into her hands and took a few long, deep breaths. People were dying because of her. How could she have been so naive? Her mind raced, desperate to find a way to fix this.

Adora jumped to her feet. "I can't just sit around feeling sorry for myself. I need to make this right."

Flicking off the TV, Adora raced to Glimmer's room. She rummaged around her friend's desk until she unearthed an unused notebook, a stack of sticky notes, and some glitter pens. Supplies in hand, Adora retreated back downstairs to her room. She spent hours filling the pages of the notebook with everything she knew about the Horde. Using the sticky notes, she charted out the hierarchies of the gang, from Hordak at the top to the street kids at the bottom. She mapped out every source of revenue she knew off, and listed as many details about Entrapta's machines and the production of Runestone that she could remember.

She was deep into her work when Glimmer arrived home with Bow on her heels. So deep in fact, that she didn't even hear them come in.

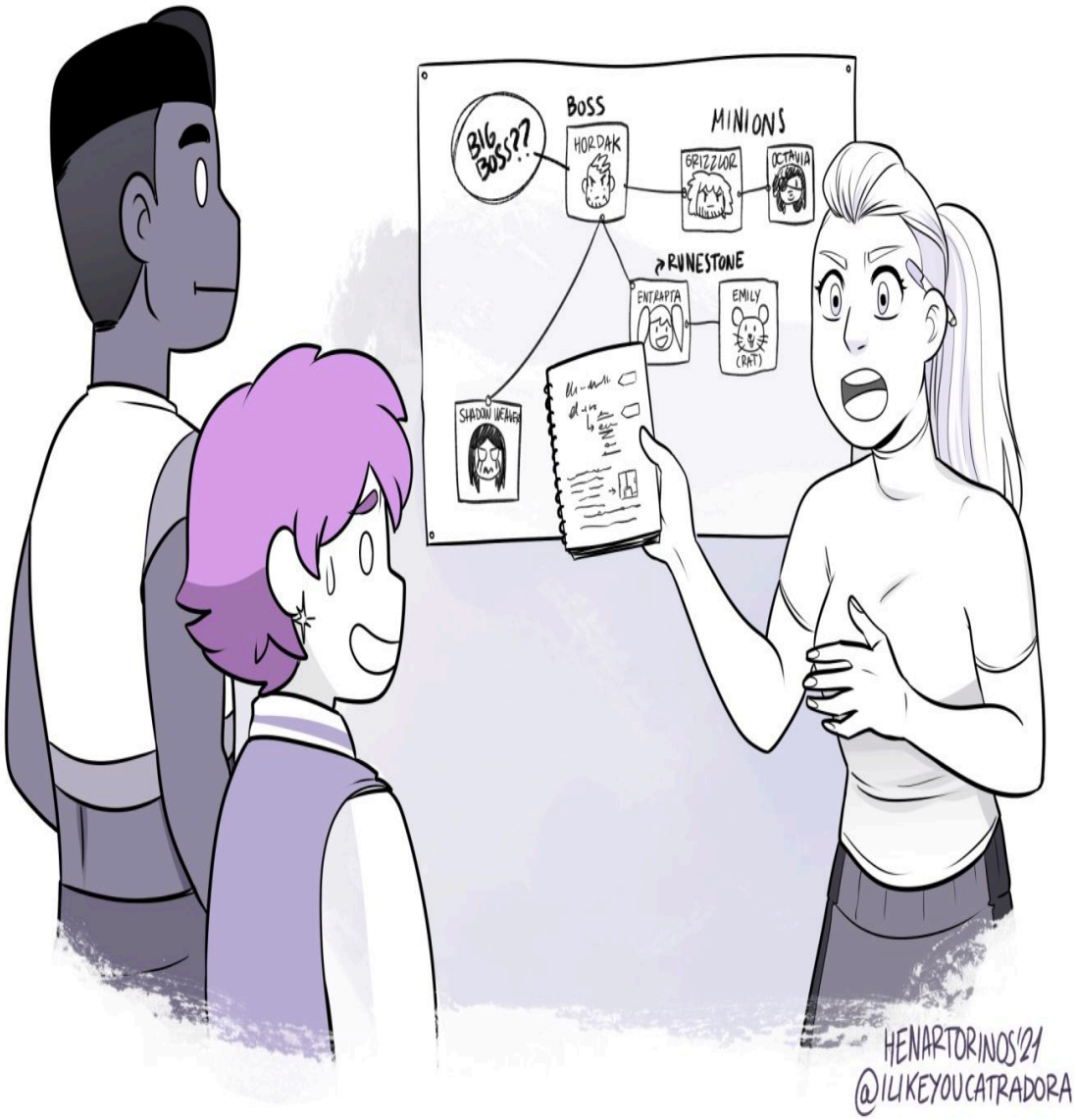
"Adora?" Glimmer called from outside the bedroom door. "Can we come in?"

"Yes!" Adora bounded across the room and threw the door open. "Come here, I have something to show you!"

Bow gasped. "Woah! What is all this?"

"Are those my school supplies?" Glimmer asked, eyeing the pastel sticky notes that covered the walls.

"Focus!" Adora said. She motioned at the chaos around her. "*This* is how we're going to bring down the Horde."



Glimmer raised an eyebrow skeptically. "It is? How?"

Adora faltered. "Well, I'm not sure yet. But I've spent most of the day writing down everything I know about the gang. There's got to be something in all of this we can use, right?"

This got their attention. Glimmer picked up the notebook and scanned a few pages at random, her face lighting up with each line she read. “This is amazing! We’ve got to show this to my mom!”

“Show me what?” Angella’s voice drifted in from the hallway. Glimmer’s eyes grew wide and Adora’s blood turned to ice. Bow lunged for the door, but it was too late.

Chief Angella Brightmoon was already standing in the doorway, her eyes firmly locked on Adora. Several expressions played across her face in rapid succession: surprise, confusion, and at last, anger.

“Someone had better tell me what is going on—” Angella’s eyes flashed dangerously “—*right now*.”

Chapter 18

Adora stood frozen in place, unable to form a single coherent thought under the stare of Chief Angella Brightmoon.

"Mom!" Glimmer cried, sounding almost more scandalized than surprised. "What are you doing here?"

Angella ripped her gaze away from Adora and narrowed it at her daughter. "I had an extremely challenging day and I decided to—Wait, why am I explaining myself? This is *my* home!"

"Please, Mrs. Brightmoon," Bow pleaded in a tone that was much less offensive than his friend's. "It's not what it looks like."

"So you're telling me that I'm *imagining* a member of the most dangerous gang in Etheria standing in my spare room?" Angella snapped. Bow winced.

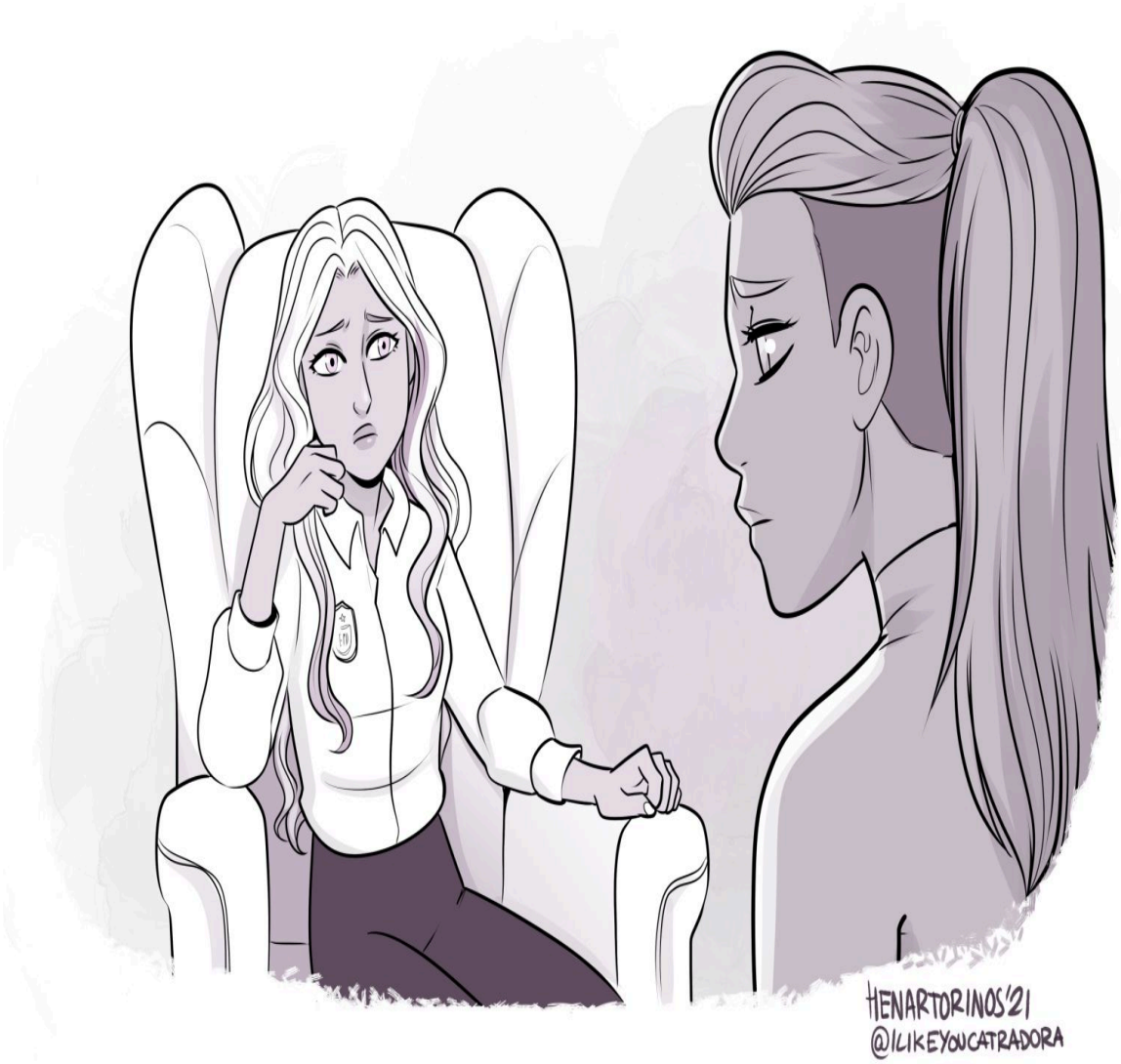
"*Ex*-gang member, Mom," Glimmer said. "Where else was she supposed to go?"

The room fell silent. This seemed to snap Angella out of her tantrum. She turned her attention back to Adora with a look of surprise. "Is that true?"

Slowly, Adora nodded. The last conversation she had with Etheria's chief of police replayed in her mind. She shrank back in shame remembering their stormy argument and the way she'd vowed to find her own way to destroy the Horde. And now here she was, living under Angella's roof like a squatter and no further ahead than before. If Adora had a tail, it would be firmly tucked between her legs.

With a heavy sigh, Angella stepped back from the doorway and motioned for everyone to follow her. Adora, Glimmer, and Bow exchanged uneasy glances as they fell into line and marched upstairs to the living room.

“Sit,” Angella said, taking a seat in an elegant winged-back armchair that made her look like a queen on a throne. “Tell me everything.”



Adora hesitated, clutching her notebook to her chest. She didn’t want to get Glimmer into any more trouble than she already was.

Glimmer, however, didn’t seem to share the same concerns.

“Adora was helping us build a case against the Horde,” Glimmer said without a hint of hesitation. “She was our woman on the inside.”

Anger flashed across her mother's face once more. Angella opened her mouth, then seemed to think better of it.

"We figured if we gathered the evidence on our own, you wouldn't have to worry about breaking police procedures," Bow said.

Angella sighed and massaged her temple. "Police procedure was never my concern." She turned her eyes to Adora. "I was worried about your safety. We talked about this."

"I know," Adora agreed sheepishly. "But I couldn't just sit there and wait for things to happen."

"So instead you joined forces with my teenage daughter and her best friend." Angella did not sound impressed.

"Pretty much," Glimmer said. She folded her arms defiantly, and Adora wondered if this was how most daughters and mothers behaved with one another. "And we were doing really great work until…" Now, Glimmer faltered. She shot Adora an apologetic look. Bow took Adora's hand in his and gave it a reassuring squeeze.

"Yes, let's talk about how you wound up hiding in my house." There was no cruelty or disappointment in Angella's voice. Instead, Chief Brightmoon seemed to be bracing herself for the story.

Adora took a deep breath. "I got caught. Somehow they figured it out. I— I must not have been as careful as I thought." She couldn't bring herself to look Angella in the eyes as she spoke. She wasn't sure if she could handle the way she was gazing at her —face full of heartbreak and pity—without breaking down.

There was a moment of heavy silence before anyone spoke again.

"Adora," Angella said softly. "Where's Catra?"

"She…" Adora paused to swallow the lump that rose in her throat at the thought of her best friend. "She stayed behind."

Glimmer and Bow didn't need to speak for Adora to know exactly what they were thinking as they exchanged puzzled looks with one another. As far as they knew, Catra had betrayed Adora — she couldn't blame them for not understanding why she wasn't saying as much. But Adora couldn't do it; she wasn't ready to completely give up on her best friend, even if Catra had already given up on her.

"Are you in danger?" Angella asked, and Adora appreciated the deft change in subject.

"If they find me, they'll probably kill me," Adora admitted, staring down at her lap. "The Horde doesn't tolerate deserters."

Angella sat back in her throne and pressed her lips into a thin line. She thought for a moment, and Adora, Glimmer, and Bow waited silently for her verdict.

"We'll have to get you into witness protection then," Angella said at last. "You can start over somewhere new, where you can be safe."

This made Adora's head snap up in alarm. "What? No!"

"Mom, no," Glimmer pleaded. "You can't just send her away!"

"She literally just said that her life is in danger," Angella said, raising her voice. "It would be irresponsible to do anything else."

"I'm not going anywhere." Adora shook her head. "Not until the Horde is finished."

"Adora," Angella leaned forward in her seat and looked Adora straight in the eyes. "Let the police handle this."

Without meaning to, Adora let out a bark of laughter. "With all due respect, the police have no idea what they're up against. I know you're trying, but you haven't managed to make a meaningful impact on the Horde for as long as I can remember — and I've been with the gang for almost my entire life."

She expected Angella to be mad — after all, it was a pretty disrespectful thing to say to the chief of police. Adora didn't have much love for law enforcement, no matter how highly she thought of Angella. But instead of blowing up in rage the way Shadow Weaver definitely would have, Angella simply sighed.

"Why now?" Angella asked. "I've known you for years, Adora. After all of the times I tried to get you to ask for help—to tell me what was going on—what changed?"

Adora's lip trembled as her mind flashed through a supercut of what led her to this point.

"I always knew the Horde was bad, but I didn't realize just how bad until I got promoted," she said. "After I turned 18, I was initiated as an adult member of the gang and…" She hesitated, remembering who she was talking to. "They made me do something I'm not proud of. All my life I thought that if I could just make it to Force Captain, I'd be able to leave all of the awful shit behind — that somehow things would get better. But there's no such thing as 'better' in the Horde. I see that now."

Beside her, Bow shifted. He pulled his knee up and twisted so he was facing her. His brow was furrowed over his dark eyes. "You've never talked about this stuff with us before. What happened to you?"

"It's not just about what happened to me," Adora said, shrinking under everyone's undivided attention. "It's about what happened to all of us — what's going to keep happening to my friends if things don't change." She could feel the words coming faster, like an eruption of suppressed confessions that refused to be contained any longer. "You have no idea what they put us through — the ways we'd be punished for every stupid little thing."

"Hold on," Angella said. "Who's 'we'? You and Catra?"

"Me, Catra, all of the kids. The Horde treats all of them like shit." Adora lifted her hand and turned it so the gold bracelet Catra had

given her shifted on her wrist. Despite everything that had happened, Adora couldn't bring herself to get rid of it. Instead, now that she didn't have to worry about getting caught with it, she never took it off. It was her constant reminder of what she was fighting for.

She had to take a moment to steady herself before continuing. As much as she wanted to forget that terrible day, the scene was burned into her mind like a hot brand into flesh. "Catra gave me this when I got promoted. She saved up for months to buy it. But when Shadow Weaver found out Catra had been stealing from her earnings to pay for it, she punished her in front of everyone. She cut her and whipped her until Catra couldn't even stand." A hot tear spilled from Adora's eye and slid down her cheek. "Maybe it's too late for Catra and I, but I can still make sure no other kid has to suffer the way we did."

The silence in the room was heavy. Glimmer balled her hands into furious little fists, while Bow pressed his hand over his mouth.

"How many children are there, Adora?" Angella asked breathlessly.

"Dozens," Adora replied. She smoothed her thumb over the *Hey Adora* engraving on her bracelet. "Some as young as 6 or 7. Shadow Weaver can't bring in as many new recruits as she used to when she work for social services, but she still manages to—"

Angella waved her hands frantically in the air. "Wait. Are you saying Shadow Weaver *isn't* a social worker anymore? Since when?"

Adora pursed her lips. She knew what Angella was really asking — she wanted to know if she had ever unknowingly released kids like Adora and Catra to a predatory gangster. Adora didn't have the heart to tell her that, yes, she had. So she shrugged instead and lied. "I can't remember exactly."

"I don't get it," Glimmer growled with loud indignation. She jumped to her feet and paced. "How does the Horde have a small

army of children at its disposal? And why do the kids stay if things are that bad?"

Though she knew Glimmer meant well, Adora couldn't help but bristle. "*We* stay because we have nowhere else to go." She lumped herself in with the other Horde kids to remind the others of their humanity. It was so easy for someone as privileged as Glimmer to forget that these kids were people too. "When your only other option is trying to survive on the streets, what the Horde is offering is hard to refuse."

"Oh," Glimmer shrank back, her round cheeks flushing a deep scarlet. "Right…"

"What exactly was the Horde offering?" Bow asked, redirecting the conversation.

"Well, for starters, a place to live." Adora flipped through her notebook to a map she'd drawn of the warehouse's location. She held it up for the others to see and pointed to the building she'd drawn in glittery purple pen. "It's not much — just an abandoned warehouse on the corner of 5th and Campbell in the old industrial district."

Angella leaned closer and peered at the page. She pointed to the notebook. "What is this?"

"I spent most of the day writing down everything I know about the Horde," Adora replied. She flipped through the pages. "Hierarchies, revenue streams, Runestone production — I may not know everything about the gang, but what I do know is in this notebook."

"May I have a look?" Angella held out her hand. Adora reached forward, ready to hand the notebook over. But then she hesitated and pulled it back against her chest.

"No."

Glimmer gawked at her. “But I thought the whole reason you wrote all that stuff down was so that we could use it against the Horde."

“I’m just trying to help, Adora.” Angella sounded hurt.

Adora shook her head. “This is my only leverage. If I hand this over, what’s to stop you from cutting me out? I already told you that I’m going to be part of bringing the Horde down. So, whether you like it or not, if you want this information you’re going to have to work with me to get it.”

Giving an ultimatum to the woman in whose house she was secretly living wasn’t very strategic on Adora’s part. While Angella straightened up and pinned her under one of her intense and inscrutable gazes, Adora set her jaw and held her ground. Finally, after what felt like the world’s longest staring contest, Angella sighed and got to her feet. She walked toward the kitchen, leaving Adora and the others to blink at one another.

“Mom?” Glimmer ventured. “Where are you going?”

Angella paused and looked back over her shoulder. “I’m going to order dinner. Glimmer, I expect you and Bow to finish your homework before we eat. Adora, go tidy your room please.”

The three friends gaped as Angella breezed out of the room without another word.

“What just happened?” Adora asked.

Glimmer let out a squeal. “I think that was my mom’s way of saying you can stay!” She and Bow wrapped Adora in a crushing group hug.

“Another win for the Best Friends Squad!” Bow crowed.

Dizzy with relief, Adora looked down at the notebook still clutched in her hands. Maybe, she hoped, things were finally starting to turn around.

Chapter 19

Adora couldn't be certain, but she was pretty sure that Angella Brightmoon hated her.

For the first couple of days Adora hardly saw her, though she wasn't sure if that was because the chief of police was avoiding her or just busy. She figured Angella was probably still mad that she had been hiding out in her house. (Which was understandable.) She was also probably bitter that Adora refused to hand over everything she knew about the Horde. (Which was also understandable, but Adora didn't feel bad about that part.)

Still, Adora didn't want Angella to hate her. After all, Angella could have kicked her out and left her to fend for herself.

But she hadn't.

She let her stay, and for that Adora was eternally grateful.

Now that her secret was out, Adora was free to move around the house at any time. She made use of her many long hours alone by being the best unexpected house guest she could be. If growing up in the Horde had given her anything, it was a good work ethic. Adora put those years of hard labor to use by scrubbing the floors, deep cleaning the bathrooms (Of which there were many.) and even doing small repairs around the home. She may not have been able to give Angella what she wanted, but she could still find other ways to earn her keep.

"You're really making me look bad," Glimmer said one day when she came home from school to find all the hardwood polished and the carpets shampooed. "You know you don't have to do all of this, right?"

"Well I've got to do something," Adora replied, falling back onto Glimmer's bed with a *whump*. "If I don't keep myself busy I think I'll go crazy."

Glimmer settled down onto the mattress beside her. "I know how you feel. I get serious cabin fever whenever Mom grounds me."

Adora chuckled. "I was going to say 'at least you don't have to worry about dying if you get caught sneaking out', but then I remembered who your mom is and realized getting caught by her wouldn't be much better."

This sent Glimmer into a fit of laughter too. "Seriously! I don't know who I'd rather face off against: the Horde or my mom!"

Maybe it was because they hadn't laughed in a while, but once Adora and Glimmer started, they couldn't seem to stop. They lay on Glimmer's bed, laughing until their sides ached and their eyes were wet with tears. It felt so good that Adora had to wonder why she didn't do it more often.

But as the laughter faded, she remembered why. She rolled over so she was facing Glimmer.

"Actually, I think your mom's mad at me," she confessed quietly.

"What? No way!" Glimmer waved off the suggestion with a flip of her hand. "Trust me, I know what she's like when she's mad."

Adora chewed her bottom lip. "But she's barely said two words to me since she caught me."

"She's just really stressed out." Glimmer sighed. "This new wave of Runestone has put a lot of pressure on the department. I heard there's a protest that's being organized for this weekend."

"A protest? About Runestone?" Adora frowned. "What's that supposed to do?"

Glimmer rolled onto her back and laced her fingers behind her head. She glared up at the ceiling as if it had done something to offend her. "It's not about Runestone — it's about the police's response to Runestone. People don't think they've done enough to fix the problem."

“Ah,” was all Adora could say to that. She knew where she stood in that debate, and she didn’t think Glimmer would appreciate her thoughts on the matter. It was things like this that really made their friendship seem so unusual. They were both after the same thing, and they both knew they had to step in to make up for the system’s failings. But where Glimmer seemed to believe in the system—that all it needed was a little extra help to make things happen—Adora didn’t trust it at all.

A light knock came from Glimmer’s door.

“Yeah?” Glimmer called.

“Glimmer?” Angella replied. “Is Adora in there with you?”

The girls glanced at one another and sat up. It was as if they’d manifested Angella just by talking about her. Adora scooted off the bed and opened the door. There, Angella stood surrounded by shopping bags from stores that a street kid like Adora couldn’t step foot in without being followed around by security.

“Is everything okay?” Adora asked.

Angella cleared her throat. “I hope this doesn’t feel like an imposition, but I picked up a few things for you on my way home.”

Adora gaped. She looked back down at the bags. “You… you got me something?”

“Just a few things,” Angella said, gathering the bags and handing them—*all* of them—to her. “I noticed that you don’t have much with you. It was thoughtful of Glimmer to share her wardrobe with you, but I thought it was time for you to have some clothes that actually fit.”

Heat crept up Adora's neck and onto her cheeks. She glanced down at her ankles, which stretched well past the cuffs of the sweatpants she’d borrowed from Glimmer. Adora wasn’t

embarrassed; she knew what a mess she was. But this… it was all so much.

"I can't accept this," she blurted, suddenly flustered. "I mean, I appreciate it, I really do! But it's— you don't have to—"

"Adora," Angella said gently as she placed a hand on her shoulder. She smiled so kindly that it almost made Adora cry. "It's okay. I think your new post-Horde life deserves a fresh start, don't you?"

"I can pay you back," Adora insisted. "Like, not right away obviously, but I promise I'll get a job and—"

But Angella shook her head. "Absolutely not. Now try everything on and let me know if it fits."

Glimmer let out a squeal and threw her arms around Adora's shoulders. "Time for a makeover!"

Blinking back tears, Adora looked back at Angella. "Thank you."

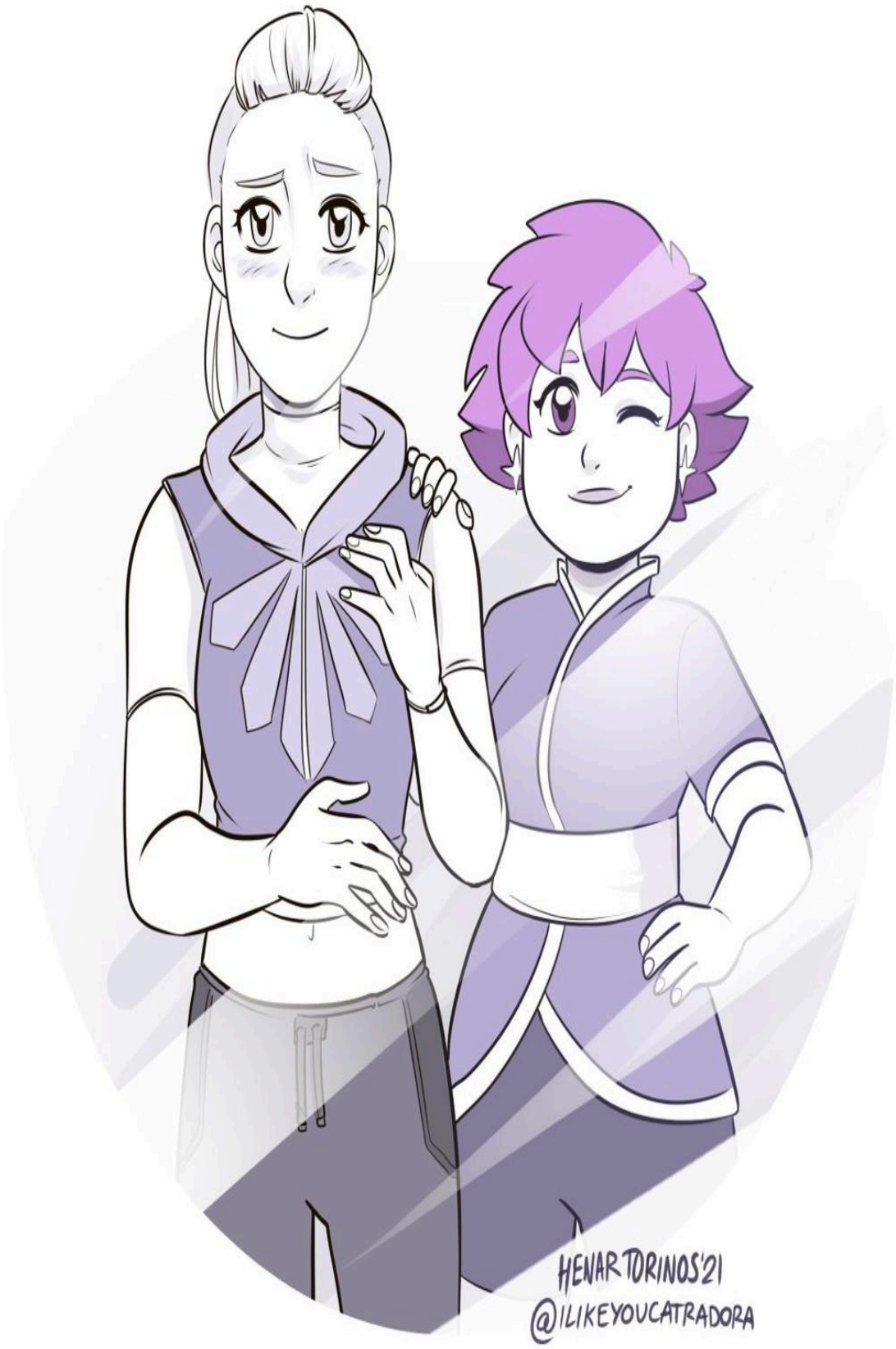
With a polite nod of her head, Angella retreated to give the girls a bit of privacy. Adora dumped the bags at the foot of Glimmer's bed and started pulling things from the mounds of tissue paper inside. It seemed that Angella's definition of "a few" was quite different from hers. In the bags Adora found several pairs of new pants and shirts, all with a sporty flare to them that she loved right away. There were new sneakers and socks, and a couple sets of pajamas. One entire bag was filled with undergarments, which she was quick to shove out of Glimmer's sight.

"I've gotta hand it to my mom," Glimmer said, holding up a red sleeveless hoodie that wasn't unlike the one Adora already had. This one however, came emblazoned with a stylized starburst embroidered in gold across the front. "She may be strict and uptight, but she's got great style."

Adora pulled on one of her new outfits and hurried over to Glimmer's full-length mirror. She ran her fingertips reverently over

the pristine fabric and unmarred hems of the clothes, trying to make herself believe that any of it was real.

Glimmer came up beside her, arms crossed and grinning widely. She caught Adora's eyes in the mirror and winked at her. "See? I told you she wasn't mad at you."


HENARTORINOS'21
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Adora was awoken on Saturday by the sound of the doorbell. Scampering out of bed, she got dressed and grabbed her notebook. She was excited to start the day.

When she made it upstairs, she found Glimmer and Bow sitting in the living room with takeaway coffee cups cradled in their hands. The TV was turned onto a news channel, which played quietly in the background of their conversation.

“Hey, Bow!” Adora chirped as she flopped into an armchair.

“”Morning, Adora!” Bow handed her a cup of her own. “I come bearing gifts!”

A paper bag sat on the coffee table. The smell of fresh baked pastries wafted from inside.

“You’re my hero,” Adora said, sliding onto the floor and tugging the bag over. The others laughed and joined her.

“Okay, team,” Glimmer announced once they’d each demolished a muffin. “It’s time to strategize.”

Bow cleared space on the coffee table and Adora tossed her notebook down so they could look at it together.

“I’ve been adding to it whenever I think of something new,” Adora said, flipping through the pages.

“What’s that?” Bow asked. He reached in and turned back to one of Adora’s drawings.

“It’s the floorplan of the Horde’s headquarters,” Adora explained.

“The one pretending to be a garage, right?” Glimmer asked as she leaned in to get a better look.

“Sort of.” Adora traced a finger through the room like a rat traversing a maze. “They actually do work on cars in the front

here, but if you go through this door it brings you to this big open space."

Glimmer jabbed her finger at the room labeled 'Entrapta's lab'. "And this is where the Runestone is made?"

Adora nodded. "As far as I know, it's all made right there."

Bow pulled his laptop from his bag and pulled up a satellite map of the area. He turned it so the others could see the screen.

"The building's way bigger than I thought it was. I can see why they use it as a home base."

Holding up her drawing next to the screen, Adora tried to visualize how the layout fit into the structure. "Wow, it looks like there's a lot of space that I've never seen. I wonder what else is in there."

"Oh no," Glimmer gasped. Adora and Bow looked up in alarm.

"What's wrong?" Bow asked. Glimmer pointed to the television. The screen showed a helicopter's view of the streets of Etheria, where a massive crowd was gathered outside of what appeared to be the police precinct.

"Is that the protest?" Adora asked, her eyes raking over the surprising size of the crowd.

Bow grabbed the remote and turned up the volume.

The newscaster's voice played over the footage. "As you can see, what started as a small, grassroots demonstration has grown quickly as hundreds of people take to the streets to protest the Etheria Police Department's response to the Runestone crisis."

The footage switched to a view from the street. The camera panned across the crowd, taking in the swarm of angry, shouting faces and hand-painted signs. DO YOU DAMN JOB, read one. Another, written in dripping red paint declared, MY SON'S BLOOD IS ON YOUR HANDS. A child riding on her father's shoulders

carried a sign that said, E.P.D SHOULD BE ASHAMED. An old man wore a sandwich board over his shoulders that asked, HOW MANY MORE HAVE TO DIE?.

Adora was breathless. She looked at Glimmer, who was gripping Bow's hand as if her life depended on it.

"I need to get down there," Glimmer said without taking her eyes off the screen.

"Glimmer, no," Bow replied. "It could get dangerous."

"All the more reason to go!" she insisted, her volume of her voice rising. "If something happens down there I don't want to find out about it on the news. My mom is in that building!"

Bow turned to Adora. She could tell by the furrow in his brow that he was hoping she'd back him up. Unfortunately for him, she was on Glimmer's side.

"I'm with Glimmer on this one," she said, getting to her feet. "We should be there. I wouldn't put it past the Horde to take advantage of the situation somehow."

"All the more reason to stay here!" Bow cried, throwing his hands up in disbelief. "Adora, you're supposed to be laying low."

"I've *been* laying low, Bow. And I'm sick of it!" Adora could feel all of her pent up frustration bubbling to the surface, threatening to explode. "I can't just sit here anymore."

Glimmer jumped up. "Adora's right — we can't keep sitting around waiting for something to happen. I mean, something *is* happening and we're missing it!"

Though he looked dismayed, Bow begrudgingly stood up. "For the record, I think this is a very bad idea."

"But you're still coming, right?" Glimmer asked, clutching his arm.

He sighed. “Yes, of course I’m coming.”

Adora punched the air victoriously. “Alright, Best Friends Squad! It’s time for our first mission!”

Chapter 20

It was the first time Adora had set foot outside in weeks, and she was surprised by how unnerving it felt. At first, as she, Glimmer, and Bow piled out the front door, Adora was exhilarated. She took in deep breaths of fresh, cool air and savored the way it filled her lungs. The day was overcast, but the natural light filtering through the cloud cover was still a welcome change.

But as she and her friends walked toward the bus stop, anxiety bloomed in Adora's chest. She pulled her hood over her head and avoided making eye contact with anyone they passed along the way. In the safety of the sprawling Brightmoon home it was easy for her to forget that she was a wanted woman. The Horde could be anywhere; she was going to have to stay alert and vigilant.

"As long as there are plenty of other people around, I think we should be okay," Bow whispered as if he could read Adora's mind. They boarded the bus and took the row of seats at the very back of it. "I doubt the Horde will try anything if there are a bunch of witnesses."

Adora didn't have the heart to tell him that, if they did, it wouldn't be the first time.

The bus pulled away, leaving Glimmer's posh neighborhood behind. Adora watched the fancy houses and spacious lawns give way to streets lined with densely packed apartment buildings and businesses. Glimmer watched the cityscape morph around them as she tapped her lips and hummed thoughtfully.

"I wonder if I should have brought my baseball bat," she mused quietly.

"What for?" Adora asked.

"To defend us." The way Glimmer said this implied that the answer should have been obvious. "Y'know, just in case things get

messy out there."

Bow shot her an admonishing look. "Glimmer, you don't bring weapons to a peaceful protest. That's how things get out of hand."

"Technically, a bat's not a weapon!" Glimmer countered. "For all anyone knows, I might be on my way to a game!"

"Baseball season is over, Glimmer," Bow said flatly.

As they bickered, Adora looked down at her empty hands. She didn't want to admit it out loud, but Glimmer had a point. Adora felt vulnerable being back in the world without anything to defend herself with.

Glimmer crossed her arms and flopped back in her seat. "I'm just saying, it would be nice to have something on hand just in case."

Bow turned to Adora. "Did you carry a weapon when you were with the Horde?"

"Sometimes," Adora admitted. "But it could be dangerous on the streets. I had to be able to protect myself."

"Like what?" Glimmer asked, leaning in with a sparkle in her eye. "Did you ever get into fights?"

Adora raised an eyebrow. She wondered if Glimmer understood what she was asking. "Yeah. They taught us how to fight growing up — how to defend ourselves."

"That is so badass," Glimmer said.

"Not really," Adora replied, shaking her head. "Having to literally fight to stay alive isn't as cool as it sounds."

"I'm sorry, Adora." Bow laid a hand on her shoulder. "That sounds really hard."

Adora nodded. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Glimmer bite her lip. Adora knew Glimmer meant well—that she probably didn't know any better—but she was still stunned by how different their realities were. Still, she knew Glimmer was learning; she was trying to be a better person, even if the growing pains were more than a little uncomfortable at times.

"Listen," Adora said, taking her friends' hands in each of hers. "If push comes to shove, I know how to defend us. But let's not go out of our way to be part of the problem, okay?"

"Of course." Glimmer smiled sheepishly. "We'll follow your lead."

The bus rolled up to the stop closest to the police precinct and most of the passengers disembarked. As they walked, Adora looked around. Her stomach sank as she wondered if all of these people were all headed to the protest as well. They heard the crowd before they saw it. Shouts and chants echoed between the buildings. Adora cast an anxious glance at her friends and saw they looked just as apprehensive as she felt.

They rounded the corner of an office building and found what they were looking for. The crowd had almost doubled in size since they'd seen it on the news. A sea of people stood between the trio and the precinct.

"Oh no," Glimmer moaned, gazing around the crowd. "This is... This is a lot of people."

"Hey, at least the crowd is calm, right?" Adora said, offering her friend a reassuring smile.

As the tallest in the group, Bow rose onto his toes and tried to see over the mass of people. "I'm not sure we're going to be able to reach the building. I can't see a break in the crowd from back here."

"I could shimmy up this lamp post," Glimmer said, pointing to the one they were standing next to.

Bow glared. "Are you *trying* to get us into trouble?"

"No to the lamp post, but you've got the right idea." Adora maneuvered Glimmer so she was standing between her and Bow. "We can give you a boost so you can get a better look."

She and Bow crouched down and made footholds of their hands so they could hoist Glimmer up. Glimmer shielded her eyes with a hand and peered over the heads of the protesters.

"Oh, I think I see a break in the crowd. If we head up the street and stick close to the buildings, we might be able to come in from the side."

Back on the ground, Glimmer motioned for Adora and Bow to follow her. Even at the outskirts of the crowd, things were busy and chaotic. But the Best Friend Squad was able to duck signs and weave around people easily enough. After about half a block, the congregation thinned out and Glimmer pointed to a small gap in the mass around some parked cars.

"This way!" she said, picking up her pace. She walked, half turned, keeping an eye on Adora and Bow as she went. Unfortunately, this meant she wasn't paying attention to what was in front of her. In the split-second it took her to glance back at her friends, Glimmer crashed right into one of the protesters and stumbled back into Adora.

"Hey, watch it!"

Adora froze.

She'd know that voice anywhere. From over Glimmer's shoulder Adora lifted her eyes and found a mismatched pair staring back at her.

"Catra?" she gasped.

A look of surprise flickered across Catra's face, and for a moment, the world stood still. The noise dissipated and the crowd fell away

as Adora's entire worldview narrowed in with laser focus on the girl in front of her.

But the moment was fleeting. In the time it took Catra to blink, her entire demeanor changed. Her eyes cut into Adora, her glare sharp with disdain. Catra had never, ever looked at her that way, and it broke Adora's heart all over again.

Catra planted her hands on her hips—hips that Adora realized were now clad in new jeans that hugged her figure in a heartstopping way—and sneered.

"Hey, Adora." There was no mirth or kindness in the way Catra said the words that used to make Adora so happy. "Pretty ballsy of you to show up to this thing." Her eyes flicked between Glimmer and Bow, who flanked Adora on either side. "And you brought your new besties. How cute."

Adora hesitated, uncertain of what to do. Instincts told her to go to Catra, to wrap her arms around her and never let go. But experience told her that the game was different now — she needed to be careful.

"Catra," Adora said, breathless. Despite her better judgement, she reached out for her hand. Catra's eyes caught on the bracelet on Adora's wrist, and for a heartbeat, her stony expression faltered. "Are you okay? I've been worried sick about you."

"Are you fucking serious?" Catra spat, yanking her hand back. "You've been *worried* about me? That's rich coming from someone who was going to turn me and everyone else you pretended to care about into the cops."

Adora gaped. "What are you talking about? I was never going to turn you in—"

Before she could finish, a towering woman with short white hair and red tattoos stepped into the space between Adora and Catra.

"Are these punks bothering you, Wildcat?" she asked, cracking her knuckles ominously.

"Woah," Glimmer said. She had to crane her head back just to get a good look at her.

"Do you mind?" Adora stepped closer. "We were in the middle of a conversation."

The tall woman shook her head. "If you want to talk to my partner, you'll have to go through me first."

Adora glanced back at Catra, who stood smirking at the woman's elbow.

"Partner?" Adora choked.

"Yup," Catra said, grinning. "A lot's happened since you decided to desert us, Adora. I've been initiated and I'm moving up in the ranks." As if to make her point, she adjusted the front of her new leather jacket. "Scorpia and I make quite a team, don't you think?"

A small part of Adora bristled at the insinuation of Catra being with someone else, professionally or otherwise. But a bigger part of her couldn't get past the fact that it had happened: Catra had been initiated, and Adora had been powerless to stop it.

"What did they make you do, Catra?" she asked. "Are you okay?"

A shadow passed over Catra's features. It was a flicker — a change so quick and nearly imperceptible that anyone else would have missed it completely. But Adora wasn't just anyone. No one else knew Catra like she did, and that ghost of a look told her everything she needed to know.

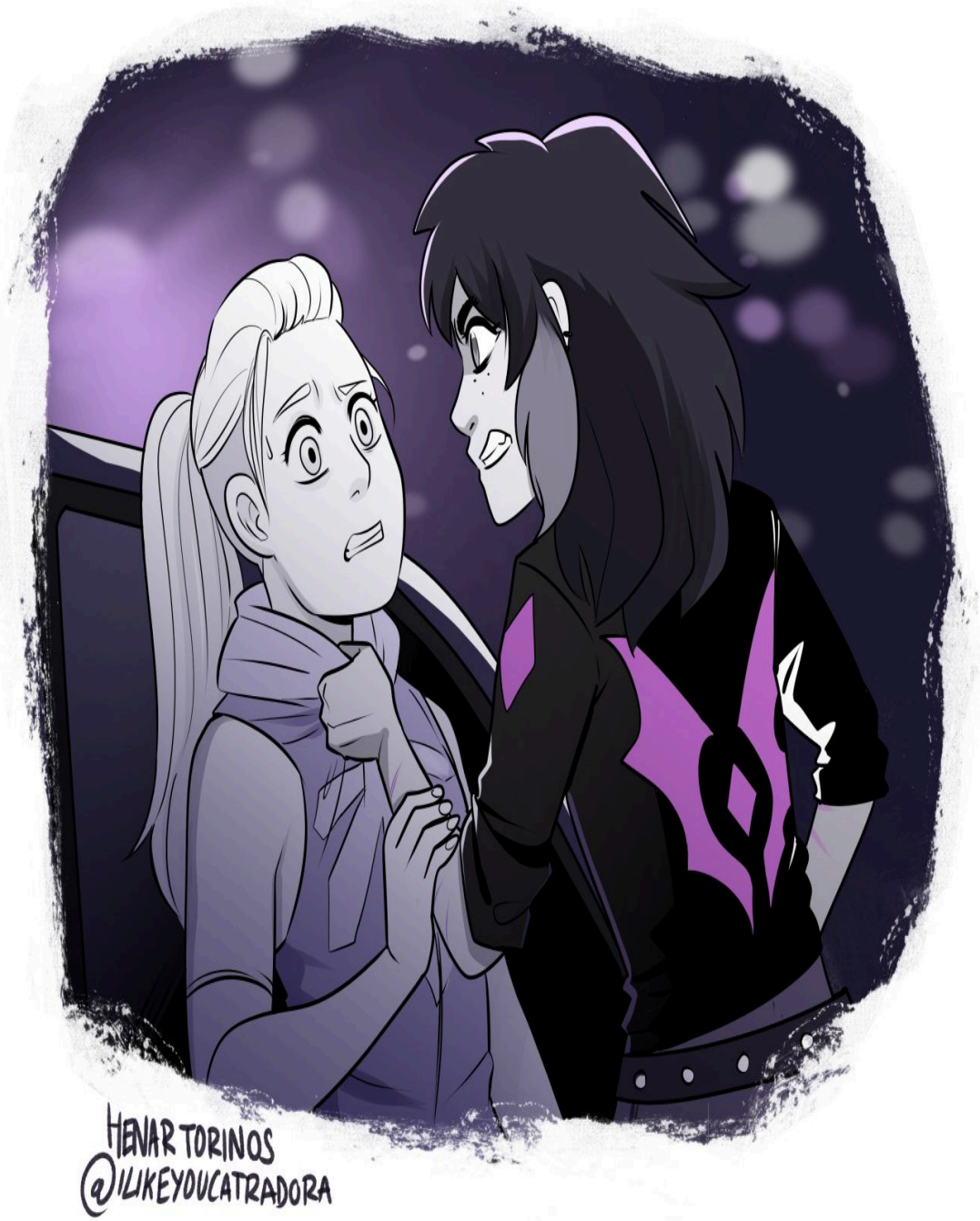
"Oh, Catra," she said and she tried to step around Scorpia. "I'm so sorry. I didn't want—"

Again, Scorpia interrupted, this time with a hard shove to Adora's shoulder that would have knocked her to the ground had Glimmer and Bow not been there to catch her.

"What the hell?" Glimmer shouted amid the gasps and reprimands of the protesters around them.

"What did I just say?" Scorpia said, looming over them. She lurched toward them, only to be pulled back by Catra.

"Stand down, big gal. I'll take care of her myself." Catra stepped forward and grabbed the front of Adora's shirt. She hauled her closer so that they were face to face. Adora could hear Glimmer and Bow shouting for Catra to stop as they tugged at her shoulders, trying to free her from Catra's grip.



Adora waved them off without looking away from Catra's gaze. "It's okay. I've got this."

This made Catra laugh. "Oh, Adora. Are you having fun pretending to be a fucking hero? Well you're doing a shitty job." She yanked Adora closer still, until there was barely any space between them.

"Don't talk to me about being sorry. I can't believe I ever trusted you."

Hot tears stung at Adora's eyes, but she forced herself not to cry. Her heart felt like it had been replaced by a stone.

"You want to talk about trust?" she snapped, shoving Catra back. "You're the one who ratted me out to Shadow Weaver. If you trusted me so much, why did you think I was trying to hurt you, Catra?"

Her words hit their mark. Catra hesitated, her grip softened. She licked her lips, and for a moment, Adora could have sworn she saw a hint of hope in those dual-colored eyes.

And then a phone rang. Adora and Catra started at one another awkwardly. When the phone rang a second time, Catra released Adora with a hiss.

"Shit," Catra said, pulling an expensive-looking new phone from her back pocket. She motioned to Scorpia. "Keep an eye on them."

She turned away, pressing the phone to one ear and her hand over the other to block out some of the noise.

"I'm kind of busy," Catra snapped instead of answering the phone like a normal person. There was a beat as she listened. Adora watched as Catra went rigid. Something was wrong.

"What?" Catra shouted. "When? How did they—" She stopped short and turned slowly. Her eyes locked on Adora, and there was no mistaking the look in them: Catra was livid.

"I'll be right there," Catra said before ending the call abruptly. Without warning, Catra blew past Scorpia, grabbed Adora by the shoulders and threw her into the parked car beside them. Adora felt the car rock with the impact as the air was knocked from her lungs. The car alarm went off, and the crowd around them backed up, stumbling and shoving to get away from the chaos.

"Catra, what are you doing?" Adora choked.

"How could you?" Catra howled, her eyes wild and unfamiliar. She drew her fist back, but Adora was able to block the punch before it landed. "Did you ever really care about any of us?"

Their hands locked and they pushed against one another, both trying to overpower the other.

"What are you talking about?" Adora grunted through the exertion of grappling with Catra, who seemed almost feral with rage.

Catra gnashed her teeth, and Adora had to twist just to avoid getting bitten. She'd seen Catra mad before, but never like this. She'd never been on the receiving end of Catra's fury, and it scared her.

In one swift motion, Catra swept her leg around, knocking Adora's feet out from under her. Adora hit the ground hard. All around them, people shouted.

"That's enough!" shouted a stranger as he and a group of protesters surged toward them. "This is a peaceful protest. Break it up."

Adora looked up at Catra, who was backing away slowly. Over Catra's shoulder, Adora could see Glimmer and Bow wrestling with Scorpia, trying to reach her.

"Leave them," Catra barked at Scorpia. "We've got to go."

Scorpia did as she was told, tossing Glimmer and Bow down like a set of luggage. The pair shoved their way through the crowd. Before they disappeared, Catra glanced back one last time.

And then she was gone.

"Adora!" Glimmer cried as she scrambled to Adora's side. "Are you okay?"

"Yeah, I think so," Adora replied. Bow reached down, and she let him tug her to her feet.

Bow was out of breath. His chest heaved as he clasped Adora's hand tightly. "What was that all about?"

With her heart and body aching, Adora looked to the place where Catra and Scorpia had escaped into the crowd. There was no sign of them now.

"I'm not sure." She swallowed hard and shook her head. "But whatever it was, it can't be good."

Chapter 21

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

[**CONTENT WARNING** This chapter contains a scene in which characters are detained by police. Though not violent, it still may be triggering to some readers. Please see the end of the chapter for specific content warnings and take care when reading. Reader discretion is advised.]

Scorpia's car was parked a couple blocks away from the precinct. Catra ran the entire way, her long brown hair streaming behind her as she darted around people on the busy sidewalk.

"What's going on?" Scorpia called between huffs of breath. Unlike Catra, she wasn't built for speed and the running was taking its toll on her.

Catra came to a skidding stop beside Scorpia's slick red and black sports car—something that probably cost more money than Catra would ever see in her life—and glared back at her partner. "I'll explain later. Just hurry up!"

Breathless, Scorpia unlocked the car and the pair jumped inside.

"Get to the warehouse," Catra barked. "As fast as you can."

Tire squealing, Scorpia peeled away from the curb and cut into traffic. Horns and angry shouts blared in their wake, but neither of them paid it any mind. Scorpia passed other cars and took sharp turns down narrow alleys as if she were in a race. Though she would never say it out loud, Catra appreciated her enthusiasm.

"So, what happened back there?" Scorpia asked as they sped through the city. Her dark eyes scanned the street, maneuvering her vehicle with expert precision. "Who called you?"

Catra's knee bounced. She had a surplus of nervous energy and it was making her jittery. Staring straight ahead, she watched the tall buildings of downtown shrink into the crumbling district she knew so well.

"It was Shadow Weaver," Catra replied. "Something's going down at the warehouse."

"Okay," Scorpia said slowly. "What does that have to do with Adora?"

The sound of Adora's name made Catra's breath hitch. It felt like being doused with ice cold water — a shock to her system that chilled her to her core. But when the shock subsided, all that was left was white hot anger.

Rather than answering Scorpia's question, Catra pointed to a side street up ahead. "Pull in there and park somewhere. We'll walk the rest of the way."

Once parked, Catra motioned for Scorpia to keep quiet and move carefully. They darted down an alley to an old metal fire escape that crawled up the side of a building. From there, it was a short climb to the top floor. Scorpia gave Catra a boost onto the roof and then hauled herself up using her impressive upper body strength. Catra was starting to think that maybe it didn't hurt to have a partner after all.

Crouching low, Catra hurried to the side of the building and peered over the edge. The warehouse she grew up in was directly across the street, and at that moment it was crawling with police.

"Woah," Scorpia whispered. Catra jumped. She'd been so fixated on what was happening below that she didn't notice Scorpia settle in beside her. "That's a lot of cops."

Catra leaned out a little further so she could get a better look at the warehouse's main entrance. It looked as though the door had been busted off its hinges. One by one, police officers led Horde kids out into the street. Some of the kids—particularly the

younger ones—looked terrified. But others weren't going down without a fight. They screamed and thrashed, spitting and shouting obscenities as they were hauled from their home and put into the back of the many cruisers on site. Catra held her breath when she saw Rogelio and Kyle emerge from the warehouse with their hands cuffed. It took two officers just to handle Rogelio and his considerable size.

Lonnie was the next to be pulled out of the building. She flailed and cursed, desperately trying to break free. With her heart in her throat, Catra watched with laser focus, just waiting for the cops to step out of line. At the first hint of overreaction, she planned to leap down from the sky and go absolutely berserk on every single one of them.

"You can't do this!" she shouted. "We didn't do anything!"

She pulled so violently that the officer who was handling her momentarily lost her grip. Lonnie used this breach to lunge toward her friends. But she was caught just as quickly, and had to watch in dismay as Kyle and Rogelio were loaded into a car without her.

Now her resolve seemed to falter. Her righteous indignation morphed into sorrowful wail. "Let me ride with them! Please, they're my friends!"

But the police didn't care about that. With a hand on Lonnie's head, the officer pressed her down into the backseat of a car with another young girl. Once the door was closed, Lonnie's screams were muffled, but even from the rooftop, Catra could tell she was crying.

"Fuck," Catra growled between gritted teeth. "Fuck!" She pounded the building's concrete ledge furiously until Scorpia pulled her back.

"Stop, you're going to hurt yourself," Scorpia said softly. Catra yanked herself out of Scorpia's gentle grip and curled into herself.

Her heart pounded in her ears. She felt helpless, and that only made her angrier.

Scorpia was staring over the ledge again, her expression bleak. "I don't understand. The Horde's been using that warehouse forever and we've never had a raid before. How did this happen?"

Scowling, Catra got to her feet and brushed herself off.

"How do you think?" she snarled.

It took a moment, but a look of understanding finally settled over Scorpia's face. She let out a nervous laugh. "No. No way. Do you really think Adora would—"

"Of course I do!" Catra said, cutting her off. Her hands were balled into fists so tight that her sharp nails bit into the soft flesh of her palms. "She's a traitor, remember? Of course she ratted us out to the fucking cops."

"But…" Scorpia seemed perplexed. She looked up at Catra and shook her head. "She had to know what would happen. All those kids are just going to end up in the system. Why would Adora do that to her friends?"

The word "friends" hit Catra like hot oil. She recoiled.

"Because she knows how much the Horde relies on the kids," Catra answered bitterly. "We just lost most of our workforce."

Scorpia slumped down and let out a long breath. "Damn. This is bad. What do we do now?"

"We do what should have been done a long time ago," Catra said as she turned back to the fire escape. "Come on, we need to get to the garage."

*

The mood at the garage was grim. Everyone was too engrossed in low, troubled conversations to so much as glance at Catra and Scorpia as they blew through the main bays and into the back.

“Bad news travels fast,” Scorpia muttered as she glanced around. “I’ve been to funerals less depressing than this.”

Catra didn’t reply. She stormed up to a cluster of other Force Captains who were huddled around an old TV set in the corner. They were watching live footage from the protest. A news ticker along the bottom of the screen spelled out the details of the raid under a banner that read “breaking news”. Catra spotted Octavia, who was supposed to be on Hordak’s security duty, mixed in with the crowd.

“Hey,” Catra barked, earning reproachful looks from the others. “Where’s Hordak?”

“He’s in an emergency meeting with Shadow Weaver,” Octavia answered without looking away from the screen.

Scorpia looked down at Catra. “Should we wait here for him?”

Catra considered this for a moment. Patience wasn’t one of her virtues at the best of times, and now definitely wasn’t a good time. She glanced around the room and her eyes landed on the door to Entrapta’s lab.

“I’ve got a better idea,” she said and motioned for Scorpia to follow.

They found Entrapta right where she always was: hunched over her workstation and elbows-deep in some kind of contraption. Through the window, Catra could hear Entrapta carrying on a spirited conversation with Emily the rat, completely oblivious to the drama playing out just beyond her lab door. Catra rapped her knuckles on the glass to get her attention. Entrapta looked up and a wide smile stretched across her face.

“Friends!” she shouted. “Come in, come in!”

“Aw!” Scorpia said fondly. “She called us her friends!”

Groaning, Catra rolled her eyes and pushed into the lab. She didn’t waste any time with small talk.

“Do you know where we keep the initiation videos?” she asked.

Entrapta blinked as if it was the stupidest question she’d ever been asked. “Sure. They’re saved on our encrypted network.”

“Great.” Catra leaned over the workbench, pressing her palms into the cool steel. “Do you know how to access them?”

“Of course I do,” Entrapta said with a laugh. “I’m the one who set up the network in the first place. I know where everything is!”

Perfect, Catra thought. For a split second, she considered demanding that Entrapta pull up the files right then and there. She wasn’t afraid to use force if that’s what it would take. But then she remembered who she was dealing with. Entrapta was Hordak’s pet — the only person in the entire world he seemed to give two shits about. Catra was going to have to be strategic if she hoped to get her hands on those files without pissing Hordak off in the process.

“Did you really?” Catra exclaimed with feigned interest. “That’s amazing!”

Entrapta beamed proudly. “Encrypted networks are easy, but I’d be lying if I said the one I built isn’t a masterpiece.”

“Uh…” Scorpia glanced between Catra and Entrapta in obvious confusion. “I thought we were—” Catra cut her off with a warning kick to the shin.

“Wow,” Catra continued, sliding around the workbench so that she was standing at Entrapta’s side. “I didn’t realize the Horde was so high tech.”

"Oh, we're not," Entrapta said. "But you can never be too careful when it comes to cybersecurity."

"Totally," Catra agreed. She inched in closer and smiled brightly. "We're so lucky to have you on our side. I can't believe I've been working with such a genius this whole time!"

The flattery was working. Entrapta's cheeks flushed at Catra's generous praise. Her eyes were wide and excited. "And I didn't realize you were so interested in computer networks!"

At this point, Scorpia finally caught on to Catra's ploy.

"Oh, yeah," she laughed. "Catra's always talking about computers. Y'know, two-factor authentication and, uh, blockchains and stuff."

It took everything in Catra's power not to tell Scorpia to shut up.

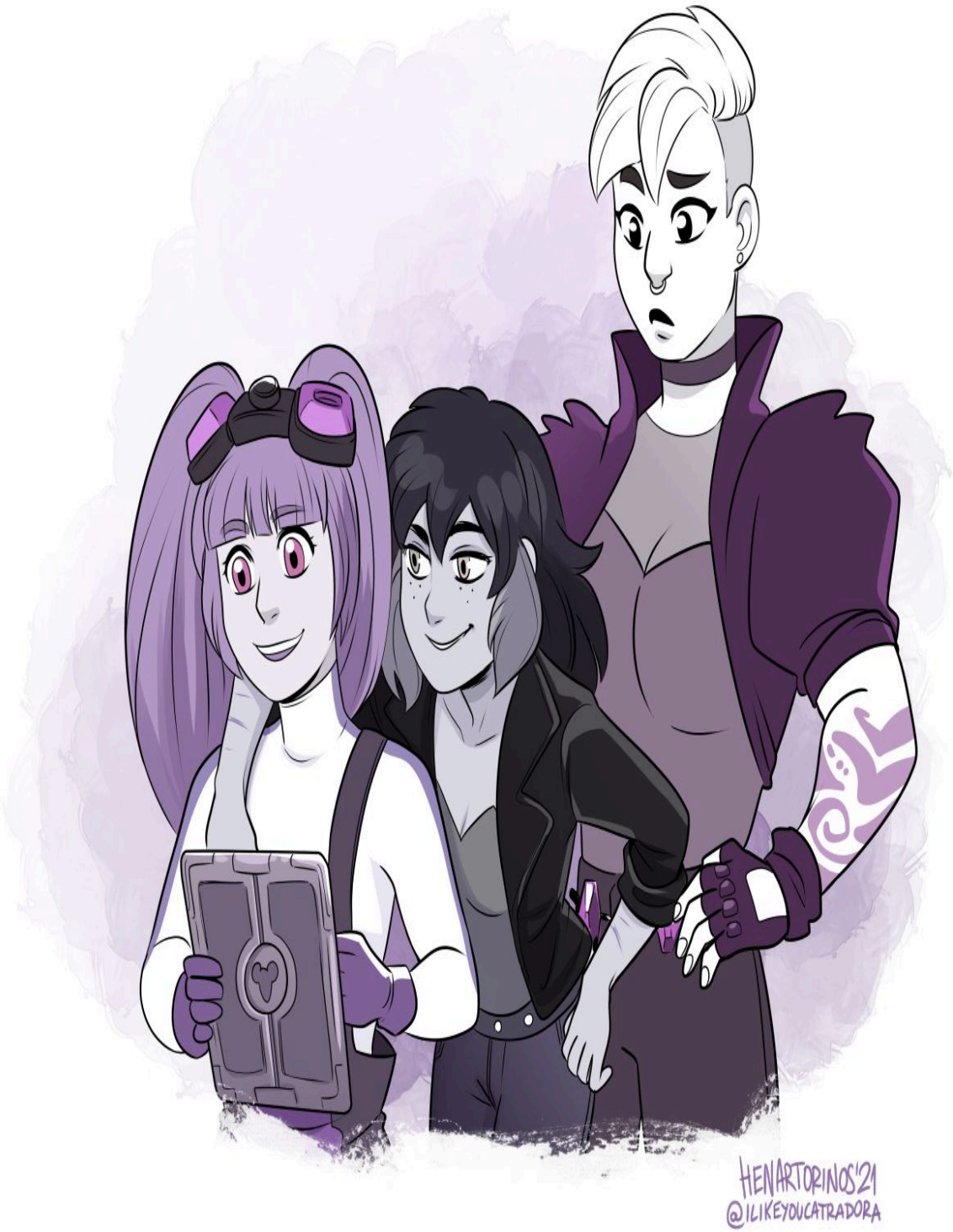
Entrapta let out a squeal of excitement. "No one's ever interested in the same stuff as me! Well, except for Hordak, but he's usually too busy to talk."

"Well, I'm all ears," Catra lied. It was impossible to match Entrapta's level of enthusiasm, but she did her best.

"Do you want to see my build?" Entrapta asked as she pulled out her tablet.

Catra smiled so wide that her cheeks hurt. *Jackpot*.

For the next twenty minutes, Catra and Scorpia listened to Entrapta explain the minutiae of how she built the Horde's secure network. Most of what she said made zero sense to Catra, who simply nodded along and tossed in the occasional appreciative "Ooh!" for good measure. But she watched the tablet screen with hawk-like focus, searching for something she could use. Eventually, Entrapta navigated out of the miles of code she used to build the system and opened a screen filled with digital files.



"And this is what the user interface looks like," Entrapta explained as she swiped along the screen. "See? This is where the initiation videos are saved."

A thrill raced up Catra's spine. "Oh, can we see?"

Entrapta tapped on the file and typed in a long, convoluted password. The screen changed to show a list of video files. Each one was labeled with a name and a date, and there were a *lot* of them.

"Wow, that's a lot of blackmail," Scorpia said weakly.

"It sure is," Entrapta agreed. She typed Scorpia's name into a search bar and the rest of the files fell away to reveal a single video from five years back. Scorpia squirmed with obvious discomfort.

"We don't have to watch that," she said.

"Is mine in there?" Catra asked.

"Yep. Every initiation is here." Entrapta changed the search parameters and Scorpia's file was replaced with Catra's. Scorpia let out a sigh of relief.

Catra was nearly vibrating with anticipation. "What about Adora? Can you show me hers?"

Entrapta laughed as she typed 'Adora' into the search bar. "Well, I can't show you the actual video but here's the— Oh."

This time, instead of a new file with Adora's name, a message popped up on the screen that read *FILE NOT FOUND*.

"Uh oh," Scorpia said, leaning in to get a better look. "What does that mean?"

"That doesn't make sense," Entrapta muttered. "I know it's here somewhere. Let me check the change logs."

She typed out a series of commands, which brought up a screen full of data. Catra looked from the screen to Entrapta's face, searching for some clue as to what was going on.

"Well?" she asked. "Where is it?"

“It looks like it was deleted,” Entrapta said, tapping her chin thoughtfully.

“What?” Catra’s stomach dropped. “Can you get it back?”

Entrapta frowned. “If this was a normal system I could. But because of all the sensitive data we keep on file, I designed this one to permanently purge deleted files.”

Frustration boiled in Catra’s chest. She was so mad that she wanted to scream. But she took a breath and fought to keep her cool. “Is there anything else you can tell me? Does the log say when the video was deleted? Or who did it?”

“It sure does,” Entrapta said. She pointed at a particular line on the tablet screen. Catra read the name once, and then a couple more times just to make sure her mind wasn’t playing tricks. Her heart sank as a fresh wave of betrayal flooded her insides.

The screen told them everything: when the file had been added, its type and size, and the fact that it had been deleted on the same date that Adora left.

And under all of that was the name of the user who had permanently deleted the file: Shadow Weaver.

Chapter End Notes

CONTENT WARNINGS:

- Police raid the warehouse and detain the Horde kids; the raid itself is not depicted on the page and no one is harmed
- Lonnie is separated from Kyle and Rogelio and tries to break free from the police; she is emotional but not harmed

Chapter 22

Catra wouldn't have to wait long to put her plan in motion.

That evening, Scorpia drove her to a condo building downtown. They pulled into the circular drive and came to a stop in front of the building's opulent glass entrance.

"Are you sure you don't want to switch shifts?" Scorpia asked. She smiled warmly at Catra. "You had a pretty big day."

"I'm fine," Catra said, turning away. Sometimes she couldn't stand how earnest Scorpia was — it made her feel small and gross by comparison. She slid out of the car and into the night. "I'll let you know how it goes."

Scorpia leaned across the center console and waved. "Okay, good luck! Call if you need anything!"

Being among the hand-selected elite of Hordak's personal security team wasn't quite as glamorous as Catra thought it was going to be. But tonight, being the lowest person on the team's hierarchy—and therefore getting stuck with back to back to back overnight shifts guarding Hordak's front door—was about to pay off.

Catra stepped into the cavernous lobby. The building had a modern industrial vibe, complete with polished concrete floors, cool metal surfaces, and exposed brick. A judgemental sneer tugged at Catra's lips as she took it all in. The way rich people liked to play at peasantry never ceased to amuse her.

Why spend heaps of cash to pretend you live in an old warehouse when you can literally do it for free? Catra thought bitterly as she strode up to the reception desk in the middle of the room.

Behind the desk sat a security guard who gave Catra a quick glance, then nodded as she breezed past him to the elevators. A thrill fluttered inside of her. After spending her entire life being chased out of expensive places like this, Catra wasn't used to

being treated like she belonged. In the back of her mind, she was always waiting for the person in charge to realize they'd made some kind of terrible mistake. She couldn't shake the feeling that, at any moment, she might be apprehended by some muscled thug and tossed back onto the streets.

She was halfway up to Hordak's floor before she let herself exhale. No one was coming for her. This was her life now. Maybe one day she'd even believe it.

When the elevator doors opened, Catra found Octavia lounging against the wall just outside the door to Hordak's condo. Octavia raised an eyebrow and checked her watch.

"You're early," she remarked. "Not that I'm complaining — I'm beat."

Octavia pushed off the wall, but Catra caught her in the chest and shoved her back.

"Hold that thought," Catra said, delighting at the look of surprise on Octavia's face. "I've got something I need to do before I clock in."

Before Octavia could say a word, Catra reached out and knocked on Hordak's door.

"What the hell are you doing?" Octavia hissed. "You know we aren't supposed to bug him unless it's important."

"Exactly," Catra replied, turning her eyes to the door as the sound of footsteps approached from the other side. She imagined Hordak peering through the spyhole to see who dared to disturb him, so she raised her chin and stood up tall.

The door swung open.

"What is the meaning of this?" Hordak growled. He looked especially menacing as he stood in the doorway, framed by the dim glow from inside his condo.

“I’m sorry, sir,” Octavia blathered quickly. “I told her that you’re not to be bothered.”

Hordak pinned Octavia under a contemptuous glare. “And yet you let her do it anyway.”

Octavia gaped, dumbfounded. “I thought she was here to start her shift. I didn’t—”

“Oh, I am,” Catra said, cutting in. She took a step closer to Hordak, infiltrating his personal space in a way that made Octavia gasp. “But first, you and I need to talk.”


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@ILIKEYOUCATRADORA

A murderous look flashed across Hordak's face. "How dare you speak to me with such disrespect," he snarled.

Catra cocked her head. The fact that she didn't cower seemed to irritate Hordak even more. But this was a good thing — she needed him to be worked up. He didn't need to know that her heart was in her throat or that she was so terrified that she felt faint. Catra had years of practice pretending to be okay when she wasn't.

"My bad," Catra drawled. "I figured you'd want to know right away if someone was deliberately disobeying the gang's protocol for personal gain."

The angry furrow of Hordak's brow softened ever so slightly, and that's when Catra knew she had him.

"Who?" he demanded.

Catra glanced at Octavia. "Are you sure you want to talk about this with *her* here?"

The way Octavia bristled almost made Catra laugh. Hordak considered them both for a moment, then stepped aside.

"Very well. We can discuss this inside." He looked at Octavia. "Maintain your post, Force Captain."

"Yes, sir," Octavia said, obliging with a respectful bow.

"Thanks, O," Catra said as she stepped past her. She could feel Octavia's rage even from a distance, and she loved it. "You're the best."

The inside of Hordak's condo struck Catra as bleak. It was the kind of carefully crafted minimalism that no doubt cost way more than it should have: stainless steel and concrete, sparse furniture made up of sharp and unforgiving angles. Even though the temperature was normal, it all felt cold to Catra. Hordak led her into the living room. Perhaps the only saving grace was the view

through his floor to ceiling windows. The city of Etheria stretched out in every direction, glittering like a reflection of the night sky.

Hordak settled himself into a black leather armchair that looked about as comfortable as a park bench.

"Explain yourself," he said.

Now that she was in his space—his domain—Catra felt unease creep up from somewhere deep inside of her. Her heart hammered; since the night of her nightmarish initiation, she had gone out of her way to make sure she was never alone with a man. They were all monsters as far as she was concerned, all somehow complicit in her trauma. And now, here she was, far from safety with the scariest man she knew.

Taking a deep breath, Catra drew herself up tall. She was determined not to let her fear show.

"Shadow Weaver is deceiving you," she said bluntly.

Hordak's eyes narrowed, but he said nothing. Catra took this as her cue to continue. "She knew all along that Adora was working with the police and she didn't do anything about it."

This got Hordak's attention. He sat up, alert. "The police?"

"Oh yeah," Catra replied. Feeling a little bolder, she planted her hands on her hips. "Adora didn't just jump ship — she was a full blown traitor. And Shadow Weaver knew it."

"How do you know this?" Hordak asked.

"Because she told me! Instead of doing something to stop Adora, Shadow Weaver had me spy on her. Who knows how much intel Adora was able to feed to Chief Brightmoon while Shadow Weaver was busy power tripping." It was taking so much mental effort for Catra to keep the rising anger out of her voice. The memory, not only of Adora's betrayal but of the way Shadow Weaver had

played them off of one another, made Catra want to hit something.

Hordak's long fingers drummed across the arm of his chair. "Perhaps Shadow Weaver was testing you, Force Captain."

Despite all of her better instincts, Catra laughed. It burst from her broken heart and punctuated the air like a gunshot. Hordak snarled, but Catra didn't care.

"Listen, I know she's your second in command and all, but I think you're giving her more credit than she deserves," she said, the words spilling out of her like a long held confession. "Was testing me worth the risk of exposing our secrets? How do you think the cops knew to raid the warehouse?"

Catra was pacing now. She couldn't seem to stand still. "If it was a test, why wouldn't Shadow Weaver release Adora's initiation tape? Isn't that the whole point of having them in the first place?"

Isn't that the reason she tried to pimp me out to a dirty cop?

"Shadow Weaver assures me she is doing everything in her power to find the traitor," Hordak said. His voice was low and dangerous, but even Catra could sense the hint of doubt behind his words. "This includes putting our insurance policy into play."

"Oh, really?" Catra replied. She forced herself to stop and face him. She stared him straight in the eyes. "I'd love to know how she pulled that off considering she deleted Adora's initiation video."

"What?" Hordak asked. There was no missing the incredulity in his voice.

"Yup. She deleted it on the same day Adora deserted the Horde." Catra folded her arms and stared Hordak down. "Isn't that interesting?"

In one swift motion, Hordak got to his feet. He loomed threateningly over Catra, and for a moment she thought he might reach out and strike her. But instead he simply glowered down at her as she stood her ground.

"These are significant accusations," Hordak said at last.

"I'm honestly surprised that you're surprised," Catra said with a smirk. "Judging by the scars on her face, this isn't the first time Shadow Weaver has let you down."

Hordak's expression darkened and Catra knew at that moment she'd gotten what she came for.

"If you don't believe me, talk to Entrapta," Catra said. At the mention of Entrapta's name, Hordak's eyes grew wide. "Like I said, I just figured you'd want to know that your second in command has been lying to you. Anyway, I should get back to work."

She turned on her heel and breezed back to the door, leaving the gang boss to process this betrayal in private.

Gripping the door handle, Catra paused to glance back over her shoulder. She flashed him a dazzling smile and opened the door. "I'll be right outside if you need anything, *sir*."

Chapter 23

*[**CONTENT WARNING:** This chapter contains mentions of the foster care system.]*

After Catra's strange departure from the protest, Glimmer redirected the Best Friends Squad's attention to the police precinct.

"Let's get to the doors and see what we can find out," she said as she motioned for Adora and Bow to follow her lead. They walked single file, clinging to the shirt hems of the person in front of them so they wouldn't get separated as the three of them wove through the crowd. Adora scanned every face they passed, wondering if any other gangsters had showed up for the event. She wouldn't have been surprised if she spotted Rogelio towering above everyone else with Lonnie and Kyle at his sides.

But, no — it seemed as though Catra and… and this Scorpia person were the only two who dared show their faces at such a public event.

Typical Catra, Adora thought bitterly.

Glimmer waved at one of the officers who stood by the door, watching the protest with an impassive look on his face.

"Hey, it's me," she said. "Can we get in?"

The officer glanced at her. "Are you experiencing an emergency or here to make a report?"

"I'm here to see my mom," Glimmer sounded confused.

"Sorry, Glimmer," the officer said. "We're under strict instructions not to let anyone inside unless it's for official police business."

While Glimmer fumed, Adora looked back at the protesters who stood closest to the front. They stared back, watching the interaction curiously. Adora wondered what they were thinking — what this conversation looked like to them. For the first time since they'd arrived, Adora felt self-conscious.

What would be worse? she asked herself privately. *If these people knew I used to be part of the Horde, or if they knew I'm sort of working with the police now?*

Both options made her feel like the bad guy, and for the first time, she started to wonder if that was true.

"Listen," the cop said, pulling Adora from her thoughts. He leaned in a little closer so he could lower his voice. "If it makes you feel any better, your mom's not even here right now."

Glimmer was taken aback. "What do you mean? Where is she?"

But before the officer could answer, Bow cleared his throat. "Guys, I think we should get out of here."

"Why?" Adora asked. She looked at him, then followed his gaze back to the crowd. Now the protesters at the front stood with their phones raised. They were recording this conversation, waiting for something to happen. She turned her back to them and pulled her hood up over her head.

"I'm with Bow," she said. "Let's go."

Though it seemed to pain her to do so, Glimmer followed them back down the steps. They skirted around the walls of the building until they found a part of the crowd that was thin enough for them to pass through easily before ducking down a side street and away from the noise.

"Why wouldn't she be there?" Glimmer muttered. She pulled her phone out and tapped out a text message to her mother. "I mean, there's a HUGE protest right outside of the precinct. Shouldn't the police chief be there?"

Interwoven with Glimmer's frustration were unmistakable notes of worry. Adora reached out and looped arms with her. She smiled at her reassuringly.

"Wherever she is, I'm sure Angella has a really good reason for not being there right now," she assured Glimmer.

"Adora's right," Bow said, flanking Glimmer on her other side. "And at least now you don't have to worry about her being caught up in all of this, right?"

Glimmer sighed. "I guess so." She looked up at Adora, her brows furrowed. "What about you? Are you okay?"

"Yeah," Bow said, leaning forward to see Adora better. "That fight with Catra was pretty intense."

Adora chewed her lip and looked down at her feet. With each step she saw her expensive new sneakers, which only made her feel guilty. What must she have looked like to Catra, dressed head to toe as she was in brand new clothes, clean and well-fed for one of the first times in her life? Sure, Catra had a whole new look of her own — and a really good one at that. Adora couldn't help but recall the plunging neckline of Catra's new top and the snug fit of her jeans. But Adora didn't need to be part of the Horde to know that those clothes hadn't been given to Catra as a gesture of good will, and she knew Catra well enough to know that she wouldn't have spent what meager earnings she'd made thus far on a new wardrobe.

No, the only reason Catra had any of that was because she was now officially a full-fledged member of the gang. She'd been initiated—the last thing Adora had wanted for her—and judging by the look on Catra's face when Adora asked, it hadn't been good.

"What do you think that phone call was about?" Glimmer mused. "And why did she get mad at you over it?"

"I'm not sure," Adora replied, though the same questions had been on her mind as well. "She was already mad about me

leaving, but it's not I've done anything useful since then. This is my first time out of hiding in weeks!"

Bow offered her a kind smile. "I wouldn't say you haven't done *anything* useful. You did put together that notebook. Just because we haven't put all of that information to use yet doesn't mean—"

Adora froze, and because her arm was still wound around Glimmer's, her abrupt pause jerked her friends back mid-stride. Horror washed over Adora as the pieces clicked into place. The notebook. Once she realized that Angella didn't spend a lot of time in the kitchen, Adora had found a spot between some dusty, neglected baking sheets to hide those precious pages. She'd stashed it away before they left, so she knew it was safe.

But Angella had seen at least one of those pages, hadn't she? The one with the hand-drawn map of where the old warehouse was. The one Adora herself said all of the Horde kids lived until they were old enough to be initiated. She thought about the look of Catra's face when she got that phone call. Her back still ached from when Catra threw her against that parked car.

Did you ever really care about any of us? Catra had asked.

"Adora, what's wrong?" Bow asked.

"Glimmer," Adora said, her voice tense. "Has Angella gotten back to you yet?"

"Uh…" Glimmer glanced at her phone and frowned. "No, not yet. She hasn't even read it yet."

"Shit." Adora's heart was racing. "We need to go. Right now."

Before the others could ask anything more, Adora took off running. Not for the first time she wished one of them had a car; it would take forever to get across town on foot. After a few blocks she came across a bus stop. Her eyes combed the route

information as the others caught up, huffing and wheezing with exertion.

"Are you… going to tell us… what's going… on?" Glimmer panted.

"We have to get to the warehouse," Adora answered. "The next bus should get us close enough."

Glimmer and Bow shared a bewildered look with one another.

"The warehouse you used to live in?" Bow asked. Adora had to respond with a nod. There was a lump of fear lodged so tightly in her throat that she thought she might choke on it. Bow's face fell, and she knew he understood.

"Oh no," he said in a hushed voice.

When the bus came, the three clamored on and found seats near the back. Adora sat with her elbows on her knees and her chin in her hands, staring at the route map and marking their progress with each stop. The trip felt like it took forever, and she had to keep reminding herself that it was faster than walking.

Finally, the bus pulled up to the closest stop to the warehouse on its route. Adora squeezed out the doors before they were even fully open and immediately took off running again. She knew she was being inconsiderate to her friends — she could hear them huffing from behind her as they strained to keep up with her pace, but she couldn't bring herself to slow down.

Adora rounded the last corner that turned onto the street where she'd spent most of her life. She skidded to a stop with a gasp. Half a dozen police cruisers sat parked outside the warehouse, some of which held Horde kids captive in their back seats. One by one they pulled away, driving in the opposite direction.

There were blockades set up along the street to prevent traffic from passing through, not that this neighborhood ever saw much of that. Without thinking, Adora vaulted over the wooden stanchion, taking the single officer who was supposed to be

keeping watch by surprise. As Adora bolted down the street, she could hear the cop calling after her, followed by Glimmer telling him that it was okay.

Though her lungs already ached, Adora pushed herself to run even faster. She shoved past the officers who stood talking by the warehouse door, who shouted and scrambled after her as she dashed inside.

“Hello?” she called into the cavernous empty space she used to call home. “Is anyone here?” Though it had never been a particularly tidy place, the overturned furniture and scattered belongings told a story that filled Adora with terror. Before the cops could catch up with her, she leapt over the upended sofa and raced for the stairs. She took them two at a time, desperate to outpace the thundering footsteps that followed only a handful of paces behind.

Upstairs, every door was wide open. Every room Adora passed was empty, including the one she and Catra had shared. Their grubby mattress still sat right where they’d left it. She reached the door that led to the roof. It too was pried open. The police had searched everywhere, even their most sacred of hiding places.

There was no one left. They’d gotten them all.

A pair of hands closed around Adora’s arms from behind. Though her instinct was to fight, she knew it wouldn't do her any good. Not now. Without a word, she let the cops maneuver her back downstairs where Chief Brightmoon stood waiting with Glimmer and Bow. Her eyes brimmed with concern as she watched Adora descend the steps.

“Let her go,” Angella told her officers, who obliged at once. Adora stormed forward until she was face to face with Angella. She could feel the heat in her face and the tears threatening just below the surface.

“What did you do?” she shouted. Her voice echoed around the empty warehouse. She had never heard it this quiet before.

Angella blinked at her in obvious surprise. “What do you mean?”

“The kids, Angella,” Adora snapped. “What did you do with them?”

“We took them into custody,” Angella replied, looking affronted. “They’re being escorted to child protective services, where they belong.”

“Where they belong?” Adora was yelling so loudly that it made her friends flinch back from her. They had never seen her like this before, and it made her realize they had no idea who they were dealing with. “The system isn’t going to take care of those kids, Angella. You know that! Hell, shitty fosters and group homes are the reason most of those kids joined the gang in the first place.”

The shock on Angella’s face morphed into anger. “You’re being unfair, Adora. There are plenty of loving foster families out there who—”

“I KNOW THAT,” Adora bellowed. Her voice carried out into the street. Pigeons took flight, and officers stationed outside rushed in just to make sure everything was okay. Adora’s chest heaved as she pulled in one frantic breath after another. “But there’s lots of them that aren’t so loving. And even if they were, you just separated all of those kids from each other — the only family they have. The only people they trust.” She was crying now. She couldn’t stop the tears even if she wanted to. But she didn’t care — she needed Angella to see what she’d done. “You have no idea what it’s like for kids like them — like *me*. Do you think any of us *want* to live like this?”



“What exactly is it that you want from me, Adora?” Angella asked. Her voice was low, her words measured. “You came to us for help, and yet every time I try to do something you react as if I’m your enemy.”

Adora threw her arms open wide and gestured around the room. “This? This isn’t helping!”

“Then what should we have done?” Angella pressed.

“You should have talked to me,” Adora replied. “This is why I didn’t want to give you my notes. I knew you would cut me out of the plan, and that’s exactly what you did.”

Angella’s eyes narrowed. Adora could tell her patience with her was at an end.

“With all due respect,” Angella said. “I don’t have to involve you in any of this. In case you’ve forgotten, I’m the chief of police and this is my job, not yours.”

Adora bristled. “In case you’ve forgotten, the police haven’t been able to put a stop to the Horde. Your protocols and strategies, they don’t work. I know how the gang works. I can help! But you won’t give me a chance!”

A tense and uneasy silence fell between them. Glimmer and Bow huddled close together. Out of the corner of her eye, Adora could see that they were holding hands, gripping each other so tightly that she knew it must have hurt. They looked torn and afraid, and a small part of Adora felt bad about being the reason they felt that way.

She wiped her tears with the back of her hand and looked back at Angella.

“You used me, Angella,” she said, quietly this time.

Angella recoiled, stung. “Adora, no. That’s not—”

“Forget it.” Adora shook her head. “Keep doing this your way. I’ll figure this out on my own.”

She turned away and stormed out the warehouse door. Past the gaping officers, who stood at the ready, waiting for Angella’s

signal. Away from the only friends she had left in the world.

Chapter 24

Adora stormed away from the now-empty warehouse. The officers who loitered around outside stepped out of the way and let her pass without so much as a word. She didn't spare them a single glance — instead, she kept her red, tear-filled eyes trained downwards as she hurried away from the scene.

She was halfway down the block when heard footsteps running up behind her. It was clear that whoever they belonged to was trying to catch up to her, but she pretended she didn't notice until she felt a hand close around her elbow and tugged her to a stop.

"Adora, wait." It was Glimmer.

Begrudgingly, Adora looked back at her. She expected Glimmer to be pissed — to be furious at Adora for yelling at her mom the way she had. But instead, Glimmer looked heartbroken and torn.

"I'm so sorry," Glimmer said. "If I were you, I'd be angry too."

Bow nodded solemnly at Glimmer's side. "I can't imagine how hard this must be for you. How can we help?"

"You can't," Adora replied, wiping the tears from her face with the back of her hand. "Unless you know how to release all of those kids, there's nothing any of us can do to help."

"I was talking about you, Adora," Bow said gently. "How can we help *you* feel better?"

Adora considered the question. Was there anything in the world that could ease the hurt and betrayal she was feeling at that moment? She combed through her memories, searching for something that would lift her spirits. But the only thing that came to mind was Catra: her squeaky laugh and mischievous smile, her weight and warmth at Adora's side on their shabby old mattress where they slept.

But Catra was gone too. Adora had nothing.

So, she shook her head. "I think this was a mistake. I should have known the police wouldn't be able to help me — not really. I should… I should probably go."

"No," Glimmer gasped, latching onto Adora's arm even tighter than before. "I know you're upset, and I don't blame you. But, please — don't give up on the Rebellion. We need you."

"Glimmer, this isn't going to work." Adora could feel frustration swelling in her chest. "The cops—your *mother*—they aren't listening."

"Then forget about them," Glimmer said. "We'll find a different way to bring down the Horde." She slid her hand down and laced her fingers with Adora's. With her free hand, she pulled Bow closer. "The three of us, together."

This took Adora off guard. She shook her head, uncertain if she was following the path Glimmer seemed to be leading her down. "But, what about your mom?"

Glimmer mustered a weak smile. "You're right — she's not listening. With all of the red tape and protocols she has to deal with, I don't think she can afford to."

"But the three of us don't have to worry about any of that stuff," Bow said. "So let's take advantage of it."

Adora chewed on her bottom lip. She wanted to believe them—to trust them—but so far trusting people hadn't really worked out in her favor. Did either of them really understand what they were getting themselves into?

"Are you absolutely sure?" she asked.

"Hey, we're the ones who came to you in the first place, remember?" Glimmer said with a grin. "We're in this to win."

"And we trust your expertise," Bow added. "None of us knows the Horde like you do. Not even Angella. Whatever you think will work, we support you."

Adora studied them carefully. "Even if it gets messy and… potentially illegal?"

With a delighted laugh, Glimmer looped her arm around Adora's and started walking again. "Don't threaten me with a good time. Now, c'mon — let's get out of here."

*

Adora wasn't sure going back to the Brightmoon home was such a good idea. After all the things she'd said at the warehouse, she couldn't imagine Angella would want her around anymore. To be honest, Adora wouldn't blame her. But Glimmer insisted, as Glimmer usually did.

"Let me deal with my mom," she said when Adora voiced her concerns. "The only thing you should worry about right now is getting some rest. It's been a long day."

She wasn't wrong. Adora was exhausted, both in body and spirit. So, she shuffled off to her room and closed the door behind her. Once inside, she got as far as taking off her hoody before giving up completely and crawling into bed.

But because nothing was ever allowed to be easy, Adora laid awake, staring miserably into the darkness. Upstairs, she heard the muffled sound of Glimmer and Bow talking and their footsteps crisscrossing the floor. Then came the sound of the front door opening, and Adora's stomach dropped.

Angella was home.

Adora squeezed her eyes shut and willed herself to fall asleep. Even though she couldn't make out what was being said, she could hear Angella and Glimmer talking in raised voices. They weren't quite yelling, but the discussion sounded heated. It made

Adora feel sick to her stomach to know that they were probably fighting because of her.

Why do I have to ruin everything? she wondered as self-pity bloomed at her core.

The sound of footsteps descended the stairs, and Adora tensed. In the basement, the steps were swallowed by plush carpeting. But she didn't need to hear them to know where they were going. Still, she jumped when a soft knock came from her bedroom door.

"Adora?" Angella's voice was quiet as she called through the barrier. "May I come in?"

Here it comes, Adora thought. *She's come to tell me to leave and never come back*.

The door creaked open, sending a beam of yellow light cutting across the dark room. Angella's voice was clearer this time. "Adora? Are you awake?"



Angella didn’t sound like a woman on the verge of kicking a homeless ex-gangster back onto the streets, but Adora was wary all the same. Swallowing hard, Adora sat up and swung her legs over the mattress. Her back was to the door. She waited.

The mattress dipped gently as Angella sat down at Adora’s side. From her tightly clasped hands to the way she pursed her lips, it looked as though Angella was just as anxious as Adora felt.

“I’ll make this easy for you,” Adora said. Her own voice sounded unfamiliar to her, as if someone else was speaking through her. “I’ll pack my stuff and be gone within the hour.”

Blinking in surprise, Angella gaped. “What are you talking about?”

“I’m talking about leaving.”

“If that’s what you really want, I’ll respect your decision,” Angella said. She sounded sad. “But I’d prefer if you stayed.”

Now it was Adora’s time to be surprised. Her head snapped to face Angella, who gazed back with a cautious half-smile.

“Why would you want me to stay?” Adora asked. “After everything I said—”

Angella raised a hand and waved off Adora’s words. “I’m not angry with you, Adora. I don’t think I agree with everything you said, but I’ll admit that what happened today was a misstep on my part.” She let out a soft sigh and Adora waited for her to continue. “I never meant to betray your trust.”

“You took the one page of information I showed you and immediately used it to your advantage,” Adora said, fighting to keep her tone civil. “Which is exactly what I was afraid would happen.”

“I know. You’re right.” Angella pinched the bridge of her nose — a sure sign that a headache was likely rising between her eyes. “And for that I am truly sorry. You have to understand, I thought I was doing the right thing. I was doing my job.”

Biting her tongue, Adora glanced away. She didn’t speak, just in case she wound up saying something else she might regret.

After a moment of silence, Angella continued. “I know it’s hard for you to trust me, especially now. And I know there’s a lot that I apparently still don’t understand. But I also know that you came to me, Adora.” She leaned closer, and Adora could feel her violet

eyes burning into her. “You wanted my help. But for me to do that, you have to meet me halfway.”

At last, Adora looked back at her. “And what exactly does meeting you halfway look like?”

“Tell me what you want from me, Adora,” Angella answered. “You know who I am. You know that I am the Chief of Police, and my role comes with specific responsibilities. So, what is it that you want me to do?”

An avalanche of thoughts crashed through Adora’s mind. It was such a simple question, and one that should have had an equally straightforward answer. But if the weeks since deserting the Horde had taught Adora anything, it was that dismantling the gang wasn’t going to be as easy as arresting Hordak and anyone else who was pulling the strings. It was crushing to know that the police wouldn’t be able to do the one thing they were supposed to, the one thing she needed: to serve and protect.

She thought back to the day Shadow Weaver beat Catra bloody — the day she decided that she’d had enough. Remembering how much she’d believed that Angella would be able to make it all go away made her feel foolish now. Adora’s eyes dropped to the bracelet that hung around her wrist, and her heart ached. All she had wanted was to get out — to keep her and Catra safe. It had all been for Catra; everything Adora did, she did for her. And yet Catra still had it in her mind that Adora had been planning to sell her out. Clearly there had been some kind of misunderstanding, and now Catra was too angry to let Adora explain herself.

“Adora?”

Angella’s voice ripped Adora from her thoughts. With her mind spinning, Adora looked at her as if she was seeing her for the first time. Perhaps Etheria’s police force couldn’t bring down the Horde, but she could still put them to good use.

“Catra,” Adora said. “Get her out of there and I’ll tell you anything you want to know. I’ll give you my notes, and I won’t stand in your way.”

Maybe Catra had given up on her, but Adora wasn’t ready to give up on Catra.

“Are you sure?” Angella sounded incredulous. Her brows arched high over her wide eyes.

Adora thrust her hand out and held it between them until Angella at last gripped it with her own.

They shook hands, and Adora nodded. “You have my word.”

Chapter 25

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

*[**Author's note** : This chapter contains blood and reference to physical violence. It also refers to events that took place in chapter 15, which may be triggering to survivors of sexual assault and police violence. Reader discretion is advised. Please see the end of the chapter for specific content warnings.]*

For three days, Catra held her breath.

Not literally, of course. But emotionally, mentally, it felt like she hadn't exhaled since her conversation with Hordak. She was waiting for something to happen — something big and earth shattering. Instead, she reported to the garage each day and found Shadow Weaver skulking around at Hordak's side as if everything was the same as it had always been.

At first, Catra was pissed; how could Hordak not act? How could he keep a traitor like Shadow Weaver so close, knowing what she'd done? Maybe this was the way it would always be. Even in a gang, everything was so stacked against Catra's success that she was starting to wonder if Adora had the right idea about wanting to leave.

By the third day, Catra was resigned to accept that her gamble hadn't paid off after all. She'd made her move, and it had failed.

Then, after yet another long night standing watch at Hordak's door and a short nap in the back of Scorpia's car, Catra wandered through the garage and shoved her way into the back where she found Hordak waiting for her. This time, Shadow Weaver was nowhere to be seen.

Catra and Hordak stared each other down by way of greeting. There were no pleasantries between them, and to be honest,

Catra preferred it that way.

“Do you need me for something?” she asked, her voice still hoarse from sleep.

Hordak replied by turning his back to her.

“Follow me,” he said.

Begrudgingly, Catra did as she was told. Out of the corner of her eye she saw Scorpia, huddled around a map of the city with a couple of other gangsters. Another strategy session. Things around the garage had been tense since the warehouse raid. Everyone was scrambling, trying to figure out how to move product and take care of all the other grunt work without the help of their loyal little foot soldiers. Losing the kids had been a major blow to the Horde’s operations, and now everyone was expected to step up to fill in the gaps. As she and Hordak crossed the room, Catra caught Scorpia’s eye. Wordlessly, Scorpia motioned to Hordak as if to ask, ‘what’s going on?’ Catra responded with a bewildered shrug before being ushered down a back hallway.

Hordak didn’t say a word as he led her down the corridor. The only sound was that of their boots thumping against the poured concrete floor and echoing back at them off the bland cinder block walls. At last, Hordak stopped his marching and turned back to Catra. He pulled a key from his pocket and slid it into the lock on one of the nondescript steel doors that lined the walls. Then, he stepped aside and gestured toward it.

“After you,” he said. There was no intonation to his words — no way for Catra to discern what his intentions were. Her heart rate quickened as she turned the key with one hand and closed the other into a fist. If this was a trap, she was prepared to fight her way out or die trying.

Instead, what she found on the other side of the door took her breath away.

There, bathed in the harsh fluorescent light that spilled into the room from the hallway, was Shadow Weaver. She sat crumpled on the floor with her hands bound behind her back. Blood poured from her mouth and a gash on her forehead, spilling down to stain her rumpled white blouse. Shadow Weaver raised her eyes and locked them on Catra. Her gaze was inscrutable and unflinching, and Catra couldn't help but shrink under the weight of it.

Terror swelled in Catra's gut. Despite having wanted this, she hadn't considered that she'd have to witness it first hand. Instantly she was back in that tiny warehouse bathroom, watching Adora frantically scrub blood out of her hair.

A hand closed around Catra's shoulder, making her jump.

"The information you provided proved to be correct," Hordak said. "I needed to confirm it for myself, of course. But now that I have…" He swept his hand toward his prisoner.

Catra nodded. Her mind was filled with so much white noise that she couldn't think of anything to say. When Shadow Weaver's glare proved to be too much, Catra looked away. Her eyes fell on her fist, still clenched at her side. Crawling up her arm like the rungs of a ladder were the scars that Shadow Weaver had given her. Years of abuse came flooding back to her, and in that moment, every memory coalesced into a single word.

"Good."

With his hand still on Catra's shoulder, Hordak steered her back into the hall and closed the door behind him. Once it was locked, he held the key out to her.

"We'll be disposing of the traitor tonight," he said, speaking as if he was talking about getting rid of an old refrigerator and not a living, breathing person. "Until then, I expect you to watch over her."

In a daze, Catra took the key. She turned it over in her hand, studying it. "What are you going to do with her?"

"Me?" Hordak almost sounded amused, if such a thing were possible. "I'm not going to do anything."

Catra looked up at him in surprise. "What do you mean?"

A cruel smirk crawled across Hordak's thin lips. Pressing the knuckle of his index finger to Catra's chin, he tipped her face back. She froze under his touch, and a light in his eyes seemed to dance at the sight of her fear.

"You'll be doing the honors," he told her before patting her on the cheek like a child. "Congratulations." Then he walked away, leaving Catra to process her fate alone.

*

At some point, Catra made her way onto the cold, hard floor, her back pressed against the door of Shadow Weaver's makeshift prison cell.

She was grateful to be alone. Being alone meant no one was around to watch her fall apart.

Alone in that dreary corridor, Catra had a panic attack. Around her, the fluorescent lights seemed to strobe as she struggled to pull in a full breath. The world felt like it was tilting at a perilous axis that threatened to pitch her headfirst down the hallway. Catra choked through tears and held herself tightly as she rode out the chaotic roller coaster that her mind had become.

Shadow Weaver deserves this, Catra thought to herself. *Think of all this shit she's done to you over the years. She's a monster. You hate her. I hate her.*

True as all this was, Catra found herself paralyzed at the idea of what Hordak was expecting of her. Killing a person was bad enough, but killing Shadow Weaver? How could she? For all the

many reasons she hated Shadow Weaver, the miserable old woman was still the closest thing Catra had to a parent. She'd been the one to teach her things like reading and counting — the sort of stuff other kids would learn in school. Shadow Weaver had given her a home, a purpose. Shadow Weaver had given her Adora — the person who had been Catra's everything until she wasn't anymore.

Thinking of Adora helped ebb Catra's tears, though not for the reasons it used to. She thought of Adora's missing initiation video, and about how Shadow Weaver had essentially let Adora get away with one of the worst things a gang member could do. Catra wasn't sure why it surprised her — after all, Adora had always been Shadow Weaver's favorite. If the roles had been reversed and Catra was the one to betray the Horde, she'd be dead by now; Shadow Weaver would have made sure of it.

"Pull yourself together, Catra," came a hoarse voice through the door. "I'd rather my last hours on Earth not be spent listening to you snivel."

That was enough to bring Catra back to her senses. Scrambling to her feet, she unlocked the door and threw it open. Shadow Weaver flinched at the sudden flood of light, but her scowl remained intact.

"Shut up," Catra snapped as she wiped at her damp cheeks. "You don't get to talk to me like that anymore."

Shadow Weaver studied her for a moment before looking away. "No, I suppose I don't."

An awful, suffocating silence fell between them. It stung Catra that Shadow Weaver could sit there, saying nothing as her final day trickled away, leaving so much unspoken.

When the quiet became too much, Catra gave in. "Well? Don't you want to know why I did it?"

“I know why you did it,” Shadow Weaver drawled. She shifted stiffly, clearly uncomfortable and no doubt sore. “But I don’t think that’s really what you’re asking, is it?”

Catra clenched her jaw. Even now, Shadow Weaver could see right through her.

“No matter what I do, I’ll never be good enough for you, will I?” There was a quiver behind her words, but she pushed through it. “Adora turned on us, and you just let her go. But I stayed, and you punished me for it.”

“In what way did I punish you, Catra?” Shadow Weaver sounded almost bored with this conversation; tired, over it. Catra fumed.

“You arranged my initiation!” Catra shouted, her voice filling the dank, dark room. “You knew *exactly* what was going to happen to me at that motel and you were just going to let it happen.”

“We all must do our part for the Horde. I’ll have you know that revenue from the gang’s escorts is second only to Runestone.”

“Stop acting like this was some kind of fucking business transaction!” Catra shouted. Her heart was hammering again, her breath coming in shallow, dissatisfying bursts. “You set me up to be raped by a dirty cop.” Hot tears spilled from her eyes, and that involuntary display of weakness just made Catra angrier. She sobbed. “What did I ever do to make you hate me that much?”

At last, Shadow Weaver turned her gaze back to Catra. There was a hint of sadness there, somewhere between her softened brow and glassy eyes, and it took Catra by surprise.

“I thought it would be enough to make you leave,” Shadow Weaver said. “I expected you to go with Adora when she abandoned us — I thought for certain you would follow her just like you always did. But you stayed. And if you stayed, I knew you’d become just as much a slave to this gang as I am.”

Catra braced herself against the wall for support. Her legs felt suddenly weak.

"Fuck you," she whispered.

Shadow Weaver continued as if she hadn't heard her.

"If Adora leaving wasn't enough to make you run, then I knew I would have to make your initiation something truly horrible to push you over the edge." Her gaze narrowed. "Imagine my surprise when you managed to turn it into an opportunity." She squirmed again, letting out a small hiss of pain as she struggled to reposition herself. She gave up with a defeated sigh and slumped back in undignified repose.

"I didn't want any of this," Catra said, more to herself than to Shadow Weaver. "This isn't how it was supposed to go."

"This isn't what I wanted for you either. But this is what the Horde is, Catra. If you insist on staying and clawing your way to the top, then you'd better get used to it," Shadow Weaver replied, lifting her scarred and bloody face. "Look at me. *This* is what decades of loyalty gets you, Catra. It will not matter how much you do for this gang — you will never be better than your worst mistake. I hope you're prepared for that. And if you're not, then you need to run."

The white noise returned, drowning out everything else. Without a word, Catra backed out of the room and fumbled to close the door behind her.

Shadow Weaver's words replayed on a loop.

This is what the Horde is… I hope you're prepared for that…

But that was the problem — Catra wasn't ready. Not to kill anyone, that's for sure. Maybe Shadow Weaver was right; maybe the best thing she could do now was leave and never look back.

And if you're not, Shadow Weaver's voice echoed in Catra's mind, *then you need to run*.

Yes. She could figure out the details later—the where and how of her new life—but for now all Catra needed to do was run.


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Chapter End Notes

CONTENT WARNINGS
- Shadow Weaver is seen after having been beaten; she is bleeding, but the violence is not depicted or described.
- Catra refers to her initiation and accuses Shadow Weaver of setting her up to be sexually assaulted by a police officer; the event is not depicted or described, potentially triggering language is used.

Chapter 26

The cool outside air did little to pull Catra from her daze.

With her arms folded tightly across her chest, she kept her head down and hurried briskly down the street. She moved as fast as she could without running; the last thing she needed right now was to draw attention to herself.

Catra wasn't exactly sure where she was going — she had no friends and next to nothing to her name. But she had a bit of money hidden away, probably enough to buy a bus ticket. She wondered how far it would get her. Anywhere had to be better than here.

She had only made it a few blocks when she heard a passing car hit its brakes. Tires screeched across the asphalt, making her wince. Assuming it was some creep who had stopped to leer (something that seemed to happen a lot more now that Catra's figure wasn't obscured by layers of ill-fitting clothing), Catra kept walking.

"Catra!" Scorpia's voice rang out. Surprised, Catra looked up. Scorpia hadn't even bothered to pull over — she idled in the middle of the street as if she owned it. "Where are you going?"

"None of your business!" Catra snapped back. Now that she wasn't trapped in the endless loop of her own thoughts, Catra felt fresh panic creeping up her back. She was supposed to be watching Shadow Weaver. Had Hordak already realized she was missing? Did he send Scorpia to find her? She had hoped to have a bit more time before anyone realized she was gone.

Scorpia pulled a u-turn and pulled her expensive car up to the curb beside Catra. She unfolded her hulking frame through the driver's side door and came around to face her partner.

"What are you doing out here?" she asked.

“What did I just say?” Catra spat. “It’s none of your fucking business.”

She swerved around Scorpia and kept walking. She was barely two steps away when she heard Scorpia say, “Hordak told us about Shadow Weaver. Do you want to talk about it?”

Catra whirled back around. “What’s there to talk about, Scorpia? My plan worked, just like I knew it would. This is a good thing.”

“Then why do you look like someone just ran over your cat?” Scorpia asked.

A flurry of excuses and insults rushed through Catra’s mind. Any of these biting remarks would have been enough to put Scorpia in her place and end the conversation. But faced with Scorpia’s painfully obvious concern for her, Catra found herself unable to say anything at all. Every time she opened her mouth, her venom seemed to evaporate into a choking breath.

She was so, so tired.

“Hordak wants me to kill her,” Catra managed at last. Her voice was small and quiet. “Tonight.”

Scorpia exhaled sharply. “Oh, Wildcat. I’m s—”

“Don’t,” Catra cut her off. “I don’t need your pity.”

“I didn’t—” This time, Scorpia cut herself off. Maybe it was the furious scowl on Catra’s face that shut her up, or maybe she was just a quick study. Either way, Scorpia cleared her throat and changed tactics. “Are… Are you leaving?”

Catra didn’t answer. She wasn’t sure if she could trust Scorpia not to rat her out. Not that it would really matter — Hordak would figure it out eventually. Scorpia’s face fell, and Catra looked away, ashamed.

Rubbing her hand across the back of her neck, Scorpia sighed. "I don't blame you, Catra, I really don't. But… you know what they'll do if you leave, right?"

It was a thought that Catra had been trying to ignore from the moment she crept out the back door and into the alley behind the garage. Hordak wouldn't make the same mistake as Shadow Weaver: the moment he realized Catra had deserted the gang, he'd leak her initiation video. Not all of it, of course. No one would see one of Etheria's finest pushing her back onto a nasty motel mattress. The video would be trimmed to make it look like she had savagely beaten a man within an inch of his life. And when word got back to the Etherian Police Force that the victim was one of their own, there would be nowhere for her to hide. And all of that assumed the Horde didn't get to her first.

"Fuck," Catra hissed, covering her eyes with her hand. She could feel the sting of tears rising again, and she absolutely did not want to cry in front of Scorpia.

A hand, large and gentle, settled on Catra's shoulder.

"Why don't we head back to the garage and figure this out there?" Scorpia said softly.

Despite every sense of self preservation, Catra nodded. She let Scorpia lead her back to the car and didn't even roll her eyes when Scorpia held the door open for her. There was no fight left in her, so she stared vacantly ahead instead. Scorpia settled back into her seat and shifted the car into drive. A minute later she was turning down the back alley behind the garage.

"Wait here," Scorpia said as she pulled up next to the back door. "I'll go through the front and let you in."

Catra slouched out of the car and propped herself up against the wall with a sigh. Far back in the recesses of her mind, she recalled the way she had chided Adora for panicking after her initiation. *What did you think was going to happen?* Catra had

asked her. What, she wondered now, would Adora say to her? She'd probably be kind, the way she always was. She'd be patient with Catra and hold her once the terrible deed was done. For a brief, wonderful moment, Catra was certain she could feel the phantom of Adora's hand in her own, their fingers laced together like puzzle pieces made only for each other. There was nothing more Catra wanted in that moment than to hold Adora's hand again.



But she couldn't — not now, and not ever again. So she curled her hand into a first instead and clenched until the feeling subsided.

The metal door swung open with a loud squeak. Scorpia stuck her head outside and glanced around. When she spotted Catra, she waved for her to follow.

"The coast is clear," she whispered.

"Great," Catra muttered in reply. She sulked down the hallway until she found the door she was supposed to be guarding. Miserably, she took her post, while Scorpia leaned back against the opposite wall.

"I don't think anyone even realized you were gone," Scorpia said, sounding more relieved than Catra felt. "Everyone's still pretty distracted with the whole 'no more kid army' problem."

Catra nodded, her thoughts elsewhere. They stood for a minute without speaking. Catra could feel Scorpia's dark eyes on her, but she refused to look up to meet them. Eventually, Scorpia cleared her throat awkwardly.

"So… Do you wanna talk about it?"

"Not really," Catra muttered, cramming her hands into her pockets. "I just need to—"

She froze as her fingertips grazed the metal key. Somehow she'd forgotten all about it.

"Wildcat?" Scorpia tipped her head curiously. "You okay?"

Catra turned to the door and stared at the keyhole, trying to remember if she'd locked it after her confrontation with Shadow Weaver. She'd been in a daze, but surely she wouldn't have forgotten to do something so important, right?

Slowly, Catra reached out and gripped the door handle. She held her breath as she twisted her hand, willing the handle not to turn.

But it did.

The door unlatched with a soft click.

Catra stared at it as white hot terror pooled in her stomach.

"Oh shit," she whispered.

*

Adora, Glimmer, and Bow sat around the dining room table, each fully engrossed in their work. Empty plates from their long-finished dinner sat pushed aside to make room for notebooks and laptops.

"Ugh," Glimmer groaned, disturbing the quiet. She tossed her pencil down onto her notebook in protest. "Who has time for calculus when there are actual, real world problems that need solving?"

Without looking away from his own math problems, Bow picked up the discarded pencil and handed it back to Glimmer. "True, but that doesn't change the fact that you have an exam to study for. Besides, Adora's working on Rebellion stuff, so it's not like we're neglecting the greater good here."

"Huh?" Adora said, only half listening. Bow had leant her his laptop, which she was using to read about other gangs throughout history and what, if anything, had led to their eventual end. Or, at least that's how it had started. Somewhere along the way she had fallen down a Wikipedia rabbit hole and now she was reading about the prison industrial complex and the importance of journalistic freedom.

"Nothing," Bow replied with a smile. "How's the research going over there?"

Adora sat back and rubbed her eyes. "Depressing. The world is such a mess."

“Wanna switch?” Glimmer asked. She nudged her textbook toward Adora with her pencil. “I don’t mind tagging in for a while.”

Laughing, Adora pushed the book back. “I don’t even know what calculus is, let alone how to do it. Trust me, it’s better this way.”

“Maybe we need a snack break,” Bow offered as he got to his feet. “I’ll go see if the brownies have cooled.”

“I’ll help.” Adora gathered the empty dinner dishes and followed Bow to the kitchen just as Glimmer’s phone rang. Glimmer glanced down at the caller I.D. and sighed before picking it up.

“Hey, Mom,” Glimmer said.

The rest of her conversation was drowned out by the noise of Adora scraping the plates and loading them carefully into the dishwasher. The room smelled sweetly of rich, warm chocolate, and it made her mouth water.

“Those smell amazing, Bow,” she said.

“Thanks!” he replied as he sank a knife into the pan of brownies. “It’s my dad’s recipe. He put his own twist on it by—”

“The brownies are going to have to wait, Bow.” Glimmer’s voice cut him off. Adora looked up to find her standing on the threshold, cell phone still clutched in her hand.

“Why?” Adora asked. “Is everything okay?”

Glimmer’s brow furrowed. “I’m not sure. That was my mom — she wants us to come down to the station right away.”

Adora’s heart leapt. *Catra.*

“Did she say why?” Bow asked. He was already tearing off a sheet of foil and pressing it over his brownies.

“No,” Glimmer replied. “Just that we should hurry.”

*

The bus ride downtown felt agonizingly slow. Adora fidgeted, restless and eager to arrive. She cursed privately every time the bus made a stop.

“She must have found something,” Glimmer said, keeping her voice low. “Why else would she need us to come to the station in such a rush?”

Pursing his lips, Bow shook his head. “If she found something, why wouldn’t she just tell us when she got home?”

“Maybe whatever it is has already been booked into evidence, and she wants us to see it.”

“Oh, that’s a good point.”

While the pair theorized, Adora stayed silent. She knew what she was hoping — that somehow Angella had managed to keep her word, and that when they arrived at the precinct, Catra would be there waiting for her. But even thinking it felt like too much to hope for. To say it out loud might jinx it, so she said nothing at all.

By the time the three friends made it to the police station, Adora thought she might burst with anxious anticipation. Chief Angella Brightmoon met them at the front doors.

“Mom!” Glimmer exclaimed as she dashed to her mother’s side. “What’s going—”

Angella pressed a slim finger to her lips and Glimmer fell silent.

“Follow me,” Angella said in a hushed tone. “I’ll explain in a moment.”

They walked in single file, past the bullpen and holding cells to a quieter corridor. Adora kept her head down. Despite everything that had happened, being in the police precinct still made her

nervous. It was just another one of those Pavlovian ticks she'd developed from a life on the streets.

Angella came to a stop in front of a door and gripped the handle. She looked back at Adora, and let out a heavy exhale.

"You mustn't breathe a word of this to anyone, understood?" she whispered. "Not even to my officers. Do I make myself clear?"

The Best Friends Squad exchanged startled looks with one another before nodding solemnly. Angella licked her lips, considering each of them for a moment before she opened the door and ushered them inside.

Adora glanced around. The room was small and unremarkable. It was also dark, with the only light coming from a wide window that took up most of one wall. Curious, Adora wandered up to it.

Her stomach dropped.

The window was actually a pane of two-way glass that looked into another, even more desolate room with only a wide table sitting at its center.

And seated at the table, disheveled and bloody, was Shadow Weaver.

Chapter 27

The world seemed to spin as Adora backed away from the window. Even though she knew Shadow Weaver couldn't see her, she still felt the need to put more distance between them.

She turned back to Angella, confused and disoriented. "You arrested Shadow Weaver? I thought you said you were going to talk to me about these things."

"*That's* Shadow Weaver?" Glimmer exclaimed, pressing closer to the glass.

"What happened to her?" Bow asked, studying the battered woman scowling in the interrogation room.

Angella shushed them again as she pulled the door closed behind her. "Trust me, Adora, I'm just as surprised as you are. She called me this afternoon and turned herself in. But no one else knows she's here, so please keep your voices down."

Glimmer turned away from the window and raised an eyebrow at her mother. "What do you mean no one knows she's here?"

"She had two conditions to her surrender," Angella explained. She folded her arms and stepped to the window, gazing through it like she was witnessing a dream. "The first was that she didn't want anyone to know that I was bringing her in. She claims that some of my officers are working for the Horde and she doesn't want word of her arrest getting back to the gang yet."

"Ugh, Mom!" Glimmer said, tossing her hands in the air. "We've been trying to tell you that you've got spies in the precinct for ages. When are you going to start trusting me?"

Angella cut her daughter a withering look. "Now isn't the time for 'I told you so', Glimmer."

“What else?” Adora asked, stepping between them. Their petty mother-daughter squabbling would have to wait. “What was the other condition of her surrender?”

Shoulders sinking, Angella sighed. “She wants to speak with you.”

“Is she allowed to do that?” Glimmer sounded incredulous.

“Is that a good idea?” Bow asked. He put his hand on Adora’s shoulder. “You’ve told us how manipulative she can be. What if this is some kind of trap?”

Adora looked back at the two-way glass. The idea of facing Shadow Weaver again filled her with dread. But if Shadow Weaver decided to turn herself into the police, there must have been a reason. Trap or not, Adora needed to know what that reason was.

“I can do this,” she said, as much to assuage her friends as herself. “I know the way she works. Besides, she has no power over me anymore. If talking to her will help us take down the gang, I’ll do it.”

Angella hesitated, clearly conflicted. For a split-second, Adora thought the police chief was about to change her mind about the whole thing. Then, Glimmer let out a groan.

“C’mon, Mom,” she said. “If you weren’t going to let us talk to her you wouldn’t have called us down here. Let’s do this already.”

“Fine,” Angella relented at last. “But you two must stay here.” She pointed at Glimmer and Bow.

“What?” Glimmer balked. Adora smiled and gave her friend’s arm a squeeze.

“It’s okay, Glimmer. Shadow Weaver probably won’t say much if you were in the room anyway. Maybe you could watch through the glass and take notes?”

With a reluctant grunt, Glimmer agreed. Adora took a slow, deep breath, then turned to Angella.

"I'm ready."

Angella stuck her head out the door and waited until the coast was clear before leading Adora into the interrogation room. They had to move quickly, which meant Adora didn't have much time to brace herself. One moment she was surrounded by the love and security of her friends, the next she was face-to-face with a monster.

"Adora," Shadow Weaver said, her voice dripping with an affection that Adora now understood to be false. "Thank goodness you're alright!"

"Cut the shit, Shadow Weaver," Adora replied as she took a seat across the table from her. "What are you doing here? And how did you know where to find me?"

Any hint of tenderness that lingered in Shadow Weaver's bruised and swollen features vanished. She turned her cold eyes to Angella, who simply shook her head.

"I can't let you speak to her alone," Angella said, clearly picking up on Shadow Weaver's unspoken concern. "I'm bending the rules for you enough as it is."

"Very well." Shadow Weaver turned her gaze back to Adora. "To answer your questions: I'm here because the Horde is done with me." Though her hands were cuffed to the table, she was still able to gesture at her blood-soaked blouse. "And between dying and prison, I've chosen to live. As for your second question, how do you think I knew where to find you?"

There was a teasing lit in her voice when she asked this, and it made Adora tense. For a horrible moment, Adora thought the answer was Catra. After all, Catra had seen her with Glimmer and Bow at the protest — it wouldn't have been hard to figure out the rest from there.

Adora's heart ached.

Wow, she thought. *Catra really must hate me.*

She swallowed hard and narrowed her gaze in an attempt to act unaffected. "Enlighten me."

Shadow Weaver chuckled. "Given how many officers at this precinct are moonlighting for the Horde, you didn't really think your involvement with Chief Brightmoon's daughter would stay a secret forever, did you?"

At her side, Adora sensed Angella bristling. When she glanced at her, Adora found Angella's cheeks turning red, though be it from anger or embarrassment, she couldn't tell.

"Who?" Angella demanded.

"Not so fast," Shadow Weaver said, sounding quite pleased with herself as she leaned back in her uncomfortable-looking metal chair. "I'm not about to start spilling my secrets without some assurances first."

Angella let out an indignant squawk. "I have done everything you've asked of me. Adora is here and no one else knows that I have you in custody. I think it's time for you to start holding up your end of the bargain."

"Those were the terms of my surrender," Shadow Weaver pointed out. "I never promised you more than that."

"Typical," Adora spat. "It's always got to be mind games with you, doesn't it?"

Shadow Weaver clicked her tongue, chiding Adora as if she were a little girl again. "Come now, Adora — I taught you better than that."

"What you *taught* me was that I was a pawn — that I only mattered so long as I was serving the gang. But it turns out you

were wrong about that, and you were wrong about me." Adora wasn't sure where this swell of confidence was coming from. All she knew was that it felt amazing to finally put Shadow Weaver in her place. "So enough with the bullshit. Either give us something useful or I'm out of here."

There was a dangerous glint in Shadow Weaver's eyes as she stared Adora down. Once upon a time, that look would have turned Adora's blood to ice. After a few agonizing moments, Shadow Weaver turned that look to Angella.

"Immunity," she said.

Angella shook her head. "That's not going to happen. A judge will never allow it."

"Then I can't promise to be as helpful to you as I could be. Between losing the children and their battalion of corrupt police officers, the Horde's operations would be devastated. Are you sure this is an opportunity you want to pass up?"

"We can arrange a plea deal," Angella countered. "A reduced sentence for whatever we're able to get from you."

Shadow Weaver considered the offer with the air of someone trying to decide what to wear. Adora held her breath until, at last, Shadow Weaver shrugged.

"That will work just fine," the old woman said. "Now tell me, how is Sergeant Lashor's recovery coming along?"

Adora frowned. Confused, she looked to Angella to see if this question meant anything to her. Judging by the open-mouthed look of surprise on the police chief's face, it did.

"How did you…" Angella gaped, struggling to think of what to say. She shook her head. "No. If you're implying that one of my most dedicated officers—"

“Is a dirty cop?” Shadow Weaver finished. “I’m not implying anything — I’m telling you. He’s been feeding me intelligence from your operation for years.”

Angella glared. “If he’s such a valuable asset then why did your thugs beat the man half to death?”

The question made Shadow Weaver laugh — a sound so foreign that it gave Adora chills.

“Thug, singular,” Shadow Weaver said. She grinned at Adora, her teeth stained with blood from the still-oozing cut on her lip. “That handy work was all Catra.”

Adora felt as though someone had knocked the wind out of her. That must have been Catra’s initiation.

“I don’t believe you,” Angella said.

“Then why don’t you ask him yourself?” Shadow Weaver replied. “I’m sure he’s not proud of the fact that he was bested by a teenage girl, but given everything else he’s done for the Horde I think that’s the least of his worries.”

Angella licked her lips and drummed her fingernails across the top of the table. Adora could tell she was torn, and she didn’t blame her. If Adora didn’t know the Horde the way she did, she would have been reluctant to believe it herself.

“If it’s true, then it wasn’t Catra’s fault,” Adora said, desperate for Angella to believe her. “She just turned 18 — this was probably her initiation as a full member of the gang. Catra never would have done something like that if they hadn’t—”

“Oh, Adora,” Shadow Weaver said. “It hurts my heart to see you still defending that girl after everything she’s done to you.”

Adora’s mouth went dry. “Stop it.”

“First, she chose the Horde over you. I can’t imagine how badly that betrayal must have hurt.”

“Shut up.” Adora’s heart was hammering in her chest. Blood rushed to her head, making her feel dizzy.

“And then,” Shadow Weaver continued unabated, “she turned on me when she discovered that I was trying to protect you. When it comes to Catra, it seems you and I were nothing more than stepping stones on her way to the top.”

Adora’s fingers ached from how hard she was gripping the edge of the table. “What are you talking about?”

Shadow Weaver leaned forward, getting as close to Adora as her cuffs would allow. “How do you think you’ve been able to avoid the Horde’s retribution for this long, Adora? You know what they do to those who step out of line. I’ve been trying to keep them off your trail since the day you left, and look where it got me.”

Instinctively, Adora’s fingertips grazed the gold bracelet on her wrist. Was what Shadow Weaver was saying true? Or was she just trying to manipulate her, the way she always did? Adora glared at her and drew up as much courage as she could muster.

“Enough,” she said, suddenly feeling eerily calm. “This isn’t about Catra — this is about you giving us enough information to save your ass. Now, talk.”

A sneer rippled across Shadow Weaver’s marred lips as she sat back again.

“Have it your way," Shadow Weaver huffed. She turned to Angella. “Start with Lashor. Once I see a signed plea deal, I’ll give you the rest of the names.”

Angella nodded. “I’ll have the D.A. draw up the paperwork.”

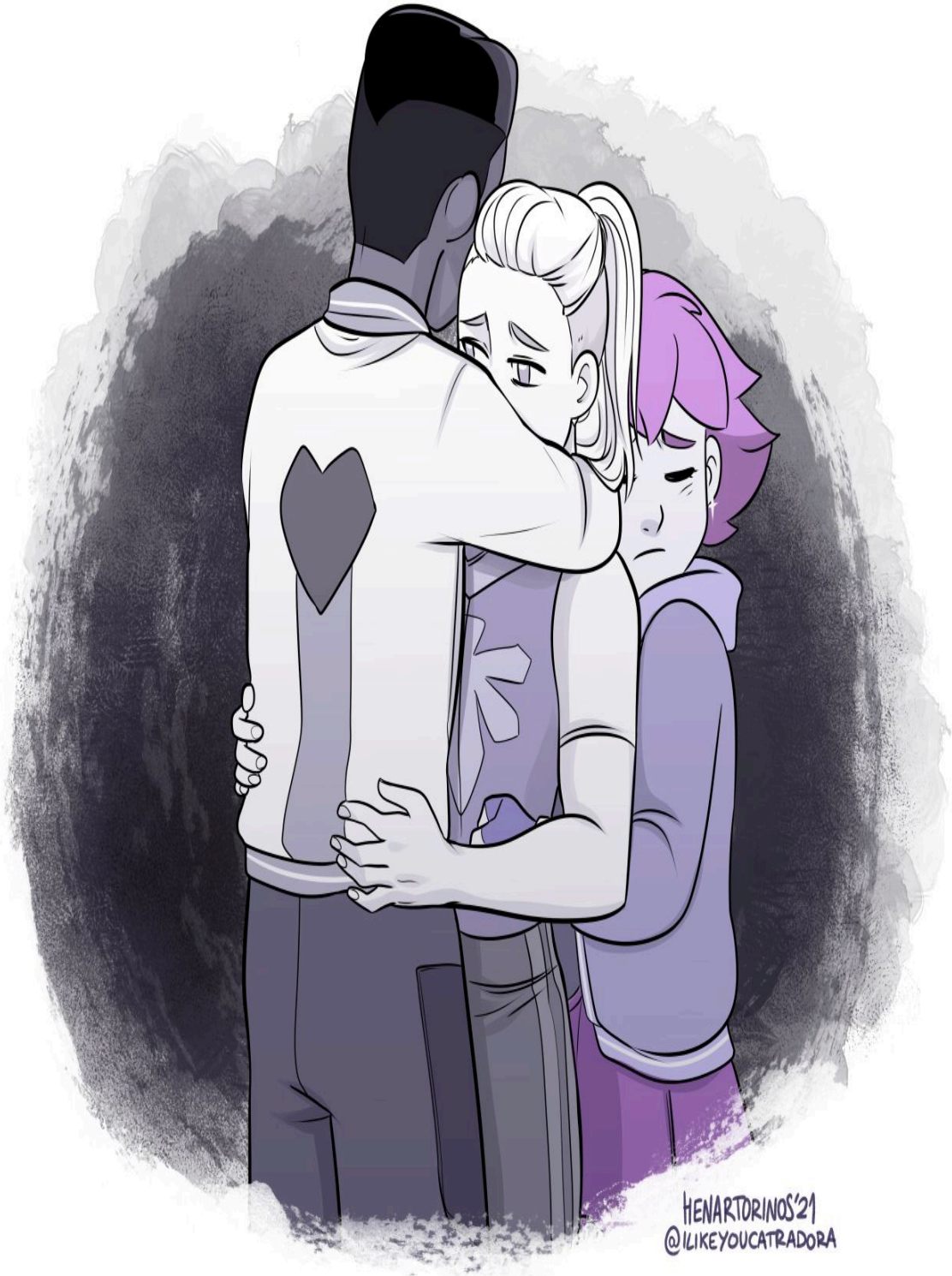
Without another word, Adora got to her feet. She willed herself to move, to not give Shadow Weaver the satisfaction of looking back

at her as she left the interrogation room.

Glimmer and Bow were waiting for her in the hallway.

“Are you okay?” Glimmer asked.

They didn’t give her the chance to respond. Instead, they enveloped Adora in a tight group hug and let her cry in the safety of their embrace.


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Chapter 28

With her face set in a scowl to hide the panic rolling at her core, Catra burst into Entrapta's lab. Hordak looked up from where he hovered just over Entrapta's shoulder, watching her work, and cut Catra a reproachful look.

"She's gone," Catra said before Hordak had a chance to admonish her.

Hordak's eyes narrowed. "What?"

"Shadow Weaver," Catra replied, following through with the half-truth she and Scorpia had practiced. "I just went to check on her and she's gone."

Without a word, Hordak stormed across the lab, shoving past Catra as he went. She took a deep breath before turning and following in his wake. Neither of them spoke as they hurried down the long hallway to where Shadow Weaver had been held prisoner. The door to the storage room stood open wide. Hordak paused to inspect the door frame, the handle, the latch. Catra assumed he was looking for evidence of tampering.

While she waited for him to step into the room, Catra shot a quick glance at Scorpia, who stood where Shadow Weaver had once been bound. Scorpia gave a tiny nod before looking up at the disturbed air vent above her. After discovering Shadow Weaver missing, the pair had worked together to fabricate some plausible way that she could have escaped that didn't include an unlocked and unguarded door. The air vent had been Scorpia's idea.

Hordak circled the room, his face twisted in rage.

"How did you let this happen?" he snarled down at Catra. She stood her ground with a defiant sneer.

"I didn't *let* anything happen," she spat back. "I was standing guard just like you told me to. How was I supposed to know her

cuffs weren't secure?" That little detail was a shot in the dark. As far as Catra knew, Shadow Weaver's hands were probably still cuffed behind her back wherever she was — it's not like she would have really needed them for her real escape. But there was no evidence that said otherwise, and if blaming the cuffs helped shift some of the blame off of her, Catra didn't mind adding to her lie.

"She must have gone through there," Scorpia said, pointing to the air vent. If it had been true, it would have been a tight squeeze for a full grown woman of Shadow Weaver's stature. But desperation made people try all kinds of crazy things — Catra was proof enough of that. "We already checked the intake vents outside and the cover's busted off."

This part was definitely true. Catra had broken it herself.

Hordak rounded back on Catra, his eyes flashing dangerously. "You were tasked with watching her," he growled between clenched teeth. "How did you miss this?"

"I did exactly what you told me to," Catra lied. "I was watching the door and checking in on her. You know what a sneaky bitch she is! I came to find you as soon as I realized she was gone. What more do you want from me?"

It was only then that Catra realized she may have pushed a little too hard. Hordak's nostrils flared as he stepped up to her, crowding her personal space until she had to step back just so she could breathe. He continued advancing until Catra's back hit the wall; she was trapped beneath his looming shadow.

"I want you to find her," Hordak said. He spoke slowly so that every word sounded like a threat. Before Catra could react, Hordak grabbed a fistful of her jacket and pulled her off her feet. He let out a furious yell as he threw her down at Scorpia's feet. "*Now!*"

Stars swam at the corners of Catra's vision as she gasped for the breath that had been knocked from her lungs. She felt Scorpia's

hands on her shoulders, but she shrugged them off and got back up on her own.

"Yes, Hordak." Catra didn't trust herself enough to say anything else, lest she get herself into more trouble. She left the room without giving Hordak so much as a sideways glance and hurried out the back door.

"Whew! It worked!" Scorpia's voice made Catra jump. She didn't realize Scorpia was following her.

"What are you doing?" she barked.

Scorpia blinked back at her, a hint of hurt flickering across her features before being replaced by her trademark smile. "I'm gonna help you look for her."

Catra shrank back. She wrapped her arms around herself and dropped her eyes, unable to handle the earnest way that Scorpia looked at her. "There's no point. Shadow Weaver will be long gone by now and besides, we're better off without her. Right now I need to focus on finding a better way back in Hordak's good books."

"Well, let's talk about it in the car. You scheme, I'll drive — at least that way we can pretend we looked for her." Scorpia walked to her car, unlocking it as she went. Catra stared, bewildered.

"You don't have to do this," she said.

"I know," Scorpia replied. She opened the passenger side door and motioned for Catra to get in. "But I want to."

Every part of Catra's brain wanted nothing more than to find some quiet place where she could be alone. She didn't want company, and she sure as hell didn't deserve kindness, especially the unrelenting kind that Scorpia offered so freely. Still, Catra was compelled, and the next thing she knew she was sinking down into the sleek leather bucket seat. She stared blankly ahead as Scorpia started the car and pulled out of the alleyway. A thick fog

filled Catra's mind, obscuring any thought she tried to muster until she gave up entirely.

They drove in silence, with only the purr of the engine as a soundtrack. Scorpia maneuvered through streets that brought them deeper into the city's business district. There was no way Shadow Weaver would be somewhere like this. Subtly, Catra stole a glance at Scorpia and wondered where she was taking them.

Scorpia turned onto a busy street packed with cars and bikes. Pedestrians cluttered the sidewalks, hailing cabs and waiting at crosswalks. As they idled at a red light, Scorpia pointed to one of the skyscrapers in the next block ahead.

"Have you heard of Black Garnet Media?" she asked.

Catra scowled. "Have I heard of the biggest media empire in the city? C'mon, Scorpia — just because I didn't go to school doesn't mean I'm an idiot."

The light turned green and traffic flowed forward. Scorpia craned her neck to look up at Black Garnet Media's head office as they drove by, letting out a wistful sigh as they passed. Catra followed her gaze and stared up at the building as well. Black Garnet Media wasn't the only media company in the city, but they were unquestionably the biggest and most influential. Even in a digital world, their newspaper sales remained strong. BGM's news network was consistently the highest rated and when a big news story broke, they were almost always the ones to run it first.

"Did you bring BGM up for a reason or was that just a weird attempt at small talk?" Catra asked as the building receded behind them.

Scorpia chewed her bottom lip for a moment before answering. "My parents own it."

"They *what?*" Catra balked, her voice filling the car with the volume of her surprise. There was a lot of information packed into those four little words. Not only did Scorpia apparently still have a

family, but they also happened to own one of the most powerful companies in Etheria? Suddenly Scorpia's luxury sports car made sense to Catra, but that was the only thing that did. "Back up a second. If you have a family—a rich and powerful family—what the fuck are you doing with the Horde?"

"It's kind of a weird story," Scorpia said with a small laugh that betrayed a touch of sadness. "I was a kid when my moms got wrapped up with the gang. They were trying to break a huge story about the Horde's influence over the city and, well, the gang didn't like that very much."

"No kidding," Catra muttered. Scorpia had her full attention now. Catra looked at her partner as if she was seeing her for the first time. "What happened?"

Shrugging, Scorpia turned off the busy main street and headed toward the city's theater district. "They struck a deal: BGM wouldn't run any negative stories about the Horde's activities, and in exchange, the Horde would provide protection for the company and my family."

"Shit." Catra slumped back in her seat. She ran her fingers through her hair as she considered the implications of such an arrangement. "So much for journalistic integrity. The gang really does have its fingers in everything, doesn't it?"

Scorpia laughed, and this time it sounded a little more real. "They sure do."

Catra cocked her head, watching Scorpia's profile and the unusually intense way that her partner stared at the road ahead. She didn't know Scorpia well, but Catra could already tell when she was holding back. "So, where do you come in?"

"I, uh…" Scorpia hesitated — a rare thing for her. Her dark eyes quickly cut to Catra before returning to the road. "I guess you could say I'm a bit of an insurance policy."

"What do you mean?"

“Well, my parents kinda went back on the deal,” Scorpia said. “They didn’t run a story, but they kept investigating. They got a lead that connected the gang to mayor Prime, which, if true, isn’t the kind of story you can sit on, no matter who’s threatening you. But Hordak found out that they were sniffing around and let’s just say that he wasn’t very happy.”

She paused for a moment, turning down a quieter side street to avoid a line of backed-up traffic. “I came home from school one day to find him in my house. He was going to kill my moms and I… I couldn’t let that happen. So I made my own deal with Hordak and offered to join the Horde in exchange for my parents’ safety. It’s kind of a win-win for him if you think about it. Now if either of us step out of line, well…”

Scorpia didn’t finish her thought, but she didn’t need to; Catra understood exactly what she wasn’t saying.

“If you betray the Horde, they’ll go after your family.” Catra said, her stomach turning. “And if your parents run stories about the Horde—”

“Then I’d be where Shadow Weaver was a couple of hours ago,” Scorpia finished with a nod. “Except I wouldn’t have the guts to run away. I’d still be stuck in that room, waiting for you to off me.” There was a tense beat of silence before Scorpia let out an awkward laugh. “Sorry, too soon. Sheesh, that got dark fast.”

The pair sat for a few long moments in contemplative silence. Scorpia continued to drive randomly throughout the city. Or, perhaps, it wasn’t random at all. They passed a chic condo building that Catra could imagine Scorpia living in with her affluent family, and a fancy prep school where Scorpia easily could have been enrolled as a student a couple years ago. Maybe this seemingly pointless trip was really a tour of the life that Scorpia couldn’t quite have.

“Why did you tell me all of this?” Catra asked quietly.

Scorpia swallowed. “Now we know each other’s secrets.”

Catra didn’t have the heart to tell Scorpia that she still didn’t know her at all. If anything, accidentally letting Shadow Weaver escape was more of an embarrassing fuck-up than a real secret. “Are you saying no one else knows who your parents are?”

“People know. Something like that’s hard to keep quiet,” Scorpia admitted. “But no one knows about the deal I made. I’ve never told anyone before — just you.”

Catra turned away and stared out the window. She debated her next words carefully, before finally giving in.

“You were right about my initiation,” she said, letting the words rush out like a breath held too long. “Shadow Weaver arranged for me to be pimped out to a dirty cop at the motel. I bashed his head in with a lamp instead.”

She expected Scorpia to react the way she usually did: with far too much emotion and far too many questions for Catra’s comfort.

But instead, Scorpia just sighed. “I’m sorry, Wild Cat.”

Suddenly exhausted, Catra slumped against the car door and rested her forehead against the cool window glass.

“Yeah,” she said. “Me too.”


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Chapter 29

"I'm worried about my mom."

Glimmer's quiet admission came during a particularly tense moment of the horror movie she, Adora, and Bow were watching. The character on screen was slowly, foolishly, creeping down a rickety wooden staircase into a dark basement. A split-second later, the killer's hand shot between two steps and grabbed the hero by her ankle, but Adora was too distracted by her friend to be scared. In fact, she actually let out a sigh of relief.

"Okay, I didn't want to say anything but I'm worried too," she said. Almost a week had passed since Shadow Weaver turned herself in. With each day that went by, Chief Angella Brightmoon became more and more distant. At this point, Adora wondered if Angella was actually sleeping at the office — if she was sleeping at all. They rarely saw her, and when they did, Angella's usually bright and kind eyes were shadowed by a perpetually furrowed brow and hung with dark circles. When she was home, Angella spent most of the time staring off, deep in thought, or sneaking away to take hushed phone calls behind closed doors.

Bow paused the movie. "Investigating your own precinct must be pretty stressful," he said, giving Glimmer's leg a reassuring pat. Glimmer, who was laying across the couch with her head on Adora's lap and her legs draped over Bow's, let out a groan.

"I know," she said. "But I just wish she would let us help!"

Adora bit her lip and let her head fall back against the plush couch cushions. She knew Angella had plenty of reasons for not letting her teenage daughter and friends help ferret out the bad seeds in the police force. Glimmer knew it too, so Adora knew telling her as much wouldn't really help.

But sitting still and doing nothing wasn't exactly Adora's forte either.

“We should get back to strategizing what our next move will be,” she said. Her mind was on her notebook and the list of gang-toppling ideas they had brainstormed together. “As much as I hate to admit it, Shadow Weaver is right: without the kids or the cops, the Horde is going to be vulnerable.”

“What do you think the Horde will do if they find out that Shadow Weaver is helping the police?” Bow asked.

It was a good question, and one that made Adora uneasy. “I’m not sure. They’ve never had a breach like that before.”

Glimmer snorted. “Yes they have! You’re literally living with the Chief of police!”

Adora shook her head. “Yeah but I’m not nearly as important as Shadow Weaver. She’s been Hordak’s right hand for years. I don’t think there’s anything about the gang that she doesn’t know.”

Humming thoughtfully to herself, Glimmer shimmied up to sit properly. “What do you think the Horde is doing without her?”

Tapping her chin, Adora ran the scenario through in her mind. She’d never known the Horde without Shadow Weaver in it. Now, without her or the kids, Hordak was probably leaning pretty heavily on the Force Captains to keep things moving. She wondered how Catra was handling the news. Out of everyone in the gang, Catra was probably the most relieved to be rid of Shadow Weaver and, after all Catra had suffered at the hands of that miserable woman, Adora wouldn’t blame her.

“Hello? Earth to Adora?”

The flash of Glimmer’s hand waving in front of her face made Adora jump. “Yes! What? Sorry, I was just thinking about Catra. I hope she’s doing okay through all of this.”

Glimmer and Bow exchanged an inscrutable look.

“You still care about her, huh?” Bow asked gently.

Adora's mouth worked silently, trying to find the words. "I mean… yeah. Of course. I can't just turn off my feelings, y'know?"

"But what if what Shadow Weaver said is true?" Glimmer pressed. "What if she really did beat up Sargeant Lashor?"

"Who cares?" Adora said, perhaps with a bit more bite than she intended. When it came to Catra, she couldn't help but feel defensive. "Lashor is a dirty cop. He got what was coming to him."

"Adora," Bow cut in with that diplomatic tone of his, "nobody deserves to be put into the ICU."

Irritated, Adora got up from the couch. She paced back and forth in front of the TV. "You guys don't get it," she grumbled, fighting to keep her anger in check. "It was probably her initiation. She didn't have a choice!"

Glimmer leaned forward, her elbows resting on her knees. "You've mentioned the initiations before. How do they work?"

Adora bit her lip. There was one thing she still hadn't told her friends — one horrible secret that she'd been carrying like a curse. Would they still look at her the same if she told them what she'd done? Perhaps, she thought, it was time to find out. She swallowed hard.

"Well, like I've said, you're not officially a part of the gang until you turn 18," she explained as she fidgeted with her bracelet. "And even then, you need to be initiated first. It's a way of proving your loyalty."

"So, does everyone have to beat up a cop?" Glimmer asked.

"No, but it's always something bad." Adora's stomach churned at the memory of that night down by the docks. "They arrange for you to participate in something illegal, and if you refuse, you're out."

Bow grimaced. “And by out do you mean…” He trailed off, unable to utter the words. Instead, he dragged his thumb across his throat and Adora nodded. Bow blanched. “What did you have to do?”

There it was: the question Adora had been avoiding since she got there. Clutching her hands into fists at her sides, she took a steadying breath and looked at her friends. “If I tell you, do you promise not to hate me?”

Glimmer and Bow were on their feet in a flash. They each took one of Adora’s hands and held it in their own.

“We could never hate you, Adora,” Glimmer said firmly.

Adora let out a dark huff of laughter. “You said that now…”

“Seriously,” Bow insisted. “You can tell us anything.”

It was now or never. Adora closed her eyes. “Do you guys know a guy named Seahawk?”

There was a moment of silence, and Adora could swear she felt the air get sucked from the room. Glimmer’s grip on her hand tightened.

“That was you?” Glimmer asked in a hushed tone. The hurt in her voice was devastating, and Adora let out a sob.

“I didn’t… Not the whole thing…” she stammered through her tears. “I only hit him once, I swear. I didn’t have a choice. But I thought I’d killed him.”

“Hey, hey. It’s okay.” Bow pulled her into a hug. For a few moments, Adora let him hold her as she cried. Then she felt Glimmer’s hand on her shoulder.

“I’m sorry, Adora,” Glimmer said. “That must have been awful.”

Adora's heart clenched. She knew those words must have been hard for Glimmer to say. Detective Seahawk was one of the good ones. He even made a few appearances on the walls of the Brightmoon home in photos of backyard barbecues and holiday parties. Adora knew he was part of Glimmer's life, and that had made the confession all the more terrible.

"I'm sorry too, Glimmer," Adora said, wiping the tears from her cheeks. "I'm so ashamed of what I did. It was one of the reasons I decided to go to your mom for help."

Bow stepped back, his kind, dark eyes watching Adora closely. "What do you think they made Catra do?"

"I don't know," Adora sniffled. "But I hate myself for not being there to protect her. I wish I could have—"

She stopped short as an idea sprang to her mind. Maybe there was still a chance to protect Catra after all. Maybe now was the perfect time.

"Adora?" Glimmer asked. "What is it?"

"Come on," Adora replied, motioning for her friends to follow as she made a beeline for the stairs. "I have an idea."

*

It was long past dark by the time the Best Friends Squad finally made it to the sketchy neighborhood that Adora had once called home. This time, Adora let Glimmer bring her bat.

"There it is," Adora said as the old hotel came into view.

"That's where the Horde's Force Captains live?" Glimmer asked incredulously.

Glancing back at her, Adora raised an eyebrow. "Yeah? Why?"

Glimmer shook her head. “I dunno. I guess I thought the gang would give its most loyal members nicer digs.”

Adora thought back to the excitement and wonder she’d felt the first time she was escorted to her very own room. “Trust me, when you come from nothing, even a decrepit old hotel feels like a serious upgrade.”

“So, which room is Catra’s?” Bow asked, eyeing the building from where he and the others loitered in the shadows of an alcove that led to a shuttered restaurant.

“Third floor, back corner.” Adora pointed to the building’s west-facing side. “The fire escape goes right past her window.”

“Are you sure she’ll be willing to talk to you?” Glimmer looked uneasy. Adora understood her apprehension, but it did nothing to dissuade her.

“All I can do is try,” Adora said with a shrug.

When they were certain that the coast was clear, the three of them darted across the street and scurried to the base of the fire escape that crawled up the side of the hotel. Bow and Glimmer gave Adora a leg up to the wrought iron ladder and waited until she hauled herself up onto the first landing before taking their posts as lookouts.

Adora climbed the fire escape slowly, taking one careful step after another so as not to make too much noise. She crept low past the windows on the second floor. Her heart pounded in her chest as she ascended the final steps to Catra’s window.

The curtains were open. Warm golden light from a single dim lamp filtered into the night. Adora held her breath and peeked inside.

There she found Catra, laying on her back sideways on the bed with her knees bent over the edge of the mattress. Her eyes were

closed, but Adora could tell she wasn't sleeping. Adora had watched Catra sleep enough to know the difference.

The room hadn't changed much since the last time Adora had been in it. In fact, the biggest changes were to Catra herself. The slick leather jacket she had adopted since her initiation lay cast aside, leaving Catra's bare arms and shoulders exposed, her scars barely visible in the faint lamplight. The sight of Catra dressed like that—in a low-cut, strapless top paired with tight black jeans—stirred up as much heat at Adora's core now as it did the first time she'd seen the new look. Adora was struck by how much Catra has changed in such a short amount of time. Gone was the gangly, tomboyish Catra that Adora had known all her life. Underneath those oversized, filthy hand-me-downs, Catra's body had grown strong and curved. Even her hair was longer now, a bit sleeker and well kept than it ever had been before. When had Catra become such an adult? And how had Adora missed it?

After a few minutes of working up the courage, Adora raised her fist to knock on the window. But before she could. Catra's eyes shot open and Adora faltered. Catra sat up, and looked toward her bedroom door. Adora crouched low and watched as the door swung open to reveal Scorpia, Catra's new partner, filling the door frame with her hulking silhouette. In one hand, Scorpia held a plastic bag, and in the other she clutched a six-pack of beer. The huge smile plastered across Scorpia's face made Adora bristle.

At first, Catra seemed affronted. Her shoulders hunched up close to her ears, and her hands gripped the blanket beneath her. Adora could tell she was giving Scorpia shit for something, and she silently willed Catra to send the formidable Force Captain away. But instead, Scorpia laughed and came into the room, kicking the door closed behind her. She handed Catra the bag before settling down on the mattress beside her. The bag turned out to be filled with takeout containers. Slowly, Catra's defensive stance seemed to soften. She handed one container to Scorpia in exchange for a beer. The world seemed to disappear as Adora watched the pair dig into their meals. They were talking as if they were old friends.

Catra even smiled, and giggled once or twice at something Scorpia said. Adora’s heart sank.


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After an agonizingly amount of time spent torturing herself, Adora finally crept back down the fire escape. She dropped from the ladder, the landing sending a wave of uncomfortable tingles up her legs. Adora welcomed the shooting pain — it took her mind off the ache in her chest.

"What happened?" Glimmer asked as she jogged up to meet her. Bow abandoned his post as well. "What did she say?"

Adora grimaced. "I couldn't talk to her — Scorpia's with her." Just saying the words out loud made her feel sick.

Glimmer and Bow glanced at one another and Adora pretended not to notice.

"Do you want to wait?" Bow asked.

"No," Adora said, hustling past both of them so they wouldn't be able to see the hurt on her face. "It's fine. We can try again some other time."

All of the things left unsaid felt like a fourth person following the trio as they hurried back to the closest bus stop. Adora could sense the questions that her friends were dying to ask, and she appreciated that they both seemed to understand that now wasn't the time. The silence between them was so thick that the sound of Glimmer's phone ringing felt even louder than usual.

Tucking her bat under her arm, Glimmer pulled out her phone and answered it. She put the call on speaker so the others could listen in.

"Hey, Mom," Glimmer said nonchalantly.

"Glimmer?" Angella's voice did not carry the same carefree tone as her daughter. She sounded worried. In the background, Adora could make out what sounded like doors being opened and closed. "Where are you?"

“I’m out with Bow and Adora,” Glimmer answered, frowning. “Why?”

“You need to tell me when you’re leaving the house,” Angella said. “Where are you? I’m coming to get you.”

Glimmer looked up at her friends with alarm. “Why? We’re on our way home anyway. What’s wrong?”

“It’s not safe out there.” Angella’s words hit Adora like a splash of icy water. “I’ll explain later, just let me—” Her words were cut off by the sound of knocking.

“Mom?” Worry was creeping into Glimmer's voice now. “Mom, what is it?”

Angella answered in a whisper. “Someone’s at the door. Hold on…” There came a sound of footsteps, Angella’s heavy breathing. Adora leaned in closer, as if that would help her figure out what was happening on the other end of the line. A rustling filled the speaker, and Adora could imagine Angella pressing the phone to her chest as she unlocked the door and opened it a crack.

“Detective.” Angella wasn’t speaking to them. Her words were slightly muffled. “What is it? Did you find out— Ah!”

Glimmer’s hands gripped the phone as what sounded like an altercation came across the line. Angella cried out. There was a scuffling sound, muted voices, the thump of heavy boots.

“Let go of me!” Angella shouted.

“Mom?” Glimmer cried, her eyes wide with panic. “Mom, what’s happening?”

She was answered by a loud clattering noise, followed by more shuffling and Angella’s muffled scream fading away. The call stayed connected, but the line fell silent.

Whatever had happened on the other end was over.

Whoever had been there moments before was gone, and from the sounds of things, they'd taken Angella with them.

Chapter 30

"Why aren't there ever any cabs around when you need them?" Glimmer shouted, her frantic voice reverberating through the desolate street. She had already told the others that taking the bus home would take too long, but this unsavory part of town wasn't the sort of place where taxis tended to hang around either. Glimmer turned to Bow with pleading eyes. "Bow, will you call for someone? I don't want to hang up just in case—"

"Already on it," Bow said, flashing his phone screen to show an internet search for Etheria cab companies. He hit 'call' on the first number and went to work.

Glimmer then turned her attention to Adora. "While he's doing that, will you please call the precinct and tell them that we need officers at my house right away?"

As much as it pained Adora to deny Glimmer at a time like this, she shook her head. "I don't think that's a good idea, Glimmer. Whoever was at her door was a detective, remember?"

A look of comprehension washed over Glimmer's face. But even though she seemed to understand what Adora was implying, her instinct to do something, anything, was doing battle with common sense. Glimmer's breath came fast and shallow as her panic deepened. "But, my mom… She needs help."

"I know, Glimmer." Adora pulled her friend into a tight, protective embrace. "And we're going to help her, I promise."

At that moment, Bow shouted for the girls to join him at the closest intersection. Adora gently guided Glimmer to the corner. All the while, Glimmer kept her eyes locked on her phone screen, which was still counting the minutes of her mother's call. Apparently it had been less than 10 minutes since what sounded like an abduction took place on the other end of the line, but to

Adora, it had felt like an eternity. Every moment felt like days. The world was moving so, so slowly.

"A taxi will be here in a few minutes, Glimmer," Bow assured. "Sit tight."

But Glimmer wasn't listening to him. Instead, she held the phone close to her ear. Occasionally the sound of a car passing could be heard over the line, but that was it. No voices, no footsteps, no Angella.

"Come on, Mom," Glimmer muttered under her breath. "Come on, just let me know you're okay…"

Adora pressed her lips into a tight line and glanced at Bow. He looked just as fearful as she felt.

Headlights cut up the block to their left as a cab pulled up to the curb. The car wasn't even fully stopped when Glimmer leapt forward, yanked open the door and launched herself inside. Bow scampered in after her, followed by Adora, who was still closing the door as Glimmer shouted, "Floor it!" The cab jolted forward, slamming the door the rest of the way with its momentum.

As the car flew through the city, Adora clutched at the overhead safety handle and watched Bow pull cash first from his wallet, and then from Glimmer's. Adora felt a sting of guilt knowing she wouldn't be able to contribute. Hopefully she'd find some other way to be helpful in this nightmare.

The cabbie had them back at the Brightmoon home in record time. Bow shoved a fistful of cash in the driver's hand as the girls spilled out into the night.

"Keep the change!" Bow said before jumping out after them. The Best Friends Squad sprinted across the front lawn toward the darkened house. They skidded to a stop when they reached the steps that lead to the door. There, laying on the front stoop, they found the cordless house phone that was still connected to the call with Glimmer. Adora's heart sank into her stomach as she

stared at the front door, which hung wide open like a yawning mouth.

Moving carefully, Bow crouched down to pick up the fallen phone.

"No, don't!" Glimmer cried, pulling him back up. "This is a crime scene. We should handle everything like evidence."

"Glimmer, we're not the cops," Bow said delicately.

"I don't care!" Glimmer snapped.

"Okay, everyone take a breath," Adora interjected. "We'll get some gloves before we touch anything. Let's just get inside first, okay?"

This seemed to placate Glimmer enough that she didn't make a fuss when Adora stepped around the phone and into the house. There was no warmth inside, and the dim street light that filtered through the windows cast ominous shadows throughout the unlit home.

Adora hesitated. "Maybe I should walk through first and make sure no one's—"

"Mom!" Glimmer yelled, cutting Adora off as she blew past her with her bat raised high above her shoulder. "Mom, are you here?"

Sighing, Adora cracked her knuckles and went in the opposite direction. Together, the friends searched the house from top to bottom, until they were certain that it was empty. When they reconvened in the living room, Glimmer's fear had been replaced with fiery anger.

"I'm going to kill them," she growled, menacingly slapping the bat into her open palm as she paced the floor. "Whoever did this is dead."

While Glimmer paced, Bow snatched her phone from her pocket and tapped in the passcode. "I'm going to check the security

camera feeds. If this person came right to the front door, we should be able to get a good look at them."

Adora peered over his shoulder and watched as he opened an app with a list of different camera locations. Though she probably shouldn't have been surprised by how many of them were, Adora couldn't help but gape at the screen. Bow tapped on an icon labeled "front door" and pulled up the most recent video. He scrolled along the tracking bar, and the two of them watched a time lapse of the sun setting over the street. At one point, a few frames of the three of them leaving on their doomed expedition to the Horde's hotel flashed across the screen. And then, out of nowhere, the screen filled with static.

"Oh no," Bow groaned.

"What is that?" Adora asked.

Glimmer stopped her pacing and joined them. "What's wrong?"

"It looks like the file is corrupted," Bow said, though he didn't sound convinced. He tried replaying the video from different starting points, but each time it hit a certain timestamp, the picture dissolved. He closed the app and re-launched it, but that didn't help either. "Okay, let me check the other feeds. Maybe one of the other cameras picked something up."

Adora and Glimmer waited and watched in breathless silence as Bow pulled up one camera feed after another. And one after another, each feed showed the same thing: a blizzard of static that kicked in at the exact same time as all the others. Bow swallowed hard and lowered the phone.

"Glimmer… I think someone hacked your security system."

"Fuck!" Glimmer screamed. With a sweep of her arms, she raised the bat up over her head. She was a split-second away from bringing it down when Adora swooped in and grabbed it.



“I know you’re mad, Glimmer,” Adora said, clutching the bat. Glimmer tried to wrench it out of her grasp, but Adora was too strong for her. “But destroying your house isn’t going to help us find your mom.”

“Well what is then?” Glimmer barked. “We can’t call the police because we don’t know who we can trust, the security feeds are useless, and Mom didn’t even trust me enough to tell me what she was doing in the first place! We have nothing to go on!”

“That’s not true,” Adora said. “We may not know the details, but I think we can all agree that she was probably following up on what Shadow Weaver said about the force being corrupt.”

Bow tapped his lips thoughtfully. “They probably caught wind of her investigation.”

Glimmer rounded on him, her eyes wide. “You think this was an inside job?”

“It would explain why a detective was at the door,” Adora said with a nod.

Looking crestfallen, Glimmer sighed. She didn’t say anything as she left the room, leaving Adora and Bow to share an uncomfortable look between them.

“What do we do now?” Bow asked quietly. “We’re completely on our own here.”

Adora thought about it for a moment. “Maybe we could try talking to Shadow Weaver again and see if she knows anything.” The idea of having to face Shadow Weaver again made Adora anxious, but she’d suffer through it if it would help Angella.

But Bow was already shaking his head. “We have no idea where she’s being held, and even if we did I doubt we’d be allowed to talk to her on our own.”

“Ugh!” Adora slumped back against the wall. She didn’t like feeling this defeated. “Okay, well what if we confronted that Lashor guy? We already know he’s dirty. Maybe we could—”

Her thought was cut short as Glimmer shuffled back into the room. In one latex gloved hand, she gingerly carried the cordless

phone that Angella had been using, and in the other she carried a heavy-duty black bag.

"Is that your mom's investigation kit?" Bow asked, eyeing the bag warily. "What are you doing with that?"

Glimmer crouched down beside the coffee table and began unzipping the bag. "I'm going to dust the phone for fingerprints, obviously."

Adora bit her tongue. She didn't want to hurt Glimmer's feelings by reminding her that, even if there was an unfamiliar set of prints on the phone, they had nothing to run them against.

"Oh my gosh, that's right!" Bow said. "Your mom called you on the house phone!"

"Of course she did," Glimmer replied, huffing a sad laugh. "You know what she like; she refuses to get rid of our dumb landline."

Bow's eyes lit up. "That's amazing!"

Both Adora and Glimmer blinked at him, confused.

"Uh, not really?" Glimmer said. "I mean, who has a landline anymore?"

"Not that." Bow waved his hands. He was almost vibrating with excitement. "I mean the fact that she was using the landline and not her cell phone is what's amazing."

What he was getting at hit Adora like a bus. She let out a gasp. "Bow, you're a genius! Glimmer, where does your mom keep her cell phone?"

Glimmer frowned. "Probably in her pocket, like everybody—" It was Glimmer's turn to gasp. In one swift movement she was back on her feet. "If she has her phone on her—"

“We might be able to track her!” Bow cried, finishing her sentence for her.

“How do we do that?” Adora asked. She was vaguely aware that she was yelling now, but she couldn’t seem to control herself; she was far too excited.

Bow, who still had Glimmer’s phone, unlocked it once more and got to work. The girls flanked him so they could watch him as he navigated through Glimmer’s contacts to Angella’s entry. He tapped into the details and scrolled down to a map. Adora wasn’t sure what she was looking at, but judging by the elated cry Glimmer let out, it must have been a good thing.

“I can’t believe I ever argued with her about sharing our locations with each other.” Glimmer wiped a rogue tear from the corner of her eye. “What does it say? Where is she?”

There was a beat of silence. Bow’s brow furrowed as he zoomed in on the map.

“Uh oh,” he said, lifting his eyes to meet Adora’s. “That can’t be good…”

*

Catra was good at a lot of things, and making the best of a shitty situation was definitely one of them.

It had taken her less than a week to get back into Hordak’s good graces. With Scorpia’s help, the gang was back to moving almost as much Runstone as they had been when they had an army of children at their disposal.

“When will this batch be ready?” Catra asked, her voice muffled through the protective gas mask Entrapta insisted she wear.

“Barring any complications, it’ll be ready to move by tomorrow!” Entrapta replied. She was excited, as was usually the case when she was working. And, given the fact that she was always

working, excited was pretty much her default setting. Entrapta turned to look up at Scorpia, who was assisting her at her lab's work station. "Ready?"

Scorpia flashed a thumbs-up. Even with her face obscured by her mask, Catra knew she was grinning. Just before Scorpia and Entrapta began their delicate work of pouring the raw Runestone mixture into one of the janky Easy Bake Oven-style contraptions, a knock came from the window. Catra turned to find Hordak motioning for her to join him. Grateful for an excuse to take off her uncomfortable mask, Catra did as she was told and slid out into the vestibule.

"Getting an early start, I see," Hordak said without taking his eyes off of Entrapta.

It certainly was an early start, especially considering that Catra and Scorpia had been up for half the night drinking and talking shit. But Catra couldn't afford to sleep late and nurse her pounding head; there was work to be done.

"Now that the new distribution points are set up, I wanted to give Entrapta the green light to ramp up production again." Catra watched through the window as Entrapta and Scorpia carefully loaded the volatile drug mixture into one of the machines. This step always made Catra's palms sweat.

"And when will this batch be ready to ship?" Hordak asked,

"Entrapta says it will be street-ready by tomorrow."

With a nod, Hordak finally pulled his attention away from Entrapta and trained his gaze on Catra instead. "Good. Now, come with me. I have a new task for you."

For a minute, Catra thought she was experiencing a severe bout of deja vu. There she was, curiously following Hordak as he led her through the main work room and into the long hallway that stretched to the back of the building. Just like last time, she had to hurry to keep up with his long strides, and just like last time, he

didn’t utter a word until they arrived at the very same door. This time however, a pair of Etheria police officers flanked the door, exchanging conversation in low, hushed tones.

Catra’s head spun.

Holy shit, she thought, her breath catching in her throat. *They found Shadow Weaver*.

This had not been part of the plan. Catra had assumed that Shadow Weaver was too smart to get caught again. Had she told Hordak about the unlocked door? Catra’s mind raced to formulate a way out of this new and unexpected mess.

Hordak tipped his chin at the officers and they stepped aside without a word. Drawing the key from his pocket, Hordak unlocked the door, sending memories of the last time she lived this moment racing through Catra’s head. She took a deep breath to steady herself as Hordak pushed the door open.

Just like last time, a figure sat hunched and bound on the floor.

Except it wasn’t Shadow Weaver at all.

“Holy fucking shit,” Catra breathed. “That’s Angella Brightmoon.”

Chapter 31

Chapter Notes

> Author's note: The illustrations for this chapter were drawn way before the fic started. As such, please ignore any inconsistencies between the two.

If Glimmer had it her way, the Best Friends Squad would have left to rescue her mother the moment Bow pinpointed Angella's location. Adora knew this because Glimmer tried, and Adora had to physically stop her.

"Let go of me!" Glimmer snarled as she thrashed against Adora's arms, which were locked around her middle.

"Oof!" Adora held strong, even as one of Glimmer's elbows nearly knocked the wind out of her. "I will, but I need you to listen to me, okay?"

With a defeated groan, Glimmer finally stopped struggling. "Fine, I'm listening!"

Warily, Adora released her friend from her grip, wincing at the dirty look Glimmer shot her as she whirled around. But Adora knew better than anyone that charging into the Horde's headquarters unprepared was nothing short of a death sentence.

"I know you want to save your mom, Glimmer. I do too," Adora said. "But we can't just rush in. It's too dangerous. We need to think this through."

"We've already wasted too much time," Glimmer shot back. She paced the room, agitated. "What if they kill her while we're 'thinking this through'?"

Adora understood her friend's panic. After everything she'd told her and Bow about the gang, after what they'd seen with their own eyes when Shadow Weaver turned herself in, Adora couldn't

blame them for worrying. But they didn't know the Horde like she did.

"For what it's worth, if they wanted to kill her they would have done it already," Adora said. "They wouldn't have bothered taking her back to headquarters."

"Then what are they planning?" Bow asked from where he sat on the couch. By now he had the map with Angella's GPS signal pulled up on his tablet. He had been watching it like a hawk, just in case there were any changes. "Could it be a trap?"

This was a possibility that Adora hadn't considered. What if Bow was right? What if this abduction was about more than just Angella getting too close to exposing the dirty cops in her midst? What if this was all a ploy to lure Adora out of hiding now that Shadow Weaver wasn't there to stop them?

Her heart sank. She could only think of one person who would put Angella's life in danger for the chance to get back at her.

"Catra." The name slipped past Adora's lips before she had a chance to think better of it. Glimmer rounded on her, eyes wide and furious.

"What about her?" Glimmer asked. "Do you think this was her idea?"

Adora's mouth gaped for a moment as she considered how to answer the question. Did she think this was Catra's idea? She didn't want to believe it, but with each passing second, the possibility burrowed itself deeper and deeper into Adora's brain until she couldn't shake it if she tried.

"I don't know," Adora said quietly. "Maybe?"

"That bitch!" Glimmer shouted. Her voice chased away the uncomfortable quiet that had settled into the house.

Bow glanced at Adora. Something about her expression must have told him that they were wading into dangerous waters with this line of thought, so he jumped to his feet and hurried between the girls. “Let’s not get ahead of ourselves, okay? The only thing we know for certain right now is that the Horde has Angella. Adora, what do you think their next move will be? Is there any chance they could be holding her for ransom or something?”

No, there wasn’t. Adora had never known the gang to kidnap something for financial gain; it was just too risky. But if the idea could help bring Glimmer some comfort while they planned what to do next, Adora could play along. “Possibly. Angella’s pretty important — they could probably get anything they wanted in exchange for her safety. Or maybe they’re just trying to find out how much she knows.”

Glimmer tossed her hands in the air. “I’m not about to negotiate with terrorists!”

“It’s okay, Glimmer,” Adora insisted. “Neither am I. All I’m saying is we have a bit of time. Let’s do this right.”

“Okay, fine.” Glimmer crossed her arms and stared Adora down. “Then what do you suggest?”

What Adora suggested was taking the next day to prepare. It was already so late, and she knew the Horde would be on high alert tonight. So, instead of barging out into the night, she instructed her friends to comb the house for anything that they could use to protect themselves with. They split up to search, and reconvened a short while later to pile their dangerous treasures into the middle of the living room floor.

With one hand on her hip, Glimmer pointed to a professional utility belt she had retrieved from her mother’s bedroom. “Mom keeps her firearm in a safe, but she left the rest of her gear out.”

“Good. We don’t need guns anyway,” Bow said as he picked up the belt and unclipped its contents. There was a canister of

pepper spray, as well as a heavy black contraption that Adora recognized as a taser. Just the sight of it made her shudder. Bow held them up triumphantly. “But these may come in handy!”

Adora crouched down to survey one of the partially empty liquor bottles that Bow had contributed to the pile. “Uh, Bow? What are these for?”

Bow smiled brightly. “Molotov cocktails! I figured we might be able to use them as a distraction.”

“Huh.” Adora turned the bottle in her hand, listening to the vodka slosh around inside. “Clever.”

“Thanks!” Bow beamed.

The pile also included Glimmer’s trusty bat and an unnerving collection of large kitchen knives, which Adora returned to the butcher’s block while Glimmer complained.

“How can you say no to knives?” Glimmer whined.

“These things aren’t practical,” Adora explained, holding up a carving knife for emphasis. “They’re big and unwieldy. You’d probably end up hurting yourself before you could use it on anyone else.”

Glimmer gasped, clearly offended. “Hey!”

“Am I wrong?” Adora raised an eyebrow at her friend. “Would you even know what to do with a knife if you needed to protect yourself with it?”

“Well, sure. I’d just, y’know…” Glimmer made a stabbing motion with her hand.

“Hoo boy,” Adora said. “We’ve got some work to do.”

She spent the next couple of hours teaching her friends how to defend themselves. After all, arming themselves wouldn’t matter

much if they didn't know how to use what they had. Adora eventually relented and let everyone carry a knife—smaller ones, like paring and utility knives—and showed Glimmer and Bow how to handle them properly. She even walked them through some basic hand-to-hand combat moves. As much as she hoped they wouldn't have to use any of this new training, Adora felt a lot better knowing she wouldn't be leading a pair of lambs to the slaughter if things went sideways.

The trio slept in shifts, just in case someone came back in the night. They spent the next day packing their supplies and practicing their sparring as they waited for the sun to go down again. Glimmer kept both her cell phone and the home phone close, just in case a ransom call actually did come through.

Bow eyed the cordless phone warily. "What do you think is happening at the precinct right now? Are they expecting Glimmer to call about Angella? Is it weird if we don't?"

Adora chewed her bottom lip and looked at Glimmer. These were good questions. Unfortunately, none of them had the answers.

In the end, Glimmer decided she wouldn't be able to keep her cool if she got one of her mother's colleagues on the phone, so they didn't bother. Instead, they waited.

And then, once the sun set and the world was dark, the Best Friends Squad set out on their rescue mission.

Angella's GPS signal hadn't changed locations since the night before. The closer the friends got to the old garage where Adora had once spent hours each day working for the Horde, the more anxious she felt. This was the first time she'd been back since she deserted the gang that had raised her, and she was surprised by the flurry of complicated feelings that fact brought up for her.

After surveying the darkened front of the garage where Adora pointed out the locations for the different security cameras from the shadows, she, Glimmer, and Bow crept around to the large

warehouse that was attached to the back of this building. Adora's eyes traced its high, plain walls. She was still surprised by how big the place was, and by how much of it she had never seen.

"I've tracked the last GPS signal to this spot," Bow said, pointing to the far back of Horde HQ. "Angella must be somewhere inside this warehouse. Do we have a plan?"


FRIGHTZONE
LOGISTICS
I'VE TRACKED LAST GPS SIGNAL TO THIS SPOT.
ANGELLA MUST BE SOMEWHERE INSIDE THIS WAREHOUSE.
DO WE HAVE A PLAN?
ilikeyoucatiadora
tumblr
instagram
henartorinos

Glimmer cracked her knuckles. “Get inside, find my mother, get her out of there safe and sound. Kick the ass of anyone who gets in the way.”

Looking nervous, Bow scratched his head. “Um, that sounds more like a statement of intent than a plan to me… Besides, I mean do we have a plan for getting inside?”

Both he and Glimmer turned to Adora, who avoided their gazes by keeping hers on the building. “It’s hard not knowing what’s in this warehouse section. I think our best bet may be to start in the vents so we can get an idea of how many people are inside and figure out where Angella’s being kept. Then we can create a distraction if we need to.”

Now that they were there, with the plan out in the open and the next dangerous steps ahead of them, Adora could feel apprehension emanating from her friends.

“That sounds pretty dangerous,” Bow said.

Adora glanced over her shoulder at him. “Nothing about this is safe, Bow.”

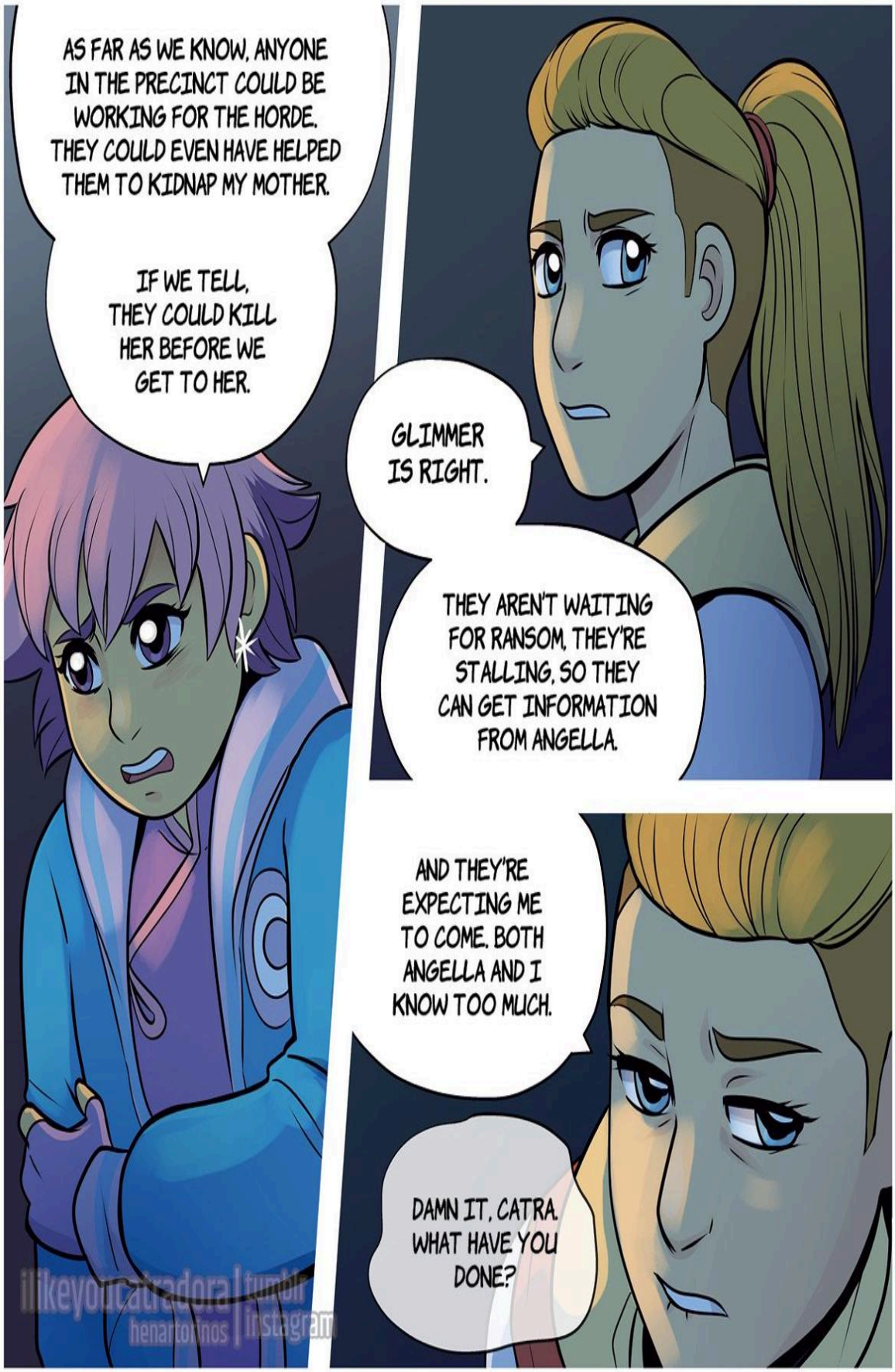
He fidgeted with his tablet for a moment and sighed. “I’ve been giving it some more thought, and I think maybe we *should* tell someone in the precinct. They can’t all be working for the Horde.” Adora blinked at him in surprise and Glimmer balked indignantly. Bow hurried to defend himself. “These people have weapons, Glimmer! Real ones! We could get killed!”

“We don’t know who we can trust, Bow!” Glimmer hissed in reply. “As far as we know, anyone in the precinct could be working for the Horde. They might even have helped kidnap my mother. If we say anything, they could kill her before we get to her.”


GET INSIDE, FIND MY MOTHER, GET HER OUTTA HERE SAFE AND SOUND.
..KICK ANYONE GETTING IN THE WAY'S ASS.
TUD
UHM, THAT SOUNDS MORE LIKE A STATEMENT OF INTENT THAN A PLAN TO ME..
I STILL THINK WE SHOULD TELL SOMEONE IN THE PRECINCT.
REBEL
THESE PEOPLE HAVE WEAPONS, GLIMMER!
WE COULD GET KILLED!
WE DON'T KNOW WHO CAN WE TRUST, BOW!

“Glimmer is right,” Adora said. As much as it would be great to have some backup, the cops were not an option. “The Horde isn’t waiting for ransom, they’re stalling so they can get information from Angella.” She sighed and admitted what she had been thinking about all day. “And they’re expecting me to come. Both Angella and I know too much.”

A sudden swell of emotion took Adora by surprise, and she had to turn away to hide it from her friends. *Damnit, Catra,* she thought miserably. *What have you done?*


AS FAR AS WE KNOW, ANYONE IN THE PRECINCT COULD BE WORKING FOR THE HORDE. THEY COULD EVEN HAVE HELPED THEM TO KIDNAP MY MOTHER.
IF WE TELL, THEY COULD KILL HER BEFORE WE GET TO HER.
GLIMMER IS RIGHT.
THEY AREN'T WAITING FOR RANSOM, THEY'RE STALLING, SO THEY CAN GET INFORMATION FROM ANGELLA.
AND THEY'RE EXPECTING ME TO COME. BOTH ANGELLA AND I KNOW TOO MUCH.
DAMN IT, CATRA. WHAT HAVE YOU DONE?

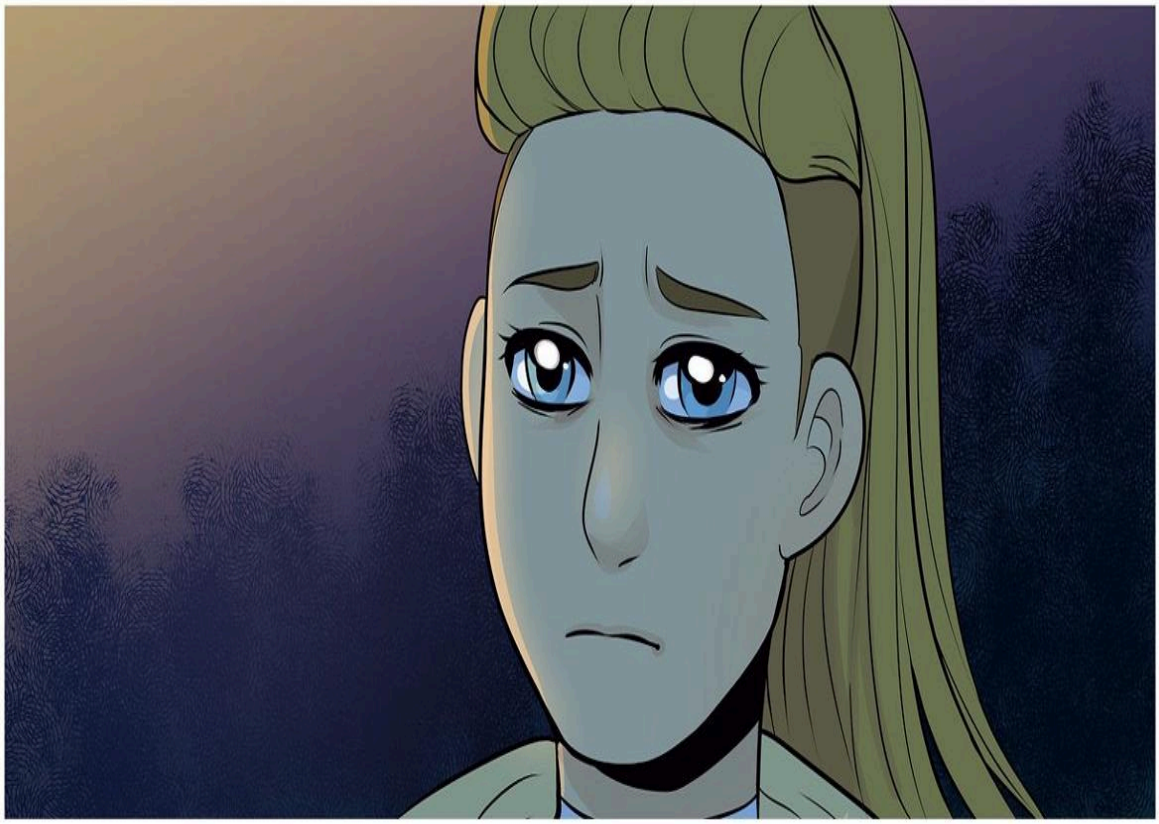
Stepping into Adora's line of sight, Glimmer clasped her shoulder tightly.

"Adora. I know what this means to you. I know what *Catra* means to you," Glimmer said as if she could read Adora's mind. "But the Horde kidnapped my mother. And I want you to know that if Catra gets in my way and I have to choose between my mom's life and hers…" Glimmer paused and took a deep breath and held Adora's gaze with her own tear-filled eyes. "I'm choosing my mom's. I don't care who I have to take down in the process. I need to know you're with me in this."


ADORA.
I KNOW WHAT THIS MEANS TO YOU.
I KNOW WHAT CATRA MEANS TO YOU.
BUT SHE KIDNAPPED MY MOTHER.
AND I WANT YOU TO KNOW THAT IF I HAVE TO CHOOSE BETWEEN MY MOM'S LIFE AND HER LIFE..
I'M CHOOSING MY MOM'S. AND I DON'T CARE WHO I HAVE TO TAKE DOWN IN THE PROCESS.
I NEED TO KNOW YOU ARE WITH ME IN THIS.
ilikeyoucatradora | tumblr
henartfinds | instagram

Her words hit Adora like a nail through her heart. For the first time, she understood what it meant to have her life flash before her eyes. In an instant, she saw every beautiful, wonderful moment she'd shared with Catra — from the day they met as kids on the street to that evening on the roof when Catra gave Adora the bracelet she still wore. But with all that good came the bad too: the look on Catra's face when she confronted Adora outside the park, the fury in her eyes when they ran into each other at the protest. Catra and Scorpia, sharing dinner and a smile, side-by-side on Catra's bed. Every memory broke Adora's heart into pieces, because she knew that part of her life was over now. It had to be.

"Catra already chose her side," Adora said, taking Glimmer's hand. "And I chose mine. I'm with you, Glimmer."




CATRA ALREADY CHOSE HER SIDE. AND I CHOSE MINE.
I'M WITH YOU, GLIMMER.
ilikeyoucatradora | tumblr
heheartonlinos | instagram

Glimmer smiled, despite her tears. She nodded, and Adora knew she understood just how hard this was for her.

“I guess it’s settled then,” Bow said, stepping up to his friends. “The Best Friends Squad is ready for the mission!”


BEST FRIEND SQUAD IS READY FOR THE MISSION!
likeyoucatradora
tumblr
instagram

Chapter 32

Chapter Notes

> Sorry for the unexpected hiatus, everyone! I caught COVID and was in recovery for two weeks (I'm double vaxxed and, while I know my symptoms could have been worse, it was STILL terrible. PLEASE remember to wear your masks in public!)
>
> ALSO: Please remember that the comics in this chapter were made long before the fic was started, so please excuse any discrepancies.
>
> CONTENT WARNINGS: images of physical assault (one character holding another by the throat), scars, and mentions of abuse.

In a corner of the main workroom in Horde HQ was space the gang used as a sort of kitchen slash break room. There was a sink (perpetually full of dirty dishes), a microwave (splattered with crusted residue), a cheap electric kettle, and an over-stuffed mini fridge, all crammed together. Catra stood at the sliver of available counter space and spread butter over a slice of bread with a trembling hand. She closed her eyes and took a breath.

It had been a long day.

At Hordak’s command, Catra spent hours trying to get Police Chief Angella Brightmoon to talk. She’d tried everything short of outright torture. At first, she’d tried appealing to Angella’s better, kinder nature. When that didn’t work, she threatened her and her daughter. At one point, frustrated and desperate, she even landed a punch squarely at Angella’s delicately pointed chin.

She actually felt guilty about that one, and that’s when she decided to take a break. After tasking Scorpia with keeping watch over their prisoner, Catra locked herself in the bathroom where

she stared at her reflection for a long time in tense silence. She felt strangely detached from the girl staring back at her in the mirror. Logically, she knew she was the same person she'd always been, but she didn't feel like it. The girl staring back at her may as well have been a complete stranger.

Eventually, someone slammed on the door and bellowed for her to hurry the fuck up because he had to take a piss. Catra barked back at him to give her a minute, for fuck sake, before splashing cold water on her unfamiliar face. She flipped the guy off as she left the bathroom, then trained her attention on coming up with a new strategy.

The only thing she'd learned so far was what had become of Shadow Weaver. Angella readily offered up that Shadow Weaver had turned herself in, trading information in exchange for a lesser sentence. What Angella wouldn't say was what kind of information Shadow Weaver had given up so far.

It was this revelation that led to Catra's fist connecting with Angella's jaw. In some ways, it was more of an involuntary reaction on her part than it was an interrogation tactic. Even though she shouldn't have been surprised that Shadow Weaver had taken the lowest road possible in order to save herself, Catra still couldn't believe that she'd turned on the gang that way. All her life, Catra had been told that her allegiance to the Horde was a lifetime commitment — that there was no greater sin than to turn on their family. Catra always felt it was a little dramatic, but at least her conscripted loyalty gave her something to believe in — something to fight for. It was one thing—one bad and heartbreaking thing—for Adora to turn on their way of life, but Shadow Weaver? She had been the one to drill this sense of loyalty into them in the first place. She had given everything to the gang, and she knew what was at stake.

Catra had expected Shadow Weaver to take her newfound freedom and run. To salvage what was left of her wasted life and find somewhere safe to live out the rest of her days. But no.

Shadow Weaver had decided that it was worth spending time in prison in order to get back at the Horde for casting her aside.

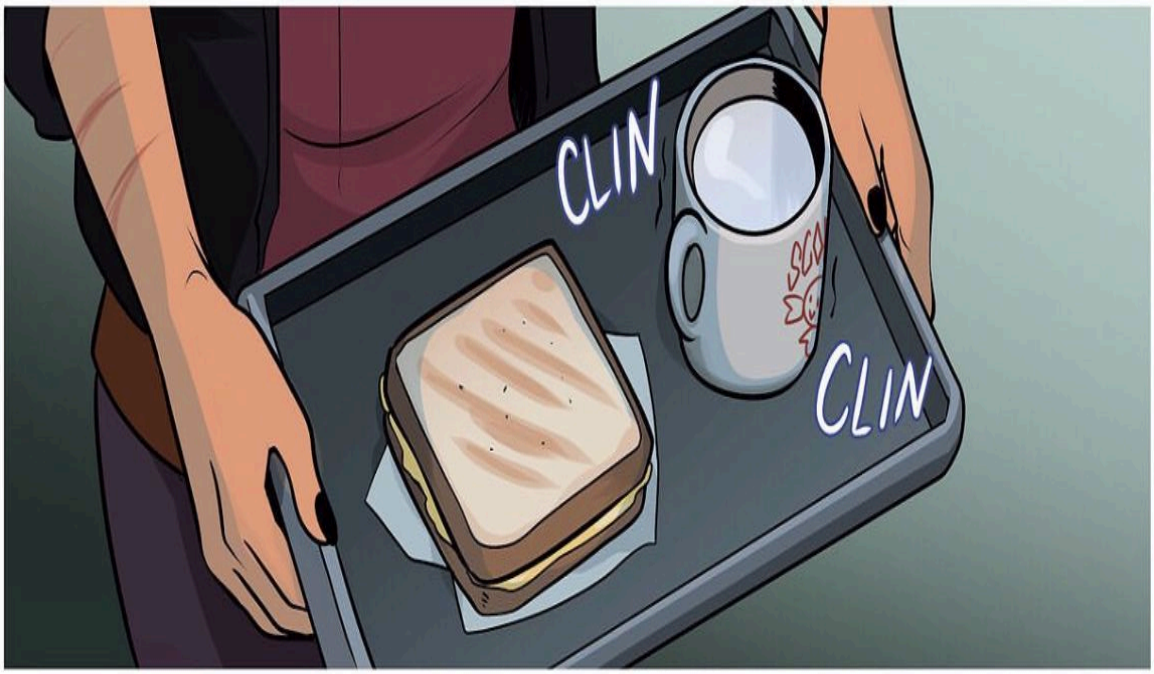
If someone like Shadow Weaver could turn on the gang, what the hell was Catra fighting for?

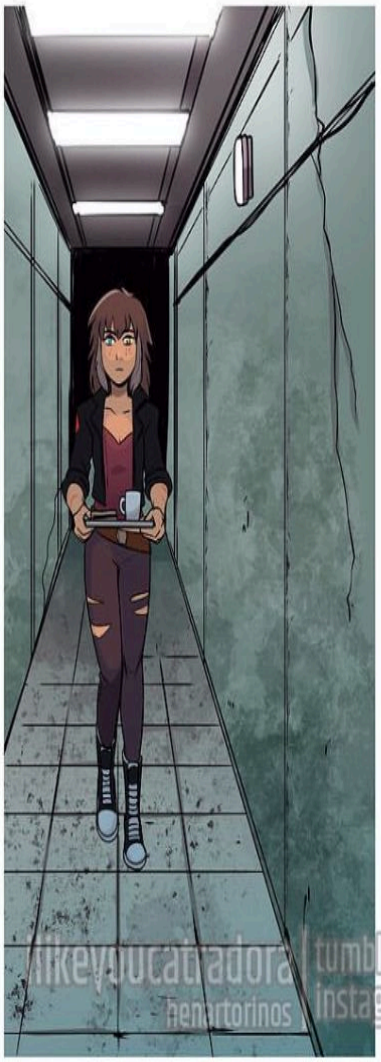
It was there, standing on the precipice of an existential crisis, that Catra made up her mind. Shadow Weaver and Adora were weak. They were traitors, and they were cowards. But Catra was none of those things, and this was her chance to prove it.

That's how she wound up in the kitchen slash break room, making a sandwich out of stale bread and processed cheese slices. It wasn't much, but it would have to do. The sound of boiling water infiltrated Catra's thoughts. She turned to the kettle just as it clicked off and poured its contents into a mug with a waiting teabag. Did the chief of police take cream and sugar with her tea? Catra had no clue. But then again, someone in Angella's position couldn't really afford to be picky, could she?

Catra laid the sandwich and mug on a plastic tray that someone must have stolen from a fast food place at some point. She gave her head a shake and rolled her shoulders back. It was time to get her head back in the game. Her footsteps echoed down the long hallway to the back of the warehouse that was attached to the garage. In the periphery of her vision, she watched the murky tea sloshing in the mug like it was throwing a temper tantrum. By the time she reached the room where Angella was being held, Catra was so focused on not spilling the tea that she didn't notice that Scorpia was no longer standing watch. In her place stood Hordak, leaning back against the wall and looking irritated, as usual.

The sight of him took Catra by surprise, briefly shaking the calm she'd worked so hard to cultivate. But when his dark, ominous eyes lifted to hers, Catra drew on years of practice masking her face with an expression of casual indifference.


CLIN
CLIN


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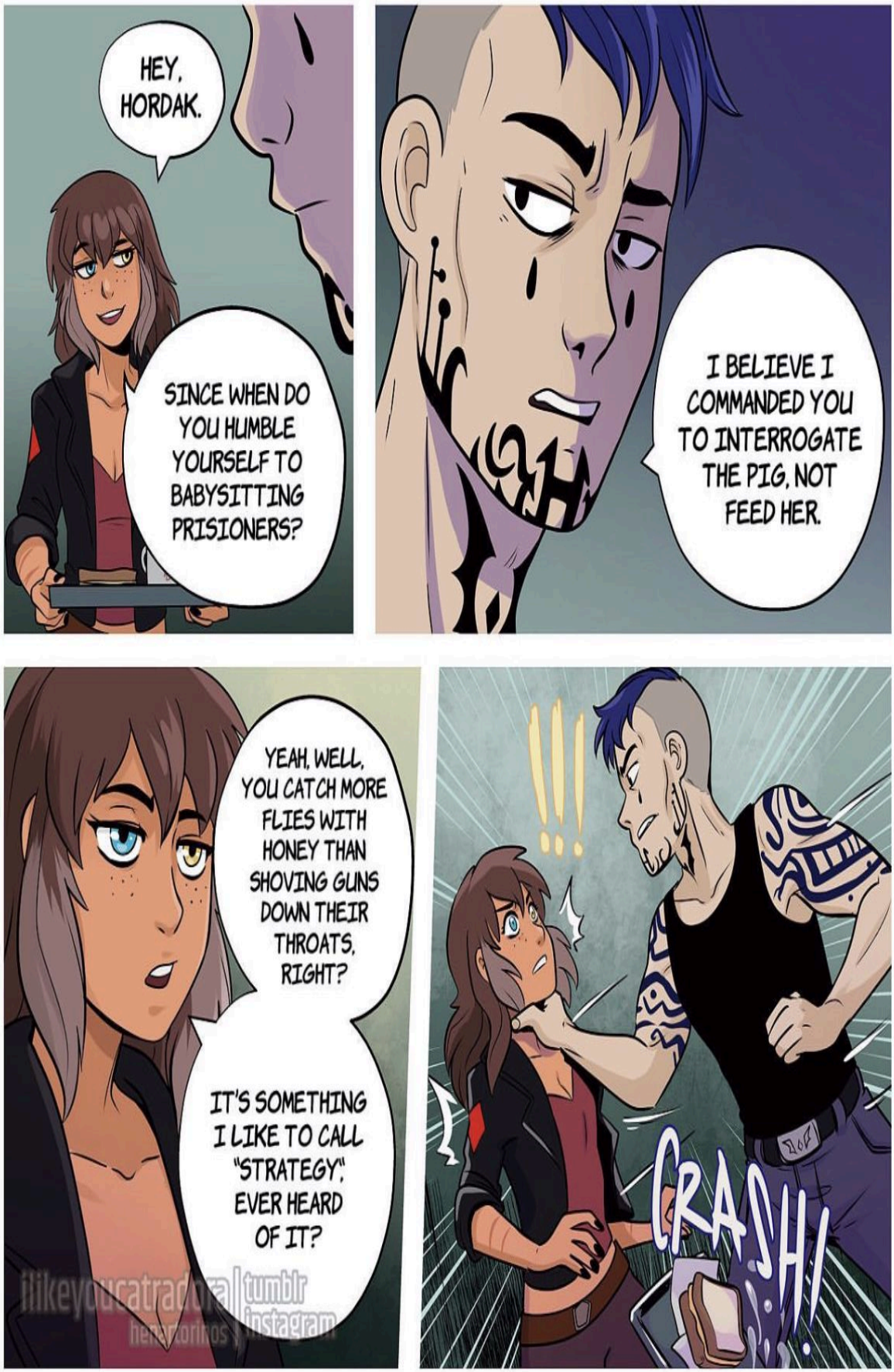


“Hey, Hordak,” she said. “Since when do you humble yourself to babysitting prisoners?”

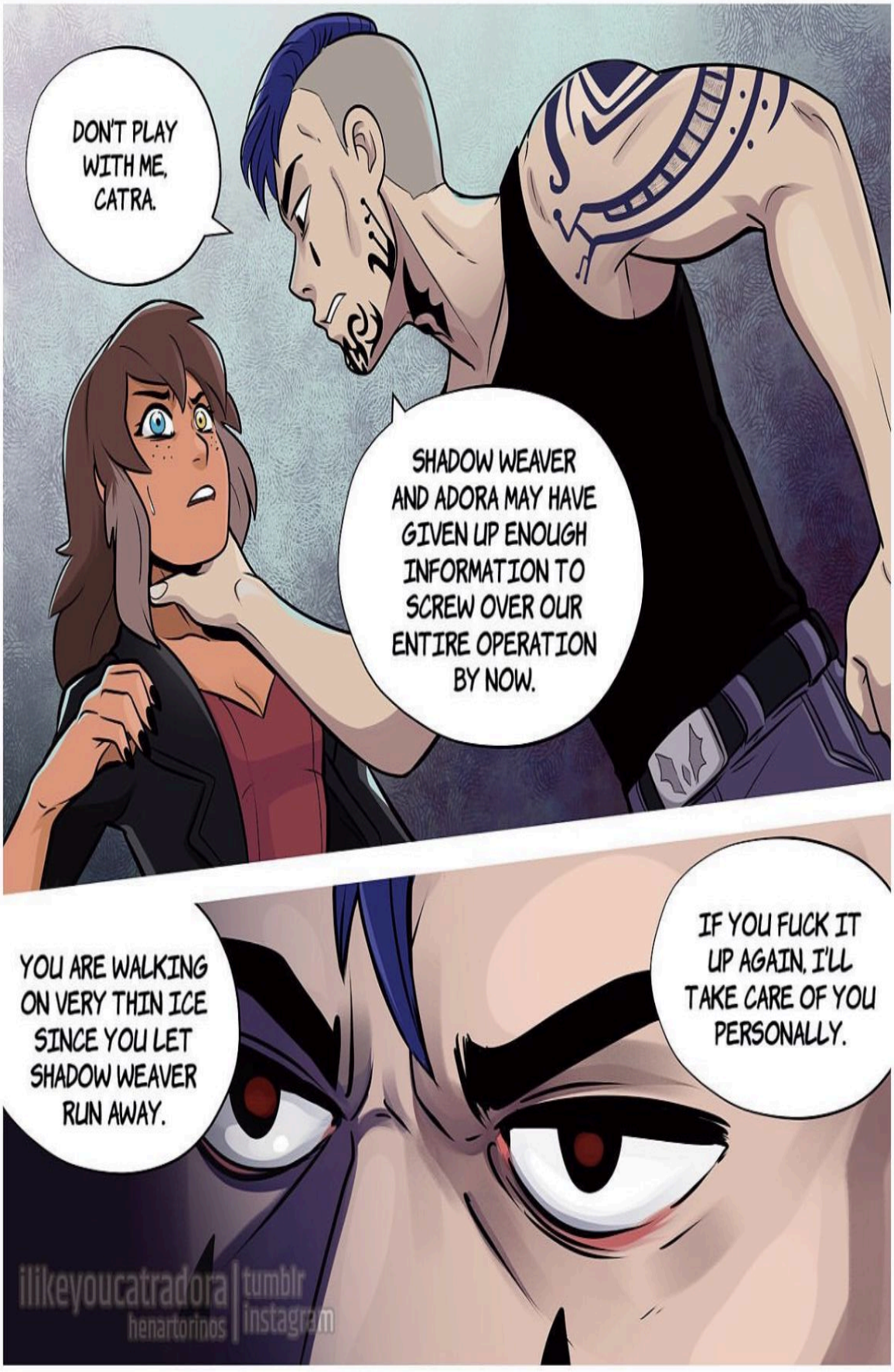
Hordak’s gaze dropped to the tray in Catra’s hands. “I believe I commanded you to interrogate the pig, not feed her.”

“Yeah, well, you catch more flies with honey than by shoving guns down their throats, right?” Catra shrugged, carefully so as not to jostle the tea. “It’s something I like to call ‘strategy’. Ever heard of it?”

Everything fell apart very quickly. So quickly that Catra didn’t even have time to process what was happening. One moment she was standing there, a sad little lunch in her hands, and the next her back was colliding with the wall. The tray and its contents clattered to the ground as Hordak pinned her in place with a single hand gripped tightly around her throat. The tea she’d worked so hard to protect over the long walk down the hall was spilled across the tiled floor that her toes barely touched.


HEY, HORDAK.
SINCE WHEN DO YOU HUMBLE YOURSELF TO BABYSITTING PRISIONERS?
I BELIEVE I COMMANDED YOU TO INTERROGATE THE PIG, NOT FEED HER.
YEAH, WELL, YOU CATCH MORE FLIES WITH HONEY THAN SHOVING GUNS DOWN THEIR THROATS, RIGHT?
IT'S SOMETHING I LIKE TO CALL "STRATEGY", EVER HEARD OF IT?
!!!
CRASH!

“Don’t play with me, Catra,” Hordak snarled. “Shadow Weaver and Adora may have given up enough information to screw over our entire operation by now. You’ve been on very thin ice since you let Shadow Weaver get away. If you fuck it up again, I’ll take care of you personally.” With a final shove, Hordak released her. Catra coughed, spluttering for breath. She could feel the angry bruises forming on her neck already. But Hordak wasn’t done with her yet. He pinned her under his icy, unwavering gaze. “Find out what that bitch knows, and then finish her. Prove once and for all which side you are on.”

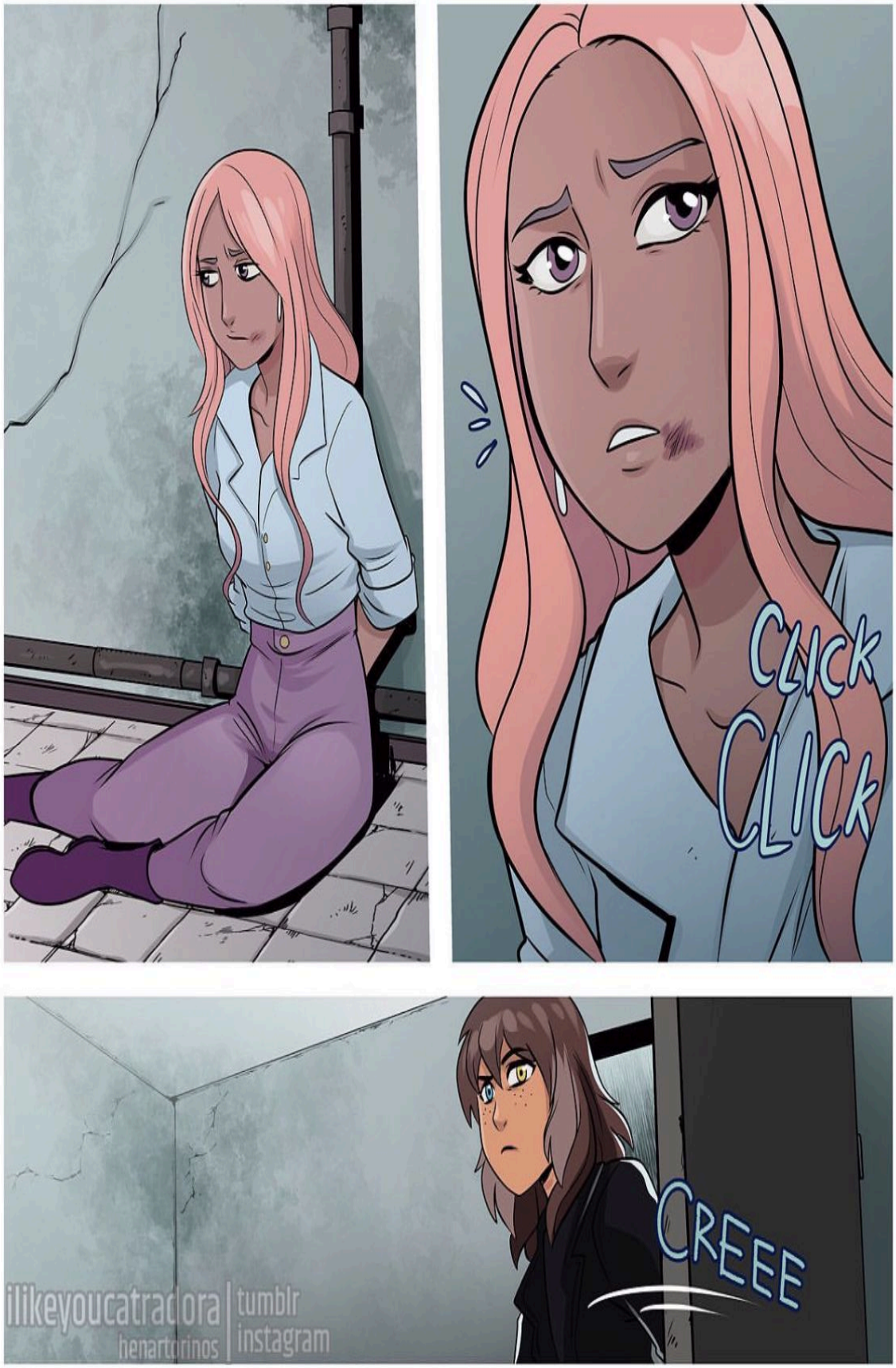

DON'T PLAY WITH ME, CATRA.
SHADOW WEAVER AND ADORA MAY HAVE GIVEN UP ENOUGH INFORMATION TO SCREW OVER OUR ENTIRE OPERATION BY NOW.
YOU ARE WALKING ON VERY THIN ICE SINCE YOU LET SHADOW WEAVER RUN AWAY.
IF YOU FUCK IT UP AGAIN, I'LL TAKE CARE OF YOU PERSONALLY.
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Catra swallowed, and her throat ached.

“Y-yes…” she muttered, ashamed at how meek she sounded. All she wanted now was to get as far away from Hordak as she could. Avoiding his glare, she hurried over the ruined remains of the lunch she’d made and slid into the room, shutting the door behind her.


FIND OUT WHAT THAT BITCH KNOWS, AND THEN FINISH HER.
PROVE ONCE AND FOR ALL WHICH SIDE YOU ARE ON.
GASP!
COF COF

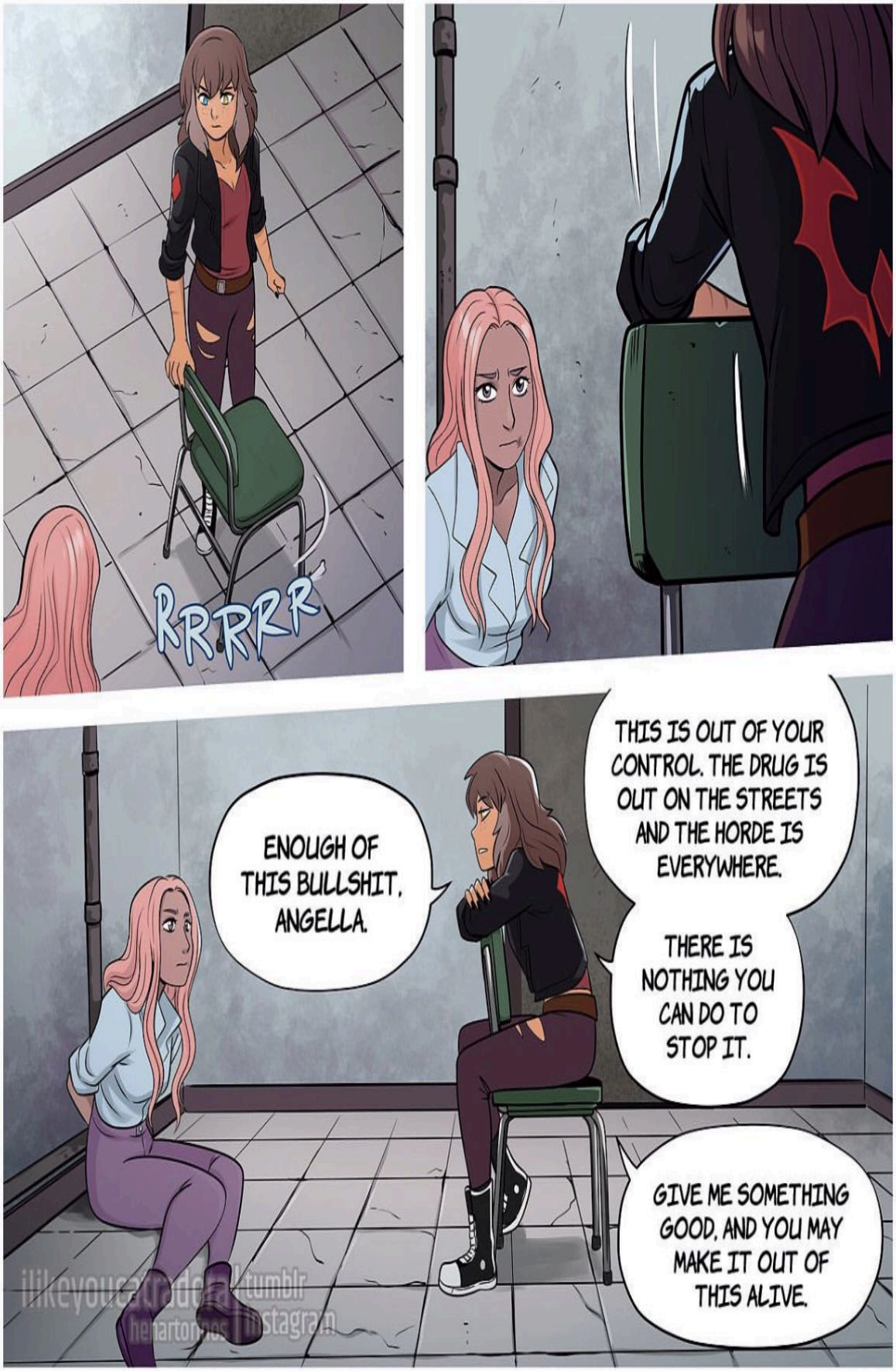

Y-YES..
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CLICK
CLICK
CREEE
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henartorinos
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instagram

Angella sat on the floor with her legs tucked underneath her. She looked cramped and uncomfortable, especially with her hands cuffed securely behind her back. A welt had formed at the corner of her mouth where Catra had struck her, and her violet eyes watched as Catra dragged the lone chair in the room over.

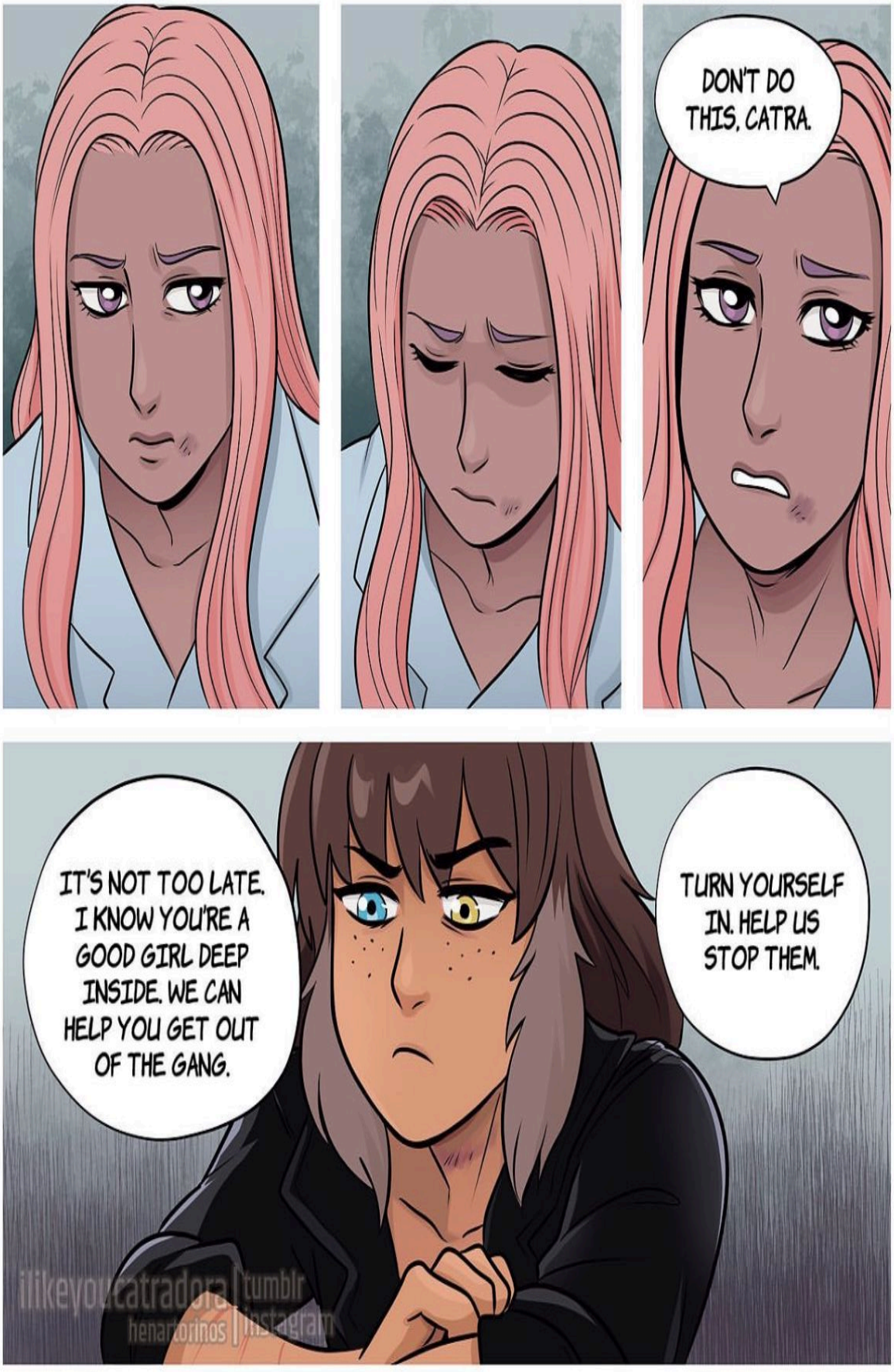
With Hordak's threat still ringing in her ears, Catra turned the chair around and sat down on it backwards so she could rest her arms atop its back. She mustered up as much malice as she could and glared down at Angella from her perch.

"Enough of this bullshit, Angella," Catra said. "Face it: this whole situation is out of your control. Runestone is out on the streets and the Horde is everywhere. There's nothing you can do to stop it now. So why don't you just give me something good and maybe you'll make it out of this alive."


RRRRR
THIS IS OUT OF YOUR CONTROL. THE DRUG IS OUT ON THE STREETS AND THE HORDE IS EVERYWHERE.
ENOUGH OF THIS BULLSHIT, ANGELLA.
THERE IS NOTHING YOU CAN DO TO STOP IT.
GIVE ME SOMETHING GOOD, AND YOU MAY MAKE IT OUT OF THIS ALIVE.

Angella gazed back at her with so much pity that it made Catra want to scream.

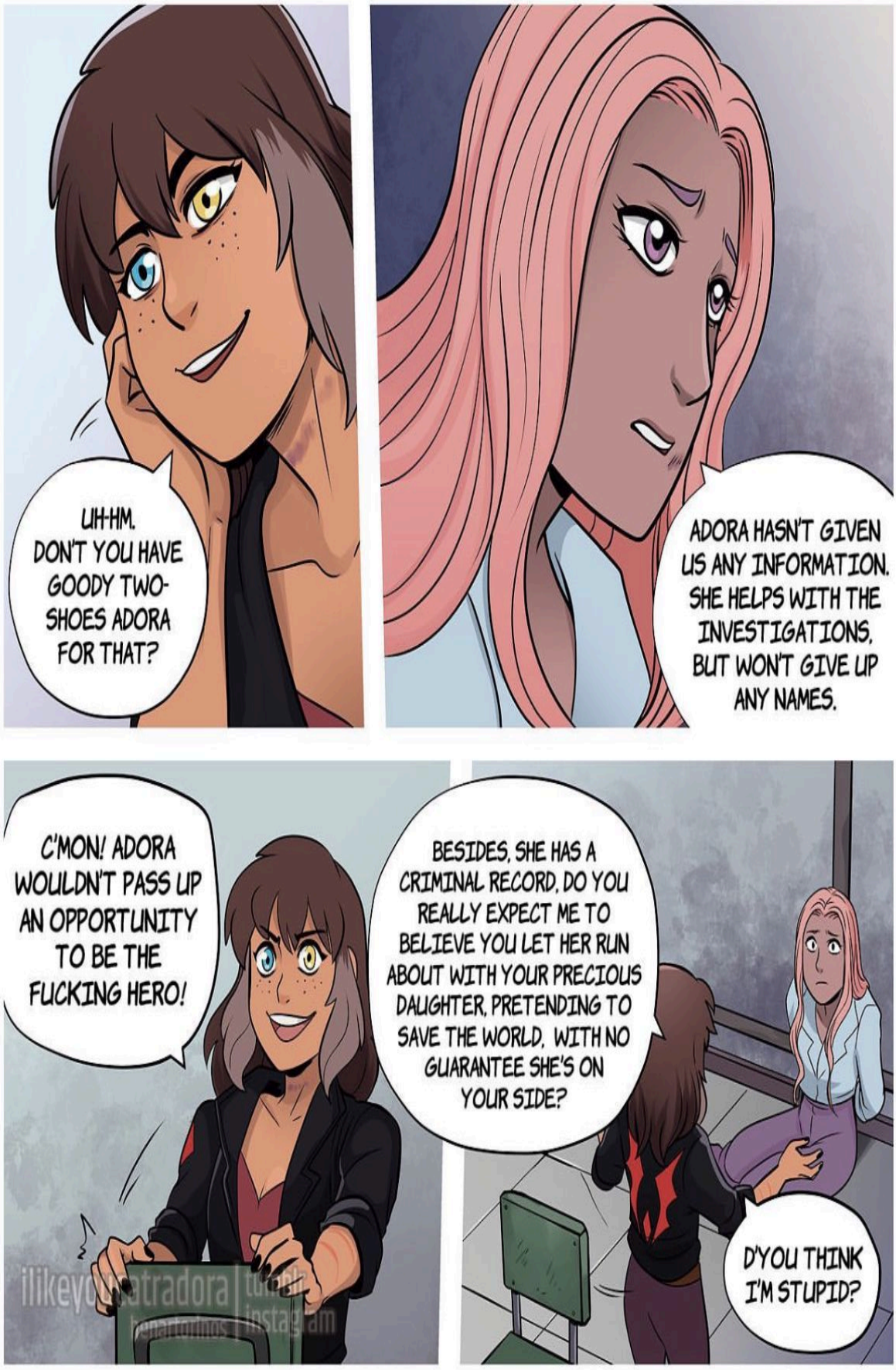
"Don't do this, Catra," Angella said softly. "It's not too late. I know you're a good girl, deep inside. We can help you get out of the gang." She offered a smile — the same one Catra had been on the receiving end of every time she'd landed in Angella's precinct as a child. "Turn yourself in. We need you. Help us stop them."


DON'T DO THIS, CATRA.
IT'S NOT TOO LATE. I KNOW YOU'RE A GOOD GIRL DEEP INSIDE. WE CAN HELP YOU GET OUT OF THE GANG.
TURN YOURSELF IN. HELP US STOP THEM.
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“Don’t you have goody two-shoes Adora for that?” Catra scoffed.

Angella shook her head. “Adora hasn’t given us any information. She helps with the investigation but she won’t give up any names.”

Something about this struck Catra as hilarious. “C’mon! Adora wouldn’t pass up an opportunity to be the fucking hero!” She laughed as she got to her feet. “Besides, she has a criminal record. Do you really expect me to believe you let her run around with your precious daughter, pretending to save the world, with no guarantee she’s on your side? D’you think I’m stupid?”

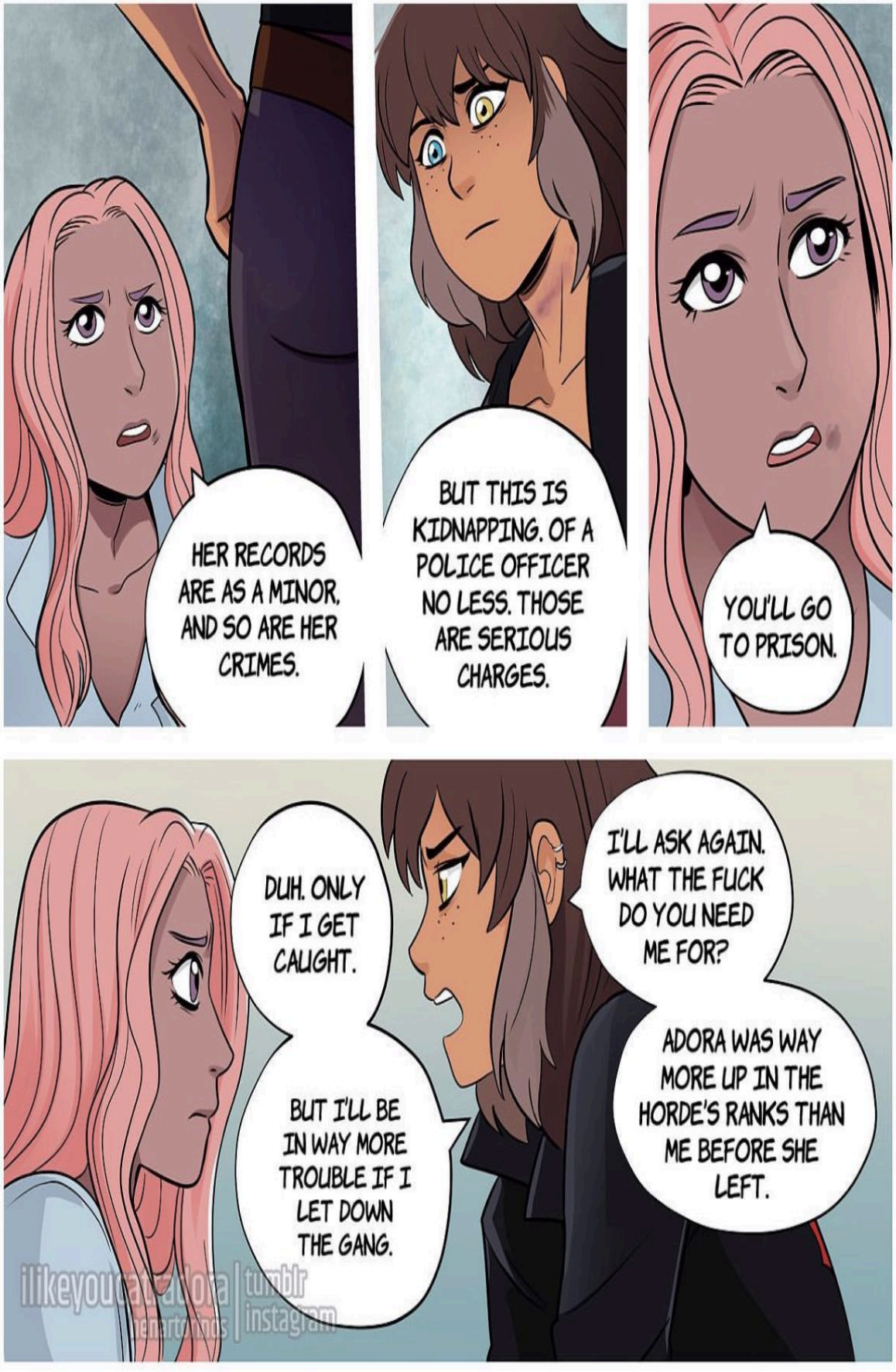

UH-HM. DON'T YOU HAVE GOODY TWO-SHOES ADORA FOR THAT?
ADORA HASN'T GIVEN US ANY INFORMATION. SHE HELPS WITH THE INVESTIGATIONS, BUT WON'T GIVE UP ANY NAMES.
C'MON! ADORA WOULDN'T PASS UP AN OPPORTUNITY TO BE THE FUCKING HERO!
BESIDES, SHE HAS A CRIMINAL RECORD, DO YOU REALLY EXPECT ME TO BELIEVE YOU LET HER RUN ABOUT WITH YOUR PRECIOUS DAUGHTER, PRETENDING TO SAVE THE WORLD, WITH NO GUARANTEE SHE'S ON YOUR SIDE?
D'YOU THINK I'M STUPID?

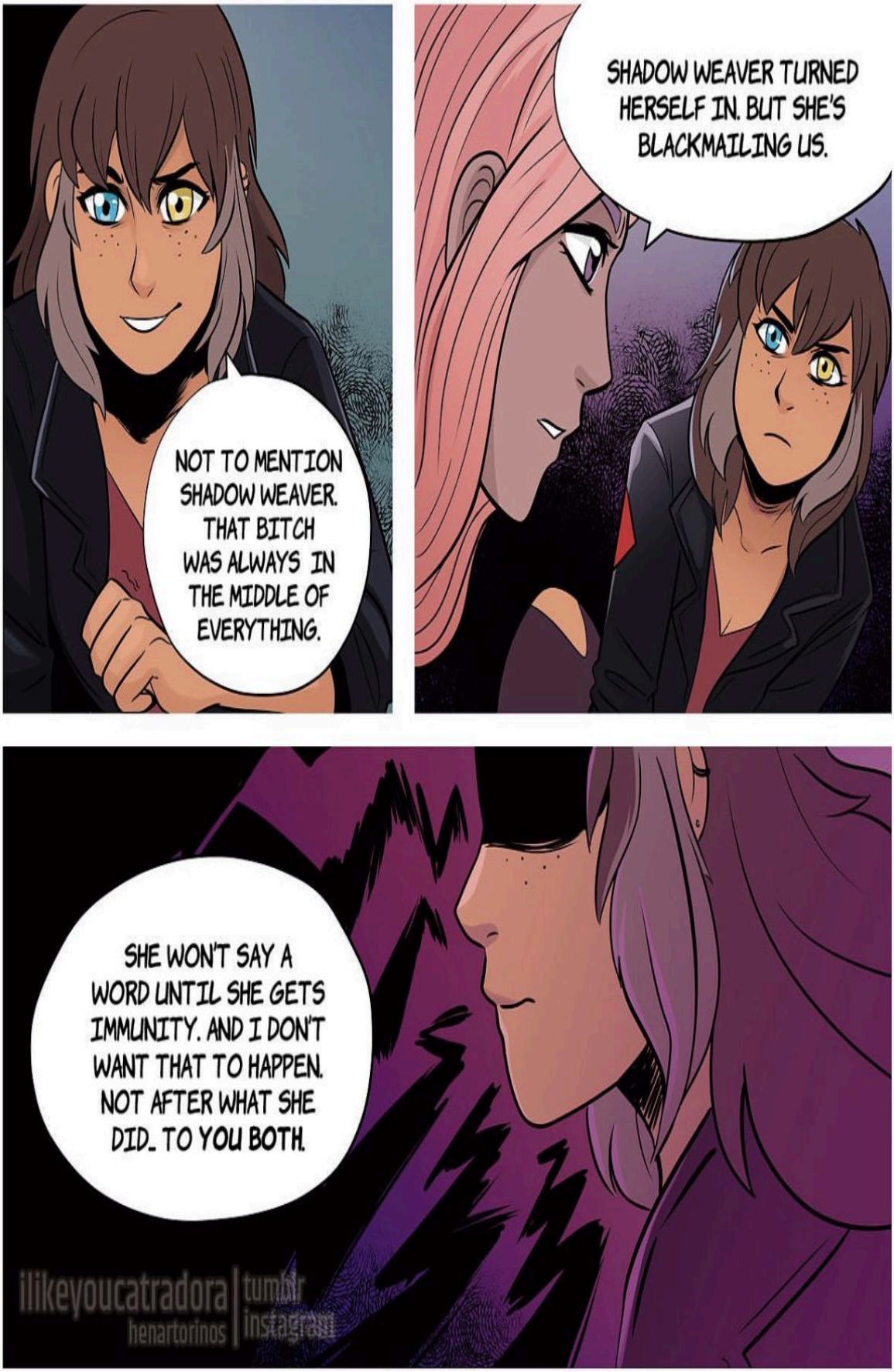
“Her records are as a minor, and so are her crimes. But this is kidnapping — of a police officer, no less. Those are serious charges.” Angella lifted her eyebrows. “You’ll go to prison.”

Catra hesitated. Only for a moment, but still. Growing up in the Horde, living hard and rough, she had never felt like a child. She often forgot that a date on the calendar was all that stood between her and a possible criminal conviction in adult court.

She regained her composure quickly. “Duh, only if I get caught. But I’ll be in way more trouble if I let down the gang. So I’ll ask again: what the fuck do you need me for? Adora was way higher up in the Horde’s ranks than me before she left. Not to mention Shadow Weaver. That bitch was always in the middle of everything.”

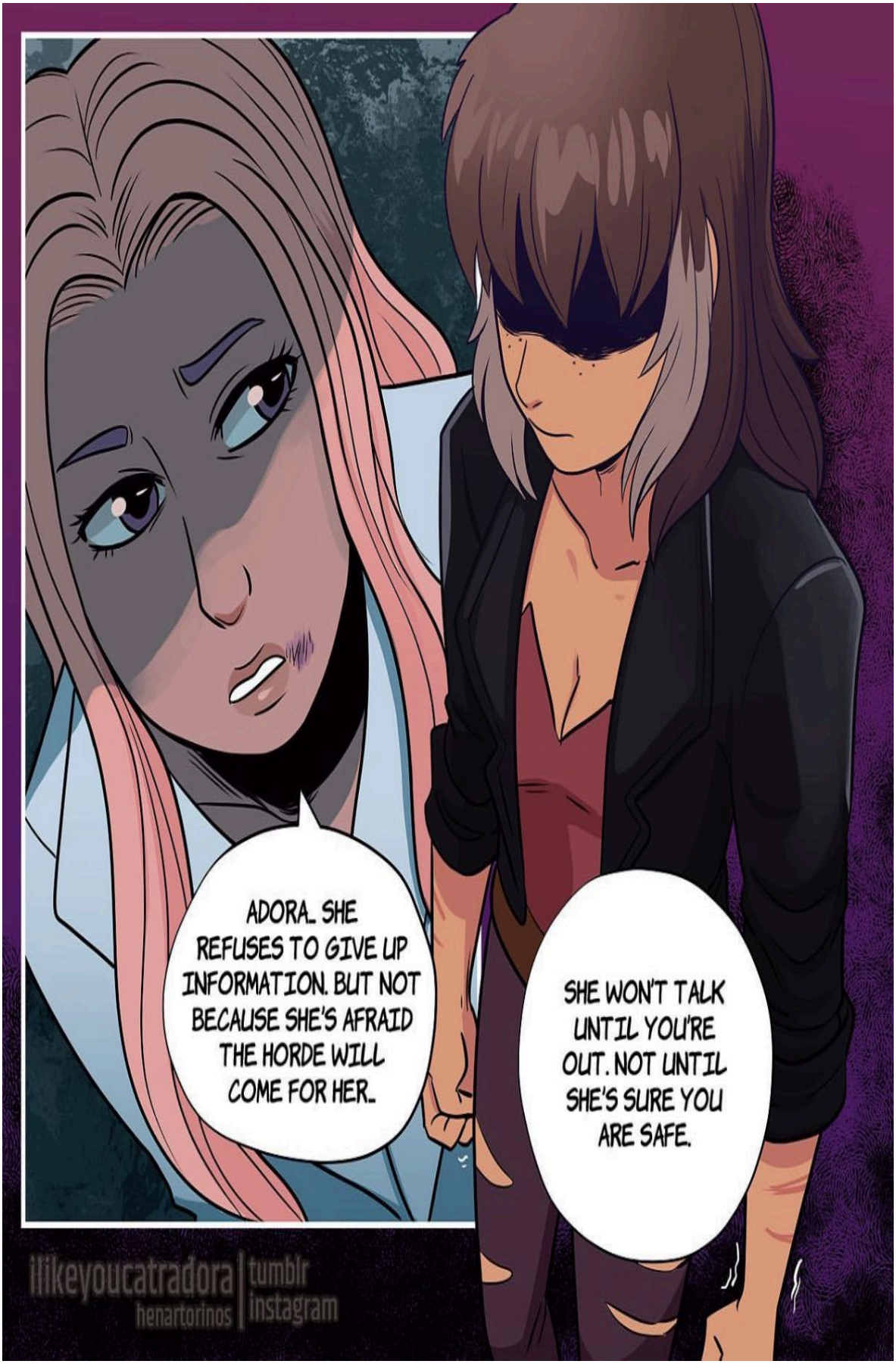
“Shadow Weaver may have turned herself in, but she’s blackmailing us,” Angella said, punctuating the statement with a sigh. “She won’t say a word until she gets immunity, and I don’t want to see that happen. Not after what she did to you both.”


HER RECORDS ARE AS A MINOR, AND SO ARE HER CRIMES.
BUT THIS IS KIDNAPPING. OF A POLICE OFFICER NO LESS. THOSE ARE SERIOUS CHARGES.
YOU'LL GO TO PRISON.
DUH. ONLY IF I GET CAUGHT.
BUT I'LL BE IN WAY MORE TROUBLE IF I LET DOWN THE GANG.
I'LL ASK AGAIN. WHAT THE FUCK DO YOU NEED ME FOR?
ADORA WAS WAY MORE UP IN THE HORDE'S RANKS THAN ME BEFORE SHE LEFT.


NOT TO MENTION SHADOW WEAVER. THAT BITCH WAS ALWAYS IN THE MIDDLE OF EVERYTHING.
SHADOW WEAVER TURNED HERSELF IN. BUT SHE'S BLACKMAILING US.
SHE WON'T SAY A WORD UNTIL SHE GETS IMMUNITY. AND I DON'T WANT THAT TO HAPPEN. NOT AFTER WHAT SHE DID. TO YOU BOTH.
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instagram

The way she said it—the way she said *you both*—hit Catra like an exposed nerve. It hurt in a way that left her momentarily stunned. And then, when the sensation came back to her limbs, all she felt was rage. Angella kept talking.

"Adora… she refuses to give up information, but not because she's afraid the Horde will come for her," Angella said, speaking faster. Maybe she thought she was losing Catra's attention. She sounded desperate. "She won't talk until you're out. Not until she's sure you are safe. We can protect you, Catra."


ADORA.. SHE REFUSES TO GIVE UP INFORMATION. BUT NOT BECAUSE SHE'S AFRAID THE HORDE WILL COME FOR HER..
SHE WON'T TALK UNTIL YOU'RE OUT. NOT UNTIL SHE'S SURE YOU ARE SAFE.
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WE CAN PROTECT YOU, CATRA.
PFF
HA HA HA HA HA
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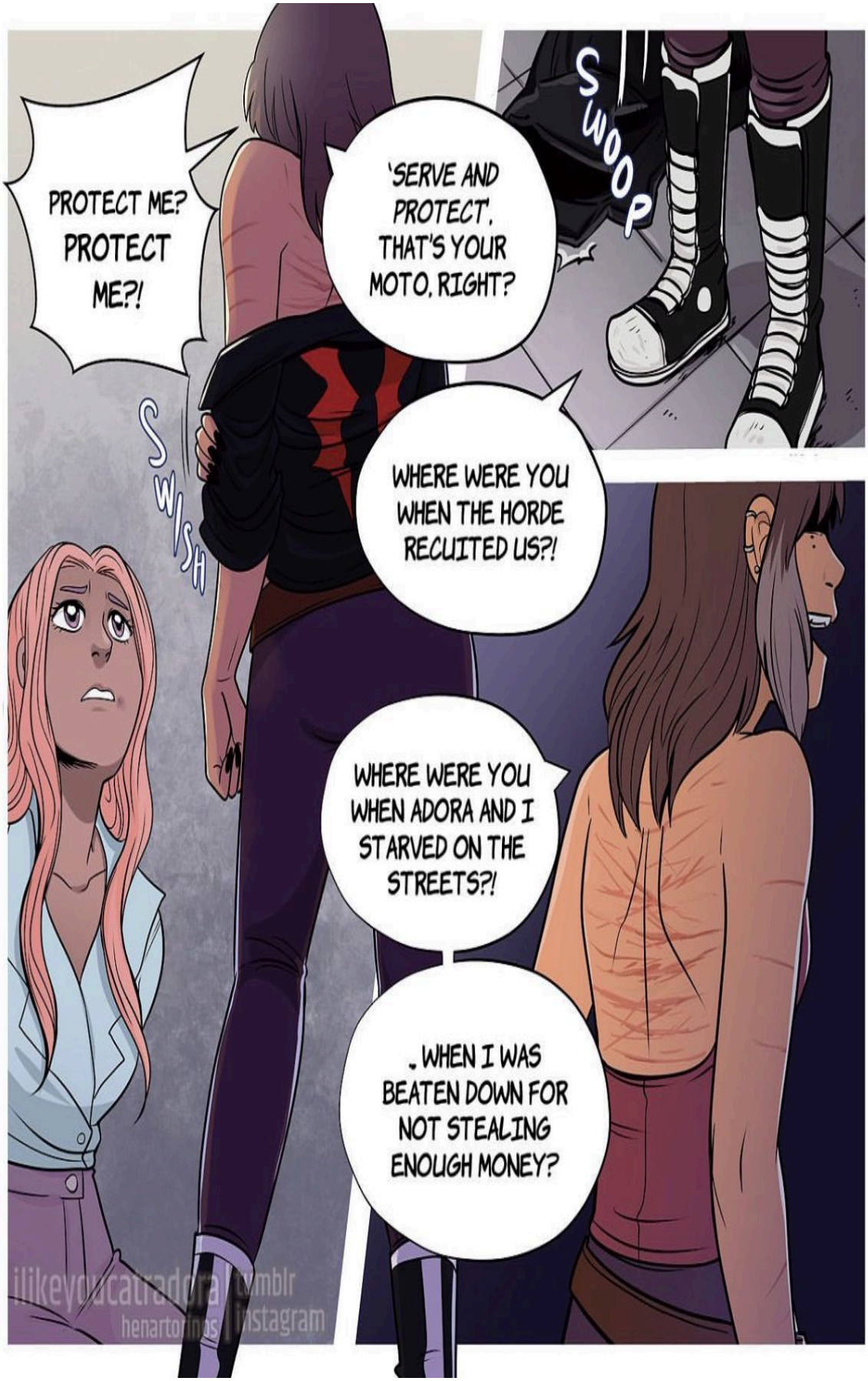
That was it: the final lie that pushed Catra over the edge. All that rage, mixed with years of fear and pain and abuse, bubbled to the surface and burst out of her in the form of maniacal laughter. She could hear how unhinged she sounded, but she couldn't stop. Angella shrank back from her, eyes wide and fearful, and that just made Catra laugh harder.

Holding Angella's startled gaze with her own, Catra peeled her leather jacket—the one she wore like a brand, marking her as the Horde's property—down her shoulders to reveal the criss-crossing scars that marred her arms and back. She watched Angella's face fall, her eyes filling with shock and horror at the damage she was witnessing.

"Protect me? *Protect me?*" Catra shouted, her voice reverberating off the walls of the small room. "'Serve and protect', that's your motto, right? Well, where were you when the Horde recruited us? Where were you when Adora and I starved on the streets? When I was beaten down for not stealing enough money?" Catra's voice cracked. She could feel hot tears stinging her eyes as she let loose her hurt and fury. "You *knew* what was happening, but every time we ended up in your precinct, you just let Shadow Weaver take us. Every. Single. Time."

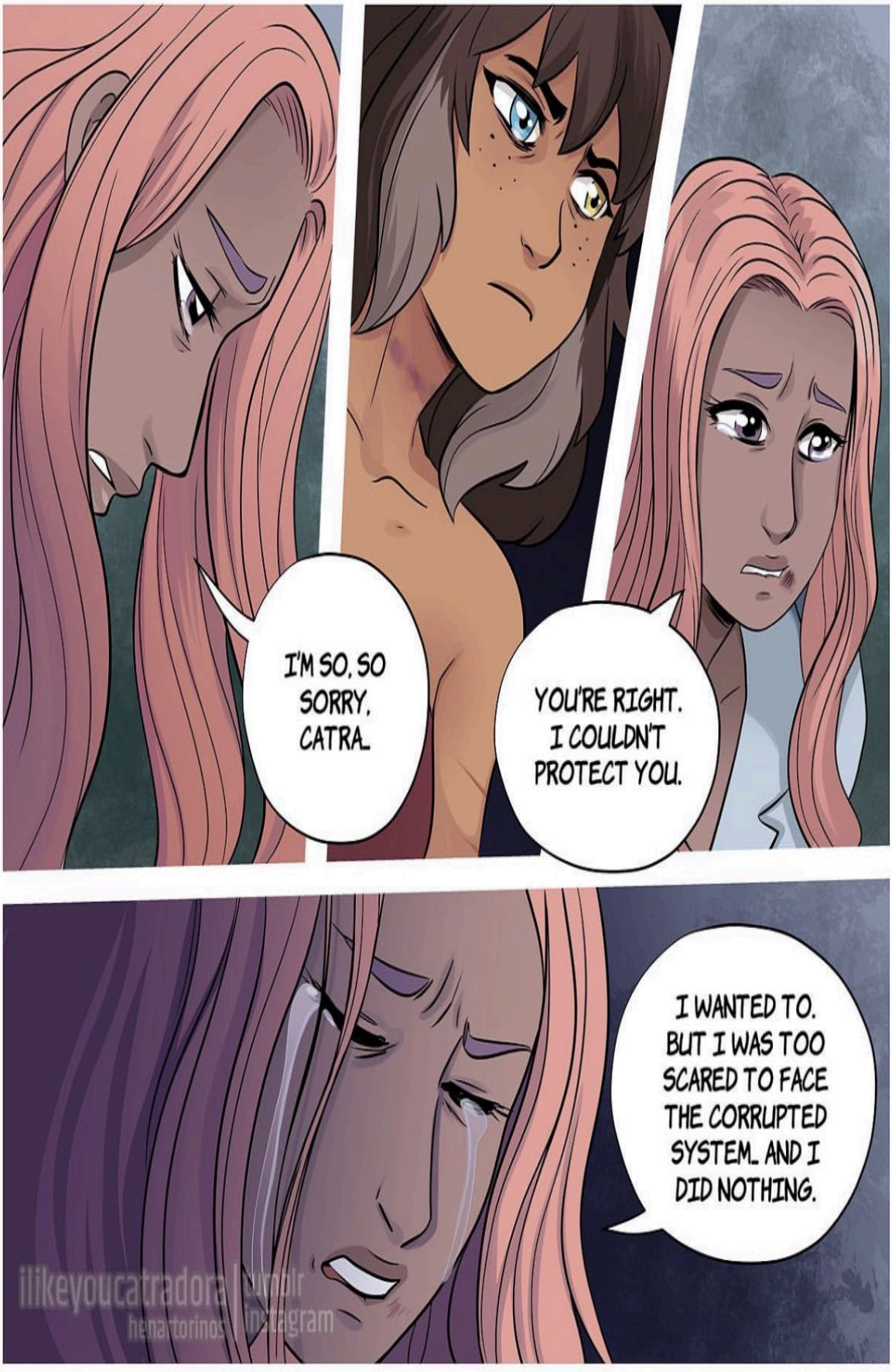
Catra closed her eyes and drew in a shaky breath. When she looked back down at Angella, Catra found her eyes brimming with tears as well, and it made her smile.

"It was right in front of you," Catra said, "and you did *nothing*."


PROTECT ME? PROTECT ME?!
'SERVE AND PROTECT', THAT'S YOUR MOTO, RIGHT?
SWOOP
SWISH
WHERE WERE YOU WHEN THE HORDE RECUITED US?!
WHERE WERE YOU WHEN ADORA AND I STARVED ON THE STREETS?!
.. WHEN I WAS BEATEN DOWN FOR NOT STEALING ENOUGH MONEY?
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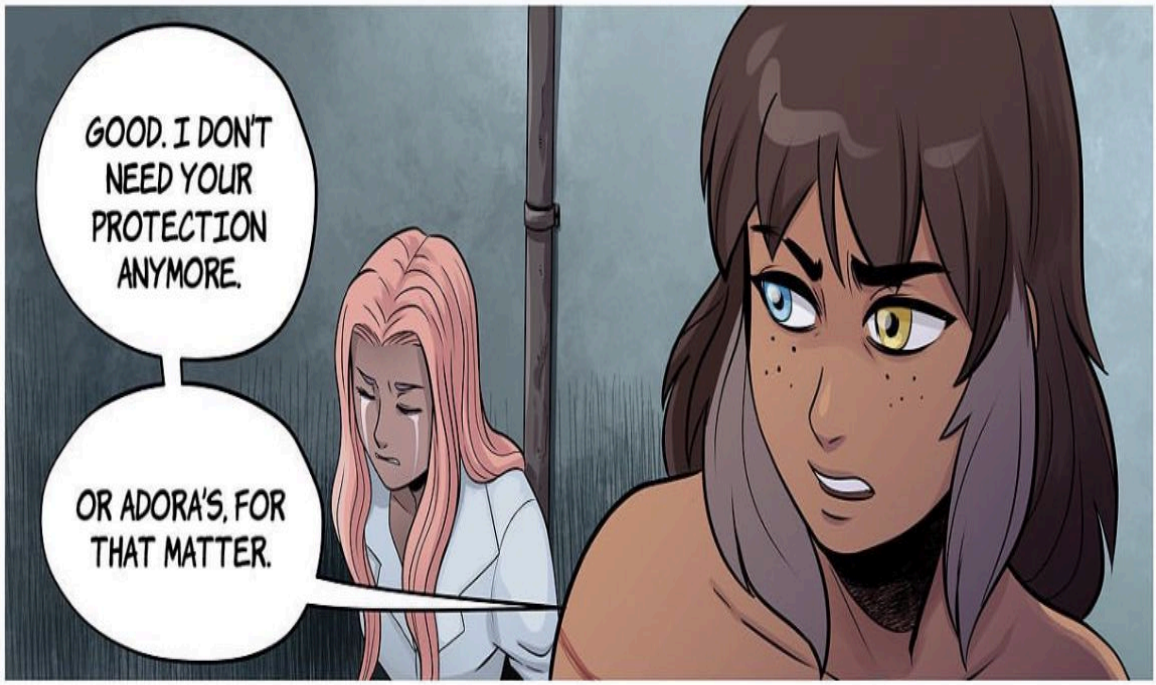

YOU KNEW WHAT WAS HAPPENING.. BUT EVERY TIME WE ENDED UP IN YOUR PRECINCT, YOU JUST LET SHADOW WEAVER TAKE US. EVERY. SINGLE. TIME.
IT WAS RIGHT IN FRONT OF YOU.
.. AND YOU DID NOTHING.
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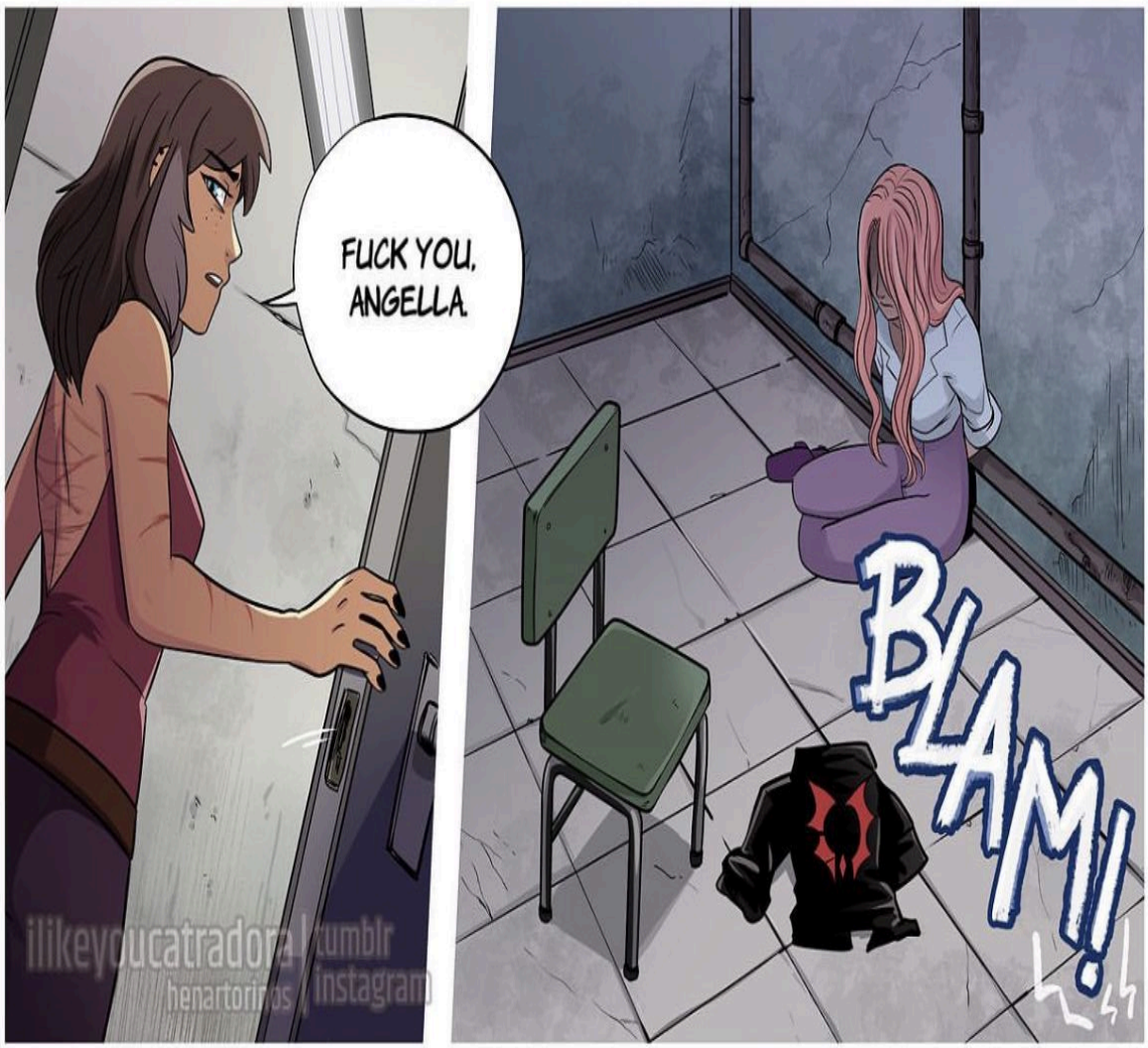
Angella let out a quiet sob. Her head drooped forward, her hair swinging forward like a curtain that masked her shame. “I’m so, so sorry, Catra. You’re right. I couldn’t protect you. I wanted to, but I was too scared to face the corrupt system, and I did nothing.”


I'M SO, SO SORRY, CATRA.
YOU'RE RIGHT. I COULDN'T PROTECT YOU.
I WANTED TO. BUT I WAS TOO SCARED TO FACE THE CORRUPTED SYSTEM. AND I DID NOTHING.
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henartorinos | instagram

This had been what Catra wanted to hear: that Angella understood just how badly she had failed at the very thing she was there to do. But for some reason, it didn't make Catra feel better.

"Good," she snapped, her voice dripping with cruelty. "I don't need your protection anymore. Or Adora's for that matter." She opened the door to leave, but paused before slipping out of the room. Glancing back over her shoulder, Catra gave Etheria's chief of police one last dirty look. "Fuck you, Angella."


GOOD. I DON'T NEED YOUR PROTECTION ANYMORE.
OR ADORA'S, FOR THAT MATTER.


FUCK YOU, ANGELLA.
BLAM!
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Catra let the heavy metal door slam shut, cutting off the sound of Angella's weeping. The hallway was empty now — no Scorpia and, mercifully, no Hordak either. Catra's breaths came fast and shallow. She leaned back against the door and tried to catch her breath, but it was no use. The panic attack sank its talons into her and sent her spiralling.

Then, when she thought she was on the verge of exploding, Catra let out a furious scream. She lashed out, punching the wall and hammering her closed fists against it again and again until her knuckles bled. Only then did she sink to the ground, shaking and breathless. She cowered, arms covering her face, and cried.


AH
AH
AH
AH
AH
AH
TUMP!
AAAAH!
TUD
TUD
TUD

We can protect you, Catra.

She heard those words echo in her mind as they triggered a memory.

In it, she was small — impossibly tiny to be living on the streets. She was scared the way she was right now, and hiding beneath the tattered old blanket that she and Adora shared at night to keep each other warm.

Adora, with her loving smile and bright eyes that watched Catra like she was the most important person in the world. Adora wrapped an arm around Catra's bundled shoulder and held her tight.

"It doesn't matter what they do to us, y'know?" the young Adora in Catra's memory said. "You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other."

Oh, how badly Catra had wanted to believe those words. Her younger self gazed up into the face of her only friend in the world — her light, her life.

"You promise?" she had asked in that small, uncertain voice of hers.

And Adora had smiled. She tipped her face forward and pressed her forehead to Catra's.

"I promise."

From between her bloody fingers, the miserable shell of the person that Catra had grown up to be glared back out at the world and whispered,

"Fuck you, Adora."


IT DOESN'T MATTER WHAT THEY DO TO US, YOU KNOW?
YOU LOOK OUT FOR ME, AND I LOOK OUT FOR YOU.
NOTHING REALLY BAD CAN HAPPEN AS LONG AS WE HAVE EACH OTHER.
YOU PROMISE?
I PROMISE.
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Chapter 33

Chapter Notes

> [CW: This chapter contains depictions of illicit drug use. This in no way is intended to condone the use of illegal narcotics. Please see the end of the chapter for specific content warnings.]

Hordak's expression said it all.

As Catra explained that Angella wouldn't cooperate, she watched Hordak's jaw set and his eyes narrow, and she knew that she had sealed Angella's fate.

"If that's the case," Hordak said once Catra finished, "then you know what must be done."

Catra bowed her face to show she understood. "Yes, Hordak."

"Good. Come find me when the job is done."

Keeping her eyes focused on the ground, Catra tried to stand perfectly still as Hordak pushed past her and out of the cramped observation room of Entrapta's lab where they'd been speaking. It wasn't until she heard the door slam behind her that she let herself exhale. Dread sat in the pit of her stomach like a block of ice that turned her blood cold. Yes, she knew what needed to be done now, and the thought of it made her feel sick.

Out of the corner of her eye, Catra noticed a flicker of movement. She turned to the large window that looked into the lab and saw Scorpia and Entrapta gazing back at her from inside. Their mouths were drawn into firm lines and their eyes swam with pity. Scorpia raised her hand and gave a cautious wave. Catra sighed. She didn't have it in her to get angry, so instead she decided to join them.

“Hey Wildcat,” Scorpia said softly as Catra slinked up to the work station. Her eyes widened with alarm as they fell on Catra’s hands, the knuckles still bloody and raw. She reached out to take one of them in her own, but Catra folded her arms and tucked them out of sight. “You okay?”

Catra huffed a dark laugh. The others must have understood just how dire the situation was. Entrapta didn’t squawk indignantly when Catra rested her elbows on the polished steel work table and dropped her head into her hands. Scorpia even managed to resist her usual instinct to pull Catra into a bone-crushing hug.

“Would *you* be okay if Hordak wanted you to kill Etheria’s police chief?” Catra replied, her face still cradled in her palms. Of course it was more complicated than that. Angella wasn’t just the chief of police: to Catra, she was the woman who had shown her and Adora kindness, even when they maybe didn’t deserve it. Yes, Angella had failed her in such a profound way, but that didn’t negate the fact that they had a history, and that made what Catra had to do next even harder.

Eventually, Catra forced herself to stand up straight, even though the weight of her grim task threatened to send her crashing to the floor. She could feel her heart racing. It hammered so hard against her ribs that she wouldn’t have been surprised if Scorpia and Entrapta could see it trying to break it’s way free.

“Do you wanna talk about it?” Entrapta asked. “You can borrow Emily if you want; she’s a really good listener.”

Catra turned to find Emily, Entrapta’s pet rat, hovering at eye-level in Entrapta’s outstretched hand and blinking at her with beady red eyes. She let out a yelp of surprise and scrambled backwards, nearly crashing into the work station.

“Easy there!” Scorpia exclaimed as she caught Catra by the shoulders. “You don’t want to knock over the Runestone mixture!” She pointed her strong chin toward the beaker of lavender-colored liquid that sat on the table, waiting to be poured. Catra had

always thought it was funny that the drug was such a soft and cheerful color, especially in its volatile fluid state. It certainly didn't look like a compound that could explode if mishandled.

For a moment, Catra didn't move. Something about the firm but gentle grip of Scorpia's hands on her shoulders made Catra feel grounded and safe. There was a tiny flutter of relief that came with knowing she wasn't alone right now.

But that feeling was a lie; she *was* alone. Neither Scorpia nor Entrapta could help her with what had to come next. Hordak had made it clear that killing Angella Brightmoon was her burden to bear. This was her chance to prove her loyalty; to make up for letting Shadow Weaver escape. With a groan, Catra wrenched herself away from Scorpia. She wrapped her own arms around herself and squeezed tightly, the way she'd learned to comfort herself as a child. Nobody was going to save her now — she needed to remember that.

"I just need to get this over with," Catra said through gritted teeth. She shook out her hands and bounced on the balls of her feet, trying to dispel the numbness that had settled into her extremities.

"Are you nervous?" Scorpia asked.

Catra glared. "Am I nervous to *murder* someone?"

Scorpia's cheeks flushed. "Right. Dumb quesiton."

Maybe it was, but it was also true. Catra was terrified, and no amount of posturing was going to change that. Before the threat of tears had a chance to betray her, Catra pressed the heels of her palms to her eyes.

"How am I supposed to do this?" she moaned. "I've never killed anyone before. But if I don't…" She didn't finish her thought, but when she looked up she could tell by Scorpia and Entrapta's expressions that she didn't need to. They knew exactly what was at stake. "I wish I could just turn off my brain or something."

Entrapta let out a nervous hum.

“What?” Catra asked.

“Well, under normal circumstances I wouldn’t dream of suggesting this but…” Entrapta reached into a shallow tray on the table in front of her and picked up a single purple pill. “It won’t exactly turn off your brain, but the physical euphoria and emotional blunting of a Runestone high might help.”

Scorpia was aghast. “Are you telling Catra to take Runestone? Didn’t you say that stuff is super addictive?”

“I’m not telling Catra to do anything,” Entrapta replied in a way that was very matter-of-fact. “I’m suggesting it as an option.” She turned her attention to Catra. Her expression was serious. “But Scorpia’s right: Runestone is highly addictive. This would only be a one-time thing. We don’t need you developing a dependence on this stuff.”

Catra was only half listening to Entrapta’s lecture. Her dual-colored eyes hadn’t wavered from the tiny purple pill. Sure, Runestone could be dangerous, but was it worse than the emotional toll of having to kill someone? And besides, Catra was way stronger than anyone gave her credit for — certainly stronger than those desperate junkies they sold to on the streets.

“Give it to me,” she said, holding out her hand to Entrapta.

“Are you sure, Wildcat?” Scorpia fretted.

“Unless you want to kill Angella for me then yes, I’m sure.”

Entrapta chewed her bottom lip, hesitating. “Just this once, okay?”

“Yeah, I got it,” Catra huffed. She snatched the Runestone from Entrapta’s hand before either of them could change their minds. “I’m not looking for a good time here. I just need to get through today.”

With the Runestone pinched between her fingers, Catra held it up to get a better look. It seemed incongruous that something so small could be so powerful. Then again, the same could be said about her.

"Do I just swallow it or what?" she asked.

"It's sublingual," Entrapta said. The unusual word earned her a glare from Catra, and she sighed. "Put it under your tongue and let it dissolve."

Catra ignored the pained, worried noises coming from Scorpia and did as she was told. Within seconds, the pill started to fizz and crackle, as if she'd stuck a piece of Pop Rocks candy under her tongue instead of a highly addictive street drug. In less than 30 seconds, the Runestone was gone.

"How do you feel?" Scorpia whispered.

Catra took stock and found she didn't feel any different. For a moment she was disappointed, but when she turned her head to complain to Entrapta, the room swayed.

"Woah," she said. She gripped the edge of the table as the world seemed to expand around her. In an instant, Catra found that the weight of her body and the various aches and pains she'd grown to live with fell away. She felt light and limitless, like her feet were barely skimming the ground. Somehow she knew, almost on an instinctive level, that the world and it's rules were nothing more than suggestions. Catra felt like she could do anything.

Catra rolled her shoulders and flexed her hands, stretching out her fingers and then curling them back into firm fists. She savored how fluid the movements were, how perfect and strong her body felt. She glanced up to find both Scorpia and Entrapta watching her closely, and she remembered what she was supposed to be doing. Her mind latched onto the thought, and made it her singular focus.

"Okay," she said in a voice that sounded like it was coming from everywhere and nowhere all at once. "I'm ready."

*

The time Adora had already spent in the air vents above Horde HQ felt like an eternity. She inched along at an agonizingly slow pace, mostly to keep quiet, but also to avoid stirring up the thick layer of dust that coated the narrow space through which she and her friends were squirming.

"Why don't the movies ever show how gross these vents are?" Glimmer hissed from her place in the middle of their crawling caravan. "I feel like I've been lied to."

"It's also way hotter than I thought it would be," Bow whispered, his voice echoing from the back of the line. "Like, I know we're up in the ceiling, but sheesh. I'm glad I wore a crop top."

Glimmer snorted. "You always wear a crop top, Bow."

"Shhh!" Adora hissed over her shoulder. Her friends immediately fell silent. They waited for a moment, holding their breath as they listened for signs that they'd been overheard. When she didn't hear any sounds of commotion or alarm below, Adora let herself breathe again.

A light glowed up ahead, indicating another grate. Adora crawled carefully toward it and peered down through the metal slats.

"Any idea where we are yet?" Bow whispered.

"We've made it to the main room!" Relief bloomed in Adora's chest. Up until this point every grate had shown her the same long, dingy hallway that seemed to run down the center of the warehouse. It had been eerily empty, but even though they knew Angella was in there somewhere, she hadn't wanted to risk dropping down to look until she knew how many gangsters were still in the building. She knew the place would be mostly deserted

at this hour, but Adora also knew the Horde wouldn't just leave a hostage unattended.

"How many goons do you see?" Glimmer asked.

Adora's eyes swept the room. She frowned. "None, actually."

"That's great!" Glimmer replied. "What are we waiting for?"

It felt off to Adora that the main room was empty, and she didn't like not knowing where the gangsters were. But they needed to get out of the vents at some point, and at least here she'd be in familiar territory.

"Right," she agreed as she carefully pried off the grate and slid it aside. "But be as quiet as you can." She dropped stealthily to the ground, rolling when she landed to lessen the impact. Glimmer tossed Adora her trusty baseball bat before doing the same, followed by Bow. Once they were all down safely, Adora motioned for her friends to follow her behind a stack of crates where they could duck out of sight.

"This place is so… I dunno, normal," Bow whispered once they were tucked away. "I guess I expected something a little more high tech. Like a super villain's lair or something."

"The only high tech you'll find in this place is through there." Adora pointed at the door behind which she'd spent so much time working at Entrapta's side. "That's how you get to the lab."

"Okay, but where would they be keeping my mom?" Glimmer asked. Her hands gripped the handle of her bat tightly, as if she couldn't wait to start swinging.

Adora oriented the others, motioning around the room as she spoke. "The actual garage is that way, so the warehouse must be through that door back there. The fact that there's no one out here tells me they must be with Angella, so once we find her we're going to have to move fast." She looked at her friends and, for a moment, she was struck by how young they were. Too

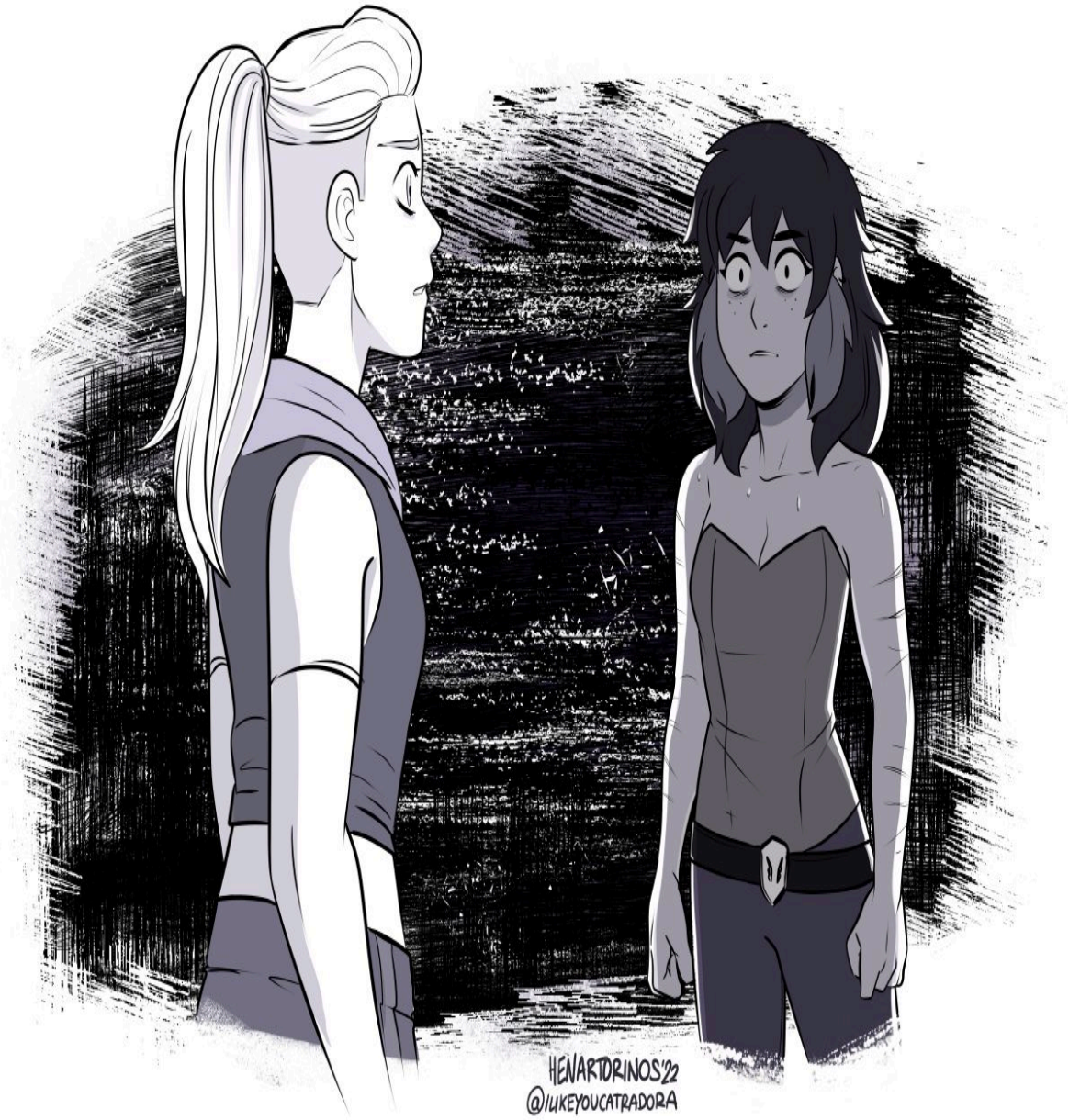
young to be doing any of this but, like the kids who grew up in the Horde, left with no other choice. “Get ready for a fight.”

If Glimmer and Bow were nervous, they didn’t let it show. Instead, they both nodded resolutely. It was time to go.

The Best Friends Squad darted across the room, keeping their steps light and their pace brisk. They were only a few short strides from the warehouse door when they heard another creak open.

Despite every instinct that told her to keep going, Adora skidded to a stop and looked toward the sound. Her heart dropped.

There, standing at the lab door, was Catra, flanked on either side by Scorpia and Entrapta. Her mismatched eyes were bright and wild as they stared unblinking back at Adora. She looked like a storm — a tornado moments from touching down. Her hair was wild and pupils constricted to pin pricks that were nearly lost in seas of blue and yellow. The leather jacket she’d taken to wearing was missing, leaving her toned and scarred arms bare. Adora noticed a faint sheen of sweat on Catra’s skin that made it look like she was glowing, and for a split-second, Catra was the most beautiful creature Adora had ever seen.



But that split-second went by in a flash. Catra's eyes narrowed dangerously, and that ethereal aura fell away to reveal something deadly.

"*You*," Catra growled, her face twisting into an animalistic snarl.

Adora was so taken aback by the transformation that her mind went blank. Who was this girl before her, and what had she done with her best friend?

But where Adora faltered, Glimmer stepped up to the plate. She raised the baseball over her shoulder and widened her stance. “Where’s my mom?”

The question sent a shark-like grin cutting across Catra’s face. She burst into a peel of laughter, loud and cruel.

“Your mommy is dead, little girl,” Catra shouted.

Adora’s head swam and the room around her seemed to pitch sideways. “That’s not fucking funny, Catra,” she snapped. “Where is she?”

Catra took a step forward. Something about her movements looked jerky and unnatural, and it made Adora’s heart clench with a sense of foreboding that she couldn’t quite place.

“I always knew you were a little dumb, but I know you’re not deaf,” Catra said with a sneer. “You’re too late — Angella’s already dead. Face it, Adora: you *failed*.”

“No,” Adora whispered. Her lungs ached, desperate for air, but Adora couldn’t seem to remember how to breathe. All of the careful planning she’d done was replaced by a flurry of white noise. How could this have happened? How could Angella be dead?

How could Catra do something like this?

A furious wail cut through the suffocating silence, wrenching Adora from her spiraling thoughts. Her head snapped toward the source of the sound just in time to see Glimmer launch herself at Catra.

“You fucking bitch!” Glimmer screamed, aiming the swing of her bat straight for Catra’s head.

But before the bat could reach its target, it was intercepted by Scorpia’s hand. Everyone seemed startled by the hulking gangster’s sharp reflexes, even Catra. Scorpia tried to wrench the

bat away, but Glimmer’s grip was so solid that she was lifted right along with it.

“Not so fast, kid,” Scorpia growled as she held Glimmer aloft. She glanced back at Catra. “Go! I’ll take care of these three.”

Shooting Adora one last cutting glare, Catra made a break for the warehouse door. A wildfire erupted in Adora’s chest. Her body moved nothing more than instinct and adrenaline as she launched herself forward in pursuit.

She may have failed Angella, but she wasn’t about to let Catra get away with it.

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CONTENT WARNING

- Catra takes Runestone in pill form, and there are discussions about the drug's addictive qualities. Some of the effects mimic the those of methamphetamine.

Chapter 34

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

[CONTENT WARNING: This chapter contains depictions and mentions of violence, death, and drug use. Please see the end of the page for a specific summary and take care when reading.]

Adora had long since accepted that she would never be as fast as Catra. Growing up, it didn't matter how hard she trained, she had never been able to match Catra's natural speed and graceful agility. Normally, that was fine — what Adora lacked in speed she made up for in sheer brute strength, and that was okay by her.

But in that moment, nothing was more important than making sure Catra didn't reach the warehouse door first.

Maybe it was desperation, or perhaps it was the undeniable rage that pulsed through every fiber of her being, but by some miracle Adora was able to summon just enough strength to catch up with Catra before it was too late. As Catra reached out for the door handle, Adora closed the distance between them and slammed into Catra from behind, sending them both crashing into the door.

From that point on, everything was chaos.

Catra shoved off of the door with alarming strength. She would have sent Adora sprawling backward had Adora not already had a hold of her shoulder. Adora wrenched her around, bringing them face to face.

"Stop it, Catra!" Adora shouted, shaking her former friend with a force she had never used on Catra before. "Why are you doing this?" Adora's fingertips lay over the scars on Catra's arms. She had never wanted to add to them; she'd wanted to protect her from them. An ember of shame smoldered somewhere at Adora's

core, but it was too weak to contend with the rising levels of fury she was feeling now.

The dam was broken. Adora couldn't have contained the flood even if she wanted to.

Catra replied with a wordless hiss and drove her fist into Adora's stomach, hard. Had she been anyone else, Adora may have buckled, but she'd spent her entire life training for fights like this. She twisted and shifted her weight, throwing Catra to the ground. But Catra—who knew all of Adora's moves because they were hers too—rolled into her landing and used the momentum to spring back to her feet.

"I'm doing exactly what I'm supposed to be doing," Catra spat back, teeth bared. "I'm doing what you were too scared to do."

The girls circled each other, both watching for an opening in the other's defenses.

"Because it's wrong, and you know it," Adora said from behind her raised fists. "C'mon, Catra. You're better than this!"

"Ha!" Catra barked. "If by that you mean better than *you*, then you're right!" Like lightning, Catra leapt. Adora managed to block, but she couldn't avoid the sharp sting of Catra's nails clawing against the flesh of her arms, drawing blood. For only a split second, Adora was stunned. Catra had never hurt her like that before, not on purpose.

But then the split-second was over, and the fight was on.

While Adora and Catra sparred, the others waged their own skirmishes with one another. No matter how hard Scorpia tried to come to Catra's aid, Glimmer and her bat refused to give her an inch. Meanwhile, rather than fighting, Bow was trying to convince Entrapta to talk to him. Unfortunately, Entrapta wasn't interested, and Bow was left to chase her as her incessant screaming filled the room.

As worried as Adora was about her friends' safety, she couldn't spare a moment to so much as glance their way, let alone help them. Catra was on the offense, and her attacks were relentless. And yet, despite the sweat that beaded Catra's brow and shimmered along her shoulders, she didn't seem to tire. When Adora blocked one of Catra's blows, the force of her strike sent a shockwave of pain that radiated out from her forearm and rattled her teeth.

Has Catra always been this strong? Adora wondered as she dropped low and swept a leg around in an attempt to knock Catra's feet out from under her. But, as usual, Catra was too fast for her; she skipped over Adora's leg like a child playing a game of jump rope. *How is she not getting tired?*

"This is pathetic," Catra laughed, watching Adora dodge out of punching range. "Is this really the best you can do? Life as the Brightmoon's lap dog has made you soft, Adora."

Adora ignored her. Instead of coming up with a witty retort, she lunged forward and moved through a combination of jabs, hooks, and upper-cuts. She didn't expect to land one (In fact, she kind of hoped she wouldn't — as angry as she was, the idea of actually hurting Catra made her stomach turn.) but with any luck the quick succession of moves would force Catra to defend and give Adora time to strategize. Catra danced backward, grinning menacingly as she avoided Adora's blows until, suddenly, her feet flew out from under her. She fell onto her back, hitting the concrete hard, and Glimmer's bat skittered past Adora's shoes.

"Ha!" Glimmer cried from across the room. She thrust a trumphent, bat-less first into the air, and Adora realized what had happened: Glimmer had rolled her only weapon into Catra's path. Her heart swelled with gratitude as she threw herself down on top of Catra and pinned her into place.

"Wildcat!" Scorpia cried, dismayed. Her face twisted into a scowl as she turned her attention back to Glimmer. "Big mistake, you little shit."

Glimmer didn’t have a chance to get out of harm’s way. Scorpia was on her in the blink of an eye, and she tossed her tiny adversary across the room and into the wall as if she was nothing more than a sack of flour.

This was enough to distract Bow from his pursuit of Entrapta.

“Glimmer!” he cried as he changed course.

As Catra writhed and swung for her face, Adora spotted Entrapta creeping down from a stack of crates she’d been hiding atop like a cat in a tree. Her magenta eyes were fixed on the door to her lab.

“Bow!” Adora cried. “Don’t let her get away!”

Beneath her, Catra let out a cry of frustration. She may have been quick and strong, but Adora was heavier. An extra couple of inches coupled with a body wrapped in diligently honed muscle gave Adora the advantage on that front, and right now she was using every pound to keep Catra trapped beneath her.

“Why are you doing this, Catra?” Adora grunted between gritted teeth, holding firm as Catra struggled. “This isn’t who you are. Please, just talk to me!”

Catra’s eyes locked on Adora’s, and the hatred in her gaze almost took Adora’s breath away. “You have no idea who I am. Not anymore.”

The words had barely left Catra’s lips when an explosion erupted from the corner of the room, followed by a shriek from Entrapta. A flash of heat washed over Adora like a wave, and when she glanced up, she found a ball of flames licking their way up the wall and across the oil-stained floor.

“Oh, shit!” Bow cried. “I’m sorry!”

“Did you seriously just throw a molotov cocktail at her?” Scorpia shouted, scooping a frightened Entrapta up in her arms.

“I was just trying to block her path!” Bow replied, watching in horror as the flames ate up their surroundings with frightening speed. “I didn’t think it would be that strong!”

Adora didn’t realize she was distracted until Catra’s fist connected with her jaw. The blow left her stunned, a fact that Catra exploited by bucking her hips and knocking Adora to the floor. When Catra’s hand closed around her throat, Adora knew she was in trouble.

“I hope you realize that all of this is your fault,” Catra snarled as she tightened her grip. She pinned Adora to the floor and leaned over her, their lips close enough to kiss. “None of this would have happened if you had just stayed.”

“We have to get out of here!” Entrapta cried frantically over the roar of the blaze. “If the fire reaches the lab, we’re dead!”

Despite this warning, Catra’s fingers dug in even tighter. Darkness crept into the corners of Adora’s vision, which was already swimming with tears.

And then, just as Adora’s broken heart convinced her that maybe she deserved this, Catra’s grip was ripped away as Scorpia hauled Catra off of her.

“Put me down!” Catra yelled, flailing.

“Sorry, Wildcat.” Scorpia said. “Entrapta’s right — we gotta go!” She took off toward the front of the garage, leaving Adora coughing and spluttering for breath on the floor.

“Adora!” Bow cried. “What do we do now?”

Lightheaded, Adora dragged herself up to all fours. She peered across the room, which was rapidly filling with smoke, and through bleary eyes found Bow helping Glimmer to her feet. Adora gave her head a shake and staggered up to standing. “Entrapta’s right — we’ve got to get as far away from this place as we can.”

She joined her friends, and helped guide them to the exit. They burst out onto the street and into the blessedly crisp night air. Adora swallowed as much as she could, letting it fill her lungs and clear her head as she and Bow stumbled down the street, dragging Glimmer between them.

"We have to go back," Glimmer cried. "My mom, she's still—"

Glimmer was cut off by a deafening explosion that knocked the three of them to the ground. They twisted and watched in stunned silence as what remained of the garage and warehouse was swallowed by flames.

Somewhere in the distance a siren wailed, the sound mingling with Glimmer's gutted scream.

*

They couldn't risk getting caught at the scene, and so the Best Friends Squad fled.

By the time she and her friends spilled through Glimmer's front door, Adora had already forgotten how they'd gotten there. Absolutely everything was a blur; nothing felt real. She locked the door and then collapsed against it while Bow helped Glimmer to the couch. Glimmer, completely inconsolable, sobbed into the plush cushions. The sounds of her grief seemed to echo through the entire house.

"Adora, can you get her some water?" Bow asked from where he crouched at Glimmer's side.

"Yeah," Adora replied with a nod. "Water, of course."

She moved as if on autopilot, staggering down the hall to the kitchen. At the cupboard, she stood staring at the rows of glasses in a daze. With shaking hands, Adora filled a glass with cold water and hurried back toward the living room. Along the way, she caught sight of herself in a large mirror that hung in the hallway. Her reflection startled her: eyes wide and terrified; filthy, ash-

covered face, streaked with tears; angry red marks around her neck. She dragged her gaze away from the girl in the mirror and scurried back to her friends.

There was nothing she nor Bow could say that could lessen the weight of Glimmer's despair. All they could do was keep her comfortable and keep her safe and she sobbed herself to sleep, wedged between them on the couch.

*

Rationally, Catra knew she was in trouble. Against all sense of self-preservation, she, Scorpia, and Entrapta had gone straight to Hordak. After fussing quietly over Entrapta, making sure that she was safe and uninjured, Hordak turned his attention to Catra. He didn't even have to speak for her to know that he was furious—that he had already decided that she would carry all the blame—but she was too distracted by the gnawing, desperate ache inside of her to care.

It was as if she could physically feel the Runestone being leaving her system. The confidence and strength she had enjoyed throughout her high was gradually displaced by overwhelming anxiety and rolling nausea. In the reflection of the floor to ceiling windows of Hordak's condo, she could see the terrible shape she was in. Thick black soot was smeared across the right side of her face and all the way down her arm, making it look as though she'd been standing too close when the blast went off. In reality, the mess was the result of a strange rescue mission of sorts. She and the others had been forced to double back after the explosion because Entrapta couldn't find Emily. Catra was the one who ultimately found the rat, cowering fearfully between slabs of charred rubble. Despite her revulsion, Catra had squeezed into the tight crevasse until she was able to scoop up the tiny animal and deposit her safely in Entrapta's waiting hands.

"Are you listening to me?" Hordak spat. He grabbed her clean arm in his fist and yanked her toward him.

Catra peered up at him, confused. She was about to tell him no, she hadn't been listening, when Scorpia piped up.

"Sir, please," she pleaded, "this wasn't her fault. Catra was doing exactly as you asked — we were all taken by surprise by the intruders."

Hordak's lip curled in disgust. "Then what good are either of you?"

As Scorpia shrank back from their boss's wrath, the sound of a phone ringing filled the air. With an irritated growl, Hordak let go of Catra's arm and retrieved his phone from the pocket of his jacket. Catra was surprised to see the color drain from his face when he glanced at the caller I.D.

"Yes," Hordak said into the receiver, his voice suddenly hoarse. He cut Catra a glare as he turned his back to her and the others. "That is correct… That won't be necessary, I have everything under con—"

Catra's curiosity burned. She'd never heard Hordak sound so uncertain before. There was a tremble there, just beneath his words. Who, she wondered, could possibly have that much sway over the Horde's ruthless leader?

She shot an inquisitive look at Scorpia and Entrapta. They shrugged, both clearly as puzzled as she was.

"Of course," Hordak said, barely keeping the irritation out of his voice. He ended the call and slid the phone back into his pocket, taking a deep breath before he turned around again. His dark eyes landed on Entrapta.

"The two of you need to leave," he said, gesturing at Scorpia without actually looking at her.

Entrapta hesitated. "Don't you mean the three of us?"

"No." Hordak glowered down at Catra, causing her stomach to perform another nauseating somersault. "She stays."

Catra could feel Scorpia's worried eyes on her; the weight of her concern was suffocating. But Catra kept her own gaze fixed straight ahead. She wasn't about to show fear or weakness, even though she likely had very good reason to feel both of those things. Fists clenched at her sides, Catra waited silently as Entrapta gently ushered Scorpia to the door, with Hordak following close behind. Catra watched her companions leave in the reflection cast in Hordak's floor to ceiling windows. Outside, a siren wailed somewhere in the streets below.

Hordak closed the door. Catra braced herself and turned, willing herself to face whatever her punishment would be head-on. But Hordak didn't so much as look at her. Instead, he started pacing, muttering unintelligibly under his breath. Catra watched as he rummaged through his open-concept kitchen and pulled out a short glass and a bottle of amber-colored liquor. Hordak poured a generous serving and downed it in a single shot.

He's nervous, Catra realized. The part of her that should have been worried was overshadowed by a cruel sense of delight at the sight of her boss slowly coming undone.

But that satisfaction was cut short by the sound of knocking at the door. Shoving his liquid courage out of sight, Hordak hurried to answer it while Catra held her breath. She craned her neck to get a better look when Hordak pulled the door open to reveal two pale men dressed in impeccable, matching white suits. They stepped inside without being invited, and much to Catra's surprise, Hordak let them. The men quickly explored the condo, barely so much as glancing in Catra's direction as they moved from room to room. When they were satisfied, the pair nodded wordlessly, and one of them retreated back into the hallway.

Scowling, Hordak came to stand at Catra's side, though she could tell by the rigidity of his posture that it wasn't meant to be an act of solidarity. Out of the corner of her eye, she could see the way he lifted his chin with just a hint of defiance. She wondered if that's what she looked like when she was staring down an

uncertain fate — something she'd done far too many times in her short life.

After a beat, the man in the suit returned. But he wasn't alone: a towering figure filled the door frame before stepping inside. This new man was intimidatingly tall, with broad shoulders that were barely contained by his sleek designer suit. The front of his long hair was pulled back and tied neatly behind his head. On his face, which looked eerily similar to Hordak's, the man wore an unnervingly placid smile — the very same one Catra had seen time and time again on posters and newspapers and Black Garnet Media broadcasts. Her mind reeled as she tried to think of a good reason why the mayor of Etheria was standing in the city's most notorious crime boss' living room.

She looked to Hordak, who cleared his throat.

"You needn't have wasted your time," he said tightly. "As I told you over the phone, I have everything under control."

The mayor sniffed and clasped his hands behind his back. "It's good to see you too, little brother."

Catra couldn't stop herself. Against all better judgment, she blurted out, "Mayor Prime is your *brother*?"

Every head turned to face her in unison. It was as if the newcomers hadn't even noticed that she was there until she said something, and now, pinned under Prime's stare, she wished she had stayed quiet.

"And who do we have here?" Prime drawled. The false sweetness in his voice sent a shiver down Catra's spine.

Hordak hurried to answer. "This is the Force Captain who is responsible for the fire at our—"

"I wasn't talking to you," Prime said, cutting him off. His words weren't cutting or forceful, and yet there was a note to them that clearly declared that he wasn't to be disobeyed. Without breaking

eye contact with her, Prime offered Catra his hand. “What is your name?”

Swallowing hard, Catra wiped her sweaty palm on her jeans before taking his hand.

“Catra,” she answered. Prime’s grip tightened — not firm enough to hurt but with enough pressure to assert his dominance. He smiled again.

“A pleasure, Catra,” he said. “And you’re a Force Captain in our little enterprise, are you?”

Catra felt the pieces click into place. The gang’s influence throughout the city, the fact that they always seemed one step ahead of the authorities — none of that was an accident, and it certainly didn’t have anything to do with Hordak’s leadership. Prime wasn’t just aware of his younger brother’s criminal escapades: he was the head of the whole damn thing.

In an instant, Catra realized that her life was in the hands of the most powerful man in the city. If she played her cards right, she might just make it out of this alive.

“That’s right,” she replied.

Mayor Prime tipped his head, his eyes scanning her soot-covered face.

“Fascinating,” he said. Releasing Catra’s hand, he gestured to the couch. “Please, have a seat.”

Catra hurried to oblige, perching herself on the end of it. She watched as Prime nodded at his brother, indicating that he was to sit as well. Begrudgingly, Hordak lowered himself onto the couch next to her while Prime settled into the armchair.

“I understand we lost our primary base of operations tonight,” Prime said matter-of-factly, his eyes boring into Catra’s.

She waited a beat, assuming he had more to say before realizing he expected her to speak.

"Yes," Catra replied, choosing her words carefully. "A group of vigilantes broke into the facility and started a fire."

Mayor Prime hummed thoughtfully as he examined the many rings that adorned his fingers. "The building was completely destroyed."

Catra's mouth went dry. She had been so consumed with sickness and fear that she hadn't paused to think about the fate of their headquarters, nor what they'd left behind when they fled. Now, the only thing she could think of was Angella, still bound in that windowless room. She had been bluffing when she told Adora and her friends that Angella was dead — it had been worth it just to see the looks on their self-righteous faces.

But, as if she had unknowingly uttered the incantation of a dark spell, Catra had wound up killing Angella Brightmoon afterall. Bile rose in her throat and she had to fight to keep it down.

"Destroyed?" she asked quietly as the room seemed to spin around her.

"Down to the studs, I'm afraid," Prime replied with a grim nod. "Everything is gone, , including an extremely valuable store of Runestone."

Fuck, Catra thought, forcing the nightmarish image of Angella burning alive from her mind. The product that had been lost was worth more than she could comprehend. The street value was staggering, and the financial loss to the Horde would be devastating. This whole mess was going to get pinned on her if she didn't think of something fast.

Focus, Catra. You can beat yourself up all you want if you make it out of this.

Narrowing her gaze, Catra shook her head sadly. "I tried to tell him something like this would happen."

“Tell whom?” Prime asked with a curious lift of his brow.

“Hordak,” Catra said. She could feel her boss tense beside her, but she ignored him as she pressed on. “I warned him that Shadow Weaver couldn’t be trusted, especially after she let a defector go. And I was right: that same defector brought those vigilantes right past our defenses tonight.”

Prime turned to his brother. “I was under the impression that you had dealt with the Shadow Weaver problem.”

Before Hordak could lay the blame on her, Catra cut in. “She escaped while he was busy trying to make an example out of her. And as if that wasn’t bad enough, she went straight to the police and turned herself in.”

For the first time since walking through the door, Mayor Prime’s stoic expression faltered. It was just a second—a fleeting glimpse of unease—but that was all Catra needed to see.

Meanwhile, Hordak exploded. “She escaped under *your* watch,” he snapped at her. “If you had just done your job none of this would have happened.”

This was it: time to sink or swim. Catra feigned concern and turned her eyes imploringly to Prime. “I still don’t understand why he would trust such an important task to anyone else, especially with so much on the line. If I was in his position I would have taken care of Shadow Weaver immediately.”

With a howl of rage, Hordak launched himself at her, only to be intercepted by the strong hands of Mayor Prime’s goons. With what seemed to Catra like no effort at all, they hauled Hordak back to his spot on the couch and held him firmly in place. Catra licked her lips and turned her attention back to Prime, who she found watching her closely.

“Tell me, Catra,” he mused, his voice smooth and unnervingly warm. “What else would you do if you were in his position?”

Catra's mind spun into overdrive. Prime was testing her, she was sure of it. "I'd rebuild, of course. But I'd be smart about it."

Prime smirked. "Go on."

"Well, for starters, it was pretty stupid to house our operations in one place," Catra said, earning a growl from Hordak. "If I was calling the shots, we'd keep everything separate. Only a few trusted people would know where the new lab was so that information couldn't fall into the wrong hands."

"A wise plan," Prime agreed, stroking his chin. "But it's hardly a revolutionary idea."

Shit.

Catra cast her mind back over the weeks since she'd become Force Captain, reviewing the things she'd seen and what she'd learned about the Horde. What else would she change if she were the one in charge?

"Losing the kids really hurt our Runestone distribution," she said, thinking back to all of the times she and Adora had been tasked with selling those little purple pills back when they were minors. "But I don't think we need them."

"Children are the safest way to move our product," Hordak interjected. "We can't afford to risk our ranks on petty drug charges."

Catra gritted her teeth and pushed past the implication that kids like her were expendable to the gang. "First of all, you and I both know that the police department is in our pocket, so don't use that shit as an excuse." Something about sitting across from Mayor Prime made Catra feel invincible, and she privately reveled in watching Hordak's face fall. "Besides, if we work smarter, we can let the Runestone sell itself."

She looked back to Prime, locking her gaze with his. Maybe she was still high, because now that she had started sharing her

ideas, she couldn't seem to stop. With Entrapta-like enthusiasm, Catra continued. "We need to attract a different clientele — the kind of people who have money to burn but have enough at stake to be discreet."

"If those people were interested in Runestone, they would already be customers," Prime countered.

Catra shook her head. "Those people *are* interested in Runestone, they just don't know it. They don't want to buy some pills from a sketchy kid on the street. These people are looking for luxe — so let's give it to them."

Hordak huffed from where he sat, still pinned in place by Prime's men. "Runestone has been chemically calibrated for maximum efficiency and return on investment. If we make it any more potent, production will cease to be profitable."

"Who said anything about making it more potent?" Catra scoffed. "The only thing that has to change is the packaging. Think about it, if we were to—"

She paused, catching herself before she unwittingly handed over all of her big ideas. A quick glance at Prime told her she had him right where she wanted him: she was onto something, and he knew it. Taking a deep breath, Catra settled back into the couch and folded her hand on her lap.

"I'm getting ahead of myself," she said carefully. "Let's just say that I have it all planned out: the rebrand, the new distribution channels — all of it."

Mayor Prime shifted in his seat, drumming his long fingers along the arm of the chair. "That sounds ambitious."

Catra leaned forward. She forced herself to smile. "It sounds like the future to me."

For a moment, no one said anything. The air hung thick with tension, and as the seconds ticked by, Catra found it harder and

harder to breathe.

And then, Mayor Prime laughed. He leaned in, mirroring Catra's position. "Then I suppose you had better get to work, little sister."

"WHAT?" Hordak bellowed. "Brother, you can't be serious."

Catra didn't realize how soft Prime's expression had been until it wasn't anymore. His eyes hardened so quickly that she didn't even see it happen. But Prime's men clearly noticed. Perhaps the change in their boss' demeanor was a signal of sorts, because without a word the pair of them hauled Hordak over the back of the couch and dragged him off, kicking and flailing, into another room.

"Brother!" Hordak cried, straining against his captors. His dark eyes were wide with panic, and the sight of them reminded Catra that she needed to be afraid. "Wait!"

"I'm sorry, little brother, but you leave me no choice," Prime said in an almost sing-song voice. He got to his feet, tutting at the sight of his brother struggling for freedom. "Perhaps it's my fault — perhaps I gave you too much leeway. It seems you've forgotten who is in charge here." Mayor Prime smiled, and it was the most terrifying thing Catra had ever seen. "But we won't make that mistake again, will we?"

One of the suited men kicked the door closed. Catra's hands gripped the edge of the couch as her brain struggled to process what she'd just witnessed. And then came the unmistakable sound of blows—the thuds of fists and feet connecting with flesh, the crack of bone—and Hordak's howls of pain. Catra's blood ran cold.

"Allow me to show you out, little sister," Mayor Prime cooed as if he couldn't hear his own brother's screams coming from the next room. Quivering from fear or withdrawal or both, Catra jumped to her feet and followed the Mayor to the exit desperate to escape

the sounds of Hordak's punishment. Prime held the door open for her, and she rushed by without so much as a backward glance.

She all but ran to the elevator.

"Oh, Catra?" Prime called just as she reached for the elevator button. Catra made herself turn around and face him. "I trust you understand what's at stake here?"

Catra's voice had abandoned her, and so replied with a nod.

Prime smiled. "Of course you do. I know you won't disappoint me." He turned back into the condo with a wave. "Sleep well, little sister."



Chapter End Notes

CONTENT WARNINGS:

- Violence: The chapter opens with an on-page fight scene between Adora and Catra, and Glimmer and Scorpia during which they exchange blow. At the end of the chapter, Hordak

is dragged into another room and beaten (implied, off-page)by Prime's men.

- Death: The Horde's headquarters explodes and Catra assumes that Angella has died in the insuring fire

- Drug use: Catra comes down from her Runestone high and the experience includes a variety of symptoms that are described on page (nausea, aches and pain, disorientation)

Chapter 35

Chapter Summary

CONTENT WARNING:

- Catra and Scorpia come across paramedics responding to an unnamed character who has died of a drug overdose; the drug use and death do not occur on-page

*[**Content warning:** Drug overdose, death. See the end of the chapter for specific details and please take care while reading.]*

Adora didn't remember falling asleep.

One moment she was curled on the couch with Glimmer tucked between her and Bow. Somehow, mercifully, Glimmer had managed to cry herself to sleep. All the while, Adora and Bow sat up like a pair of sentries without speaking.

And then, quite suddenly, Adora found herself blinking against bright midday sunshine as it filled the room. *How long did I sleep*, she wondered. *What time is it?*

Why am I awake?

The answer to that last question came in the form of a loud knocking at the door. Any lingering notion of going back to sleep vanished. Adora glanced at her friends and found them still dozing in a peaceful embrace. Not wanting to wake them, Adora crept off the couch and darted to the front door.

Her heart was in her throat as she peeked between the curtains that covered the windows on either side of the door. There she found a woman shifting anxiously from one foot to another. She wore her dark hair in a practical bun and her eyes seemed familiar, though Adora couldn't quite place why.

“Who are you?” Adora barked, loud enough to make the woman jump with surprise. “What do you want?”

“Who am I?” the woman asked, her tone indignant. “I should be asking you the same question! What are you doing in my sister-in-law’s house?”

Adora mapped out the family tree in her mind. Suddenly the familiar eyes made sense — she recognized them from photos of the late Micah Brightmoon. “You’re Glimmer’s aunt?”

The woman’s face fell at the mention of Glimmer’s name. “Yes, she’s my niece. Is she there? Please, I need to speak with her. It’s important.”

“What’s going on?” Glimmer’s groggy voice drifted from somewhere over Adora’s shoulder.

“There’s a lady outside claiming to be your aunt,” Adora replied, earning a wide-eyed gasp from her friend.

“Aunt Casta?” Glimmer exclaimed, rushing forward. Before Adora could stop her (for all they knew, this could have been a trap) Glimmer had unlocked the door and flung it open.

The woman—Aunt Casta, presumably—immediately burst into tears. She pulled Glimmer into a crushing hug. “Oh, my sweet girl! Thank goodness you’re safe. I’ve been worried sick!”

This struck Adora as a very suspicious thing to say. She clenched her hands into fists and took a step forward, ready to fight for her friend if necessary. “Safe from what? What do you know?”

“Geeze, Adora. Stand down!” Glimmer said, her voice muffled from within her aunt’s embrace. “She’s family!”

Casta straightened up, her eyes locking onto Adora curiously. “So, *you’re* the Adora Angella told me so much about.”

Hearing Angella's name was like a shot to Adora's heart. All at once, the previous night came flooding back to her, and the pain was almost too much to take. Instinctively, she looked to Glimmer, ready to comfort her. But to Adora's surprise, Glimmer didn't crumble into a weeping pile of grief the way she had the night before. Instead, her brows furrowed as she pushed her way out of her aunt's arms.

"Wait, when did Mom tell you about Adora?" Glimmer demanded. "A week ago she was complaining about how she hadn't heard from you in almost a year."

For a split second, Casta looked offended. She opened her mouth, but seemed to think better of whatever she'd been planning to say. Pinching the bridge of her nose, Casta sighed. "Right, of course. Glimmer, we have to talk. It's about your mother."

Only now did Glimmer seem to deflate. She looked away, her bottom lip trembling. "She's dead. I already know."

The heavy silence that followed was punctuated by an electronic beep. Adora recognized the sound, and it sent her heart racing. She whirled around to find Bow staring down at a tablet in his hands.

"Sorry," he said meekly when he realized everyone was watching him.

"Is that Entrapta's tablet?" Adora asked. "How did you get it?"

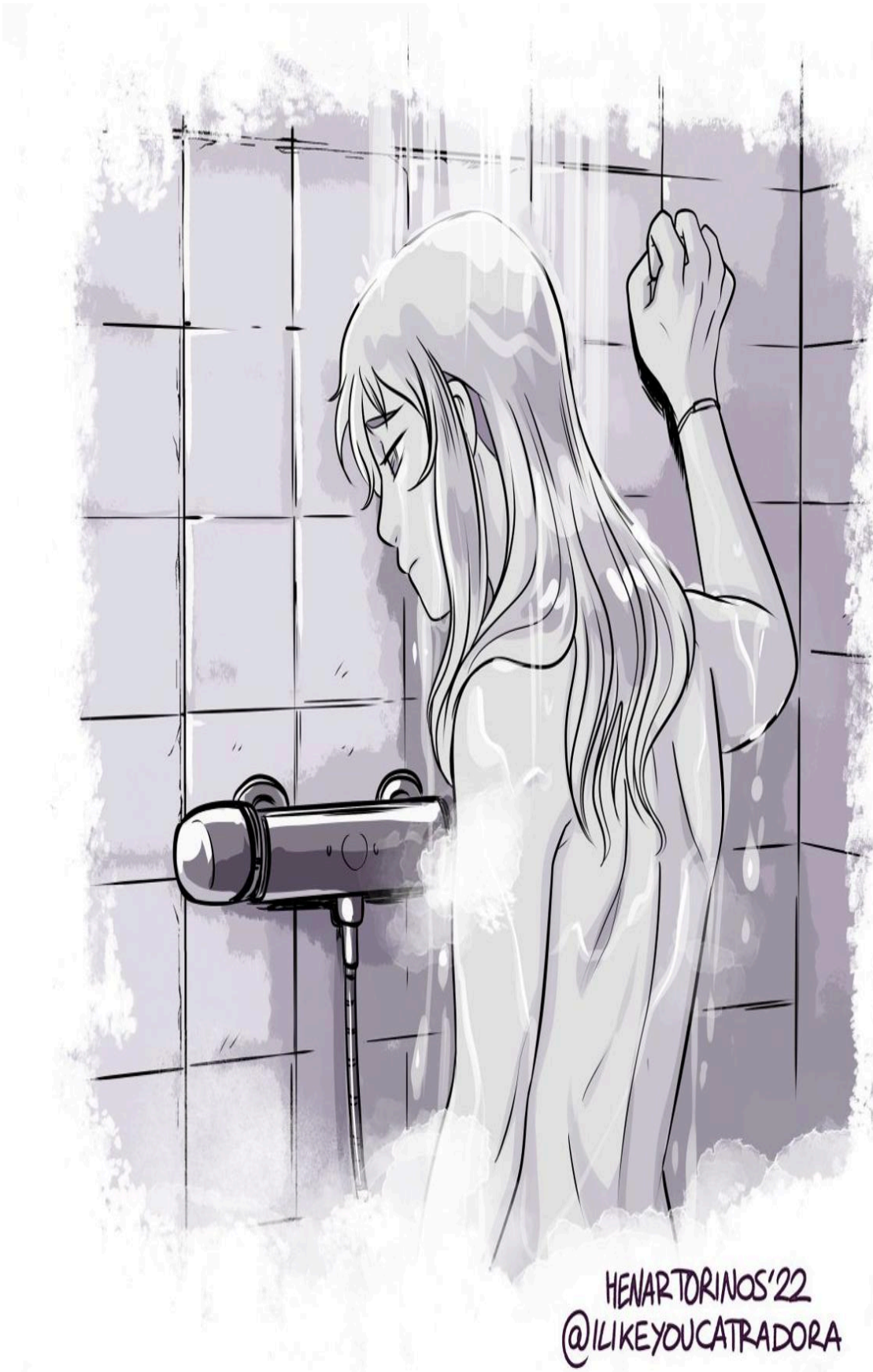
Bow frowned at the screen. "She dropped it while she was running away from me. I've been trying to get into it, but the security on this thing is intense."

Casta brought their attention back by clearing her throat. She pressed her lips into a tight line and folded her hands neatly in front of her. "How about you all go get cleaned up? I'll make us something to eat and then we can talk."

There didn’t really seem to be any reason to argue. Adora, Glimmer, and Bow each disappeared into one of the home's many bathrooms and showered off the ash and grime from the night before. As Adora watched the evidence of her failed rescue mission swirl down the drain, her numbness eventually gave way, and she let herself cry.

Angella was gone, and it was all her fault. She shouldn’t have made them wait to rescue her — what good had all that planning done in the end? When she closed her eyes, all she could see was Catra’s face, wild-eyed and glistening, a shadow of the girl she’d loved for so long. How could she do it? How could she kill anyone, let alone one of the precious few people who had ever shown them any kindness?

Does Catra really hate me that much? Adora wondered miserably.


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Eventually, when the smoke and tears and ash had all washed away, Adora forced herself to get dressed and face the others. She slinked into the kitchen, where Casta was sliding sizzling bacon onto a trio of plates even though it was almost 2 o'clock in the afternoon. Bow was already there, chatting quietly with the woman who looked so much like her brother than it made Adora uneasy. When he spotted Adora out of the corner of his eye, Bow gave her a sad smile and pulled a chair out beside him at the breakfast counter. A few moments later, Glimmer shuffled in and took a seat of her own. Casta pushed their plates toward them.

"I'm not feeling very hungry," Glimmer mumbled down at her plate. Tears shimmered on her lash line, and the sight made Adora's heart ache.

"I know, sweetheart," Aunt Casta said kindly. "But you have to eat something. At least try finishing a few bites, please?"

Even Adora, who was never not hungry, had a hard time choking down a few forkfuls of food. No matter how much juice she drank, her throat felt permanently dry. Eating felt like a luxury that she didn't deserve.

After a few minutes of eating in silence, Glimmer finally set her fork down and looked at her aunt. "So, what happens now?"

Casta hid a grimace behind her steaming cup of tea. She took a delicate sip, then set it down with trembling hands. "There's no easy way to say this, so I'm just going to spit it out."

The three friends waited.

One moment bled into the next.

Adora cleared her throat. "Are you ok—"

"Your mother isn't dead!" Casta blurted out at last. Her face was flushed and she stared down at her tea, avoiding the stunned faces of the trio sitting across from her.

The moment seemed to stretch on forever. With her mouth hanging open, Adora turned to look at Glimmer, uncertain of how to read the situation. She didn't know this Casta woman at all — was this her idea of a joke?

Glimmer's brows furrowed, her expression a mix of hurt and hopeful. "What are you talking about, Aunt Casta?"

With a sigh, Casta reached into the purse she'd left resting on the kitchen counter and pulled out an envelope.

"Here," she said, handing it to her niece. "This will explain everything."

Glimmer tore into the envelope and unfolded the handwritten pages inside. "This is Mom's writing!" she exclaimed.

Adora leaned closer to read the letter over her shoulder.

My dearest Glimmer,

I'm so terribly sorry to have left you to worry about me. Please let me explain, and then you can be mad at me all you want.

Ever since Shadow Weaver's arrest, I've been working in secret to get to the bottom of the corruption within the Etheria Police Department. I didn't want anyone to know what I was doing because I didn't know who I could trust, and as I began to uncover just how much control the Horde had over my officers, the more justified I felt in that decision.

My only regret now is that I kept you in the dark too. At the time I thought I was keeping you safe. Now, I'm not so sure.

Two nights ago I was abducted and held captive by the Horde. By now you've likely heard about the fire at the gang's headquarters. I still don't know what caused it, but it provided enough of a distraction for me to escape undetected.

Now, my sweet, brave daughter, I have to ask more of you than any mother should ever ask of her child. Right now, the world probably thinks I'm dead, and I desperately need you to let them.

If my investigations into the Horde proved anything, it's that the police are not the answer to bringing them down. And so, in a move that I think might make you proud, I'm going rogue. I'm going deep undercover to continue my investigation. I need to figure out how far the Horde's influence reaches, and the best way to do that is as a ghost.

Though it probably would have been safer, I couldn't leave without letting you know that I am alive. I don't know how long this will take, so I have entrusted your aunt with this information. She will take care of you until my return. Please be kind to her.

I know this is terrible. I'm sure you're angry with me, and I do not blame you for that. I hope you can find it in your heart to forgive me someday.

I am so proud of you, Glimmer. I will love you forever.

Because I know you will tell Bow and Adora regardless of what I say, I won't ask you to keep this a secret from them. However, I hope you all understand the need for discretion.

Until we can be together again, take care of each other.

Love always,

Mom

P.S. Please tell Adora that I am sorry that I couldn't keep my promise to her. I will never forgive myself for failing to protect them, but I swear that I will do everything in my power to make things right.

Adora didn't realize she was crying until Casta gently nudged a tissue box in her direction. Glimmer sobbed and pressed the letter to her heart.

“Is this for real?” she asked her aunt through tears. “Please tell me I’m not dreaming right now.”

“You’re not dreaming.” Casta gave her niece a small smile. “Your mother came to me late last night and explained what was going on. I tried to talk her out of it, but you know how she is.”

Chuckling, Glimmer wiped her eyes with the back of her hand. “Yeah, I do.”

“This definitely calls for a group hug!” Bow exclaimed, pulling his friends into a crushing embrace. Adora let herself be held—let herself feel the realness of her friends—just to stave off the numbness inside of her.

Once Bow released his hold on them, Glimmer smoothed the letter out on the counter and turned to Adora. “What’s she talking about in the postscript?”

“Yeah,” Bow chimed in, “who did she fail to protect? Is this about the kids from the warehouse?”

That was a good guess, but Adora knew better. She shook her head slowly as she struggled to speak. Fresh tears burned at her eyes, and she let them fall.

“Catra,” she managed to say. “I asked her to save Catra.”

Burning with shame, Adora covered her face with her hands as she wept. Her stubborn unwillingness to give up on Catra had almost gotten Angella killed. From the moment Catra claimed that Angella was dead, Adora had been in a freefall. Despite everything Catra had done, Adora still didn’t want to believe that she had become some kind of monster — that she was capable of doing something as heinous as murder. But what really made Adora feel ashamed was the fact that she was relieved. Relieved that Catra wasn’t actually responsible. Relieved that she hadn’t done the unthinkable.

But how could she say any of that to Glimmer? Glimmer, who had spent the last many hours believing her mother was dead. Glimmer, who still had to live without her until this whole mess could be resolved.

"Hey, it's okay," Glimmer said gently. "It's not your fault. Sometimes we give people second chances who don't deserve them. At least you tried, right?"

Adora sobbed harder.

Pull it together, she admonished herself. *This isn't about you. Glimmer needs you right now*. She took a fistful of the tissues from the box and hurriedly mopped her face with them.

"Now what do we do?" she asked, changing the subject so she wouldn't have to think about whether or not Catra deserved the chances she'd been given.

"Now you carry on with your lives," Casta said. "And you don't tell anyone about Angella's plan."

The Best Friends Squad shared a skeptical look.

"No offense Aunt Casta, but I don't know how you can expect us to get back to 'business as usual' after everything that's happened."

Casta's expression brightened in a way that made Adora wary. "Don't you worry about that, sweetheart. That's what therapy's for!"

What Adora would come to learn was that Aunt Casta was actually a doctor—head of psychiatry at Mystacor Memorial Hospital—and thus a very big believer in talk therapy. Her first order of business as Glimmer's (and, in a way, Adora's) temporary guardian was to arrange therapy sessions for them. Even Bow went along with the idea.

“There is absolutely no reason any of you should be having to work through all this trauma on your own,” Casta explained later that day. “Of course, there’s a bit of, shall we say, ‘conflict of interest’ with me being your therapist, so I’m bringing in one of my best and brightest students to work with you instead. You’re going to love her!”

Adora wasn’t sold on the plan. “Are you sure that’s a good idea? I mean, we’re all dealing with some pretty dangerous stuff here. I don’t know if we should be talking to an outsider.”

“Don’t worry,” Casta said brightly, waving her off. “Even among residents, doctor-patient confidentiality is paramount.” She paused and shifted uncomfortably for a moment before adding. “Plus she needs my sign-off to complete her program, so unless she wants to blow years of medical school training and her ungodly tuition fees then she won’t be stepping out of bounds.”

And so, Adora, Glimmer, and Bow were introduced to Perfuma, Dr. Casta’s bright young protegé.

Every week, month after month, Perfuma would arrive at the Brightmoon’s front door to make a house call. At first, Adora spent her hour-long sessions with her stewing in silence. How was she supposed to confide all of her terrible secrets in this complete stranger?

But if Perfuma was unnerved by Adora’s unwillingness to open up, she didn’t let it show. Slight and lanky, with perpetually sun-kissed skin and cloud-like blonde hair, the young psych-student was unflappable. She would show up each week, smelling strongly of patchouli and peppermint, usually with some kind baked peace offering tucked neatly into a glass container. Slowly, without realizing it, Adora found herself warming to her.

“Energy ball?” Perfuma said one afternoon as she held this week’s treat under Adora’s nose. “They’re vegan!” They had been at this for nearly three months now, and while Adora had discovered that

she did not share Perfuma's enthusiasm for vegan cuisine, she still took the gifts to be polite

"Thanks," she muttered, carefully plucking one of the strange, sticky balls from the container and taking a cautious bite. The thing tasted strongly of dates and coconut, neither of which Adora liked, but she smiled anyway.

Perfuma beamed. "So, how are things going this week?"

Adora shrugged. "Same as last week. Glimmer and I are still trying to figure out where the gang has gone, Bow's still trying to hack into Entrapta's tablet, and none of us are having much luck."

"Mhmm." Perfuma scribbled into a notebook that was kept locked in a safe under Glimmer's bed, just to be safe. "And how about your heart? How are you feeling?"

"Like shit," Adora replied. She'd stopped cringing at the fluffy way Perfuma approached the topic of feelings. "I'm frustrated — we've been investigating for three months and we still haven't heard so much as a whisper about what the Horde is up to. We have no idea where they are and it's driving me nuts!"

Perfuma hummed thoughtfully as she set her pen down. She waited for Adora to meet her gaze before speaking.

"May I ask you something?"

Adora snorted. "Can I stop you?"

Ignoring the jab, Perfuma continued. "Why is figuring out what the gang is up to so important to you? Isn't finding them what Mrs. Brightmoon has gone undercover to do?"

"Well, sure." Adora shifted uncomfortably in her seat. "But that doesn't mean we should stop trying. The sooner we bring down the Horde, the sooner Angella can come home."

Perfuma tipped her head to one side and pinned Adora under her strangely compelling stare. Adora recognized that look—the one that conveyed that Perfuma wasn't buying whatever half-truth Adora was peddling—and it made her squirm. "I believe that's Glimmer's motivation for continuing the search, but what about you?"

There was a part of Adora that wanted to push back at the insinuation that she wasn't in this for Angella's sake. Of course she wanted Glimmer to get her mom back. But she also knew that's not what Perfuma was implying, just like she knew that Perfuma was right. So, Adora dropped her eyes and sighed.

"I know I shouldn't care anymore. Catra made her choice, but…" Adora hesitated, "I still want her to be okay."

"Why do you think you shouldn't care anymore?" Perfuma asked.

"Because of everything she's done? Because she knows the difference between right and wrong and yet she continues to make bad choices? Take your pick!"

Perfuma smiled at Adora; soft and warm, without pretension. "Adora, love is complicated." The L-word made Adora tense-up, but Perfume chose to ignore it. They both knew the truth at this point, even if Adora hadn't come right out and said it. "And when you love someone, different things can be true at the same time. You can love Catra and still disapprove of her actions. You can want her to be safe without forgiving her. And you can do all of this without beating yourself up over it. From where I'm sitting, the only person you need to forgive right now is yourself."

Sometimes it scared Adora just how easily Perfuma seemed to see right through her. Rather than say anything in reply, Adora shoved what remained of the half-eaten energy ball in her mouth. As a contemplative quiet settled between her and her therapist, Adora let her mind wander back to Catra and wondered, without shame, what she was doing now.

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Three months. That's how long it had taken Catra to get the gang's Runestone production back up and running.

Three months of hard work.

Three months of sleepless nights.

Three months of constantly looking over her shoulder, just in case.

True to her word, Catra managed to set up a secret lab for Entrapta. Inspired by her early days as a Force Captain, she rented a storage locker under a fake name and put Scorpia to work turning the tiny space into one where Entrapta could work. It wasn't perfect, but it was better than nothing.

Catra hadn't quite figured out the new distribution channels yet. But if Prime was worried about her progress he had a strange way of showing it. In those three short months, Prime had already moved her into her own apartment. It was small and unremarkable, but certainly a step-up from the room she'd had at the old—and now defunct—hotel. At Catra's insistence, the hotel had been vacated. They couldn't risk Adora tapping into her pre-existing knowledge of the Horde again. Other Force Captains were relocated to various apartments, often in clusters like unwilling roommates. But Catra was on her own.

Not that she spent much time there anyway. Instead, she was working around the clock, desperate to prove her worth and ensure she didn't end up comatose like Hordak. Or worse.

Besides, as long as she was working, Catra wasn't sleeping. And if she wasn't sleeping, then she wasn't haunted by recurring nightmares. Most nights she was forced to bear witness to Angella's fiery demise. But sometimes, Catra would instead dream that she was the one burning alive, tossed into the flames by a cold-eyed Adora seeking vengeance. Ultimately, Catra would rather live on caffeine and Runestone than face either vision.

Runestone. It all came back to those little purple pills.

With limited supplies, Entrapta was churning out only a fraction of what she'd been making before the fire, but it was still enough that no one seemed to notice that Catra was skimming a little out of each batch. Not a lot — just enough to keep the sickness and the nightmares at bay.

One late spring morning, Catra realized she was out of her secret supply. Her heavy hair, which had grown so long now, clung to the sweat on the back of her neck. She fidgeted with an increasing restlessness that made it hard for her to focus on anything else.

"Goddammit," she hissed, digging through her pockets and shaking out her bedsheets in search of one last overlooked pill.

Just as she felt herself creeping closer to an outburst—something she'd become prone to while coming down off of her highs—Catra's phone rang.

"What?" she snapped when she answered it.

"Hey, Catra," came Scorpia's cautious reply. "How's it going?"

Catra gritted her teeth through the building frustration. "I don't have time for small talk, Scorpia. What do you want?"

"Right, right." Scorpia cleared her throat. "Entrapta wanted me to let you know that it's ready."

This got Catra's attention. She pulled her head out from under her bed (no Runestone there, either) and sat up straight. "I'll be right there."

Grabbing her keys and helmet off the counter, Catra dashed from her apartment and took an elevator down to the parking garage. A familiar mix of excitement and dread curled in her stomach as she strode toward the motorcycle—her motorcycle—that waited in her designated spot. Another gift from Prime.

"I need you to be mobile," he had explained over the phone the day it was dropped off. But despite this perfectly utilitarian justification, Catra knew there was no such thing as a free ride in the Horde. Just like with the apartment, every lavish gift from her boss was just another line of debt she owed to him.

If I'm selling my soul to the devil, I may as well have fun doing it, she thought as she pulled on her helmet (It had been a gift from Scorpia, complete with custom cat ears on the top. The note had read, "For my Wildcat". Catra still cringed every time she thought about it.) and straddled the bike. The roar of the engine was her new favorite sound, if for no other reason than the way it filled her head and drowned out everything else.

She arrived at the storage facility a short while later and parked the motorcycle behind the row of lockers for safe keeping. With her helmet propped against her hip, Catra knocked a coded pattern onto the door of locker #5—a hold-over from her days in the warehouse—and waited to be let in.

The door rolled up just high enough for her to duck under before slamming back down behind her.

"Hey, Wildcat," Scorpia said. The effort it took her not to pull Catra into a hug was obvious. "How was traffic?"

Catra glared at her. "What did I *just* say about small talk?" As Scorpia shrank back, Catra turned her attention to Entrapta. "Well? How did it turn out?"

Entrapta looked up from behind the cramped folding card table that now functioned as her work station. "It turned out perfectly, of course. You asked me to half the dose, not invent the cure for cancer."

The gang's resident scientist hadn't been the same since the night of the fire. Losing her lab, her tablet, and almost losing Hordak all at once had been devastating to Entrapta, and she never quite bounced back to her old, bubbly self. Catra ignored her sarcasm

and stepped up to the table, where she was greeted with a squeak of delight from Emily. Much to Catra's chagrin, the rat had taken a real liking to her after she rescued her from the rubble.

On the table sat two trays, one filled with the familiar purple Runestone and the other with a new pill, magenta in color.

"I made them the color of Emily's eyes," Entrapta explained as Catra pulled on a latex glove and plucked a pill from the tray to examine it closer. "I'm calling this one Robots."

Catra raised a quizzical eyebrow at her. "Why?"

Entrapta shrugged. "Because I like robots."

"I guess junkies don't really give a shit what it's called, so long as it does the trick," Catra murmured as she turned the pill over in her hand. She picked up a purple one and compared them side-by-side. "So the Robots are the exact same potency as usual?"

"Everything about its chemical makeup is the same." Entrapta nodded toward the tray of purple pills. "And the Runestone looks the same as it always has, but it's only half as strong."

Scorpia stepped up to the table and gave Emily the ear scratch that Catra denied her. "So, tell me if I'm following this right… We're going to start selling Runestone that's only half as good as it used to be, and when people complain, we gaslight them into thinking they've just built up a tolerance to it?"

"Yep," Catra replied, sifting carefully through the magenta stock with gloved fingers. "Then we tell them that there's a new designer drug on the scene called Robots that's twice as strong."

"Except, in reality, Robots are just as strong as Runestone used to be?" Scorpia spoke slowly, working through the plan.

"But they cost twice as much." Catra couldn't help but grin. "Now all we need is to build some buzz around Robots and find classier

sales people who can focus on pushing this stuff on losers with more cash to blow."

A low grumble filled the small storage locker. Catra turned to Scorpia, whose cheeks flushed red.

"Sorry," Scorpia said with a sheepish smile. "I haven't had lunch yet."

Catra considered her own empty stomach. When was the last time she'd eaten a proper meal? "I could eat. What about you, Entrapta?"

"Nah," Entrapta replied with a shake of her head. "You two go ahead. I'm going to get started on the next batch of Robots."

"Suit yourself," Catra said with a shrug. "Let's go, Scorpia."

While Entrapta turned back to her work and Scorpia hurried to open the door, Catra peeled the gloves off her hands, turning them inside out as she did so. As the latex folded over itself, it concealed the pills that were still in Catra's palm. She could already feel the phantom of relief as she tucked the illicit package into her pocket and followed Scorpia out into the day.

*

Catra didn't realize how hungry she was until she had a bodega sandwich in her belly. She and Scorpia meandered through the streets as they finished their lunch, taking their time on their way back to the storage locker. Catra sipped at her bottled water and only half-listened as Scorpia blabbered on about whatever. She was too preoccupied with the small package in her pocket and counting the seconds until she could sneak one of those little hits of euphoria in peace. The fatigue was starting to catch up with her.

"Uh oh," Scorpia said as they arrived at an intersection. She gestured down the street to their right where a small crowd was gathered around an ambulance. "That doesn't look good."

A morbid curiosity whispered at the edge of Catra's mind. "Let's check it out."

They made their way toward the scene, craning their necks to get a better look at whatever was going on. But as Catra scanned the crowd she was distracted by a familiar face loitering just along the fringes.

"Razz?" she exclaimed. A small old woman with long, unkempt hair turned and peered up at her through a thick set of rose colored glasses.

"Catra, dearie! Is that you?"

Despite Catra's steadfast "no touching" policy, she let the woman take her hand and give it a feeble squeeze. "I haven't seen you in years, Razz. How've you been?"

"Ha!" Razz let out a raspy bark of laughter. "I'll bet you thought old Razz was dead, didn't you, dearie?" She adjusted her glasses and squinted up at Scorpia. "Hmm, you're not Adora."

Catra's stomach dropped and Scorpia chuckled nervously.

"This is Scorpia," Catra said, hoping that if she kept talking she wouldn't have to hear that name again. "Scorpia, this is Razz. I've known her forever. She was kind of like an auntie to all of us Horde kids."

Razz nodded sadly. "Yes, and I was heartbroken when I heard about the raid. Those poor children." She reached up to cup Catra's face between her knobby hands. "And you! A grown woman now. But you look like shit."

"Gee, thanks," Catra mumbled.

"You look like you haven't slept in a month," Razz continued unabated. "You need to take better care of yourself. You—" she jabbed one of her arthritis-ridden fingers toward Scorpia "—make sure this girl takes care of herself!"

A smile tugged at the corner of Scorpia's lips. "Believe me, I'm tryin'."

Face burning, Catra pulled back from Razz's grasp and changed the subject. "Anyway, what's this all about?" She gestured to the ambulance and Razz sighed.

"That terrible Runestone has taken another soul from the streets," she said, shaking her head. At that moment, a member of the crowd shifted just enough for Catra to catch a glimpse of a woman laying on the ground. She barely had time to register the ghostly pallor of the woman's skin before she was swallowed by a body bag.

Catra could feel Scorpia's eyes on her as she kept her own locked on the scene. The crowd was waved back so the paramedics could raise the gurney and wheel the corpse into the ambulance. A wave of nausea rolled through Catra's stomach, and she had to force herself to look away.

"Are you sure it was an overdose?" she asked.

"I've seen Runestone take enough lives at this point." Razz scowled. "It's the same every time. But does the city do anything to help? Of course not! They don't care that people on the streets are dying. They don't care about us at all."

You've got that right, Catra thought darkly. A feeling of lightheadedness swept over her, and she was about to make an excuse to leave when Razz grasped her hand once more. This time, the old woman's grip was surprisingly strong.

"But people do care about her," Razz said motioning toward the ambulance. "Her family needs to know. Will you help me get a message to them, dearie?"

If it was anyone else asking, Catra would have told them to do their own dirty work.

But this was Razz — the street auntie she had grown up fetching cups of herbal tea for so she and… So she could sit at the old woman's side and listen to her wild stories for hours. Catra couldn't say no to her.

So, she nodded. "Sure thing, Razz. Where can we find them?"

Chapter 36

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

*[**Content warnings:** Mentions of death and sex work, on-page drug use. See the end of the chapter for more details. Also: This is a safe, sex positive space. Derogatory comments about sex workers will not be tolerated.]*

Catra and Scorpia stood on the sidewalk, staring up at a three story industrial-looking building.

"This can't be right," Scorpia said, scratching her head and glancing up and down the street. "I'm pretty sure this place is a nightclub. Maybe your friend was confused?"

Razz's directions had led them into a part of the city known for its alternative clubs and bars. It certainly didn't seem like the kind of place where anyone actually lived. Then again, most people would say the same thing about a seemingly abandoned warehouse, so Catra stepped up to the door under an unlit neon sign that read The Crimson Waste, and gave it a few swift kicks. Old as she was, no one knew the streets of Etheria quite like Razz. If this was where she said they needed to go, Catra trusted her.

It took another couple of kicks before someone finally came to the door, wrenching it open with a frustrated yank.

"What the fuck?" the hulking woman who answered shouted. She was just as jacked as Scorpia, with a long white ponytail that spilled down her back. "We're not open, so quit kicking my goddamn establishment you little punk."

Before the door could be slammed in their faces, Catra stepped forward and braced a hand against it.

“We’re here about Goatia,” she said, parroting the phrase Razz told her.

The woman rolled her eyes and stepped aside. “It’s a bit early for that, don’t you think?”

Catra and Scorpia shared a confused glance and the woman grunted, annoyed.

“Whatever floats your boat, ladies.” The woman turned and walked back into the darkened club, waving over her shoulder for her guests to follow. “Lock the door behind you.”

They did as they were told. It took a moment for Catra’s eyes to adjust to the dim lighting after being out in the bright afternoon sunshine, but once they did she was able to take in the cavernous room around her. A well worn dancefloor took up most of the space, with a long bar running across the far wall. There was nothing remarkable about the place; not the handful of booths and high top tables, nor the stage with its raised DJ booth. But what did catch Catra’s attention was a heavy red velvet curtain that hung in one corner.

“Sit,” the woman said, pointing at the closest booth. She didn’t wait to see if her guests did as she commanded. Instead, she strode over to the curtain and pulled it back to reveal a staircase that disappeared upward.

“Trouble!” she shouted up the stairs. “Get your scrawny ass down here!”

A few moments later, Catra heard the sound of light footsteps descending from the floor above. The curtain parted with a dramatic flourish to reveal a tall figure dressed in a silky pink robe with feathers lining the sleeve cuffs and hem. A pair of golden eyes glared.

“Huntara, if you’re going to wake me from my beauty sleep, at least do it with a kiss,” the newcomer snapped. “What’s with all the yelling?”

The woman nodded toward the booth, and the newcomer's expression morphed from irritated to delighted.

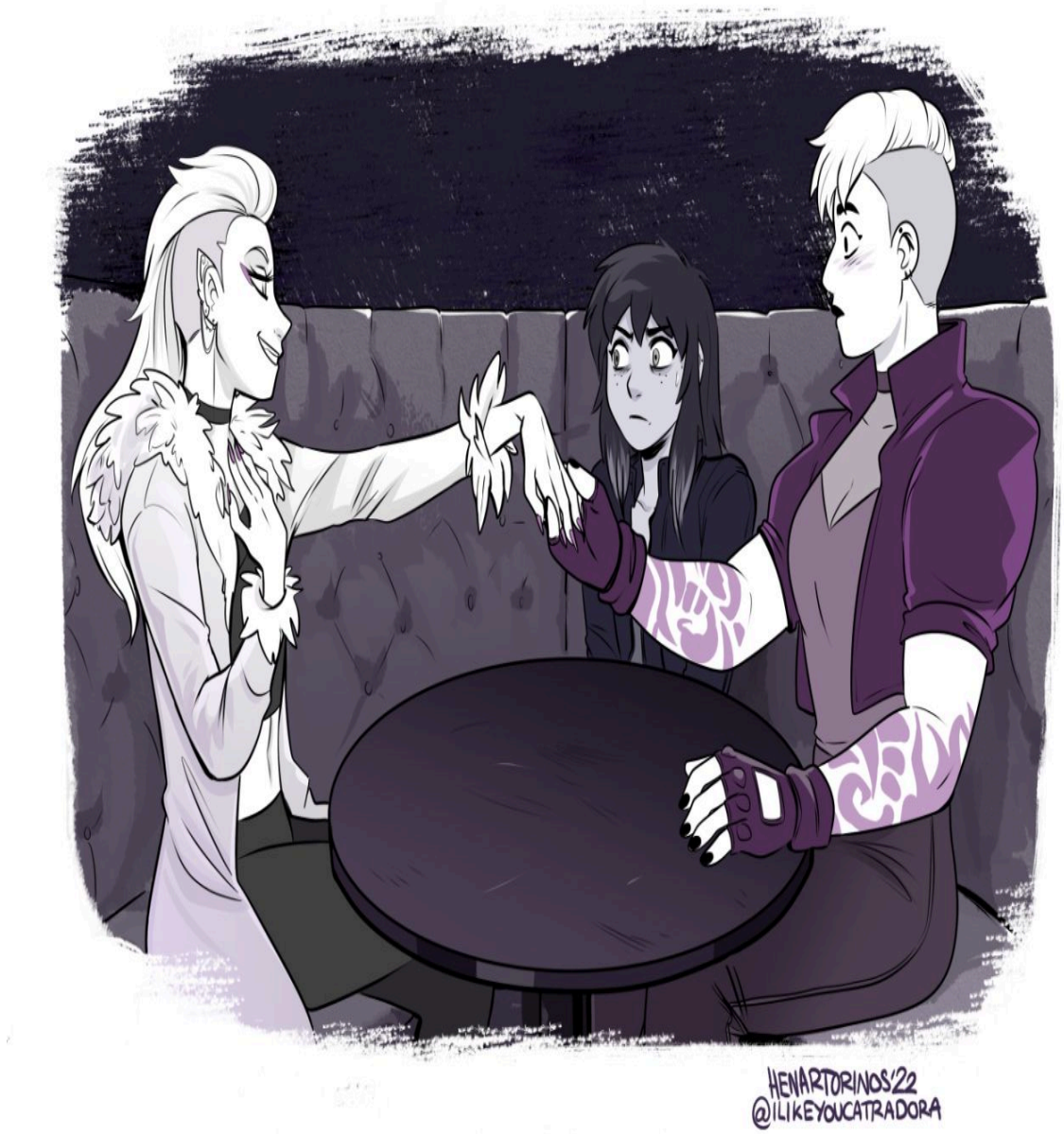
"Well, who do we have here?" they asked, sliding into the booth across from Catra and Scorpia and eyeing them mischievously. "I'm usually appointment-only, but I'd be willing to make an exception for you two."

Catra crossed her arms and sat back, putting a bit more distance between herself and the stranger. This situation just kept getting stranger, and she couldn't quite put her finger on what was going on. "Who are you?"

"Anyone you want me to be, kitten." The stranger winked. They turned their attention to Scorpia, holding their thin hand out to her. "But you darlings can call me Double Trouble."

"Oh!" Scorpia's face flushed. She took Double Trouble's hand and shook it gently. "It's, uh, a pleasure?"

Double Trouble laughed, their voice trilling brightly. "Oh, honey, the pleasure is all mine."



"Okay, that's enough flirting," Catra grumbled, smacking Scorpia's hand down. "We're here about Goatia."

The mirthful look on Double Trouble's face faded. They gave Catra a critical once-over. "What do a couple of Horde gangsters want with one of my squad?"

"Wait, Goatia's her *name*?" Scorpia balked. "I thought it was some kind of code word! What kind of name is Goatia?"

Double Trouble lifted their carefully shaped brows. "No one in the sex business uses their real name, sweetie. Do you think my parents actually called me *Double Trouble*?"

Catra felt the pieces click into place.

"The club is a front for a brothel," she said.

The woman from earlier—the one Double Trouble called Huntara—had been leaning against the table, listening to the conversation in silence. Now, she straightened up and snarled, "The Crimson Waste isn't a front for anything."

"That's right, sweetie." Double Trouble gave Huntara's arm a reassuring pat. "Huntara and I are business partners, thank you very much. I lease the space upstairs so my squad has a safe place to work out of."

Catra grinned. The first inklings of an idea were forming in her mind. "Sounds like you've got quite a unique business model here."

At this, Double Trouble bristled. "Excuse you! Sex work is real work, honey. This is a more legitimate profession than whatever it is you thugs do."

"Hey, I wasn't being facetious," Catra said, raising her hands to show she meant no harm. "I agree with you. This is a good set up — I'm impressed."

Placated slightly, Double Trouble sat back against the vinyl booth seat and eyed Catra warily. "You were asking about Goatia?"

"Right…" Catra glanced up at Scorpia, who looked panicked. She shot her a look of her own that she hoped screamed 'shut up and let me do the talking' before turning back to Double Trouble. "I'm afraid I have some bad news."

Double Trouble stiffened in their seat. "Did she get arrested again?"

Catra shook her head. “She’s dead. I’m sorry.”

The expression that swept across Double Trouble’s face looked caught somewhere between distraught and resigned. “When?” they demanded. “How?”

Out of the corner of her eye, Catra saw Scorpia open her mouth to answer. But before Scorpia could utter a word, Catra grabbed her thigh and gripped it tight.

“It happened today, but I’m not sure how.” The lie came to Catra so easily that she almost believed it herself. “All I know is that, had she been my friend, I would have wanted to know. Razz told us how to find you so we could deliver the news before you found out through the rumor mill.”

With an exhausted sigh, Double Trouble closed their eyes and massaged their temples. “That’s sweet of you, kitten. Thank you.”

Huntara sank down onto the bench seat next to Double Trouble. She looked a little lost as she turned to her business partner. “What do you wanna do?”

“I’m going to have to make some calls,” Double Trouble replied. “See if the others have time to take on some of Goatia’s clients tonight.”

“Can’t you just tell ‘em what happened?” Huntara asked. “I mean, shit, one of your friends just died. The last thing any of you should be doing right now is working *more*.”

Double Trouble let out a sad chuckle. “The show must go on, sweetie. We can’t afford to miss that many appointments in one night.”

Catra’s ears perked up. There it was: the in she had been waiting for.

“Huntara’s right,” she said, her voice dripping with false-sympathy. “The only thing you should be doing right now is grieving. And if

it’s money you’re worried about, I think I have an idea that could help us both out.”

Huntara replied with a grunt, which Catra took as an invitation to keep talking.

“We’re looking for someone to distribute our new product,” Catra explained. “It’s twice as strong as Runestone, so the price tag is higher too. We see it appealing to a, let’s say, higher clientele than usual.”

“That’s your idea?” Huntara said, glowering darkly at Catra. “You want me to let you sell your new drug at my club?”

“Of course not,” Catra replied. “I’m saying *you* should sell it at your club. Buy the product straight from the source and mark up the price however you see fit. Think about it — people already come to places like this to score Runestone. Why shouldn’t you make a cut?”

Double Trouble and Huntara looked at one another, communicating wordlessly. All the while, Scorpia nudged at Catra’s side, desperately trying to get her attention. Catra ignored her. She felt gross enough about all of this without having to see it in Scorpia’s eyes too. Besides, Catra knew she was too close to sealing this deal to let guilt derail her now.

“Catra…” Scorpia whispered, pouring all of her concern into those two simple syllables.

“I’ll tell you what,” Catra said loudly, drowning Scorpia out. “I’ll even give you exclusive neighborhood distribution.”

This got the business partners’ attention.

“You serious?” Huntara asked skeptically.

“Well, I do have one condition,” Catra conceded.

Double Trouble crossed their arms and frowned. “And what is that?”

Catra licked her lips. Only now did she let herself look up at Scorpia. For reasons she didn’t quite understand, Catra didn’t want her to think she was a complete monster, even if she was starting to second guess it herself.

“You can’t sell it to anyone who works here,” Catra said. “This shit is strong. Keep your friends off it.”

With a sharp smile, Double Trouble extended their hand across the table once more. “You’ve got yourself a deal, kitten.”

Before she and Scorpia left The Crimson Waste, Catra excused herself and slinked off to the bathroom. She had waited as long as she could. Her hands trembled as she pulled the latex glove from her pocket and worked one of the Robots pills free. She dropped it under her tongue, leaned against the chipped sink, and closed her eyes. The popping sensation of the pill dissolving subsided after a moment or two, and Catra felt the drug enter her system. When she opened her eyes, she didn’t recognize the person staring back at her from the mirror. Razz was right: she did look like shit.

But none of that mattered now: she’d just fulfilled her biggest promise to Prime. She deserved the ecstasy that the Runestone—no, the Robots—made her feel, now more than ever.

Buzzing, Catra pulled open the bathroom door only to come face to face with Double Trouble. They leaned languidly against the doorframe, the collar of their feathered robe sliding down one narrow shoulder.

“It’s been a pleasure doing business with you, kitten.” Though they sounded aloof, there was an uncomfortable intensity behind their eyes that made Catra want to get the hell out of there, fast.

“Likewise,” she replied as she attempted to slide by. But before she could escape, she felt Double Trouble’s thin fingers close around her wrist and tug her back.

“A word of advice from one savvy bitch to another,” Double Trouble whispered into Catra’s ear, “getting high on your own supply is never good for business. Be careful, kitten.”

Stunned, Catra couldn’t even think of a reply. But it didn’t matter: Double Trouble released their grip on her wrist and sashayed away without looking back.

Her mind stayed trapped in that moment, even as she and Scorpia hurried away from The Crimson Waste. They had covered several blocks and were cutting down an alley when Scorpia finally stepped into Catra’s path.

“Why did you lie to them?” Scorpia asked. Her voice trembled. “Why didn’t you tell them that Goatia overdosed?”

Catra scoffed and stepped around her partner. “Don’t be stupid, Scorpia. They wouldn’t have agreed to distribute Robots if they knew the truth.”

“Then maybe we shouldn’t have done it,” Scorpia replied. The boldness of her words made Catra freeze mid-stride. “I mean, you don’t actually feel good about this, do you?”

Maybe it was the Robots coursing through her system that made her do it. When the high eventually wore off, Catra would choose to blame the drugs for what she did next.

With a growl rumbling deep in her throat, she whipped around and shoved Scorpia up against the wall hard enough to knock the breath from her lungs. Scorpia’s eyes were wide with shock and, perhaps, a touch of fear as Catra snarled up at her.

“Is this a game to you?” Catra shouted, making Scorpia flinch. “Because in case you haven’t noticed, we’re in a fucking gang. We’re criminals, Scorpia — we’re the bad guys.” Somewhere in the back of her mind, Catra knew she was overreacting. But all the stress and anxiety that usually simmered just below the surface was chemically amplified now, and she couldn’t stop even if she wanted to. She grabbed fistfuls of Scorpia’s vest and slammed her

back again, pinning her speechless partner in place. “Maybe you don’t understand what’s at stake here; if this doesn’t work out, you can always go running back to your mommies and your cushy fucking life. But me? This is all I have, and it’s life or death.”

Breathless, Catra finally released her hold on Scorpia and stepped back.

“It was them or us, Scorpia,” she said. “And I chose us. If you can’t live with that, then get the fuck out of here.”

The heartbroken look of betrayal on Scorpia’s face was more than Catra could bear, so she didn’t wait for a response. She turned away from the last person who seemed to give a shit about her and ran.

Chapter End Notes

CONTENT WARNINGS

- Catra tells Double Trouble that their friend has died
- Double Trouble, who is a sex worker, talks about their role as the head of a consensual brothel
- Catra takes a Runestone/Robots pill; the beginning effects of her high are described
- When confronting Catra, Scorpia mentions the overdose death from chapter 35

Chapter 37

Adora and Glimmer were exhausted.

They had spent hours roaming the streets of Etheria in the late spring heat. It was clear that summer was just around the corner, which only served to remind Adora that time was passing without any progress. It had been a few weeks since word of a new designer drug called Robots hit the mainstream news, and yet the Rebellion was no closer to figuring out where people were getting their hands on it. All Adora knew for sure was that, even though the Horde was still laying low, they certainly weren't slowing down.

"I don't get it," she huffed as she and Glimmer slinked off the bus in defeat. "We've been all over this city and we haven't found a single seller. How is the Horde moving this new drug?"

Looking like a wilted flower, Glimmer sighed. She didn't say anything, which wasn't like her at all. But Adora didn't push her; she knew her friend was just as frustrated as she was. Officially, these reconnaissance missions were meant to ferret out the gang, but Adora saw the way Glimmer's eyes searched every face they passed, every corner of every alley. She was still looking for her mom, and each fruitless search dulled Glimmer's glow a little more.

Hoping to lighten the mood, Adora nudged Glimmer with her elbow. "Hopefully Bow's done helping his brother move by now. What do you want to do this afternoon?"

"I dunno." Glimmer shrugged as they made their way up the path to the house. "I'm kinda tired. I might just take a—"

Before she could finish her thought, the front door flew open. Bow stood at the threshold with Entrapta's tablet in hand and looking ashen. "There you are! Guys, you've got to see—"

He stopped mid-sentence, his eyes flicking over his friends' heads. Adora turned to see what he was looking at just as a police cruiser pulled into the driveway. Her stomach dropped. She could feel Glimmer tense up at her side.

"What the hell..." Glimmer muttered under her breath. It had been a long time since anyone from the E.P.D. checked in with them. It was always a tricky conversation to navigate given that they had to play up their grief over Angella's disappearance, and acting wasn't exactly Adora's strong suit.

The trio closed ranks, clustering close together and eyeing the cruiser warily. Adora braced herself as the car's engine cut, her mind racing through what could be to blame for this unexpected visit. But when the car door opened, all those thoughts fell away until only one question remained.

"Who is that?" Adora whispered as she watched an unfamiliar officer rise from inside her vehicle. She was startlingly tall, with striking features that were framed perfectly by her hijab. Her bright eyes focused, hawk-like, on the friends.


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Glimmer shook her head slowly. "I have no idea."

The woman strode up to the front steps with an almost robotic precision. She gave the friends a polite nod.

"Miss Brightmoon," she said in a soft, airy voice that seemed incongruous with her military-like professionalism. "I am Interim Police Chief Hope." She held out her hand, and while Glimmer cautiously took it in her own, Adora and Bow shared wide-eyed glances with one another.

"I don't remember seeing you around the precinct," Glimmer said, eyeing the woman with obvious distrust..

"That's because I don't work for the E.P.D.," Chief Hope replied. "I've been brought in from First City to oversee operations for the time being." She nodded curtly toward the door. "May we continue this conversation inside?"

"Do we need a lawyer?" Bow blurted out. His shoulders hunched at his ears as he clutched Entrapta's tablet to his chest. "Are we in some kind of trouble?"

Glimmer rounded on him, her eyes wide with incredulity. "Why would we need a lawyer? We didn't do anything wrong."

"No, Bow's right," Adora interjected. "I've always heard that you shouldn't talk to cops without a lawyer."

"We should at least have an adult present, right?" Bow added.

"Technically Adora's an adult," Glimmer said, tapping her chin. "Does that count?"

Adora nodded. "Sure it does. Don't worry, Glimmer — I'll protect you."

Chief Hope cleared her throat. "Perhaps I haven't made myself clear. No one's in trouble. I'm simply here to introduce myself and to give you an update on your mother's case."

Glimmer's face flushed. "Oh, right. Well, in that case..." she stepped aside and gestured toward the door.

They settled onto the couch in the living room, while Chief Hope took a seat in the armchair that Adora had always thought of as Angella's throne. It made Adora's insides turn to see anyone else sitting there; it was an affront to Angella's memory.

But Angella isn't dead, Adora reminded herself as she stared the interim chief down. Stay calm and listen to what this woman has to say.

"So, how exactly does this interim chief gig work?" Glimmer asked. "Is this a trial run to see if you're the right person to replace my mom?"

Chief Hope shook her head. "My position in Etheria is exactly as described: I'm here in a temporary capacity."

Adora was struck by Chief Hope's careful choice of words. Clearly this woman had mastered the art of playing her cards close to the chest. "Why did they bring someone in from another city?" She asked, one part suspicious and one part genuinely curious. "Why not temporarily promote from inside?"

Folding her hands neatly in her lap, Chief Hope lifted her chin and took a moment to look over each of the friends before she spoke. "What do you know about what Chief Brightmoon was working on before her disappearance?"

Adora felt Glimmer tense beside her. Obviously she wasn't the only one who thought the question felt like a trap.

"You'll have to be more specific," Glimmer said coolly. "My mom was the chief of police — she was working on a lot of things."

With a thoughtful hum, Chief Hope turned her unnerving gaze to Adora. "Let's start with her work with the Horde."

Apprehension settled over Adora's shoulders like a heavy coat on a sweltering day. "Angella wasn't working with the Horde," she snapped, perhaps a bit too quickly. "She was trying to bring the Horde down and—" The sensation of Glimmer's fingers digging into her thigh stopped Adora mid-sentence. Glimmer gave an almost imperceptible shake of her head and Adora fell silent.

"With all due respect, ma'am," Glimmer said, her voice cutting, "let's get to the point. Why are you really here?"

Adora looked at her friend with a mixture of pride and surprise. Glimmer had always been the sort of person to rush in first and ask questions later. But losing her mother—even if only temporarily—seemed to have inspired Glimmer to slow down a little and let herself play the long game. That didn't mean she'd lost her edge though, and Adora was glad about that.

Chief Hope didn't react to Glimmer's hostility. She tipped her head and considered the question for a moment.

"I won't lie, I'm surprised by your resistance," she said at last, her stare just as unwavering as always. "Given the circumstances, I thought you would be open to working together."

Glimmer crossed her arms and glared. "Listen, I'm not going to let you use my missing mother to guilt me into helping you. We know there are moles in the E.P.D. and for all we know, you're one of them."

"Ah," Chief Hope nodded slowly. "Does this have something to do with the criminal investigation your mother launched against Sargeant Lashor?"

Adora's breath hitched. From the other side of the couch, Bow let out a small whine of discomfort. They hadn't heard anything about Sargeant Lashor since the day Shadow Weaver turned herself in. Not knowing what had happened with him—or how Catra played into it—had driven Adora nuts. But Angella wouldn't talk about it; she hadn't even mentioned the investigation. It took

every ounce of self-control that Adora had not to pepper Chief Hope with her many unanswered questions.

Apparently the Best Friends Squad's silence was enough for Chief Hope. She sighed. "Very well then. If that's the case, I understand your reluctance to be forthcoming. As a show of good faith, I'll be honest with you: I'm aware of your mother's personal investigation into the corruption within her force. In fact, her work is the reason I'm here."

"Why you?" Glimmer asked, looking Chief Hope over as if she was seeing her again for the first time. "And how do you know about all of this?"

"Your mother and I trained at the academy together," Chief Hope explained. "I think we recognized the ambition in one another right away. We became friends, and we stayed in touch over the years. When she started uncovering how pervasive the corruption in her office was, she reached out to me as a confidant." She paused. Her eyes flicked to a framed family portrait that sat on the mantel, and for the first time, her expression softened. "The work was dangerous, and Angella knew it. She asked me to step in if anything happened to her, and I agreed."

Out of the corner of her eye, Adora watched Glimmer's reaction. Her friend's lips pursed, and her eyes shimmered, but she stayed stoic even as Bow wrapped an arm around her shoulder. Adora placed a hand on Glimmer's knee, and Glimmer covered it with her own.

Suddenly, Chief Hope rose to her feet. "I want you to know that your mother's mission is my own: I am just as dedicated to ending the Horde's control over this city as she was. I don't blame you for caution, but I do believe that, in time, you'll come to find that we are on the same side."

"Thank you," Glimmer said as she got up from the couch. Standing next to Chief Hope, she looked even younger than she already was. "I'll walk you out."

Adora and Bow waited for their friend to return, neither of them speaking as they listened to the sounds of Chief Hope's boots moving across the tiled floor and the front door opening, then closing again. A moment later, Glimmer hurried back into the living room, her brow furrowed.

"Well, that was weird," she announced. "What do you guys think? Can we trust her?"

"I dunno," Bow replied, drumming his fingers across the surface of Entrapta's tablet. "But if she's telling the truth, it would be handy to have someone in the force on our side again."

"I wish we could get our hands on your mom's work without having to cooperate with the police," Adora said. Her mind was racing through one possible scenario after another. "I really want to know what they have on Lashor."

At this, Bow cleared his throat. The girls turned to him in unison and found him staring down at the tablet on his lap. He chewed his bottom lip nervously as he lifted his gaze to meet them. "Actually, I think I might have an idea, but you're not going to like it."

It felt as though a jolt of electricity ran from the tip of Adora's toes all the way to the poof of hair on her head. She sat up at attention. "Oh my god. You got into Entrapta's tablet, didn't you?"

"Bow!" Glimmer squawked. "Why didn't you say something earlier?"

"I was literally in the middle of trying when Chief Hope showed up." Bow's cheeks flushed as he clutched the tablet against his chest. "There's a lot of stuff on here..." he hesitated. He looked at Adora with pity in his eyes. "Including a folder full of initiation videos."

Adora's blood turned icy in her veins. Her mind scrambled back in time. She didn't remember anyone recording as she laid that final,

devastating blow to Seahawk the night she officially became a Force Captain.

"I didn't know there were videos," she said quietly, her mouth suddenly dry. "Did— did you watch mine?"

Bow shook his head. "Actually, yours isn't here. But Catra's is."

As if by instinct, Adora grabbed the tablet and tried to wrench it from Bow's grip. "Let me see."

"Adora, wait!" Bow scrambled back, holding the tablet out of her reach. "I need you to listen to me first."

Huffing, Adora sat back and folded her arms. She fidgeted restlessly. "Okay, fine."

"You're making me nervous, Bow," Glimmer said as she sat back down at Adora's side.

Sighing, Bow woke the tablet and tapped a series of keys into the password field. The screen flashed to an open folder full of video files. "I just want you to know that this isn't easy to watch. I could tell you what happens if you'd rather not—"

"No," Adora said, cutting him off. Her stomach was in knots and her heart hammered. No, she didn't want to watch her former-best friend go through something terrible, but she felt like she had to. Whatever was on that video was her fault; it was the result of her own failure to save the girl she'd loved. For that, Adora felt like she owed it to Catra to bear witness to whatever the Horde had made her do. "I left her behind, Bow. I need to know—"

Glimmer's hands settled onto Adora's shoulders, and she gave her friend a reassuring squeeze. "It's okay, Adora. We get it. Whatever it is, Bow and I are here for you."

"Thanks, Glimmer," Adora said, her voice shaking ever so slightly. She turned back to Bow and reached for the tablet. "I'm ready."

Bow grimaced and pulled up a video onto the screen. A double bed with a dingy comforter in a dimly lit room filled the first frame. Adora felt light-headed at the sight of it.

Oh, Catra, she thought as she reached her trembling hand out to press play. What did they do to you?

***

Author's note: A huge thank you to lightinna_ and sunsetsketchez on Instagram, who graciously helped us with Light Hope's design in this chapter. Please go give them both a follow!

Chapter 38

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

[CONTENT WARNING: This chapter contains scenes depicting police activity, panic attacks, and drug (mis)use. Reader discretion is advised. Please see the bottom of the chapter for specific content details.]

Catra hadn't slept in days.

Exactly how many days, she couldn't be sure. After a while the sunsets and sunrises all started to blend together. But there was so much work to do. Catra couldn't have slept if she wanted to.

So maybe it was a good thing that the nightmares had gotten worse. It seemed like every time she dozed off, Catra found herself back in a moment she wished she could forget. Face down on a crate as Shadow Weaver's switch bit into her skin. Fighting for her life in a cheap motel room. Watching helplessly as the girl she loved abandoned her again and again, like a shitty song stuck on repeat. Catra couldn't understand why her mind insisted on bringing her worst days back to her. Then again, it's not like she had a lot of good memories to choose from instead. Maybe her subconscious was just working with what it had.

Sleep had become the enemy just as Catra's grand plan started to take off. As expected, it hadn't taken long for people to realize the Runestone they were used to just wasn't cutting it anymore. Using The Crimson Waste to move Robots to higher-paying customers had been a stroke of genius. The Horde was back in business in a very big way.

All of this should have been a good thing. Catra had delivered exactly what she'd promised. And yet, it never seemed to be enough. Nearly every day she was fielding calls from Prime demanding more. At this point, just the sensation of her phone

vibrating in her pocket was enough to send Catra's anxiety skyrocketing. She'd had to talk herself out of chucking her expensive electronic tether into the river more than once.

At this point, the only thing that brought any comfort at all were those little magenta pills.

It was Robots that helped sustain Catra through the long, sleepless nights.

It was Robots that gave her the stamina to keep pushing through the stress of Prime's endless demands.

And it was Robots that lied to her, whispering sweetly that everything was going to be okay.

It was Robots that occupied Catra's mind late one Saturday night as she paced in her apartment alone. She was getting used to spending what little free time she had that way, holed up by herself with nothing but her thoughts for company.

Things between her and Scorpia had been strained since their first visit to the Crimson Waste. Scorpia's usual bubbliness had been replaced by something distant and wary. Now, instead of greeting Catra with a dazzling grin, Scorpia's lips only twitched into an unconvincing half-smile. Her gaze seemed to waver between cautious and pity, and Catra couldn't stand it.

Still, Catra caught herself reaching for her phone, intending to text Scorpia and see what she was up to. She was surprised to find herself longing for those nights back at the old hotel, when she and Scorpia wrapped up a shift and returned to her tiny room to gorge on Chinese take-out and get drunk on cheap beer. It all felt like a lifetime ago now. Catra gave her head a shake and pulled her hand back. She didn't need Scorpia's pity, and Scorpia didn't need to share in the hellish burden that Catra's life had become.

Alone and feeling sorry for herself, Catra was about to get high when her phone buzzed.

“Can’t I get one fucking night off?” she grumbled as she fished it out of her jeans, fully expecting to see *UNKNOWN CALLER* flashing on the screen — a sure sign that Prime was waiting on the other end of the line. Instead, she was met with a photo of Double Trouble blowing a kiss. They’d assigned it to their contact details when Catra asked them to save their number in her phone. She blinked down at the picture, confused. The two of them had texted before, but they’d never called one another.

Catra answered the phone and put the call on speaker. “Double Trouble? Why are you—”

“No time for chit-chat, kitten.” Double Trouble’s voice was hushed but urgent. They sounded out of breath. “We’ve got a problem.”

Panic surged through Catra’s veins. “What kind of problem?”

“A police problem. One sec—” Shouting voices could be heard in the background from Double Trouble’s end of the line. Catra held her breath and listened to the rustling of motion. After what felt like hours, Double Trouble spoke again. “They’re raiding the Waste.”

“What??” Catra shouted, dizzy with disbelief.

“Hey, don’t shoot the messenger,” Double Trouble replied. “I thought you said these guys were in the Horde’s pocket. Did you set us up?”

Snatching her helmet and keys, Catra dashed from her apartment. “Of course not! Where are you right now?”

“I managed to sneak out at the first sign of trouble. I’m across the street watching this shit show go down.”

“Okay,” Catra said as she hammered the elevator button. “Stay put and stay out of sight. I’ll be there in a minute.”

Even at this late hour, the streets of Etheria were still somehow busy. With her mind racing, Catra wove her motorcycle between

cars like the rules didn't apply to her, earning more than a few angry honks in the process. She flipped the city off and sped away.

She made it to the entertainment district in record time and navigated her bike down an alleyway on the opposite side of the street from the club. Cutting the engine, Catra darted down the darkened alley until she found a break between the buildings to sneak through. The flashing red and blue lights of police cruisers bounced off the walls, disorienting Catra for a moment until her eyes caught sight of a tall, thin silhouette standing in the intermittent dark.

Catra slid up next to Double Trouble and followed their gaze toward the chaos. The Crimson Waste was crawling with cops. The doors were flung open and party-goers were being ushered out onto the sidewalk where they were corralled like cattle. Another group stood clustered between two cruisers, their shoulders draped with blankets and robes. Catra looked from them to Double Trouble; she didn't need to ask to know that these were their people. The whole scene evoked flashbacks of the day Catra watched the police drag her friends out of the warehouse and forcefully dismantle the only family she'd ever known. Fury burned at the pit of her stomach as her hands curled into tight fists, nails biting into the soft flesh of her palms.

"They got Huntara," Double Trouble said at last. They cut a cold glare down at Catra. "How did this happen?"

"I don't know yet," Catra replied as her eyes flicked from one uniformed officer to the next. With each unfamiliar face she saw, a creeping sense of unease grew stronger. Something wasn't right here. At last, she spotted someone she knew: a beat cop by the name of deputy Cobalt. "But I'm going to find out. Stay here."

Clutching her helmet like a weapon, Catra strode across the street and up to the edge of the police barricade where Cobalt was talking into his radio. She gave a quick, sharp whistle—the way

one might call for a dog—to get his attention. His brow furrowed when he spotted her, and he shook his head.

"Don't make me come over there," Catra said, just loud enough for him to hear. "Because you know I will."

Deputy Cobalt's cheeks flushed as he scampered over, casting nervous glances back at his colleagues.

"You shouldn't be here, kid," he hissed.

"Neither should you!" Catra replied. "What the fuck is going on, Cobalt? Who ordered the raid?"

Eyes darting, Cobalt jutted his chin toward an officer who stood questioning one of the club's patrons. She was a towering, imposing woman with an obvious air of authority. A pair of bright eyes peered out from beneath her hijab, taking in everything at the same time. On her sleeve, Catra noticed an unfamiliar insignia.

"F.C.P.D.?" Catra read aloud. "Who are they?"

"First City," Cobalt answered, keeping his voice low. "The brass brought in outside help. Sorry, kid, but we're not calling the shots anymore."

The world seemed to spin. Catra opened her mouth to argue, but she couldn't think of anything to say. She glanced back toward the alley where Double Trouble peeked back at her from the shadows. Her mouth went dry. "Where's the club owner? You can still help drop bail, right?"

"Not a chance," Cobalt replied. Catra noticed that he was gradually creeping away from her, as if she carried a plague that he was trying to avoid. "The new chief isn't messing around, kid. If I were you, I'd make myself scarce for a while." With that parting piece of unsolicited advice, the deputy turned back to the club and disappeared into the crowd. Catra blinked at the space

he left behind, stunned. She took a beat to collect herself before retreating back to Double Trouble.

“Well?” they asked.

Catra hesitated. “Do you have somewhere safe to go tonight?”

Double Trouble straightened up, their posture suddenly rigid. “Why?”

“This mess is going to take a little while to sort out,” Catra explained, coming dangerously close to making a promise she couldn’t keep. “In the meantime, you should probably lay low.”

For a moment, Double Trouble didn’t say anything. But they didn’t need to — the sharpness of their glare seemed to say more than words possibly could. Catra felt microscopic.

“Did I make a mistake in trusting you?” Double Trouble asked at last.

The question pierced Catra like a dagger. “No! You can trust me. This is just a hiccup — an occupational hazard. Just leave it with me. I’ll get everything figured out.”

With a shake of their head, Double Trouble looked back at chaos as they clutched their robe tightly around their slender shoulders. “You talk a good game, kitten, but I don’t think you’re cut out for this shit.”

“What?” Catra snapped, recoiling as though she’d been slapped. “You don’t know me! This is just a fuck up — I can fix it.”

“I’m not talking about this—” Double Trouble gestured toward the raid “—I’m talking about you. Pretending to be something I’m not is part of my job, so I know it when I see it.” They turned to Catra and laid a single finger at the center of her chest. “And your heart isn’t in it.”

“Fuck you,” Catra snarled. “I know what I’m doing.”

Double Trouble gave her a pitying smile. “I know you do, baby. But is it what you *want* to be doing?”

The question left Catra speechless. She gaped up at Double Trouble, unable to think of a come-back — unable to think of anything, even as Double Trouble patted her softly on the cheek.

“Just something to think about,” Double Trouble said as they turned away and slinked off into the shadows. Catra stared after them, half-believing that they would reemerge any second and take her with them. It took a moment for her feelings to catch up with her, but when they did, the weight of them was agonizing.

Fear.

Confusion.

Helplessness.

She hated all of it.

In her pocket, Catra felt her phone buzz. She pulled it out in a daze and cringed at the sight of *UNKNOWN CALLER* on the screen. Prime. No doubt he’d already heard about the raid. He would want answers — answers Catra couldn’t give him. Or rather, answers she didn’t want to give him until she knew how to clean up this mess. Against all better judgment, Catra slid the phone back into her pocket unanswered, returned to her bike, and headed for home.

By the time she stepped off the elevator and onto her floor, Catra’s mind was nothing more than white noise. She’d missed two more calls from Prime on the ride, so she turned the phone off completely. A bad idea? Sure. But at this point she’d do anything for a moment of silence. She just needed to come up with a plan.

But as she rounded the corner to her apartment door, all hope for that moment of silence fell away. There, standing outside her door, was Scorpia and Entrapta, and they looked worried.

“There you are!” Entrapta cried, far too loud for such a late hour. “Where have you been?”

“None of your business,” Catra snapped back as she shoved between them to unlock her apartment door. “What are you two doing here?”

“We have a problem,” Entrapta said. She was clinging tightly to the new tablet she’d gotten to replace the one that was lost in the fire.

Catra groaned. That was the second time she’d heard those words tonight, and she didn’t have the capacity to deal with another crisis. “So do I,” she said, sliding into her apartment without leaving enough space for the others to follow. “So you’re going to have to figure this one out on your own.”

She shoved the door, but Scorpia caught it before Catra could slam it shut.

“No, Catra,” Scorpia said, her voice as steady as her hand. The sound of her real name on Scorpia’s lips sounded foreign to Catra’s ears. She was so used to Scorpia calling her Wildcat that anything else felt wrong. “This is important. You can’t keep ignoring us.”

Scorpia didn’t wait for a reply. She gently pushed past Catra with Entrapta at her heels. Catra swore and slammed the door closed.

As she followed Scorpia and Entrapta into the living room, it dawned on Catra that this was the first time she’d had them both over. Why, she wondered, hadn’t she done this before? Maybe it would have been nice to have company under better circumstances. But Catra also knew better than that; she didn’t get to have a life filled with things like friends and idle chit-chat. Her life was nothing more than bad news heaped on top of trouble and, judging by the grim expression on Scorpia’s and Entrapta’s faces, whatever had brought them to her apartment in the middle of the night was likely to be a bit of both.

“Well?’ she snarled, her foot tapping with agitation. “Spit it out already. I don’t have all night.”

Entrapta looked to Scorpia, who gave her a reassuring nod. “Someone hacked our system.”

It took a moment for her words to sink in. Catra blinked. “Someone *what*?”

“I got an alert earlier today letting me know that another device had logged in,” Entrapta explained as she held up her tablet to show Catra the screen. On it was an access log that showed which devices had logged into the Horde’s system and when. Most of the entries were listed as “Darla”, the name Entrapta had assigned to her new tablet after her old one, “Dryl”, was destroyed. Prime’s device was scattered throughout the list as well.

But haunting the top of the list like a digital ghost, was a login from Dryl.

“Isn’t that your old tablet?” Catra asked.

“Exactly,” Entrapta replied. She looked worried—almost afraid—but Catra didn’t understand why.

“Couldn’t that just be a glitch? Nothing survived that fire, and you said yourself that the tablet’s been offline ever since.”

“I was really hoping it was a glitch too,” Entrapta said, shaking her head. “But this is Dryl’s device signature, so it’s not an account issue. So, I pulled up its activity log to see if it was a phantom login but it’s not.” She tapped rapidly on the tablet screen until she pulled up another log. This one showed lines of activity that seemed to be populating in real time.

Frustrated, Catra pinched the bridge of her nose. “Oh my god, just get to the point!”

In response, Entrapta shoved the tablet into her face. “Someone is actively using the tablet right now! All this data? This shows

what files are being accessed—and worse—what's being copied to an external device."

Now the gravity of the situation was starting to make sense. Catra felt her stomach bottom out. "Can't you stop it? Like, lock it out or something?"

"I'm working on it," Entrapta said. "But Dryl has the highest level of permissions of any on the system, so I'm having to build a workaround. It's going to take some time."

Catra let out an exasperated growl as she dragged her fingers over her scalp and through her hair. She didn't need this — not today of all days. "How the fuck did this happen? How can someone be using a melted piece of tech to hack our system?"

"Well…" Entrapta shifted on her feet, suddenly looking incredibly uncomfortable, "if someone's using it, then obviously it wasn't destroyed. Which means…" She trailed off without finishing her thought. Her hesitance only fanned the fire of Catra's frustration. She opened her mouth, ready to let forth a slew of profanities, but Scorpia spoke first.

"It means that someone got their hands on the tablet before the fire," Scorpia said. "And if it wasn't us, then there are only three other people who could have grabbed it."

Catra froze.

Three other people. The only other people in the building, aside from the Horde's doomed captive.

Bow.

Glimmer.

And Adora.

"No." Catra's voice cracked. The flames that had been raging inside of her only seconds earlier were doused in a frigid tidal

wave of fear. “No, no, no.”

Scorpia sighed. Cautiously, she reached out and laid her hand on Catra’s shoulder. “I’m sorry, Catra.”

Catra didn’t hear her. All she felt was the weight of Scorpia’s hand on her shoulder, and it felt like one more boulder stacked on top of the mountain of other things that had gone wrong that day. It was too much, and under the pressure, Catra broke.

She screamed, a furious guttural sound that made both Scorpia and Entrapta jump back from her in surprise.

“How could you let this happen?” Catra shouted. Her head was pounding. She couldn’t seem to pull in a complete breath. “How can you two be so fucking useless?” She rounded on Entrapta, pointing a sharp finger in her direction as she stalked up to her with a menacing snarl. “Aren’t you supposed to be some kind of genius? How the hell did a bunch of teenagers hack into your system? Do you have any idea what you’ve done?”

“Woah, Catra!” Scorpia cried as she jumped in between them. “This isn’t her fault. All of us thought the tablet had been destroyed. This isn’t Entrapta’s fault.”

Catra stepped into Scorpia’s space and grabbed fistfuls of her vest in her quaking hands. “Then who’s fault is it, huh? Because you know who’s going to take the blame for this, right? If Prime is willing to put his own brother into traction, what do you think he’s going to do to me?”

Scorpia blanched. She cupped Catra’s hands with her own and held on tight. “We won’t let that happen to you. We’ll figure something out, I prom—”

“No!” Catra shoved Scorpia away with such force that the towering woman nearly fell backward. “Don’t make me promises when you know you can’t keep them. No one ever does.” She whirled around, turning her back on them both. “Get the fuck out of here. Just leave me alone.”

She stormed into her bedroom and slammed the door behind her. There, in the privacy of her room, Catra crumbled. Consumed by blind panic, she sank to the floor and struggled to catch her breath. In less than 24 hours, everything she had fought to build had come crashing down around her. As soon as Prime found out just how spectacularly she'd fucked up, she'd be lucky if she wound up dead. But, knowing Prime, he would find a way to make her punishment much, much worse. Catra pressed her hands over her mouth to muffle the sound of her frantic sobs. She had never felt so out of control in her entire life.

"I've gotta figure this out," she whispered to herself as she crawled to her night stand to where she kept an old mint tin that now housed her stash of Robots. It took her trembling hands a couple of tries to pop the lid, and when it finally opened the pills jostled from the tin and clattered onto the floor. Catra plucked one from the ground and swallowed it dry. She closed her eyes and waited for the drug to work its magic.

There was a knock at the door.

"Catra?" Scorpia called from the other side. "Can I come in?"

Another wave of panic surged through Catra's body, drowning out any inkling relief that the Robots provided. Why was it taking so long? She needed it to work — if she had to spend another minute feeling this way, Catra was certain she would die.

"Are you fucking deaf?" she shouted back at Scorpia as she fumbled to collect the scattered pills. "I told you to go away!"

Her eyes dropped to the couple of doses she had collected in her sweaty palm. Even Robots seemed to be letting her down today. Her dependance on that little bit of magenta magic had finally caught up to her. It seemed like a cruel joke that she would develop a tolerance to it; the same lie she'd peddled to customers about Runestone to trick them into switching in the first place.

Scorpia knocked again.

“Fuck it,” Catra said. She opened her mouth and tossed the pills in.

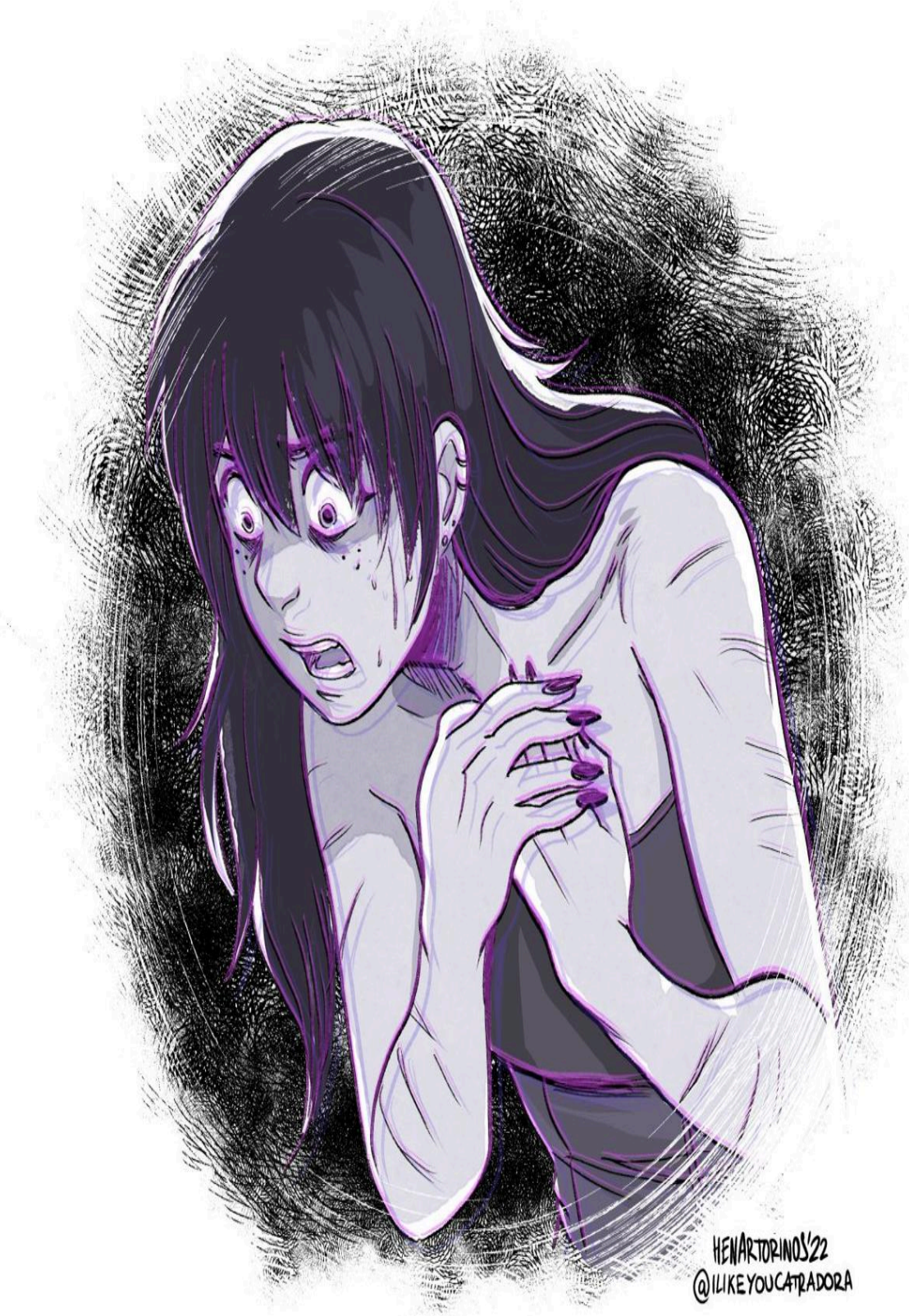
Still shaking, she pulled herself onto her bed. She sat on the edge of the mattress and waited for relief as she tried desperately to tune out the sound of Scorpia’s persistent knocking.

“C’mon, Wildcat,” Scorpia said. “We can figure this out.”

Catra opened her mouth to scream at Scorpia to fuck off, but nothing came out. Her throat felt tight, constricted the way it was the day Hordak wrapped his fingers around her neck and squeezed. She took a breath, but her lungs stayed empty.

Fiery pain radiated from Catra’s chest, as if her heart had burst into a ball of flames and was burning its way out of her. Her panic attacks had never felt like this before, nor had her highs.

Something was wrong.


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It seemed to take every ounce of strength she had to get up off the bed. But standing turned out to be a terrible idea; the world around Catra spun into a dizzying blur, and before she could take a single step her legs gave out beneath her. She crashed to the ground like a stone, her forehead striking the floor with a sickening crack. But any pain she may have felt from the fall was upstaged by her blazing heart and an intense stabbing sensation in her stomach. Even her lifetime of injury and misery didn't compare to the hurt she was suffering now.

"Catra?" Scorpia's voice was tight with worry. "What was that sound? Are you okay?"

The world was a blur, and Catra's limbs refused to do anything other than tremble violently.

A dense fog crept in from the corners of Catra's consciousness. She barely registered the sound of the doorknob turning.

"Y'know what, I don't care if it makes you mad," Scorpia's voice sounded to Catra like it was being blasted through a wall of speakers. "I'm coming in."

Light spilled in from the hallway.

Catra heard Scorpia gasp.

There was some shouting.

And then, nothing.

Chapter End Notes

CONTENT WARNINGS:
— The police raid The Crimson Waste. There is no violence or arrests made on page, but arrests are implied and discussed
— Catra experiences a panic attack. Her symptoms are described on page.
— Catra uses Robots and accidentally overdoses. Her

symptoms are described on page. (Don't worry — she'll be ok!)

Chapter 39

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

[Content warning: This chapter includes reference to sexual assault and drug overdose. Please see the end of the chapter for specific content references and take care while reading.]

Adora was pissed.

She was also scared. And stressed too.

She was feeling so many things at once, and because of Glimmer and Bow, there was nothing she could do about any of it. Deep down, under all of the fury and fear, Adora knew that her friends were just trying to help when they refused to let her take off into the city on her own. She knew they were right when they said that trying to find Catra now wasn't going to change anything: it wouldn't undo what Adora had seen in that video, nor would it close the chasm that yawned between them.

But maybe, Adora thought, it could be the first step toward something—anything—better than where they were now.

To make sure Adora didn't sneak away on some ill-conceived rescue mission, Glimmer and Bow had insisted on a good ol' fashioned Best Friend Squad sleepover in Adora's room. But if the idea was to keep an eye on her, Adora's friends had already failed. She lay in the middle of her bed, with Glimmer curled into her left side and Bow snoring loudly on her right. The soft glow of Bow's laptop screen reached out from where he had tucked it under the bed. Knowing that it was only a matter of time before Entrapta realized they had hacked into the Horde's network, he left his computer running in an attempt to copy as many files as possible before he was inevitably kicked out. From where she lay, Adora could hear the devices whirring without stopping; they sounded the way her brain felt.

It had been wishful thinking on Glimmer's part to think Adora would be able to sleep. How was Adora supposed to do anything other than fixate on every gut-churning moment of Catra's initiation video? In her mind, she saw everything in torturous detail: Lashor's meaty hand gripping Catra's clenched jaw, the horror in her eyes as he took her by the hips and shoved her back onto the bed. Adora could pinpoint the moment when Catra realized what was about to happen, and no matter how hard she tried, Adora couldn't scrub that helpless expression from her memory. Even knowing that Catra managed to escape her fate (because if anyone could get out of a situation like that, it would be Catra) didn't bring Adora any comfort. She made herself nauseous thinking about what would have happened if Catra hadn't fought back. She wondered how deeply the events of that night had colored every moment of Catra's life that came after it.

Did Catra blame Adora for not being there? Would the initiation have been different had Adora stayed?

Would Catra ever be able to forgive her?

After what felt like hours, Adora finally gave up on sleep. She shimmied out from beneath the covers, careful not to disturb her friends. Holding her breath, she crept out of the room and closed the door softly behind her.

Now what? she wondered. A stress headache was mounting beneath her skull. Maybe she would just start with a glass of water and figure out the rest later.

Adora made her way up the stairs and noticed that the kitchen lights were still on. Curious, she sneaked down the hall and peered around a corner. There, seated at the counter in her flowing violet robe, was Castapella. She clutched a mug of tea between her palms and stared at nothing in particular, her gaze unfocused beneath her furrowed brow.

"Casta?" Adora said quietly, startling the woman out of her reverie. "Are you okay?"

“Adora.” Casta let out a breath. She glanced at the clock above the stove. “What are you still doing up?”

Shrugging, Adora slid in the seat next to her. “Can’t sleep.”

Casta hummed to herself. “Are you thinking about your friend again?”

“I haven’t been able to think about anything else.” Adora set her elbows on the countertop and rested her head in her hands. “What I saw in that video… It's why I wanted to get Catra and I out of the Horde in the first place. But I just wound up driving her deeper into everything I wanted to protect her from instead.” She let out a shaky sigh. “How did I screw everything up so badly?”

With a click of her tongue, Casta set her mug down and swiveled in her seat to face her. “May I ask you a question, Adora?” She waited for a consenting nod, then continued. “Why do you think it’s your responsibility to protect your friend?”

The question struck Adora as ludicrous. Why *wouldn’t* it be her responsibility to protect Catra? It’s what they did for each other — it always had been. But when Adora opened her mouth, she found herself struggling to express just how instinctual that urge was.

“Because we look out for each other,” she said at last. “Nothing bad was supposed to happen as long as we had each other.” She could feel the space between her words and breaths grow shorter as her heartbeat quickened, sending liquid guilt pumping through her veins. “And then I left her, and look what happened!”

“Adora, take a breath,” Casta said gently.

Only then did Adora realize she was trembling. So she did as she was told and pulled in a deep lungful of air, holding it for the count of five before releasing it slowly, just like Perfuma taught her. She was getting better at recognizing when she was spiraling out of control, but sometimes she still needed a gentle reminder.

“I’m sorry that you were made to feel like taking care of your friends was your responsibility,” Casta said as she rose from her seat and made a beeline for the kettle. “And I’m sure you did the best you could. Yes, helping the people you care about is noble, but so is helping yourself. From everything you’ve told me, you did everything you could with the tools you had at your disposal. Don’t discredit all of the good you’ve done just because things haven’t worked out the way you hoped they would.”

These little nuggets of wisdom were what Glimmer liked to call Casta’s “truth bombs”. Adora thought it was an accurate description given the way they rocked her to the core. She knew what Casta was saying was true, but that didn’t make it hurt any less.

“I hate feeling like this,” Adora mumbled down at her hands.

“Like what, dear?” Casta asked as she poured a fresh cup of tea for each of them.

Adora had to swallow the hard lump in her throat before answering. “Helpless.”

Casta glanced back and gave her a sympathetic smile. “It’s hard to accept our limitations,” she said as she placed a steaming mug in front of Adora like a peace offering. “Especially when you’re someone who prefers to be in control. But there will always be things in this life that we can’t fix or change, no matter how good our intentions are, or how we try.”

“I know,” Adora groaned. She glared into the aromatic herbal tea in front of her, feeling petulant. “I get it, I really do. But none of that changes the fact that I want Catra to be okay.”

Settling back into her seat, Casta blew lightly across the mouth of her cup. “Trying to support someone who isn’t ready to receive that help rarely works the way we want it to. I know you probably don’t want to hear this, but it sounds like Catra needs to make her

own mistakes right now. Sometimes the kindest thing we can do is leave space for our friends and be patient."

"How am I supposed to leave space for her?' Adora scoffed. "Even if Catra *did* decide to ask for help, I doubt she'd want it from me."

"I wouldn't be so sure about that if I were you."

The sound of Bow's voice took both Adora and Castaspella by surprise. They turned in unison to find Bow and Glimmer standing at the kitchen entrance.

"Maybe she just needs to know that you're here if she needs you," Bow continued with a smile.

Glimmer rubbed the sleep from her eyes.

"We thought you sneaked out," she said through a yawn as she shuffled across the tile floor. She draped her arms around Adora's shoulders and hugged her from behind. "And, as much as I hate to admit it, Bow's right."

"He is?" Adora was shocked. Lying about Angella's death had firmly—and understandably—landed Catra in Glimmer's bad books.

Glimmer straightened up and crossed her arms. "Listen, I may not like Catra, but I know what she means to you. If this is what you need to do to feel okay, then I support you."

"Me too," Bow chimed in.

Adora peered up at them both, her heart aching. "You really think I should talk to her? After everything that's happened?"

"I mean, if you still like her after everything she's done then I guess she must have *some* redeeming qualities," Glimmer replied begrudgingly.

Bow nodded. "Besides, maybe it'll help give you closure. Catra might not be willing to listen to you, but at least this way you'll

know you've done everything you could."

It wasn't the solution that Adora was after. What she really wanted was for Catra to understand that there was a better life out there, if only she was willing to chase it. At this point, Adora didn't even care whether Catra's future was entwined with hers, as long as it meant that Catra was safe. But maybe her friends were right; maybe this was the kindest thing she could do for Catra now.

"Okay," she said, feeling a twinge of hope tugging at her insides. She even let herself smile a little. "That sounds like a plan to me."

"Good," Glimmer said, triggering another yawn. "Does this mean we can go back to sleep now?"

Before Adora could reply, the house shook with a thunderous pounding sound. Everyone froze and stared at one another with wide eyes. The pounding happened again, and this time Adora realized it was coming from the front door.

"Why would someone be knocking on our door in the middle of the night?" Glimmer hissed, clutching Bow's arm so tightly that her knuckles turned white.

Casta scrambled to unlock her phone. "I'll pull up the security feed."

Another round of knocking filled the room, but this time Adora heard something else. She stood up and strained to make out the sound. "Do you guys hear that?"

"Someone's yelling," Bow replied uneasily.

Yes, that's what it was. Different voices, their words muffled through the door but their urgency painfully apparent. Adora inched toward the hallway where she could hear the voices better. Her brain pinged at their familiarity.

“Is that… Entrapta?” she wondered aloud. Without waiting for an answer, she sprinted for the foyer.

“Adoooooraaaa!” the voice wailed frantically.

Yes, it was definitely Entrapta screaming on the other side of the door.

“Open the door already!” boomed a second, deeper voice.

Entrapta and… Scorpia?

Against all better judgment, Adora unlocked the door and threw it open wide. Maybe this was a trap, but at that moment Adora felt ready for anything. She flipped the switch for the front lights. Entrapta and Scorpia winced against the sudden brightness, which illuminated a small, frail-looking figure clutched in Scorpia’s strong arms.

Adora’s stomach plummeted.

“Catra!” she cried as she rushed forward. She took Catra’s face in her hands and was startled by how pale and clammy her skin felt against her palms. There was a nasty looking gash above Catra’s eye that split her eyebrow in two, and her face still bore streaks of blood left behind by a hasty clean-up job. “What happened?”

“She overdosed,” Entrapta said, her expression grim.

“We didn’t know where else to go,” Scorpia said, her words tumbling over each other. “Please, she needs help!”

Adora blinked. She could feel her mouth hanging open. Surely she misheard. “What do you mean she overdosed? Overdosed on *what*?”

“On Runestone, obviously!” Entrapta’s voice soared.

“Stop yelling and get inside!” Castaspella shouted over the chaos. “Glimmer, go get my medical kit. You —” she pointed at Scorpia

"—take her to the bedroom at the end of the hallway."

They formed a frantic procession, moving from the front foyer to the master bedroom like some kind of panicked parade. Adora hurried after Scorpia. Behind her, Entrapta filled everyone in at mach speed.

"Actually, she took Robots, but technically it's the same thing. We're pretty sure she took two, maybe three doses at once. Thankfully she swallowed them instead of letting them dissolve sublingually."

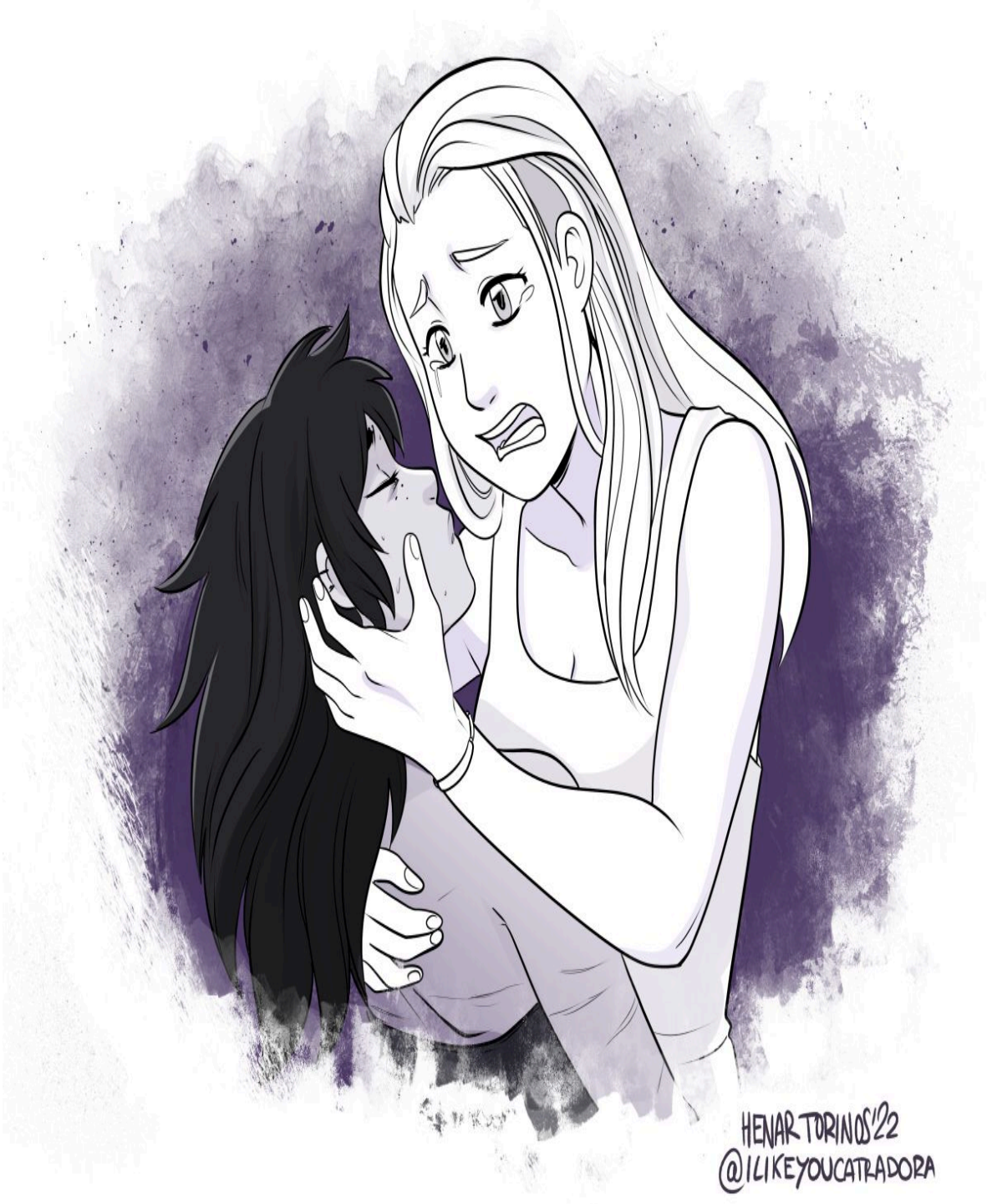
"In that case we'll need to start by purging her stomach," Casta replied, as cool and composed as if she were treating a patient at the hospital.

"We already did," Entrapta said.

Adora's head spun. None of what they were saying made any sense. Catra didn't do drugs — how could she have overdosed on Runestone? Had she been forced to take it?

The moment Scorpia placed Catra down on the bed, Adora shoved her out of the way. She crawled up onto the mattress and crouched over Catra protectively.

"Catra, can you hear me?" she pleaded, brushing Catra's sweat-soaked hair from where it clung to her forehead and cheeks. "Please, open your eyes!"



Glimmer returned with a hard plastic case and handed it to her aunt. Casta set it on the mattress, unlatched the lid, and flung it open to reveal a collection of medical supplies.

"Adora, I need you to leave," Casta said as she plucked a sealed packet from the case and tore it open.

"Are you insane?" Adora snapped, pulling Catra into her arms. "I'm not going anywhere!"

"I'm not asking," Casta replied, her voice firm and commanding. She jutted her chin at Entrapta. "I don't know what your background is but it sounds like you know what you're talking about. You stay. Everyone else needs to get out and let us work."

Adora was conflicted. Instinctively she tightened her hold on Catra's limp and unresponsive body. She had abandoned her once before — she wasn't about to do it again. But the rational part of her brain knew that Catra needed help that she couldn't provide.

"Come on, Adora," Glimmer said, coaxing her from the edge of the bed. "Aunt Casta is a doctor — she knows what she's doing."

At Glimmer's side, Bow held out his hand. Adora knew they were right. She hated it, but she had to trust them. Reluctantly she laid Catra back down. But before letting her friends guide her away, Adora pressed a kiss to Catra's cheek.

"I am *not* giving up on you, Catra," she whispered into Catra's ear. "You're going to be okay, got it?"

In the split-second before she was ushered out of the room, Adora could have swore she saw Catra's eyelashes flutter.

Once everyone was back in the hall, Entrapta slammed the door shut behind them. Numb and speechless, it took Adora a moment to realize that a heated conversation was happening around her.

"Why didn't you take her to the hospital?" Glimmer asked, jabbing an accusatory finger at Scorpia.

"Oh, sure. I bet that would have gone over super well." Scorpia rolled her eyes. "The last thing we need is word of this mess getting back to the cops. Or worse, our boss…"

Bow threw his hands up in disbelief. "I'm pretty sure getting in trouble is better than *dying*!"

Scorpia scowled. “That’s easy for you to say — you don’t know our boss!”

“Okay, but why bring her here?” Glimmer wondered.

“Well, Entrapta and I figured that doctor lady would probably be able to help.” Scorpia shifted awkwardly, her cheeks flushing. She cleared her throat before adding, “We’ve *maybe* been keeping tabs on you guys ever since you burned down our headquarters.”

“That was an accident!” Bow squawked in dismay. Ever the good guy, Bow still harbored a lot of guilt about tossing that fateful molotov cocktail.

Every word grated against Adora’s nerves like sandpaper on a sunburn. There was only one question that mattered right now.

Adora turned to Scorpia and pinned her with a scalding glare.

“How did this happen?” she demanded.

Scorpia hesitated. “You heard Entrapta — she took too much.”

“But *why* was she taking it in the first place?” There was danger in Adora’s voice as she crowded into Scorpia’s space. Startled, Scorpia scrambled back until she bumped against the wall. Adora took another menacing step closer. “How long has Catra been using, Scorpia?”

“I don’t— I’m not sure,” Scorpia stammered. “I don’t know when it started, but I think it’s been going on for a while.”

Anger boiled in the pit of Adora’s stomach. “Then why didn’t you stop her?” she shouted, barely resisting the urge to launch herself at Scorpia fist-first. “Why wasn’t anybody looking after her?”

“Adora, take it easy,” Bow said, stepping between them like a referee. Behind him, Scorpia deflated.

“I tried,” Scorpia said, her voice breaking. “I swear, I’ve tried. But you know how Catra is.”

Adora’s shoulder slumped. She sank back. Yes, she *did* know what Catra was like. If Catra was determined to self-destruct there was no way Scorpia was going to stop her. Hell, Adora probably wouldn’t have fared any better.

Scorpia took a tentative step forward. “Things have been… Well, they haven’t been easy. I knew Catra was struggling, but I didn’t realize…” She trailed off as she lowered her watery gaze to the ground. Adora was surprised to find that she actually felt sorry for her.

For a few moments, no one spoke. The only sound was Scorpia sniffling as she tried, and failed, to hide her weeping. Adora couldn’t even pretend to be angry now. If anyone understood the fear and hopelessness that had brought Scorpia to their door, it was her. Empathy flooded into the space her hatred left behind, and Adora’s heart ached. She reached out and took Scorpia’s hand.

“Come on,” she said, tugging Scorpia toward the kitchen. “I’ll make you some tea while we wait.”

Chapter End Notes

CONTENT WARNINGS:

- Adora reflects on what she saw in Catra's initiation video - text mentions Lashor pushing Catra onto the bed, attempted sexual assault is implied

- Catra is seen on-page post overdose - she is unconscious, and has suffered a cut to her forehead from when she fell

Chapter 40

[CONTENT WARNING: This chapter contains scenes depicting the symptoms of drug withdrawal. Please take care while reading.]

The mood in the Brightmoon home was tense. After four cups of tea were poured, Adora and the others settled around the dining room table and sipped from their mugs in silence. Had Adora been any less preoccupied, she would have found it strange to be sitting across from Scorpia. But the only thing on Adora's mind at that moment was Catra. Not knowing what was happening behind that bedroom door was eating Adora alive from the inside out. Her knee bounced anxiously as she eyed the clock on the wall and agonized over every passing minute.

When their cups were almost empty, Scorpia cleared her throat. The Best Friends Squad looked at her with expressions that varied from surprise to expectant.

"So," Scorpia ventured as her gaze darted furtively to Glimmer, "is that doctor lady related to you or something?"

Glimmer raised an eyebrow at her. "I thought you said you've been spying on us — shouldn't you know that already?"

Blushing, Scorpia let out a nervous laugh. "It's not like we had your place bugged or anything. We just had a few stakeouts, y'know? To be honest, we didn't even do it that often."

We. Adora imagined Catra sitting with Scorpia, watching the house from a car down the street for hours on end. It certainly sounded like something Catra would do. Adora wondered how often Catra had been out there, watching her in secret. She wondered what went through Catra's mind every time she saw her.

"That doesn't make it any less creepy," Glimmer told Scorpia. "But if you must know, Castaspella is my aunt. She's the head of

psychiatry at Mystacor Memorial."

Scorpia's face fell. "She's a shrink? I thought she was a doctor! Will she even know how to—"

"Will you relax?" Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Psychiatrists go to medical school. And thanks to the Runestone epidemic, she has the same overdose intervention training as everyone else at the hospital. Trust me, she knows what she's doing."

"Okay, good. I'm glad…" Scorpia chewed her bottom lip and drummed her fingertips along the outside of her mug. "Does it normally take this long though?"

Adora was wondering the same thing but was too afraid to ask. She turned to Glimmer, but judging by her friend's irritated glare and deep frown, Adora didn't think any of them were going to get an answer. Perhaps Bow sensed the impending meltdown, because he changed the subject.

"Does the gang know where you are?" he asked. "We're not in any danger with you here, are we?"

"Oh, no!" Scorpia waved her hands and shook her head, looking distressed. "Nobody knows we're here."

As if on cue, the doorbell rang. The sound was so unexpected that it made everyone in the small group jump.

"What now?" Glimmer growled as she rose from her seat. From down the hall, Adora heard the master bedroom door open.

"Get that!" Castaspella shouted before slamming it shut again.

Confused, Adora and the others dashed to the front door for the second time that night. This time it was Perfuma they found waiting for them on the steps. Her cloud of blonde hair was pulled back in a messy braid and her eyes were heavy with fatigue. In her hands she clutched a medical transport container.

“Do I want to know why Dr. Brightmoon needed an I.V. kit delivered in the middle of the night?” Perfuma asked, doing very little to hide how annoyed she was to be there.

Before anyone could answer, the bedroom door creaked open again. “Bring it here, Perfuma!” Castaspella bellowed from down the hall. “Quickly!”

Perfuma cast a startled look at everyone before hurrying away to complete her task. Adora followed her like a lost puppy, hoping to get an update or even catch a glimpse of Catra. But Castaspella was ready for her, and she shut Adora out of the room without so much as a word of acknowledgement.

Sighing, Adora slumped against the wall and slid down to the floor. She resolved to wait there all night if she had to. One by one, the others joined her stubborn vigil — Glimmer and Bow sat down at her side while Scorpia settled across from them.

“Who was that?” Scorpia whispered, nodding toward the door. Her dark eyes were wide with curiosity.

“Perfuma,” Glimmer explained as she rubbed her eyes and stifled a yawn. “She’s one of my aunt’s residents.”

Bow offered Glimmer his shoulder, which she snuggled into immediately. “She’s also our therapist,” he said. “She’s super nice. I think you’d really like her.”

About 15 minutes later, the bedroom door finally opened. Adora scrambled to her feet as Castaspella, Entrapta, and Perfuma filed out into the hallway.

“Well? Adora pressed. “How is she?”

“She’s stable,” Castaspella replied — two simple words that nearly brought Adora to her knees. “Ideally I’d like to run some tests to check on her heart and kidneys, but otherwise I think she’s going to be okay.”

“Oh, thank goodness!” Scorpia exclaimed, pulling Entrapta into a bone-crushing hug. “I was so worried!”

Castaspella eyed the two gangsters bitterly. “As you should have been! Do you have any idea how dangerous that drug is?” She gestured to Entrapta, who flinched back. “I can’t believe someone as smart as you is involved in something so monumentally stupid. What a waste of your brilliant mind.” Entrapta’s bottom lip quivered as she hung her head in shame.

As much as Adora wanted to watch Entrapta and Scorpia receive a well-deserved verbal thrashing, she had somewhere more important to be. She made a move toward the bedroom, but Castaspella stepped in to block her path.

“Where do you think you’re going?” Castaspella demanded.

“I need to see her,” Adora replied, trying to squeeze past her.

“What you need to do is let her rest.” Castaspella took Adora by the shoulders. “The next few days are going to be rough on her.”

Adora tensed. “Why? I thought you said she was going to be okay!”

“She will,” Perfuma said in that same assuring tone she used in their therapy sessions, “but she needs to get through a detox period first.”

Castaspella nodded, her expression grim. “Withdrawal is not a pleasant experience, but it’s necessary. We’re going to have to keep a close eye on her until the drug is completely out of her system.”

“Then let me do it,” Adora insisted. She clasped her hands in front of her, ready to beg if that's what was necessary. “I’ll stay with her. Just tell me what I need to do and I’ll do it. Please, just let me see her.”

For a single, horrible moment, Adora was certain that Castaspella wasn't going to budge. But then, the doctor sighed and stepped aside. "Fine. But if she shows any signs of distress, come and get me right away."

Weak with relief, Adora gave Castaspella a hug that might have rivaled one of Scorpia's, then hurried into the bedroom before Castaspella could change her mind.

The master bedroom was dark, save for a single bedside lamp. Its light washed softly over Catra's sleeping face and almost made her look peaceful. But even in sleep, Catra's expression was taut and troubled. Adora hoped she wasn't having a nightmare.

As she tip-toed closer, Adora was struck by how small Catra looked in that giant bed. Time and space played tricks with Adora's tired eyes, and for a split-second she could have sworn they were kids again. But then she blinked, and Adora could see the toll the years had taken on her friend. The split in Catra's eyebrow had been cleaned and carefully secured by a butterfly bandage. A plastic tube snaked from the crook of Catra's arm up to an I.V. bag that was hung on the headboard. As much as it hurt Adora to see Catra this way, she was at least relieved to see a faint glow of color had returned to her cheeks and lips.

Gingerly, Adora eased down onto the edge of the mattress. For a few minutes, she simply sat and watched Catra sleep, grateful for the rise and fall of each breath her friend took. In the lamplight, Adora caught the shimmer of sweat on Catra's forehead. A small stack of washcloths sat on the bedside table, and Adora used one to dry Catra's brow. Tender as Adora tried to be, Catra's eyes fluttered open under her touch. Their eyes locked, and Adora held her breath.

Perhaps it was a trick of the light, but Adora could have swore she saw a ghost of a smile pass across Catra's lips.

"Hey, Adora," Catra whispered, her voice rough and weak.

Adora couldn’t help it: she burst into tears. She cradled Catra’s face in her hands and lightly pressed their foreheads together.

“I’m so glad you’re okay,” Adora sobbed. Her tears fell onto Catra’s cheeks where they caught the lamplight like glitter.

“You dummy,” Catra mumbled as her eyelids drooped. “Of course I am.”

Chuckling, Adora sat back and wiped her tears from both of their faces. “Of course you are. And I’m going to stay right here to make sure you stay that way.”

“Hmm,” was Catra’s reply. Eyes closed, she turned her head and pressed her cheek into Adora’s palm. One quiet moment passed, then another, until Adora assumed Catra had drifted back to sleep. But when she slid her hand away, she heard Catra murmur, “don’t go.”

“I won’t,” Adora whispered. She switched off the lamp and crawled onto the mattress where she laid down at Catra’s side. In the dark, Adora slid her hand into Catra’s and laced their finger together. “I promise.”

Adora drifted off to the familiar sound of Catra’s breathing. In the moment before sleep took her, Adora thought about how their hands still fit each other perfectly, and she smiled.

*

The sleep Adora managed to get was peaceful but brief.

Shortly before sunrise, something startled her awake. For a few disorienting seconds, she couldn’t remember where she was or how she got there.

It was the sound of Catra’s pained moaning that brought everything crashing back.

“Catra?” Adora sat up and fumbled for the light. The room illuminated with a click. Catra let out a yelp as she squeezed her eyes shut tight and draped a scarred forearm over them for good measure. Her skin was slick with sweat — so much so that her clothes were soaked right through. Between groans, Catra breathed in tiny gasps, each of which made her wince. Adora’s heart was in her throat as she tried to pry Catra’s arm away from her face. “What’s wrong? What do you need?”

“Get off me!” Catra cried, pulling away from Adora’s touch. She struggled to sit up, and when Adora reached out to help, Catra swatted her away. “What are you doing here?

Adora blinked, confused by the question. “Don’t you remember? You… you overdosed last night, Catra. Scorpia and Entrapta brought you to Glimmer’s place to get help.”

Catra narrowed her dual-colored eyes in a menacing glare. “I mean why are you here right now?”

The question was so cold that Adora actually shivered. “I’m taking care of you.”

“Ha!” Catra barked, followed by a hiss of pain that made her grit her teeth. “That’s the last thing I need.”

“You asked me to stay,” Adora said quietly, feeling so incredibly small.

The pair stared at one another. Adora searched Catra’s eyes, looking for some sign that Catra remembered, or that she even cared. But if there was anything to be read in Catra’s expression, it was hidden under the pain that was painted across her face.

“Fuck this,” Catra gunted. She wrestled with the duvet, trying to free herself from both it and the sweat-soaked sheets that had become twisted around her legs. “I have to get out of here.”

All of Adora’s hurt was suddenly displaced by panic as she watched Catra claw at the bandage that secured her I.V. drip.

“Stop it! You’re going to hurt yourself!” She grabbed Catra’s hand and pulled it away, nearly getting bit in the process.

“Let go!” Catra cried. She flailed and struggled, but couldn’t seem to muster the strength to fight Adora off. “You can’t keep me here!”

“Catra, please calm down,” Adora pleaded. “You’re sick — you need to rest.”

“I *need* to leave!”

“You’re in pain!”

“You’ll be in pain if you don’t— Gah!” Catra’s body went rigid, her muscles contracting into a tight knot of agony. Adora took this as her opportunity to get Catra under control. She pushed Catra back down onto her pillow and slung one leg over her friend’s body so that she was straddling her, pinning her in place. Catra swore. She swung her sharp-nailed hands for Adora’s face, but Adora caught them easily and held them firmly in place.

“Enough,” Adora said, kind but firm. “If you don’t want me here, that’s fine. I’ll go, but not until you promise to stay put. I’m not going to let you hurt yourself anymore than you already have.” She frowned at Catra, who’s gaze refused to meet her own. “Are you even listening to me?”

Catra blinked, sending a trail of tears spilling down her cheeks. For a split-second Adora feared she had hurt her.

“That’s the bracelet I gave you,” Catra whispered, staring in wide-eyed disbelief at the gold chain that circled Adora’s wrist. “I can’t believe you kept it.”

“Of course I kept it,” Adora said. Her heart ached mournfully at the memory of the day Catra gave her that precious little gift, and ripple of events that came after. “I never take it off.”

Catra frowned, her brows knitting together in confusion. “But why?”

“Because it’s the only piece of you I had left.” The words caught in Adora’s throat, and they came out sounding as broken as they made her feel. In her hands, Adora felt Catra go limp.

“But… you hate me,” Catra said. Tears leaked from the corners of her eyes and slid down into her matted, unruly hair. Adora released Catra’s hands and wiped the tears away, smiling softly.

“I never hated you, Catra.”

Her words elicited a small gasp from Catra’s lips. The moment hung between them, heavy with so many things left unsaid. Catra squeezed her eyes shut and turned her face into the pillow.

“You should,” she sobbed, not even trying to hold the tears back now. “Everyone should.”

“Too bad,” Adora replied. She brushed her fingers gently across Catra’s face, smoothing back the hair that clung to her sweaty skin. “Now, will you please tell me what’s wrong?”

After a few more seconds of stubborn silence, Catra finally caved. “Everything hurts.”

Adora eased off of her. “Okay, I’m going to get Castaspella.”

Catra grabbed Adora’s hand before she had the chance to move. She gazed up at her, eyes filled tears and a touch of fear. Adora responded by giving her hand a squeeze.

“I’ll be right back,” Adora assured her with a smile. “I promise.”

She found Castaspella dozing on the couch and apologized as she shook her awake. Together they hurried back into the bedroom. Adora paced anxiously at the foot of the bed while Castaspella tended to her patient.

“Well, the good news is that you’re doing quite well, all things considered,” Castaspella said after she finished taking Catra’s blood pressure.

“What’s the bad news?” Adora fretted.

“The bad news is that I can’t give you anything to help with the pain.” The doctor gave Catra’s hand a sympathetic pat. “The muscle aches are a common symptom of withdrawal — one of a few that you’ll probably experience over the next few days, I’m afraid.”

Catra let out a low groan, and Adora wondered if it was one of frustration, pain, or both.

“There’s got to be something we can do for her,” Adora insisted.

Castaspella shook her head. “Until the last traces of Runestone clear your system, Catra, I’m afraid you’re just going to have to ride it out.

“Fan-fucking-tastic,” Catra hissed between gritted teeth.

“We’ll do everything we can to make you comfortable in the meantime,” Castaspella said, getting to her feet. “Let’s start with some dry clothes, shall we?”

“I’m on it.” Adora hitched her thumb over her shoulder toward Angella’s closet. Surely there would be something in there that Catra would be comfortable in. “What else?”

Castaspella exhaled deeply and placed her hands softly on Adora’s shoulders. “Detox is an unpleasant business, Adora. It tends to get worse before it gets better. She’s going to be in pain, she’s going to get sick. Patients in withdrawal can sometimes be volatile, cruel — especially when the cravings set in. Are you sure you—”

“Yes,” Adora said without hesitation. “I’m not leaving her.”

“Alright then,” Castaspella relented, clearly too tired to argue. “I’ll be back in a little while with a fresh I.V. bag. If she seizes or becomes unresponsive, come and get me immediately.”

A feeling of gratitude flooded Adora from head to toe. She threw her arms around Castaspella and hugged her tightly. “Thank you so much.”

As Castaspella excused herself, Adora raided the closet and emerged with a pair of Angella’s running shorts and an old t-shirt that may have belonged to the late Mr. Brightmoon. She offered them to Catra with a bashful smile. “I know they’re not really your style, but at least you’ll be comfortable, right?”

Looking miserable, Catra sat up and accepted the clothes with a grunt. Adora turned around to give her some privacy, but after a few minutes of labored breathing and frustrated cursing on Catra’s part, Adora started to fidget.

“How’s it going back there?” she asked awkwardly. “I know you can do it but I could—”

Catra cut her off with an exasperated growl. “Ugh! Will you stop being weird and just help me already?”

The pair worked in awkward silence to peel away Catra’s damp clothes and shimmy her into the dry ones. Adora did her best to keep her eyes averted, but it was hard to miss just how thin Catra had become since the last time she’d seen this much of her. How much longer would Catra have been able to keep up with a life that seemed to take so much more than it gave?

“Can I get you anything?” Adora asked once Catra was fully dressed. “Water? Something to eat?”

“Please don’t talk about eating right now,” Catra said with a wince. “I think I just need to lay down.” She didn’t balk when Adora jumped in to help ease her back down onto the mattress, nor did she say anything—snarky or otherwise—while Adora adjusted her pillows and replaced the heavy duvet and damp sheets with a

light blanket that she also unearthed from the closet. Catra simply watched her work until Adora finally sat back down at her side.

"You don't have to stay," Catra said at last. She avoided Adora's eyes by staring resolutely up at the ceiling. Her tight grip on the blanket was all that gave away how much pain she was in. "You don't have to do any of this."

"I'm not doing it because I have to," Adora said as she stretched out beside her. She poked and nudged until Catra let out a disgruntled sigh and shifted over to make room. "I'm doing it because I want to."

Catra scowled at the ceiling. "Okay, but why would you want to after… y'know, everything."

Adora considered the question. It was a good one, and it was one with only one real answer.

"Why do you think?" Adora whispered. She watched breathlessly as Catra's expression softened.

"Because you're an idiot?" Catra offered, turning her face toward where Adora's waited on the pillow next to her. For the first time in ages, Adora recognized Catra as the girl she'd always known: the best friend she'd grown up with, and the person she never stopped loving, despite it all.



It was impossible to say who broke first. All Adora knew for certain was that one moment she was staring across the breath of space between them—falling into the shades of blue and yellow that had always felt like home to her—and the next moment the space was gone. Her lips pressed into Catra's like two hands in prayer: passionate and full of worship. Adora wasn't sure how something so new could feel as natural as breathing. Kissing Catra

felt like an art that Adora had spent lifetimes before this one perfecting, all for the sake of this moment. This kiss was a masterpiece.

When it ended, neither girl pulled away. They hovered together, their lips grazing with each breath they took. Each featherlight touch sent a thrill racing through Adora's body.

"I knew it," Catra mumbled against Adora's mouth.

"Knew what?"

"I'm dead." Catra shrank back ever so slightly. It was a nearly imperceptible movement, but it was enough to leave Adora feeling exposed and alone. "I died. That, or I'm dreaming."

Instinctively, Adora reached out and pulled Catra back to her. She held her the same way they used to sleep curled together as kids on that single lumpy mattress: so close that they may as well have been one person.

"Why would you say that?" she asked.

Catra's eyes were still closed, but now her brows furrowed as she pulled in a sharp, pained breath. "Because in real life, Adora doesn't want me." Tears gathered at the corners of Catra's eyes. She ducked her chin to hide her face. "Not like I want her."

Her words hit Adora like a sword through her heart. She didn't know what was worse: that Catra had wanted her this whole time, or that she didn't believe Adora could possibly feel the same way. Adora combed her fingers through Catra's damp hair and smiled.

"Now who's the idiot?" she chuckled.

Catra responded with a wince and a groan. Her body trembled with a fresh wave of pain. Adora hated to see her hurt just as much as she hated that there was nothing she could do to stop it. So she did the only other thing she could think of: she kissed her again. She pressed her mouth to Catra's insistently and moved

against her lips like water lapping against the shore. Slowly, Catra's rigid body softened, and she sank deeper into both Adora's kiss and embrace.

At last, Catra opened her eyes just a little. Her lips quirked with the smallest hint of a smile. "Don't let this go to your head but… that almost made me forget that my body hates me right now."

Adora beamed with delight. "Well there's more where that came from."

"Good," Catra replied, leaning in to brush her lips against Adora's once again, "because I think I'm going to need all the help I can get."

Chapter 41

Catra had hoped that Castaspella was just being dramatic about how hard withdrawal would be.

Unfortunately, that wasn't the case. Not even a little bit.

The first couple of days were the worst. When she wasn't sweating through rolling waves of body pain and searing headaches, Catra was desperately willing her stomach to settle. She had never thrown up this much in her life, including the time she and Adora came down with a wicked case of food poisoning after dumpster diving as kids. With every violent, heaving purge, Catra wondered if her body was trying to expel more than just her stomach contents; maybe it was trying to get rid of every rotten thing that made her who she was. She was too tainted, too ruined to keep going as she was now. If she wanted to survive, she would need to start from scratch.

There were precious few moments of clarity in those early days, and the ones she had were fleeting. A part of Catra's brain still refused to believe that Adora was really there, let alone pressing tender kisses to her lips, and she certainly didn't have the mental acuity to consider what any of it meant. Not that it mattered; Catra's mood swings were so vicious and volatile that she wouldn't have been surprised if Adora left again, this time for good. Sometimes Catra cried, reaching for Adora with pitiful and unabashed need. But other times, when the pain and frustration and cravings were at their worst, Catra was awful — even by her own standards.

"I hate you!" she shrieked when Adora refused to let her leave the room. "You think you're so fucking special, don't you? I don't need your help!"

Adora took a deep breath, steeling herself against the vitriol. "Catra, you're still sick."

“I wouldn’t be sick if I had a bit of Runestone,” Catra replied, pacing the floor like a wild animal forced into captivity. “I should be weaning off of it, not quitting cold turkey.”

“Too bad,” Adora said. She crossed her arms and leaned back against the door like the prison guard she had become. “Doctor’s orders.”

Catra sneered. “You’re such a fucking narc. Fuck the doctor and fuck you too.” She flailed and swore until the exertion made her stomach turn and she was forced to dash for the ensuite bathroom to vomit.

You deserve this, she thought miserably as she curled over the toilet bowl. *This is what you get for being such a shitty person*.

But whether Catra was getting what she deserved or not, Adora still didn’t leave her side. As Catra’s stomach heaved, she heard the soft padding of bare feet across the bathroom tile. Hands gathered her unruly hair and held it back. The feeling of cool air on the back of her neck was one of the few pleasures Catra had these days.

When she was finished, Catra sat back, weak and shivering. She took the wad of toilet paper Adora offered and used it to wipe her mouth.

“I hate this,” she whined, fighting the urge to cry for the millionth time. She wasn’t sure she could spare the moisture at this point. As if she could read Catra’s mind, Adora filled a glass at the sick and passed it to her.

“I know,” Adora said as she settled down beside her on the cool tiled floor. “But it won’t be like this forever, right?”

Catra closed her eyes. No, it wouldn’t be forever. But would the life that waited for her on the other side of this nightmare be much better? She had barely been lucid enough to think about how she was going to explain all of this to Prime; the police raid, the hack, the overdose, all of it.

“I think I would have been better off if Scorpia had just let the Runestone kill me,” Catra thought.

Or, at least she meant to think it. But judging by the horrified look on Adora’s face, she may have said the quiet part out loud.

“Don’t say shit like that, Catra,” Adora admonished. Her bright blue eyes were glassy with tears.

Catra let out a dark chuckle. “It’s true. You have no idea how fucked I am.”

With a furious huff, Adora clambored to her feet. She snatched a washcloth from a shelf above the toilet and ran it under blasting cold water for a few seconds. Catra could see Adora’s anger in the way she wrung out the cloth, twisting it with far more strength than necessary. When she flopped back down, Catra raised her eyebrows.

“Do you feel better now?” she snarked.

“Shut up.” Adora shoved Catra’s hair out of the way and dabbed her forehead with the cloth. She kept at it for a minute or two, cooling Catra’s skin with both the cloth and her icy silence. But, because Adora was who she was, she couldn’t keep up the silent treatment for very long. “Is that why you did it?” she blurted suddenly.

“Did what?” Catra was having a hard time concentrating on anything other than the soothing sensation of cold on her hot skin. She pawed at her mane, shoving her hair out of the way so Adora knew where to focus on next.

Adora pulled away, holding the cloth back like a hostage. When Catra opened her mouth to complain, she realized that Adora was crying.

“Overdose,” Adora said, her voice trembling. “Were you trying to kill yourself?”

Catra gaped mutely at the question. Sure, she had been upset that night—desperate, even—but was she trying to hurt herself?

"No. It wasn't like that. I just…" she hesitated. Why *had* she done it? It's not like she didn't know how easy it was to take too much of the drug she'd come to rely on. "I needed an escape. I didn't want to feel like myself for a little while." She cut a quick glance at Adora, wondering how she could look so pretty, even when she was crying. "It was an accident — I wasn't thinking straight."

Biting her bottom lip, Adora stared down at the cloth she clutched tightly on her lap. She looked so impossibly sad that, for a split second, Catra found herself pulled out of her own misery. Her heart clenched knowing that the tears that shimmered on Adora's cheeks were her fault. Without thinking, Catra reached out and cupped Adora's cheek with her hand.

"I'm serious," she insisted. "It was just an accident. And it'll never happen again."

Adora sniffed and lifted her eyes. "You promise?"

"Yeah, I promise," Catra said.

"Okay, good," Adora said, a hint of a smile tugging at her lips. She nuzzled her damp, soft cheek against Catra's palm. It was a simple gesture that unleashed a cloud of butterflies in Catra's stomach — a welcome reprieve from the nausea, but worrying all the same. Adora must have seen the conflict playing out on Catra's face. "What's wrong? Are you going to be sick again?"

Catra shook her head and shrank away. "No, I'm just… thinking, I guess."

"About?"

"About what happens next." Catra closed her eyes against the flutter of anxiety in her chest. "I don't know how to come back from this."

Chewing her bottom lip, Adora fidgeted with her gold bracelet. She hesitated in silence while Catra waited impatiently. Eventually, the heavy silence between them got to be too much, and Catra sighed dramatically.

"What?" she asked, fighting to keep her temper in check. "I know you wanna say something — just say it already."

Adora locked eyes with her, and her gaze was so earnest that Catra felt strangely exposed.

"You don't have to go back there," Adora said. "Please, Catra, don't go back to the Horde. I know you're still mad at me for leaving. Believe me — if I could go back in time and do it differently, I would. I wish I had just told you what I was doing instead of leaving you in the dark. I thought I was—"

"Adora—"

"—protecting you, but I betrayed your trust instead and I'm so sorry for that—"

"Adora, shut up—"

"—and if you don't want anything to do with me after this then I'll respect that but please, please, don't go back to the Horde!" Finally, Adora took a breath. She gazed at Catra, her blue eyes watering, and clasped her hands in front of her heart as if she was actually begging.

For a moment, Catra stared back. She took the time to consider her words carefully before speaking again. "You're right — you should have told me what you were doing. We were supposed to trust each other, Adora."

"I know, and I—"

"No, let me talk," Catra insisted, and Adora snapped her mouth shut. "It hurt me that you didn't trust me enough to be honest with me—that you literally trusted complete strangers over me.

But…” she pinched the bridge of her nose and forced the words out, “I guess I should have trusted you too.”

That was it — the closest thing to an admission of guilt that Catra could muster. She knew it wasn’t nearly enough, but it seemed to be enough for now. Gently, Adora took Catra’s hand. The pair sat in silence, clinging to each other as if their lives depended on it.

After a while, Adora tightened her grip. She tipped her head and rested it on Catra’s shoulder. “You can stay here — with me,” she whispered.

Catra huffed a laugh. “Yeah right.”

“I’m serious.”

“So am I,” Catra replied. “Your new friends hate me, Adora. They’re not going to want me here.”

Adora sat up, her face awash with dismay. “Catra, everyone has spent the last few days worried sick about you. All they want is for you to be okay. Trust me, no one here hates you.”

Heat filled Catra’s cheeks. Embarrassed, she had to look away. “Well, they should. I mean, I’m the reason Angella is…” Catra’s mouth went dry; she couldn’t finish her thought.

“Oh, Catra.” Adora wrapped her arms around Catra’s shoulders and held her tightly.

“Stop it,” Catra hissed as she tried to squirm away. “I don’t deserve—”

“Angella isn’t dead.”

Catra froze. “What?”

“Angella is alive, Catra.” Adora said, her voice kind and gentle. “She managed to escape before the fire.”

A surge of emotion hit Catra like a tidal wave. Had she not been sitting down, she likely would have crumbled on the spot. All those sleepless nights and guilt-filled days came rushing out of every dark corner of Catra's soul and flowed out of her in a torrent of tears. She sobbed like a child, her body rocking in the safety of Adora's embrace.

Adora let her cry. She rubbed Catra's shoulders and pressed kisses into her hair.

"I never wanted to hurt her," Catra wailed into the crook of Adora's neck. "I never wanted to hurt anyone. But I've done so many awful things…"

"There is nothing you've done that you can't come back from," Adora assured her. "And you don't have to do it alone, either."

Slowly, Catra's tears ebbed. As if a demon had been exorcized from her heart, Catra felt empty. She felt new. Still, she didn't have the heart to tell Adora that she was wrong; that her faith was misplaced. Catra knew there would be no coming back from her entanglement from Prime. But maybe that was a conversation for another day.

"Come on," Adora said as she got to her feet. Catra took the hand she offered and let Adora pull her up off the floor. "You should get some rest."

As Adora led them from the bathroom, Catra caught reflection in the mirror. She recoiled from herself, with her matted hair and sallow skin. Even without the tell-tale signs of her sickness, Catra hated the person staring back at her, hated the things that person had done. She swiped her hair from her face, and she had an idea.

"Actually, do you think you can help me with something?" she asked.

Adora watched curiously as Catra rifled through the vanity drawers. "Sure. What do you need?"

After a minute of searching, Catra found what she was looking for. Feeling triumphant, she held a pair of scissors out to Adora and smiled. "A haircut."

*

Despite Adora's insistence that no one was mad at her, Catra couldn't bring herself to face the others. After more than a week of detox, Catra had shaken the worst of her withdrawal symptoms. Still, just the idea of walking into a room full of people who had seen her at her worst—whom she had been an absolute bitch to at one point or another—made her want to hurl.

But even her intense shame and mortification wasn't enough to distract Catra from how absolutely sick and tired she was of Angella Brightmoon's master bedroom. Now that she wasn't sleeping all of the time, Catra found herself coming down with a new affliction: cabin fever.

"If I don't get out of this room soon, I'm going to lose it," she grumbled to herself one afternoon. Adora had left her alone to nap. Catra could hear the murmur of Adora's voice mingling in conversation with others somewhere beyond the bedroom door. As much as Catra longed for a change of scenery, she didn't want to risk being seen by anyone else. So she tossed and turned instead, trying to get comfortable while wondering how it could be possible to actually get bored of sleeping.

She was just about to give up when a long, pained yowl cut through the quiet. Catra's eyes snapped open and she held her breath, listening. After a beat or two, the cry came again, and then again. Catra kicked off the sheets and slid off the bed to follow the sound. Whatever it was seemed to be coming from behind a heavy set of floor-to-ceiling window curtains. Curious, Catra pulled them aside to find a set of French doors that appeared to lead into the back yard.

"Are you kidding me?" Catra griped as she flicked the deadbolt and carefully eased one of the doors open. "I can't believe I could

have been sitting outside this whole damn time."

A light breeze swept across the yard, taking Catra by surprise as it ruffled through her new pixie cut. It had been a couple of days since Adora had helped her chop of her suffocating locks, but Catra was still getting used to it. She took a deep breath in, filling her lungs with blissfully fresh air. This, she decided, was much better than being cooped up in the bedroom.

Catra sat down on the steps that led from the small white-washed patio down to the grass. She leaned back and closed her eyes, tipping her head back to enjoy the feeling of sunshine on her face.

That's when she heard the sound again. She jolted upright and glanced around the yard. Suddenly, her eyes caught some movement under a bush against the fence and her heart leapt into her throat.

What if this is a trap? she thought. *What if Prime sent someone to find me, and I just walked right into it?*

But then the cry rang out again, and it was a sound so pitiful that Catra couldn't resist. Whatever was making the sound, it was clearly in pain. Catra tiptoed through the grass and crouched down low. Ready to run at the first sign of trouble, she lifted some branches and peered underneath.

There, huddled at the base of the bush, was a cat. The animal was ragged and dirty. Even with its fur standing on end, Catra could see that it was painfully thin. It watched her with wide, wary eyes. In a weird sort of way, Catra saw a lot of herself in the stray.

"Are you the one making all that noise?" Catra asked, keeping her voice low. As if in response, the cat let out a sad little mew. Catra held out her fingers and clicked her tongue, holding herself perfectly still as the cat gave her a cursory sniff. "It's okay. I'm not gonna hurt you."

Amazingly, it seemed as though the cat believed her. Gingerly, it crawled out from beneath the bush. Catra noticed that the animal seemed to be favoring one of its back legs as it hobbled out into the open. It took a bit more coaxing, but eventually the cat crept close enough for Catra to see the deep gash on one of its rear paws.

"Ouch," Catra said as she eased down to sit cross-legged in the grass. "No wonder you're crying. That looks pretty bad, kitty."

The cat let out another pathetic mewl and crawled into Catra's lap. For a moment, Catra sat stunned and unsure of what to do next. She gave the cat a cautious scratch behind the ear, and the cat responded with a rumbling purr. Catra's devotion to the sad, wounded creature was instantaneous.

Moving carefully, Catra bundled the stay into her arms and cradled it protectively against her chest. She got to her feet and hurried inside. Without pausing to think, she shuffled through the bedroom, out the door, and down the hallway. Before she knew it, Catra was standing at the threshold of the living room where Adora was sitting and talking with everyone else.

Every face in the room gaped up at her in disbelief.

"Catra!" Adora jumped up. "Are you okay?"

"Your *hair*!" Scorpia exclaimed from where she sat between Entrapta and the blonde girl who had helped Castaspella on that harrowing first night.

Glimmer did a double take. "Is… is that a *cat*?"

"Err, hi," Catra said weakly. Her heart was hammering in her chest, but she chose to focus on the soothing vibration of the cat's purr instead. "I know I owe you guys an explanation but… can someone give me a ride to the vet first?"


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Chapter 42

A couple of hours and one expensive vet bill later, everyone was back at the Brightmoon home and gathered around the expansive dining room table like the most awkward family reunion of all time. As she looked around the room, Adora couldn't help but feel like she was in the middle of a particularly vivid fever dream. After so many days together, the edges of her old life and her new one blurred together as a surreal sense of familiarity settled over the group. Logically, Adora knew it didn't make sense for Glimmer and Bow to be sitting in the same room as Scorpia and Entrapta. And yet there they were, chatting quietly with one another like… well, perhaps not like old friends, but amiably enough considering they'd all been enemies barely a week earlier.

And then there was Catra.

Perched closely at Adora's side, Catra's entire focus was trained on the freshly bathed and bandaged stray that sat purring loudly on her lap. The cat was so content that it didn't even seem to mind the ungainly plastic cone of shame that hung around its neck. Out of the corner of her eyes, Adora marveled at the small but genuine smile that played on Catra's lips as she scratched behind the cat's ears. Under different circumstances, Adora might have cooed out loud over how cute the scene was. But right now, her mind kept wandering back to the way Catra had paid the vet bill, seemingly without a second thought. She knew it was a strange thing to be hung up on, but she couldn't help it. After a lifetime of poverty—of rarely having more than a few dollars to their name—Adora wondered if Catra would be able to walk away from the comfort only a well-padded bank account could offer.

Across the table, Glimmer cleared her throat.

"So," she said, her voice cutting through Adora's thoughts, "I guess the cat's staying then?"

"Melog," Catra said by way of reply.

Glimmer blinked. “Excuse me?”

“That’s his name,” Catra explained. As if on cue, the cat let out a meow that, surprisingly, sounded a lot like it was saying *Melog*. Catra gestured at him as if that settled the matter. “And yeah, he’s staying.” Adora was about to give her a warning nudge—a gentle reminder that she was supposed to be playing nice—when Catra lifted her eyes for the first time since they’d all sat down. Adora clocked the slight twitch at the corner of Catra’s mouth, the involuntary tick that betrayed the anxiety Catra always worked so hard to mask. But while the others may not have noticed it, Adora knew Catra too well to miss it. Without speaking, she laid her hand atop Catra’s knee and gave it a gentle, reassuring squeeze as if to say *I see you, I’ve got you*. Melog looked down at Adora’s fingers and considered them for a moment before laying his own little paw on her hand. Seeing this, Catra let out a shaky laugh.

“I wanted to say thank you,” Catra said as she looked around the room. “Y’know, for taking care of me. I appreciate it, especially after everything I’ve put you guys through.”

Adora held her breath, watching to see how her friends would take this rare moment of vulnerability from Catra. After a beat of surprise, Glimmer and Bow smiled.

“Well, if Adora likes you then we figured you couldn’t be all that bad,” Bow said with a wink, sending a heat racing up Adora’s neck that spilled across her face. To her surprise, she noticed Catra’s cheeks flush too.

The touching moment was suddenly interrupted by the sound of a ringing phone. Scorpia jumped in her seat and fumbled with her cell as she silenced the call. Adora noticed the way Scorpia’s face paled as she looked down at her caller I.D. Beneath her hand, Adora felt Catra tense.

“It’s him, isn’t it?” Catra said. There was something low and resigned about her voice, and it sent a chill down Adora’s spine.

Scorpia sucked in a sharp breath between clenched teeth as she forced a smile. “Maybe?”

Catra narrowed her eyes, and Scorpia crumbled immediately.

“Okay, yes, it’s him. He’s been calling to check in a lot—”

“We told him you have mono,” Entrapta interjected in that matter-of-fact way of hers. “Lengthy symptoms, contagious enough that we’ve needed to keep you quarantined, but not so serious that you’d need to be hospitalized. It’s kind of the perfect cover story when you think about it.”

“Shit,” Catra hissed, dropping her face into her hands. “Shit, shit, shit. Okay. It’s fine. I can fix this, I just need—”

“Catra, stop,” Adora said. Her heart felt clenched between the pressures of panic and a desperate need to protect the person she cared about most in this world. She pulled Catra’s hands away from her face and held them tight. “Take a breath. You don’t have to deal with this on your own.”

But Catra pulled away, and Adora was stung. “Of course I do!” Catra snapped. “A lot has changed since you bailed, Adora. The situation is complicated, and I’m not…” She hesitated. She wrapped her arms around Melog and held him close. “I’m not dragging you back in to clean up my mess.”

Adora felt as though she’d been doused in ice cold water as dread washed over her. “Catra, what are you saying? You’re not seriously thinking of going back to the Horde, are you?”

Catra grimaced. “I have to fix this, Adora. You don’t understand —”

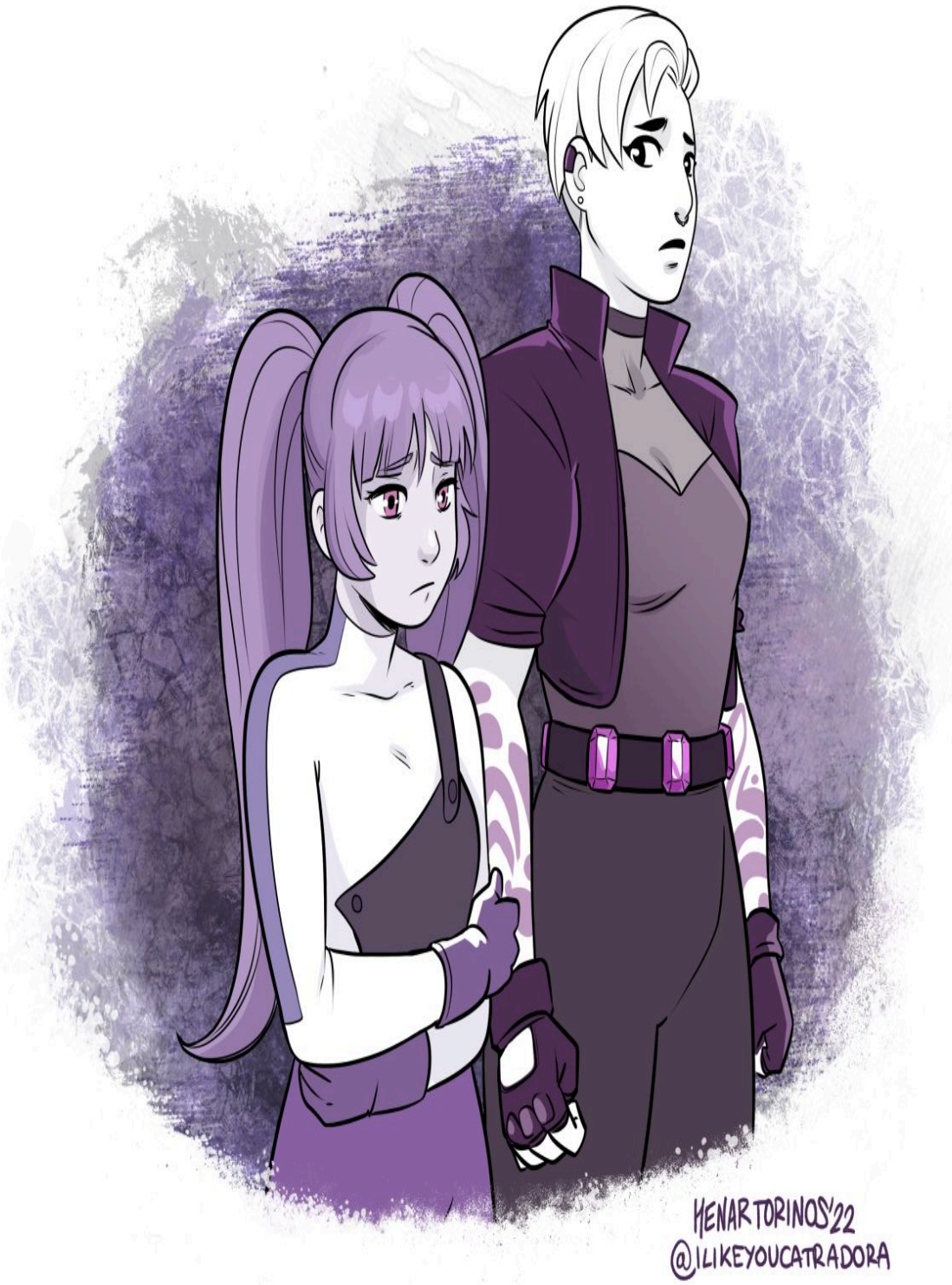
The sound of a chair scraping back from the table drew both of their attention back to the rest of the group. When they looked up, they found Scorpia standing. She held herself with an air of defiance, though Adora didn’t miss the slight tremble in her hands.

“Well, if you’re going back, you’re going on your own.” Scopia didn’t yell, but it felt as though she had. Adora’s mouth fell open in surprise. Seated at Scorpia’s side, she watched Perfuma smile up at her and offer an encouraging thumbs-up.

Catra’s eyes were wide and unblinking. “What are you saying?”

Scorpia swallowed hard before answering. “I’m saying that I’m out. I’m done. I can’t do this anymore, and I don’t think you should either. I mean, seriously, Catra — look at what it’s done to you! The stress, the threats — it’s no wonder you started using.” Her expression softened as she gazed at Catra sadly. “I just wish you’d told us what you were going through.”

Before Catra could respond, Entrapta stood as well. Though she barely came to Scorpia’s shoulders, her presence was just as big. “I’m out too. I always knew Runestone could be dangerous, but I had no idea…” She looked down at her hands, staring as if she didn’t recognize them. “You almost died, Catra. And I would have had to live with that guilt for the rest of my life… Heck, I *do* have to live with that guilt, because now I understand what it’s done to others.” Shaking her head, Entrapta wrapped her arms around herself in a self-soothing hug. “I should have left after what they did to Hordak. I wish I had.”



At this, Adora sat up straight in her seat. "What *who* did to Hordak?" she asked. She glanced at Glimmer and Bow, wondering

if perhaps this was something that had come up in conversation during the many hours she's spent at Catra's side. But they both looked as alarmed as she felt.

Catra's turned to Scorpia and Entrapta. "You haven't told them?"

Scorpia shook her head. "I figured you'd be mad if I did."

"Haven't told us what?" Glimmer asked, her hands gripping the edge of the table so hard that her knuckles turned white. Adora looked expectantly at Catra, but Catra was still focused on Scorpia. A tense silence stretched out uncomfortably between the two until Scorpia finally let out a sigh. Her strong shoulders slumped with resignation.

"C'mon, Catra," she said softly. "I know you weren't happy — I know what we were doing bothered you too. You don't have to go back there."

Catra's breath quickened. Adora could sense the conflict and panic rising inside of her. Apparently Melog did too; with a concerned chirp, he pressed his soft body tightly against Catra's chest.

"What about your parents?" Catra asked. "Won't they be in danger if you leave?"

"Your *parents*?" Adora cried, unable to reign in her surprise. She'd never known anyone in the Horde who had a family outside of the gang before.

Scorpia chuckled softly as she rubbed the back of her neck, obviously uneasy. "Yeah, it's a bit of a long story." Her eyes flicked back to Catra, to whom she offered a half-smile. "I haven't worked out all of the details yet, but I know we can figure something out." She motioned to Glimmer and Bow. She even nodded at Adora; a rare show of acknowledgement that she hadn't always been keen to offer before. "Maybe we can all help each other. What do you say?"

Her question hung in the air. Everything seemed to hang on Catra's response. Adora's heart pounded in her chest at the thought of Catra pulling away again. Desperate, Adora held her hand out, ready to get on her knees and beg if she had to.

"Please, Catra," she said, her voice tight with emotion. "Please stay."

Catra met her gaze. And then, ever so slowly, she nodded.

"I don't know if we can beat them," she admitted as she slid her hand into Adora's. "But I'm willing to try."

The room exploded with cheers of elation. Overcome with relief, Adora leaned in and kissed Catra in front of everyone. She felt Catra smile against her lips.

"You should probably wait to hear what we have to tell you before you start celebrating," Catra told the room. Her smile faded and her expression grew grim. "Because I guarantee you're not going to like it."

Chapter 43

Catra had heard the term "deafening silence" before, though she didn't understand it. To her, it seemed like a dumb thing to say; the very definition of an oxymoron. She wasn't sure how the quiet could also be loud.

But as soon as she told Adora and the others who was really calling the shots for the Horde, Catra understood. In that moment, with the room in perfect silence, Catra wondered if it was her: had the overdose messed with her hearing somehow? It felt like every sound had been blocked out so completely, leaving behind only a soundless void so vast that it threatened to swallow her whole.

Glimmer was the first to snap back to her senses.

"MAYOR PRIME IS THE LEADER OF THE HORDE??" she cried, making everyone else jump.

"IT GOES ALL THE WAY TO THE TOP!" Entrapta affirmed with a shriek.

"I don't understand," Adora said. She shook her head as if this was all a strange and terrible dream. The movement dislodged a golden tendril of hair from the poof she still insisted on styling it in, and Catra had to resist the urge to reach out and tuck it back into place. This, Catra reasoned, was hardly the time to be looking for an excuse to run her fingers through Adora's hair. "How did they keep this from us for all these years? How did we not know?"

Thinking about Prime made Catra's stomach sour. She scowled. "We didn't know because he's a goddamn psychopath."

"No kidding," Bow muttered in disgust. "He'd have to be to do something like that to his own family. I can't imagine standing there while one of my brothers got his ass kicked. How does he sleep at night?"

"Right?" Entrapta exclaimed, apparently mistaking Bow's horror for empathy. "Hordak's made some mistakes, but he didn't deserve that."

Catra and Adora shared a furtive glance, but chose to keep their opinions to themselves.

With a disheartened groan, Glimmer got to her feet. Catra's eyes followed her as she paced the length of the dining room. "No wonder the police force is so corrupt! Ugh, my mom didn't stand a chance with those backstabbing dickheads."

As if on instinct, Catra reacted before her better judgment could stop her. "The EPD is corrupt because cops are bastards, plain and simple."

Glimmer spun on her heel, her eyes alight with barely contained fury. "Excuse me?"

"I said what I said," Catra snarled. She could feel herself getting swept away in a sudden wave of rage; a riptide she was powerless to resist. "Sorry to shatter the illusion, Princess, but the police are complicit in everything that's wrong with this dumpster fire of a city. Even if your mom's—" she raised her fingers into a pair of air quotes "—'one of the good ones', that doesn't absolve the rest of them."

Catra didn't realize she was shaking until she felt Adora's arm wrap around her shoulder and pull her in tight. She braced herself, waiting for both a reprimand from Adora and a verbal thrashing from Glimmer.

But neither came.

Instead, she watched the self-righteous anger behind Glimmer's eyes fade as she sank back down into her chair looking defeated and tired. She glanced down as Bow slid his hand into hers and sighed.

"You're right," she admitted, earning a jolt of surprise from Catra. "The system is broken. I can love and respect my mom and still admit that she was on the wrong side."

An unexpected twinge of guilt flared in Catra's heart. She'd been so relieved to learn that Angella was still alive, but she hadn't thought to question why the chief of police didn't seem to be around. Only now did it dawn on Catra that she hadn't seen Angella since that awful day at the garage. She chewed her lip nervously before asking, "Where is Angella, anyway?"

The only reply Glimmer offered was a dark glare, so Adora cleared her throat and answered instead.

"Hopefully she's somewhere safe."

If shame was an ocean, Catra would have drowned in it.

Though the tension in the room was almost thick enough to see, Perfuma spoke up as if she didn't even notice. "Sorry if this is a dumb question but... if we can't trust the police, how are we going to stop Mayor Prime?"

Scorpia raised an eyebrow at her.

"We?" she chuckled. "Are you sure this is a mess that you want to be involved in?"

"Yes," Perfuma said without a beat of hesitation. As Catra watched the pair beam at one another, seemingly unaware of anyone else in the room, Catra couldn't help but smile too. She didn't know what was going on between the two of them—hell, maybe they didn't either—but whatever it was, it seemed to be making Scorpia happy. That much, Catra knew, was something Scorpia deserved.

Across the table, Bow tapped his chin. "Prime is an elected official. There's got to be a way to get him ousted from his position."

"I can't believe people voted for him in the first place," Glimmer grumbled.

"How would anyone have known not to?" Catra said with a shrug. "Me and Adora grew up in the Horde and we had no idea he was involved. Besides..." she glanced at Scorpia, looking away before she noticed, "when you have the money and power that Prime does, you can get pretty much anyone to look the other way."

This time it was Adora who jumped from her seat and started to pace. Catra knew the expression on Adora's face well—her features tight and drawn as she worked through a problem in her mind.

"That's the problem, isn't it?" Adora said, gesturing wildly as she spoke. "People don't know—they literally have no idea! They don't even know about the people who are turning a blind eye to all this bullshit. So, what would happen if they knew the truth?"

Bow cocked his head as he considered the question. "I mean, hopefully they would vote differently, but it's not like we have time to wait for another election."

"People would be furious!" Glimmer slammed her hands on the table, earning a reproachful squawk from Melog. "And they should be! I think if this city really knew what's been going on, they wouldn't stand for it. They'd riot. Hell, we *should* riot!"

"What if we held a protest instead?' Perfuma offered. "I was the head of the student union when I was in undergrad — I'm really good at organizing rallies!"

"I like where your heads are at," Adora said. "But none of that will work unless everyone knows the truth. We need Etheria to understand who their Mayor really is and what he's done to the city. How do we do that?"

Catra sat up in her seat. Adora's impassioned speech had given her an idea. Once more, she looked across the table, and this

time she found Scorpia looking back at her with eyes wide and expectant.

"Hey, Scorpia," Catra said. "You're serious about leaving the Horde, right?"

Scorpia nodded. "Yup."

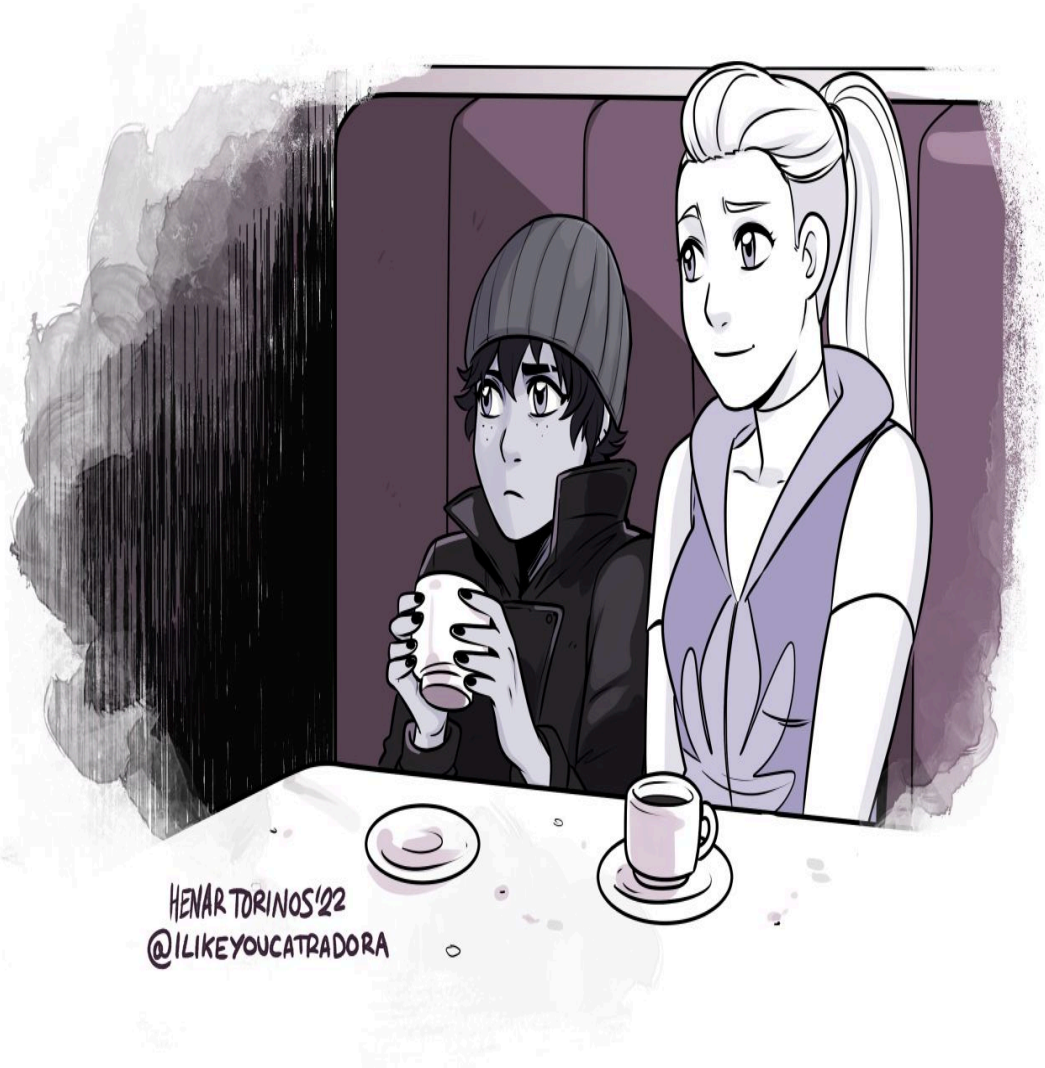
A sly grin tugged at Catra's lips. "In that case, maybe it's time to pay your parents a visit."

*

Later that evening, Catra and Adora sat side-by-side, wedged close to one another in the back corner booth of an all-night diner. Catra nursed a cup of coffee with one hand while she tugged at her beanie with the other, pulling it lower over her forehead.

"Relax," Adora whispered, despite the fact that she herself had just been nervously picking at a crack in the vinyl booth seat. "No one's gonna see you."

"You don't know that," Catra hissed back as she sank lower. "And I'm not taking any chances."



Adora wriggled down so they were shoulder to shoulder and smiled. "Don't worry, I'll protect you."

"Pfft." Catra rolled her eyes. "You know I can take care of myself."

"I know, but just let me be chivalrous, okay?"

"Ooh, chivalrous." Catra laced her fingers with Adora's as she smirked. "Look at you and your big new fancy words."

They fell quiet for a few minutes, both of them alternating between watching the door and checking the loud ticking clock that was mounted over the bar.

"I hope Scorpia's okay," Catra said as she watched the second hand make yet another lap around the clock's face. She could feel Adora's eyes on her. "The Horde really fucked her and her family over."

Adora hummed thoughtfully. "Do you think her parents will support her?"

"Shit," Catra shuddered. "I really fucking hope so."

"What about you?" Adora asked. She rubbed her thumb against the back of Catra's hand. "How are you feeling?"

Catra took a sip of her coffee. It had already gone cold. "I just want to get this over with."

"No, I mean how are you feeling, y'know, health-wise?"

"Oh." Catra chewed her bottom lip. The truth was that she felt tired and jittery. She probably didn't need the coffee, but it helped take the edge off the creeping cravings that seemed to be right on the edge of every conscious moment. "All things considered, I think I'm okay."

"Okay." Adora nodded. Catra knew how badly she wanted to keep digging, but Adora also knew better than to push her luck. "I'm glad."

Just then, the diner door swung open and three figures hurried in from the night. One of them was Scorpia, and when their eyes met across the room, Catra could tell she'd been crying. But, being who she was, Scorpia's face still broke into a smile as she led her small party to the booth.

"Moms," Scorpia said as she motioned to the table, "these are my friends, Catra and Adora."

The two women—Scorpia's parents—looked completely out of place in this greasy spoon of a diner. Both were dressed for the office in expensive clothes and designer shoes, and neither looked

like they were the type to indulge in reheated coffee and syrupy pancakes in the middle of the night. Still, like their daughter, the pair radiated a kind of openness and warmth, even despite being clearly on edge. As they slid into the booth, their eyes nervously scanned every face in the diner.

"Thanks for agreeing to meet with us," Adora said once everyone was settled. "I know we're probably putting you in a bad spot, but —"

One of the women—the taller of the two with sleek dark hair—shut Adora down with a wave of her hand. "If anyone should be apologizing, it's us."

The other, who's bobbed hair was the same shock white as Scorpia's, nodded solemnly. "That's right. We should have stood up to Prime a long time ago."

Catra's heart leapt into her throat. All this time, the idea of convincing Scorpia's parents to use Black Garnet Media to spread the truth about Prime and the Horde had felt like a long shot. After all, doing so could very well be a death sentence for their entire family.

"Does that mean you'll help us?" Catra asked breathlessly. "Even with the risks?"

Scorpia's moms looked at each other. The taller of the two squared her shoulders and pinned Catra under a resolute gaze.

"Our daughter is the one putting herself at risk, and it shouldn't have taken her making that decision for us to do the right thing." She looked at Scorpia, who beamed proudly back at her. "If she's willing to fight back, then so are we."

Under the table, Adora squeezed Catra's hand so hard it hurt.

"Thank you!" Adora said, barely managing to keep her voice down in her excitement.

"What do we do now?" Catra asked, getting straight down to business. "What do you need from us?"

Scorpia's bob-haired mother folded her hands on the table between them, her expression somber. "If this is going to work, we're going to need more than just the word of a few Horde defectors. We need something compelling and explosive—something the viewers can't refute."

Catra considered the implications of what she was saying carefully. "You need Prime," she said. "You need a confession."

"Ideally? Yes."

Adora turned to Catra, her face ashen. "How are we going to get something like that?"

For a moment, Catra didn't answer. She considered their options—what they knew, what they had at their disposal, what kind of access they could get—and she came up with only one viable solution.

It wasn't a good one, but it was the best shot they had.

"I can do it," Catra said. "I'll get the proof you need."

Chapter 44

Adora and her friends stood on the sidewalk, staring up at a swanky downtown hotel.

“Wait,” Bow said, “aren’t we supposed to be meeting Scorpia’s moms? Why are we at a hotel?”

“We need a command center.” Catra said, shifting from one foot to the other.

Bow tipped his head. “But wouldn’t it have been easier to meet at the Black Garnet offices?”

“Prime might have someone planted in the newsroom,” Adora explained. “We can’t risk this getting back to him.”

“I love it!” Glimmer was nearly vibrating with excitement. “I feel like I’m in a spy movie.”

For all intents and purposes, Adora should have been excited too. After all, they were meeting with Scorpia’s moms to finalize their plan, and there were few things Adora enjoyed more than a strategy session.

But instead, Adora was anxious. Her stomach tossed and pitched knowing that this plan revolved around putting Catra directly in harm's way. Instinctively, she reached out and looped her arm around Catra’s and held her close to her side.

“Come on,” she said with false confidence, “let’s do this.”

The four of them filed through the hotel’s rotating doors and across the polished lobby floor to the elevators. When the elevator doors slid open and they shuffled inside, Adora double checked the text she’d received from Scorpia earlier that day.

“Twelve,” she said to Glimmer, who gave the appropriate button a quick jab. Soft lounge music filled the elevator, smothering the

nervous silence of its riders with a soothing melody and an easy beat. With each floor light that flashed above the brushed bronze doors, Adora knew they were creeping ever closer to an ending. Though whether that ending would be the one Adora hoped for was impossible to know; a fact that she found both exhilarating and terrifying all at the same time.

A cheerful ding announced their arrival to the fifth floor. When the doors opened, the friends found Scorpia waiting for them.

"You made it," she said, her broad shoulders slumping with unmistakable relief. "C'mon, we're down here." They followed Scorpia down the hall and around a corner to a corner room door. She scanned her keycard and stepped aside so the others could file in before her. Once they were all securely inside, she slid the security lock into place.

"Woah," Adora whispered, gazing around what seemed more like an apartment than a hotel room. "This place is huge!"

Catra carefully extricated her arm from Adora's grip. "Like I said: it's our command center."

In the middle of that command center was a dining table that Entrapta and one of Scorpia's moms were busy transforming into an elaborate work station filled with monitors and harddrives connected to laptops and headsets. A tangle of cables spilled onto the floor and snaked outward to various outlets, like an estuary of rivers seen from above.

Scorpia's other mother motioned for them to join her in the sitting area, where she had already laid claim to a chic armchair in the corner.

"We're just about ready on our end," she said as Adora and her friends settled onto the sofa. Adora couldn't help but notice the way her eyes followed Catra's every move, watching her as though she were appraising her readiness for what lay ahead. "Have you figured out your angle yet?"

Everyone looked at Catra expectantly. The plan, as decided in that cramped corner booth, wasn't particularly sophisticated: Catra—sporting a clandestine streaming camera and mic—would meet with Prime under the guise of wanting to get back to work now that she had been given a clean bill of health. The tricky part would be getting Prime to incriminate himself, and that was the "angle" Scorpia's moms had tasked them with figuring out.

To Adora, the best approach seemed pretty clear cut: they would use her as a pawn. Catra would return to Prime with the Horde defector in tow as a way to win her way back into his good graces. With Catra back on his good side, Adora figured it would be way easier to get Prime to say something they could use against him.

Adora had expected Catra to balk at the idea — to refuse it outright initially, before eventually coming around. Instead, Catra simply shrugged.

"I dunno. Let me sleep on it," Catra had said with a maddening level of indifference for someone who was about to put her life on the line.

By the time the pair finally went to bed, they were no closer to figuring out how exactly Catra was going to get Prime to talk.

Which is why Adora was so surprised when Catra nodded and answered with a confident, "Yes."

"Yes?" Adora exclaimed. "When did that happen? And why didn't you tell me?"

Catra glanced at her, and it was only then—when she saw the unmistakable guilt in Catra's eyes—that Adora realized it was the first time that Catra had met her gaze all day.

"I didn't tell you because I knew you wouldn't like it," Catra said.

A foreboding chill ran down Adora's spine. Her throat was suddenly dry. "Wouldn't like what?"

“You’re not coming with me, Adora.”

“Like hell I’m not!” Adora tried to jump to her feet, but Catra caught her by the elbow and pulled her back down onto the sofa beside her. Undeterred, Adora ranted on. “I’m not letting you go in there alone. What if something goes wrong?”

“She won’t be alone,” Glimmer cut in, “because I’m going with her instead.”

“WHAT?” Adora and Bow cried in unison.

Bow took Glimmer by the shoulders and wheeled her around to face him. His eyes were wide with panic. “What are you talking about?”

“Catra’s going to pretend that she’s taken me prisoner as a show of good faith,” Glimmer explained.

“No, that was *my* plan,” Adora said. She sounded like a petulant child, throwing a tantrum because she wasn’t getting her way. “I’m the one who—”

“Adora, stop it!” Catra shouted with such force that the entire room fell quiet. It was in that silence that Adora could hear the catch in Catra’s breath. When Catra looked into her eyes again, Adora could see that they shone with tears. “It doesn’t always have to be you, okay?”

Adora swallowed hard. “But—”

Catra cut her off. “No. This isn’t a negotiation. Me and Glimmer talked it through after you fell asleep and it just makes sense. Prime doesn’t give a shit about some traitor — you don’t have anything he needs. But the police chief’s daughter?” She looked back at Glimmer. “She could be of value.”

Glimmer nodded. “We’re going to tell him about my mom being undercover and make it seem like I know more about her plans than I actually do.”

“Are you sure that’s a good idea?” Bow asked.

“It’s risky,” Glimmer admitted, “but what part of this plan isn’t?”

Upset as she was, Adora couldn’t deny that it was a good plan. She wanted to argue, to point out big, obvious holes in their logic. But their idea was too solid. Catra was right — Adora didn’t have any leverage, and Prime would know it. From everything Adora had heard about him so far, Prime would probably just kill her, and then Catra would be on her own.

As if she could read her mind, Catra gently took Adora’s face in her hands and pressed their foreheads together. “You can be angry with me if you want, but it’s the right move, and you know it.”

“I just—” Adora struggled to form a coherent sentence. “What am I supposed to do?”

Catra laughed, and it had been so long since Adora had heard that adorable, squeaky sound that she nearly fell to her knees.

“You’re on the extraction team with Bow,” Catra said as though the answer should have been obvious. “Once Glimmer and I get the dirt on Prime, we’re gonna need you to bust us out of there asap.”

Adora pursed her lips as she considered the compromise. “Are you sure you’ll be safe?”

“Don’t worry, Adora.” Glimmer draped her arm around Catra’s shoulders. “Prime doesn’t stand a chance against the two of us.”


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Over the top of their heads, Adora met Bow's morose and defeated gaze. From the looks of things, he'd already begrudgingly accepted that this was an argument he couldn't win. So, Adora relented.

"Fine," she said. "But let the record show that I hate this plan."

Catra grinned. "Noted."

*

A couple of hours later, when everyone else was distracted with their own tasks, Adora slipped into one of the suite's bedrooms and closed the door quietly behind her.

They had finished putting the finishing touches on the plan. She and Bow knew exactly what they needed to do to get Catra and Glimmer out safely, and Entrapta and Scorpia would be on the ground and ready to provide back-up at a moment's notice. It was as good as it could get given the circumstances.

But as much as Adora loved a well laid plan, she hated this one. She hated the idea that she would have to wait, worried and useless, while her friends tried to blackmail the most powerful man in Etheria. It was dangerous. It was brash and reckless.

And, if something went wrong, it would be all her fault.

It would be her fault for not fighting harder for her original plan.

Her fault for not finding a way to stop the Horde before things got this far.

Her fault for leaving in the first place.

"Adora?"

At the sound of her name, Adora whirled around to see Catra sliding into the room.

“I saw you sneak off,” Catra said, keeping her voice low. “What’s wrong?”

Adora bit her lip and looked away. She knew there was no point in lying — Catra could read her like a book.

But when Adora didn’t answer, Catra sighed. She took a step closer, overwhelming Adora’s senses with her presence alone. “Listen, I know you’re mad at me, but—”

“I’m not mad at you,” Adora interrupted. “I’m scared. I don’t— If something happens to you—”

“It won’t.”

“You don’t know that, Catra.”

For a moment, neither of them spoke. Catra’s mismatched eyes searched Adora’s face as if she might find the answer to all of their problems hidden in the flush of her cheeks or the curve of her mouth.

“We’re so close, Adora,” Catra whispered. She reached up and traced a fingertip across Adora’s bottom lip. “We’re almost out.”

Adora closed her hand around Catra’s and pressed a kiss into her palm. She swallowed against the catch in her throat. “I’m so sorry, Catra.”

“Sorry for what?”

“We wouldn’t have to do any of this if it weren’t for me.”

Catra shook her head, rustling her short hair that Adora still hadn’t gotten used to. “We’d still be in the Horde if it wasn’t for you. We’d probably still be getting played by Shadow Weaver if it wasn’t for you. Hell, we might already be dead by now if it wasn’t for you.” She tipped her head to the side, her expression thoughtful. “I’m not saying I’m over what happened—I still wish

you'd just been honest with me from the start. I missed you, Adora. I didn't know what to do without you."

Guilt clawed at Adora's insides. She pulled back, trying to turn away. "I know, and I'm so—"

"I swear, if you say you're sorry, I'm going to lose my mind." Catra took Adora by the shoulders, forcing her to look at her; forcing her to stay. "Seriously, you're acting as if *you* were the one who stayed with the Horde and made them more powerful than ever."

Adora tried to smile. "Strange flex, but okay."

"Listen, I have a lot of shit to atone for," Catra said, playing at nonchalance. "Let me have this."

Despite Catra's attempt at levity, Adora couldn't seem to absolve herself from the consequences of her actions. She knew what Catra was doing — she knew all too well how quick Catra was to gloss over her own pain. No one disowned their trauma quite like she did.

"Nothing bad is going to happen to me, Adora," Catra insisted. "We have a plan, and it's gonna work."

"But bad things have already happened to you, Catra," Adora blurted. She felt as though she was possessed; suddenly all of the things she'd been too afraid to say came spilling out of her as if someone else was speaking for her. "That's what I'm saying! As soon as I was initiated—as soon as I realized what the Horde was really about—I knew I had to get you out of there, but— ow!"

Catra's hands had tightened on Adora's shoulders so tightly that it hurt. But it was clear from the wide-eyed, horrified look on Catra's face that she wasn't trying to inflict pain — she was simply reacting to it.

"Who told you?" Catra asked in a strained whisper. She didn't say anything else, but she didn't need to: Adora knew what she was talking about.

“Bow hacked into the Horde’s network using Entrapta’s tablet,” Adora confessed. “I found the initiation videos, and I…” She couldn’t think of what to say next.

Catra’s expression grew distant, vacant. She yanked her hands back and wrapped her arms around herself instead.

“You watched it?” Catra’s voice was so quiet, so small.

Adora nodded slowly. “I did.”

The color drained from Catra’s face. “I didn’t want you to know.”

“I’m sorry,” Adora said gently. “I’m sorry they did that to you.”

“I took care of it,” Catra said, taking another distracted step back. “It’s fine — I’m fine.”

“I know you took care of it,” Adora replied. “And I’m so proud of you for getting yourself out of there. But it’s not fine, Catra. Nothing about it’s fine, and you don’t have to be either.”

She watched as Catra seemed to shrink into herself, withdrawing into a space where no one could follow.

“But I want to be fine.” Catra’s voice was barely a whisper.

Moving slowly, cautiously, Adora held out her arms. She reached for Catra without encroaching on her personal space. She wanted Catra to have the choice — to know that she would be there if she wanted her to be. “I want you to be fine too,” she said. “I want you to be better than fine. I want you to be happy, Catra. It’s okay if you’re not there yet. But if you’ll have me, maybe we can figure out how to get there together?”

The seconds that followed dragged on like hours. Catra lifted her eyes, sending silent tears tracing down her face. Adora held her breath and waited.

“You promise?” Catra asked at last.

Adora smiled, “I promise.”

Catra threw herself into Adora’s patient embrace, wrapping her arms around Adora’s neck. It was impossible for Adora to hold her as closely or as tightly as she wanted to — she wanted to stay that way forever, their edges fitting together perfectly as they clinged to one another for dear life.

But forever would have to wait a little longer.

“When this is over, I’m never going to let you go,” Adora murmured into Catra’s hair.

Catra lifted her face from where she was nuzzled into Adora’s neck and kissed her long and hard. When their lips finally parted, Catra smiled. “Then I guess we’d better get this over with, shouldn’t we?”

Chapter 45

As she stepped over the threshold into the lobby of Etheria's City Hall, Catra was well aware of the other line she was crossing: the point of no return.

This was it. Whatever lay ahead, whatever happened next, there was no turning back now.

"Ow! Would you take it easy?" Glimmer hissed under her breath. "You're gonna break my arm if you keep squeezing it like that."

"Sorry," Catra muttered. She relaxed her grip but kept it securely planted on the back of Glimmer's arm. Her mismatched eyes scanned the lobby, which was bustling with public servants hurrying between meetings and chatting over takeaway cups of coffee. She was waiting for security to materialize out of nowhere and escort her and Glimmer roughly out of the building, but no one gave them so much as a backwards glance.

Out of the corner of her eye, Catra could see Glimmer watching her as they marched toward the reception desk.

"Nervous?" Glimmer whispered.

Catra scoffed.

Glimmer smiled weakly. "Yeah, me too."

The tight knot in Catra's stomach unclenched by a fraction. Though she wouldn't admit it to a soul, she was glad that Glimmer was there. She was grateful to not be doing this alone, and she was even grateful to be playing this dangerous game with Glimmer, of all people. Sure, Catra still felt the sting of resentment toward Glimmer whenever she saw her and Adora together. It was hard to forget that this was the girl who had lured Adora away in the first place. But the more Catra got to know her, the more she had to admit that she saw the appeal of having a friend like Glimmer. She was tenacious, gutsy, and far smarter than Catra

initially gave her credit for. The fact that she was here at all said a lot about her character, and Catra admired her for it.

"How are your hands?" Catra asked as they waited for the young man at reception to finish with his phone call. She glanced down at the jacket that was draped over Glimmer's forearms. To anyone else, it would look as though Glimmer was merely holding it in front of her body. But in reality, the jacket was hiding the zip tie that bound Glimmer's hands at the wrists.

"I haven't lost feeling in my fingers yet, if that's what you're asking." Glimmer glanced down at her front and then at Catra. "At least the zip ties are keeping me from messing with my equipment."

At this less-than-subtle dig, Catra dropped her spare hand back down to her side. She knew she wasn't supposed to mess with the small, inconspicuous streaming camera that Entrapta had hidden in the collar of her jacket, but there was some comfort to be found in affirming that it was still affixed in place. That camera was her connection to Adora; it made her feel safer.

Finally, the man behind the reception desk hung up the receiver and smiled politely up at them. "Good afternoon, ladies. How can I help you?"

"We have a meeting with the mayor," Catra said. Glimmer opened her mouth to add something, but Catra squeezed her arm, and she seemed to think better of it.

The young man's eyebrows shot up, and for a split-second Catra thought he was going to do something stupid like ask for I.D.. Instead, he motioned to a bank of elevators in the corner of the lobby.

"Of course. Just take any of the elevators to the top floor and follow the signage."

Catra waited until they'd crossed the room before letting out the breath she'd been holding.

“Geeze, are you always this rattled?” Glimmer teased. “It’s not like you were lying.”

“I know that.” Catra jabbed the ‘up’ button with a scowl. She did, in fact, have a meeting scheduled with Mayor Prime. Of all the ways she expected him to react when she finally surfaced after her unsanctioned sick-leave, him penciling her into his busy day wasn’t one of them. “And I’m *not* rattled — I’ve just never been to his office before.”

This was also true. In all the time that Catra had led the Horde, she never once stepped foot into City Hall. In fact, it had been expressly forbidden for members of the gang to come calling on the Mayor at his place of business. Apparently the man valued his work/life/crime balance. Still, when Catra had called to apologize for disappearing—for having the audacity to catch mono, of all things—Prime hadn’t threatened or scolded her. In fact, all he’d said was that he was glad that she was on the mend before telling her to book a time with his assistant for them to meet.

“That’s so weird,” Glimmer mused as the elevator dinged. “Even *I’ve* been here before. Although, in my defense, I didn’t know it was—”

“Shut it,” Catra snapped, shoving Glimmer forward as the doors slid open.

Glimmer squawked indignantly. She rounded on Catra with murder in her eyes. “Hey, what the hell?”

Catra gave Glimmer a pointed look as she motioned toward the top corner of the elevator, playing off the gesture as though she was brushing hair out of her face. Glimmer shrank back, and Catra knew she understood: the domed security camera in the corner saw everything, and no doubt heard it, too. Under its omniscient, unblinking eye, the pair needed to put on the performance of a lifetime.

The elevator ascended swiftly after Catra pressed the button for the top floor. They rode in strained silence, with nothing but the mechanical whir of the lift to drown out the sound of their shallow breath and racing hearts. When they slid to a halt, Catra grabbed the back of Glimmer's arm once more and felt that she was trembling. This time when Catra gave Glimmer a light squeeze, it was meant to be reassuring.

As it turned out, the 'signage' the man at reception referred to was hardly necessary. To the immediate left was a massive glass-walled board room, which boasted a long glossy table and a collection of expensive-looking executive chairs. There was only one other door on the entire floor, so Catra steered Glimmer toward it. She reached out to knock, only for the door to swing out before her knuckles connected with the frosted glass. One of Prime's towering, white-clad cronies filled the doorframe. He looked the girls over without speaking, lingering curiously on Glimmer before stepping aside and ushering them through a receiving chamber and into Prime's office.

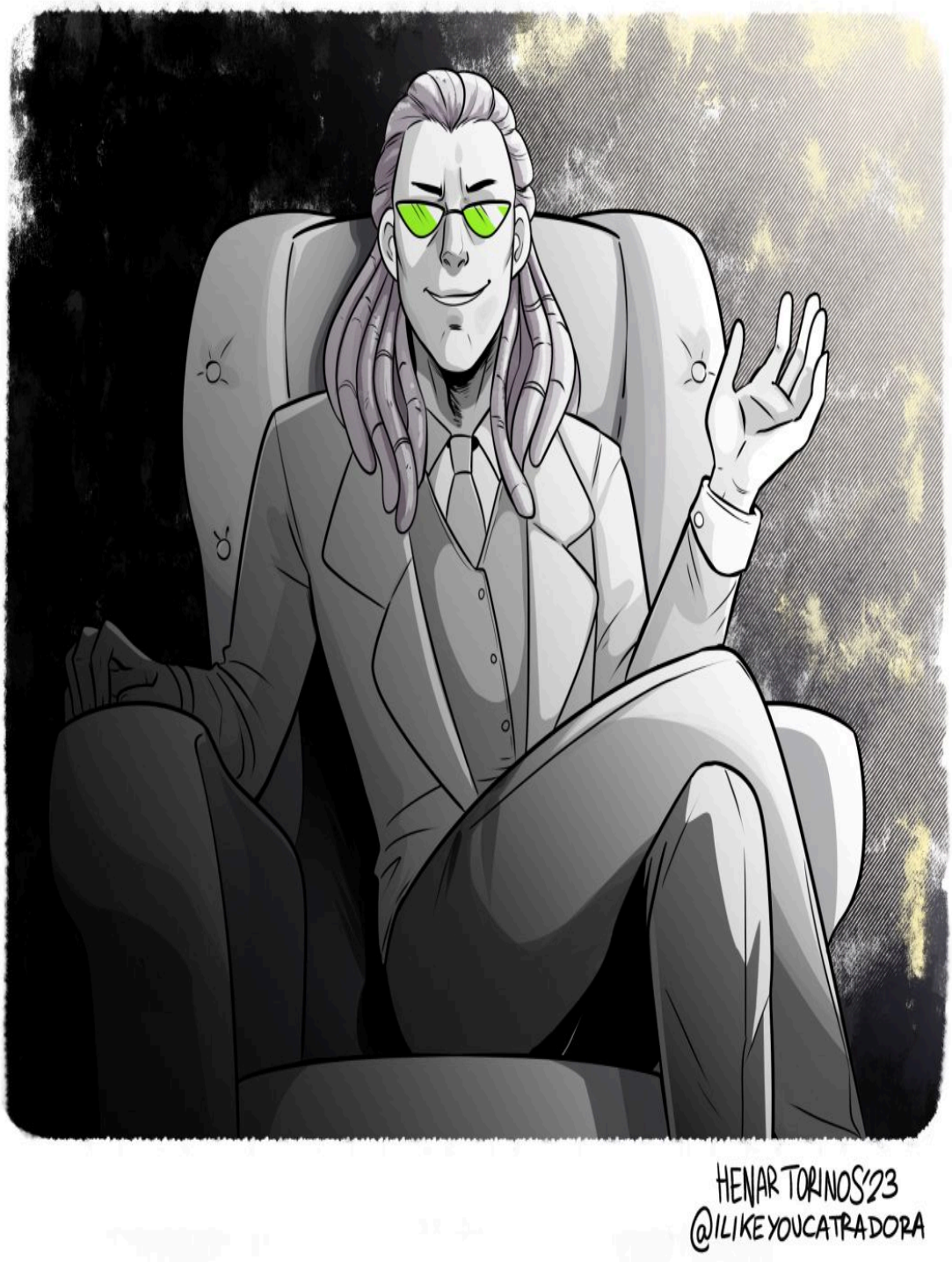
It took effort for Catra to control her reaction. To call this space an 'office' felt like a cruel joke. The room was massive — bigger than her entire apartment combined. It was fashioned with sleek furniture and white quartz that shimmered in the light that poured in from the full wall of windows on the opposite side of the chamber. A tidy desk the size of the Brightmoon's dining table sat silhouetted in front of the windows, behind which an office chair was turned away. Outside, the city stretched as far as the eye could see. It was the perfect view for a reigning despot.

Swallowing hard, Catra shoved Glimmer forward toward the desk.

"Thank you for making time to meet with me, Sir," Catra said, her words almost echoing in the cavernous space.

"But of course." The velvety drawl of Prime's voice drifted not from the turned chair, but from a shadowy sitting area to the left that Catra hadn't even noticed. She and Glimmer jumped at the sound of it, freezing like a pair of mice in the middle of an open field. A

lamp clicked on, bathing Prime's sharp features in cool white light. He smiled like a hawk. "Anything for my favorite little sister."



Though the very sight of Prime made her blood run cold, Catra turned to face him. She needed to make sure he was captured in the camera's lens. With a rough yank, she dragged Glimmer over

to the sanitized glow of the lamp. Prime's gaze was inscrutable as he took them both in.

"You didn't tell me you were bringing a friend," Prime said almost playfully.

"She's not my friend," Catra said with as much disdain as she could muster.

Hooking his ankle over his knee, Prime leaned an elbow into the arm of his chair and tapped his chin thoughtfully. "Then why is she here?"

"This is Angella Brightmoon's—"

"I'm aware of who she is." Prime's eyes flitted to Glimmer. "I'm terribly sorry about your mother, Miss Brightmoon. She was the finest officer this city has ever known — rivaled only by your father."

Catra felt Glimmer go rigid in her grip.

Prime slid his gaze back to Catra. "I'll ask again: why is she here?"

"Consider her an apology gift," Catra said. Her mouth was impossibly dry, which made every word an effort to speak. "Atonement for being unavailable recently." She pulled the jacket off of Glimmer's hands so Prime could see the zip ties.

"An interesting choice," he drawled, considering Glimmer with slightly more interest now. "I can't say I was in the market for an orphan, but I suppose it's the thought that counts."

At this, Glimmer bristled and Catra let out a mean-spirited laugh.

"And what if I told you she isn't an orphan?" Catra was starting to loosen up now. She felt herself slipping into the role she was tasked with playing. Prime quirked an eyebrow.

"Go on."

“Angella Brightmoon is alive,” Catra said. “She’s gone underground and is working to undermine the Horde.” She shoved Glimmer roughly to her knees. “And little miss sparkles here knows all about it.”

“I don’t know shit,” Glimmer spat. “And even if I did, I wouldn’t tell you, bitch.”

A sharp smile cut across Prime’s face. “Well, that certainly does change things. Well done, little sister.”

Relieved, Catra let herself smile.

Prime rose elegantly to his feet and stepped up to Glimmer, whom he helped back up off the floor. All of Glimmer’s bravado faltered under his touch, and her terrified eyes swiveled to Catra as she was led to a white leather sofa.

“Have a seat, Miss Brightmoon,” Prime cooed as he eased her down. She did as he wished, albeit stiffly; a stubborn doll with plastic joints. “It sounds like you and I have a great deal to discuss. But first…” He turned his attention back to Catra, and the quality of his smile changed. There was something ominous in the way he beheld her that chased away any sense of ground gained. Like a shark, he circled her, and it took every ounce of willpower she had to stand her ground and not flinch away when he combed his fingers through her cropped hair.

“This is… different.” he said without inflection. Catra had to clear her throat in order to respond.

“I needed a change.”

With a thoughtful hum, Prime moved his hand to her shoulder and squeezed it tightly; too tightly. “Hopefully that’s all that has changed.”

The hairs on the back of Catra’s neck stood on end. “What’s that supposed to mean?” she asked and hoped he couldn’t tell how hard her heart was pounding.

“A lot has happened in your absence,” Prime said cooly, “very little of it good. You left us with quite a mess on our hands.”

“It’s a mess I intend on cleaning up, I promise.”

“I don’t trade in promises.” The smile on Prime’s face slid away. His gaze was dispassionate. “I need to see loyalty in action, and since the raid at the Waste I’ve seen absolutely nothing from you.”

Panic rose like bile in Catra’s throat. Her mind screamed with alarm bells. “That’s why I brought you the girl,” Catra argued. “I know I let you down, but I’m just as committed to the Horde as I’ve always been. I’m here, I’m healthy, and I’m ready to get back to work. Just tell me what you want me to do.”

For a few agonizing moments, Prime didn’t say a word. He stared down at Catra, watching her squirm — no doubt reveling in the power he had over her. The man reeked of sadistic intent. Then, just when Catra was certain she couldn’t take his mind games a second longer, he spoke.

“What do you think?” he asked loudly, seemingly more to the room than to her. “Do you believe her?”

Catra hesitated. She glanced at Glimmer, wondering if the question was intended for her. Glimmer opened her mouth, but before she could answer, another voice beat her to it.

“Not in the slightest, Sir.”

The bottom of Catra’s stomach gave way. For a split second, she was certain that she had to be dreaming. She knew that voice; missed it and dreaded it at the same time. Her attention snapped to the giant desk by the windows, and the chair that was turning to face them.

“You,” Catra breathed in horrified disbelief as the chair’s occupant slid into view. Her knees nearly buckled at the familiar sight of that gnarled face and cruel smile.

“Hello to you too, Catra,” Shadow Weaver said.

Chapter 46

The sound of Shadow Weaver's voice in her earpiece made Adora's blood run cold. For a split-second reality slipped and the moment felt more like a nightmare. It took the warm and steady hand of Bow gently squeezing her shoulder to bring her back to reality.

"Just breathe, Adora," he whispered. "It's going to be okay. Glimmer and Catra have got this."

Adora swallowed the lump of fear in her throat and glanced around nervously. She and Bow were roaming City Hall, stacks of pizza boxes held in each of their arms. They had needed a reason to be in the building so they could be close by — just in case. Pizza was what they'd come up with. The guy at the front desk hadn't batted an eye when she announced that they were there to deliver an order to the accounting department.

"Looks like someone's having a party!" Bow chirped, smiling widely over his stack of boxes.

"I guess so," the guy replied. "Tell them to let me know if they have any leftovers, okay? I forgot to bring my lunch today."

"Sure thing, pal!" Adora called over her shoulder. She was already half-way to the elevators, almost sprinting to catch one before its door closed. Once inside, she held the door open with her foot while Bow scampered after her. They rode it up to the second floor in tense silence, shielding their faces from the watchful eye of the security camera beneath the brims of their borrowed baseball caps.

No one seemed to notice or care as the pair of them wandered through the building, which made it easy for them to monitor Catra and Glimmer's progress via the surreptitious earpieces they all wore. Outside, in a van parked along the street, Scorpia and Entrapta were monitoring the video feed as it transmitted from

the miniscule camera hiding in Catra's jacket. Up until that moment, everything had been going so smoothly that Adora almost didn't care that the audio was her only connection to Catra and Glimmer.

But Shadow Weaver hadn't been part of the plan. Adora could feel the adrenaline spiking in her system; an old familiar response to the sound of a voice that still haunted her nightmares after all this time. She could imagine how Catra must be feeling in that moment, unexpectedly face to face with their life-long tormentor. It killed Adora to not be there with her now, and it took every ounce of willpower she had not to throw her decoy pizza to the ground and race for the top floor. Instead, she chose to trust Bow. She kept her head low, followed Bow up another flight of stairs, and listened to the drama unfolding in her ear.

"What are you doing here?" Catra demanded. She was doing an admirable job of acting hard and collected, but Adora knew her better than that — she could hear the subtle note of alarm around the edges of Catra's voice, that she was fighting to stay calm. "Last I heard, you were behind bars."

"I posted her bail," drawled Prime, his velvety tones making the hairs on the back of Adora's neck stand on end. "She isn't much good to me in prison."

Of course, Adora thought bitterly. *Leave it to Shadow Weaver to still be playing both sides*. She felt foolish for having ever believed that Shadow Weaver had her best interests at heart, embarrassed by the part of her that had always wanted to measure up to her expectations. The only person Shadow Weaver cared about was herself.

"That's bullshit!" Glimmer spat, feisty as ever, even under the circumstances. "I know for a fact that she wasn't up for bail. What did you do, play your mayor card to arrange a jailbreak?"

Cupping a hand over his earpiece, Bow grinned. "That's my girl," he whispered. "Call it what it is: political corruption!"

Adora was grateful that Glimmer still had the presence of mind to gather evidence. Catra was painfully silent. In her mind, Adora could perfectly picture the panic-stricken expression that was no doubt cemented to Catra's face — the one that anyone who didn't really know her might mistake for bored indifference.

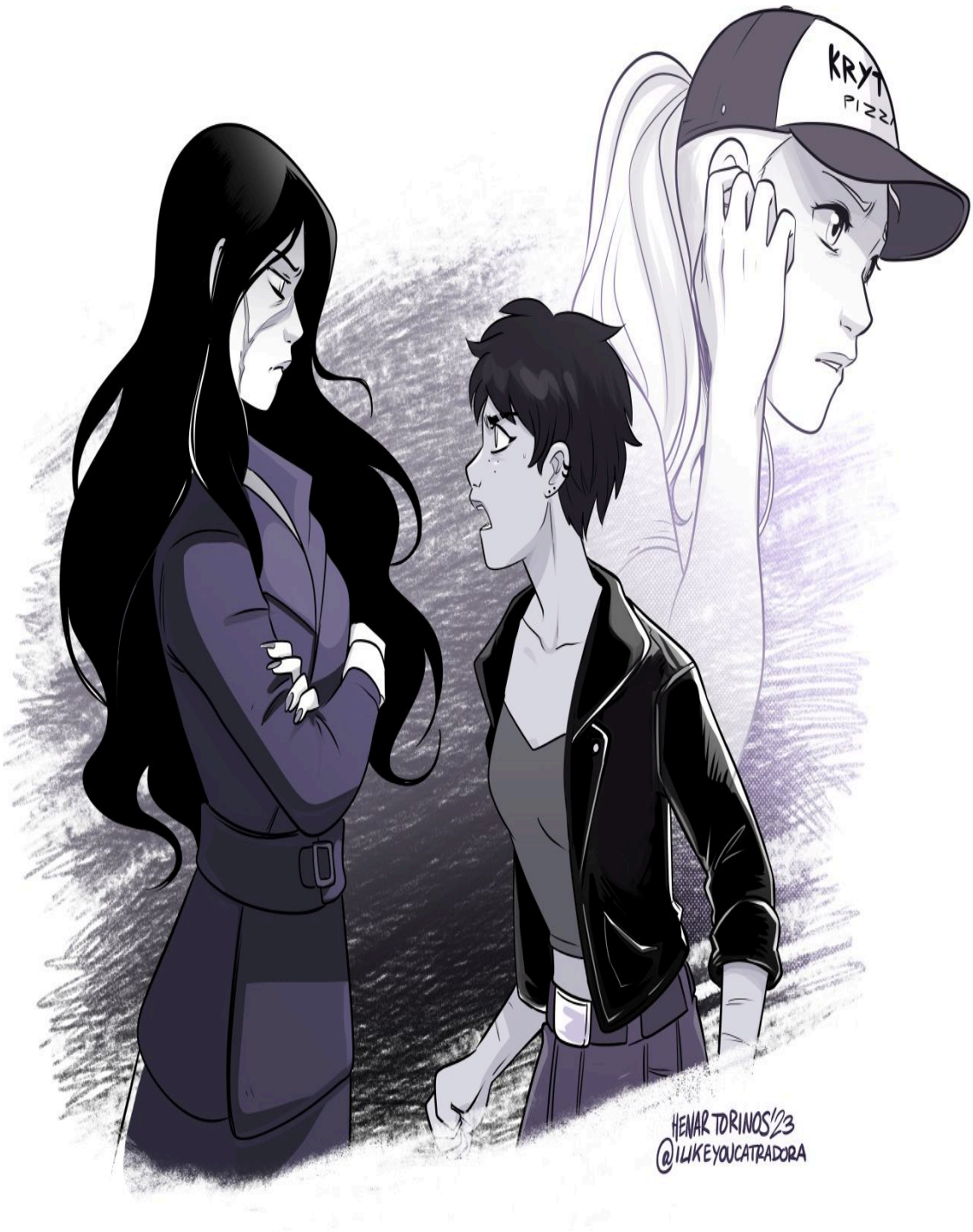
"We should get up there," Adora hissed. "This wasn't part of the plan."

"They can handle this, Adora," Bow replied, steady as always. "Let's let them play it out a little bit longer."

Again, Shadow Weaver's voice filled their earpieces. "Have these two been checked for wires?"

"Ha ha! Go for it, I dare you!" Entrapta cut in on the line, loud enough to make both Adora and Bow wince. Adora could forgive the resulting headache though; Entrapta had earned the right to be boastful. After taking one look at the recording equipment provided by Scorpia's parents, Entrapta had gotten to work making alterations to eliminate extraneous wires and reduce the size of everything so that it would be harder to find under inspection.

Adora's heart leapt as Catra's scoff sounded in her ear.



"Oh, please," Catra said, her voice laced with hatred. "You really think I'm the shady one here? I've got nothing to hide." There was a rustling that Adora knew was Catra lifting the hem of her shirt and turning in place to bare her wire-free torso.

Glimmer laughed. “Seriously — that’s rich coming from you, Shadow Weaver. Mayor Prime, do you know why she was in jail in the first place?”

“I was picked up under suspicion and held on some trumped up charges,” Shadow Weaver said indignantly. “A violation of my rights, I’ll have you know. I have half a mind to sue.”

“Is lying the only thing you know how to do?” Glimmer asked. “Because that is *not* what happened. You turned yourself in! You were ready to trade everything you knew about the Horde in exchange for immunity.”

“You spoiled little brat,” Shadow Weaver snarled. “How dare—”

“Yes, I’m well aware of Shadow Weaver’s immunity deal,” Prime drawled, as casually as if he was talking about the weather. Adora and Bow exchanged a confused glance. The part of Adora that hated Shadow Weaver — the part of her that was angry over the lifetime of abuse and manipulation that miserable woman had inflicted on her — was furious. How, after everything she’d done, did Shadow Weaver keep winning? Adora didn’t want to believe that being a terrible person was the only way to get ahead in life, but Shadow Weaver’s entire existence seemed to make a compelling case for the contrary.

But at the same time, alarm bells were sounding in the back of Adora’s mind. She had never met Prime but, based on everything Catra told her about the man, he didn’t seem like the type to give a traitor a second chance. He was too cruel and too cunning, and something just wasn’t adding up.

“I don’t understand,” Catra said slowly, her words respectful and carefully measured. “If you know about the immunity deal, why is she here? She was going to sell us out to save herself!”

“Watch your tongue, you insolent whelp.” Shadow Weaver spoke in the same low voice that Adora had long recognized as a threat. Any Horde child on the receiving end of that tone knew they were

in danger. Instinctively, Adora clenched her hands, mangling the bottom pizza box in the process. There was commotion in her ear — the sound of movement and a startled gasp from Glimmer and cries of alarm from Scorpia and Entrapta.

"Scorpia, talk to us," Adora demanded as she picked up the pace. She skipped the next floor and kept climbing the stairs, taking the steps two at a time. "What's going on?"

"She was going to hit her!" Scorpia replied. "Shadow Weaver tried to hit Catra, but Prime stopped her and—"

"That is quite enough," said Prime, unnervingly cool as always.

"But Sir, I— ah!" Shadow Weaver's words were cut short by a heavy *thwump*.

"Oh, man," Entrapta whispered, "Prime just threw Shadow Weaver to the ground."

Adora's mouth went dry with dread. Something didn't feel right. "Keep talking. What's happening now?"

Neither Scorpia nor Entrapta answered. Instead, Prime's voice filled the airspace between them.

"I understand your confusion, so allow me to explain: I've brought Shadow Weaver here for you, little sister."

"For… me?" For the first time since setting foot in Prime's office, Catra's stony facade slipped. Adora held her breath. "What do you mean?"

"You're here for a second chance, are you not?" Prime asked.

"Yes…" The wariness in Catra's voice put Adora even more on edge than she already was. Catra was usually so confident — so good at reading situations and knowing exactly how to twist them in her favor. But if something about this one made Catra uneasy, Adora knew to trust her instincts. She glanced at Bow, who was

already watching her closely from beneath his knitted brow, and motioned upwards with a jerk of her head. They needed to pick up the pace.

As they quickened their pace, Prime droned on. “And I truly want to believe that you deserve it. But I didn’t get to where I am today on blind faith. Can I trust you, little sister?”

“Of course!”

“Then prove it.”

Through the earpiece, Adora heard Scorpia and Entrapta gasp in unison.

“Adora, we have a problem!” Scorpia shouted.

“What?” Adora demanded, her voice echoing throughout the stairwell. “What happened?”

“There’s a gun! Prime has a gun and he…” Scorpia trailed off for a moment. “He’s… handing it to Catra?”

Adora didn’t realize she’d dropped the pizzas until they toppled to the floor at her feet. The cardboard tower tumbled down the stairs, flinging greasy slices sliding across the concrete floor like an oil spill.

In her ear, Adora heard Catra suck in a sharp inhale. “What am I supposed to do with this?”

“Isn’t it obvious?” Prime’s voice dripped with sinister glee. “I want you to show Shadow Weaver what the Horde does to traitors. I want you to kill her.”

Chapter 47

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

*[**Content warnings:** violence, gun use, blood, death. Please see the end of the chapter for specific details and take care when reading.]*

Prime's words played on a loop in Catra's mind until they lost all meaning. What he was telling her to do and the idea of actually going through with it created a cognitive dissonance so strong that Catra's head ached.

She turned the gun over in her hands, hyper aware of the cool metal against her skin. The weight of a handgun — so little yet so heavy — always struck her as strange. She recognized something of herself in it: they were both small, easy to underestimate, but deadly all the same.

The gun felt foreign to her, like a word in a language she didn't understand. Which was strange, because this wasn't the first time she'd held one. All Horde kids were taught to use a gun. As soon as they were strong enough to hold one at eye-level, the kids learned how to clean, load, and fire the small collection of illegal firearms in the Horde's arsenal. The kids weren't allowed to carry them — hell, Catra didn't even have one now, despite her elevated position in the gang — but they had to know how to use them, just in case.

It had been years since Catra fired a gun, but she still remembered how to use it.

The question was: would she use it now?

She could feel Prime's eyes on her, watching. This was a test Catra wasn't sure she could pass.

“Is there a problem?” Prime asked, his voice as cold as a biting winter wind. He dropped his gaze down to where Shadow Weaver sat in a quivering lump on the floor. “I thought this would be easy for you, little sister. After all, think of what she’s done to you.”

Adrenaline surged through Catra’s veins, her nerves flaring. It was as if Prime was reading her thoughts. Did he know how many times she’d wished for an opportunity just like this? The number of nights she lay awake on the filthy mattress she shared with Adora, fantasizing about all the ways she’d get back at Shadow Weaver if only she was a little bit braver? A bullet between the eyes would be a mercy compared to what that miserable woman deserved. Catra would carry the evidence of Shadow Weaver’s sins on her until she herself was turned to dust.

In the scars across her arms and back.

In the fissure through her heart that never seemed to heal.

In the way that trust would never come easily ever again.

Yes, Prime was right: killing Shadow Weaver would be the easiest thing Catra ever did.

She watched as her hands repositioned the gun in her grip, seemingly of their own volition. Her finger tip grazed the trigger, feeling the smooth slope of it and marveling at how something so small could lead to so much devastation.

“What are you doing??” Glimmer cried, her wide eyes locked on the gun. “Put that thing down!”

Catra barely heard her over the hammering of her own heart and the rush of blood in her ears. She stared down at Shadow Weaver, both revolted and transfixed by the horrified look on her tormentor’s ruined face.

“You wouldn’t,” Shadow Weaver said, though her tone said she herself wasn’t so sure.

“Stand up,” Catra commanded. She motioned upward with the barrel of the gun, making Shadow Weaver flinch and Glimmer gasp.

Shadow Weaver hesitated. “Why would—”

“Did I stutter? I said get up!”

This time Shadow Weaver did as she was told. Disheveled and trembling, she scrambled to her feet and held her hands up, pleading. “Catra, please. I—”

Her words fell short as Catra lifted the gun and took aim. Unlike Shadow Weaver, Catra’s hands were steady.

“Stop!” The pitch of Glimmer’s frantic voice soared. “This is insane!”

Catra addressed her without shifting her gaze away from the woman trapped in her crosshairs. She chose her words carefully, and hoped Glimmer would understand.

“How are your hands, Sparkles?”

For a split second, the world ground to a halt. Time seemed to move in slow motion as Catra watched Prime and Shadow Weaver’s expressions register their confusion. Then, with a warrior-like bellow, Glimmer raised her hands above her head and brought them — or rather, the space between them — down hard and fast against her body, just like Catra had taught her. The zip tie gave way with a snap, and Glimmer was sprinting for the door before the plastic even hit the ground.

This was Catra’s moment. She held her breath, adjusted her aim, and pulled the trigger.

She fired once, twice; again and again until the gun was empty.

In Shadow Weaver’s eyes, Catra saw a fear she never thought someone that evil was capable of. It was more satisfying than she

thought possible.

Shadow Weaver whirled around to the wall of windows, where crooked spider web cracks reached out from every bullet hole Catra had shot into it. Even though it was empty, Catra hurled the gun as hard as she could, then turned to run. She didn't get to see it collide with the window, but she relished in the sound of the glass shattering.

At the doorway, Glimmer grappled with Prime's henchman. She was holding her own, but they didn't have time for her to get the upper hand. Catra screamed, and when the man turned she rammed her shoulder into his hip. With his center of gravity destabilized, she had no trouble throwing him to the ground. She and Glimmer barreled into the antechamber and slammed the door shut behind them. They barricaded it with the desk and knocked a filing cabinet down for good measure, but Catra knew it wouldn't hold them back for long. As the pair spilled out of the office, Catra held the door closed while Glimmer dashed down the hall and started mashing the elevator button.

"C'mon, c'mon…" Glimmer hissed. They watched the elevator light creep up each floor number. Without easing up her assault on the call button, Glimmer glanced back at Catra. "You scared the shit out of me. I seriously thought you were going to shoot her!"

"Give me some credit, Sparkles," Catra replied. "I may have grown up in the Horde but I'm not a complete monster. We just needed a distraction."

The sound of furniture slamming boomed from the office. Catra tightened her grip and braced her foot on the wall just as someone started pulling on the door from the inside.

"Shit!" She grunted with the effort it took to keep the door from flying open. "Why didn't we take the stairs?"

"Fuck! *That's* what the door in Prime's reception office is for." Glimmer's voice felt too loud for the hallway to contain.

The elevator was almost there, only one more floor to go. But the distance between the office door at the elevator was far — too far, Catra realized, to cross without being caught. There was nothing to block the door, nothing to litter behind her to slow their pursuers down. Even if she made it to the elevator, there was no way those golden doors would have a chance to close before someone reached them. As if to confirm her fear, the office door shuddered. Catra's hands were so sweaty that she almost lost her grip.

A bright ding sounded, announcing the elevator's arrival. Glimmer squeezed into it before the doors had finished opening and Catra heard her slam a button inside. A split-second later, Glimmer's pink-haired head appeared again.

"Hurry," she shouted. "I don't know how long the door will hold!"

It turned out the answer was 'not long'. Within seconds, the elevator let out an angry buzzing and started automatically sliding the doors closed. Glimmer swore and pushed back against it, but the door kept sliding undeterred. Her face was flushed, her teeth clenched. Glimmer was frantic — terrified —but Catra knew she wouldn't let that stop her.

"Catra, come on!"

They wouldn't make it. Catra knew it in her bones, just like she knew there was no point in arguing with Glimmer about it.

So, Catra reasoned, she wouldn't bother.

"Adora," Catra said quietly, trusting the microphone to relay her message, "I'm sorry."

She let go of the door handle and ran. Prime's goon was already on her heels before she had even made it halfway down the hall. The elevator doors were almost shut. Glimmer trembled with the effort to keep them open.

"Hurry!" Glimmer screamed. "He's right behind—"

Catra reached out and shoved her, hard. Startled, Glimmer tumbled into the elevator. Their eyes met just as Catra turned back toward the henchman, fists raised and ready to fight.

*

Adora's blood felt like ice water in her veins as she listened to Glimmer's voice screaming over the earpiece.

"Catra's still up there!" Glimmer explained through tears. "I think… I think she saved me."

With her heart on fire, Adora picked up her pace. She pushed through the searing cramp in her legs as she continued to scale the stairs two at a time.

"Glimmer, where are you?" Bow asked, his voice echoing through the stairwell.

"I'm getting off on the eighth floor," she said.

"The cavalry's coming, guys," Entrapta's voice crackled in their ears at the same moment Scorpia shouted, "Wildcat needs help *now!* "

Adora stopped and turned to Bow. "Go find Glimmer and make sure she gets out of here safely."

He opened his mouth to argue but Adora was already moving again. "I've got Catra. Just go!"

She could tell by the sound of his footsteps that Bow was descending, and she was grateful he hadn't put up a fight. It helped to know that she didn't have to worry about him and Glimmer, because the only thing that mattered to Adora now was Catra.

By the time Adora stumbled up the final step, every breath she drew was a battle. She had to shove at the door on the landing a few times to get it open enough to squeeze through. A quick scan

around the room explained why: the door opened into a small reception office that appeared to have been ransacked. A filing cabinet lay tipped on its side, partially blocking the stairwell door. A desk and chair had been flipped as well. Two other doors accessed the office, one of which led to a hallway. The other boasted a polished gunmetal sign that read ‘Mayor Prime’.

Before barging in, Adora took stock of her surroundings and searched for something to use as a weapon. She spotted a glass-encased emergency cabinet that housed a sizable fire extinguisher. All it took was one well-aimed kick for her to shatter the glass. Immediately, an ear-splitting alarm cut through the air. As she ripped the extinguisher from the bracket, Adora hoped the fire alarm would cover the sound of her entrance. She leapt over the fallen filing cabinet and slammed into the door to Prime’s office, nearly knocking it off its hinges.

Adora charged forward with a primal scream, taking in the scene as she barreled through the chic office. In the split second before everyone turned to face her, Adora clocked Prime glowering down at where his bodyguard struggled to keep Catra pinned to the floor. Catra, battered and bloody as she was, refused to go down without a fight. She thrashed and kicked at her captor, and her tenacity sent a swell of pride rushing to Adora’s heart. Another split second later all eyes were on Adora, including the wide and shocked gaze of Shadow Weaver, who sat cowering against the far wall. The entire scene was backlit by the dazzling light of midday pouring in through the shattered wall of windows. At this height, the wind howled its displeasure.

Before anyone could react, Adora raised the fire extinguisher and aimed the nozzle right in the bodyguard’s face. She let out a blast of chemical cold, earning a yowl of pain and confusion from her opponent. He spit and pawed at his eyes, and Adora took advantage of his momentary distraction by bringing the extinguisher’s canister crashing down on his head. The blow landed with a sickening crack, and the goon crumpled to the floor.

By the time Adora lifted her head, Prime was already on top of Catra. He closed his fist around her throat and hoisted her off the ground in one terrifyingly fluid motion.

"No!" Adora screamed. She hurled the fire extinguisher, but Prime batted it aside as if it was a house fly. Catra clawed at his hand and forearm, desperately fighting for breath as he tried to squeeze the life out of her. Adora grabbed the tall lamp that glowed beside a sleek armchair. The cord snapped as she swung it over her head like an ax and brought it down hard on Prime's shoulder. He let out a furious bellow, but still he clung to Catra's neck like an animal unwilling to release its prey. When Adora swung the lamp again, he caught it in his free hand and held it with the same ferocity. Adora struggled, trying to free the lamp from Prime's grip. But Catra's face was turning blue, and Adora knew they were running out of time. She dropped the lamp and launched herself onto Prime's back. With one arm wrapped around his thick neck, she used her other hand to land one blow after another against the side of his head. He bellowed and staggered, trying to shake Adora loose. She dug her fingertips into the soft flesh around his eyes, determined to dig them out of that's what it took.

Finally, Prime let Catra fall from his fist. But the relief that Adora was short-lived – with both hands free, Prime grabbed whatever he could reach and launched forward, throwing her over his shoulders and sending her slamming into the cold marble floor. The impact knocked the breath from Adora's lungs.

"This must be the golden traitor I've heard so much about," Prime drawled as he wiped away the blood that trickled from his lips. "Adora, is it?" He grinned, revealing teeth that were stained red, like a wolf fresh from a feast. Exhausted and winded, Adora tried to scramble away but it was no use. Prime grabbed her by her ponytail and used it to drag her to her feet. Adora gritted her teeth and swallowed a yelp of pain; she didn't want to give him the satisfaction of seeing her cry.

“The only traitor here is you,” Adora spat, earning her a hard shake from Prime’s hand. The skin of her scalp throbbed in agony, but she didn’t stop. “You’ve betrayed this city’s trust and turned it into a wasteland.”

“A wasteland?” Prime chuckled. He walked toward the gaping hole where his floor-to-ceiling windows used to be, forcing Adora to follow at his side, and gestured widely to the city below them. The dizzying height made Adora’s head spin. “I don’t expect a child like you to understand the genius of what I’ve built, but know this: Etheria thrives because of me. You’re too young to remember what this city was like before me. It was a stunted, irrelevant mess. It needed a leader to bring it into an age of prosperity, and that’s exactly what I did. I created order where before there was only chaos.”

Now it was Adora’s turn to laugh. “All you’ve done is pit vulnerable people against each other to secure your own power. We’re all just pawns in your sick game.” She twisted in his grip so she could lock eyes with Shadow Weaver. “ *All* of us.”

Prime pinned her with his cool, dispassionate gaze. His energy was strangely placid, and it made Adora shudder involuntarily. At the sight of her unease, a sharp, cruel smile sliced across Prime’s bloody mouth. “Do you know what’s so wonderful about pawns, Adora?” With a jerk of his wrist, he pulled her face close to his and sneered. “They’re expendable.”

Before Adora could even register what he’d said, Prime flung her forward and released his hold on her hair. The force of his throw sent Adora tumbling. She hit the ground and slid across the polished marble, sending her legs swinging out into the nothingness beyond the window ledge. Her hands scrambled for purchase, desperately searching the slick floor for something to grab onto as gravity pulled her body down toward the chasm of the streets below.

This is it , she thought in disbelief. *I’m going to die.*

Then, just as her fingers slipped over the edge, something caught Adora by the wrist.

"I've got you!" Catra screamed. Her hands clasped Adora's forearms and held on with every ounce of strength she had left.



Panic scorched Adora’s insides. “Catra, stop! You’ll fall too!”

“I’m not letting go!” Catra replied through gritted teeth.

Over Catra’s shoulder, Mayor Prime stepped into view. His hands were clasped casually behind his back, as if two girls weren’t fighting for their lives at his feet.

“By tomorrow every news story in the city will be about how I survived an attack by two unhinged street urchins,” he mused thoughtfully while Adora scrambled, trying to pull herself up. “In response to such senseless violence, I’ll set my traumatic experience aside and instead launch a new initiative to help unhoused youth find their purpose in life. I’ll be hailed as a selfless hero, and the two of you?” Prime placed his foot on Catra’s back, knowing she was helpless to stop him. “Well, you’ll be dead.”

Adora and Catra locked eyes, their horror and helplessness reflecting back at each other in an infinite loop. Everything that could have been — the future that she and Catra should have had together — flashed before Adora’s eyes. The unfairness and rage of it all manifested as a scream in Adora’s throat.

And then—

A flash of movement—

Adora ripped her gaze from Catra just in time to see something — no, *someone* — racing toward them.

It was Shadow Weaver.

With a furious yell, the old woman launched herself at Mayor Prime, knocking him off balance. She locked her limbs around him as he pitched forward, and Adora and Catra could only scream as the pair sailed over the edge and fell down to the streets of Etheria.

“Holy shit!” Adora cried. “Holy shit, holy shit!”

“Focus, Adora!” Catra shouted. “I don’t know how much longer I can do this!”

The wind whipped at Adora’s back and made the world feel like it was swinging perilously around her. Once more, she summoned her upper body strength and tried to hoist herself upward. But even with the adrenaline coursing through her system, Adora’s body was weak. Catra strained and pulled, but her sweat-slicked hands were losing their grip.

Hopelessness settled across Adora’s shoulders like freshly poured concrete. She knew they were deadlocked: Adora not wanting to pull Catra down with her, Catra unwilling to let go. She closed her eyes.

“Hey!” Catra’s voice was furious. “You better not be giving up!”

“Catra, please,” Adora said, sobbing, “you have to let go.”

“Like hell she does!”

Adora’s eyes snapped open. Through her tears, she saw Glimmer emerge over Catra’s shoulders. Glimmer wrapped Catra in a bearhug. Bow appeared on Catra’s other side and grabbed Adora’s arm. Together, they helped hoist them back up over the ledge and onto solid ground. Trembling and breathless, the four friends fell back into each other’s arms on the polished floor of Prime’s office and held on for dear life.

The wind roared. In the distance, sirens seemed to come from every direction.

Everything else was still.

Only then, surrounded by the loving arms of her friends, did Adora realize that their nightmare was finally over.

Chapter End Notes

CONTENT WARNINGS:
- Catra handles and fires a gun
- Catra and Adora fight with Prime and one of his goons
- Shadow Weaver throws herself and Prime out the window, killing them both

Chapter 48

Adora and her friends waited in the gutted remains of Prime's office. Through their earpieces, Scorpia informed them to sit tight; help was on the way. In the background they could hear Entrapta shouting numbers that leapt chronologically by hundreds at a time. It took Adora a couple of minutes before she realized that the numbers represented viewers. Thousands of people were watching the feed that Entrapta and Scorpia's parents had set up to livestream the Horde's downfall.

Soon, all of Etheria would know just how deep the cancer burrowed into the marrow of their city.

Soon, everyone would know that Adora and Catra had been involved.

There would be no more hiding in the shadows for any of them.

The only sound in the room was the wind sweeping in through the jagged maw of the broken windows. It howled around the four friends who sat in a heap on the floor, their arms wrapped protectively around one another, and drowned everything out like thunderous white noise. Strangely soothed, Adora rested her cheek against the top of Catra's hair and breathed her in. She savored the warmth of Catra's face nuzzled into the crook of her neck. Aching bodies and bleeding skin aside, it was a peaceful moment.

That moment, unfortunately, was short-lived. There was shouting out in the hallway, voices calling out to them. Adora vaguely registered Bow shouting back in reply, or the sound of footsteps racing across the marble floor toward them.

From there, things happened quickly.

At first the paramedics tried to separate Adora and Catra, but when they realized one wasn't going anywhere without the other

they helped the pair over to the sitting area and sat them down on the sofa side by side. Adora held Catra's hand firmly as the paramedics examined their injuries and cleaned their wounds, only letting go long enough for them to tend to the cuts that criss-crossed her palms and fingers. When they finished, the paramedics draped them both in scratchy gray blankets. Catra lifted Adora's bandaged hand to her lips and blessed each fingertip with an achingly gentle kiss that made Adora's breath hitch with emotion.

Their tender moment was interrupted by the sound of Glimmer screaming out in the hallway. Both Adora and Catra tensed and shared a fearful glance.

What now? Adora wondered as she summoned what little strength she had left to defend her friend. But as she listened, Adora realized Glimmer wasn't in danger at all: the screams were excited, the tears were happy ones.

"What the hell?" Catra muttered, sounding both curious and anxious at the same time.

Then, as if in reply, a figure stepped into the room. Adora sat up in surprise as a bright, intense pair of eyes, framed by a carefully pinned hijab, met her gaze. "Chief Hope?"

Light City's police chief let out a heavy exhale. "Adora, thank goodness." Chief Hope crossed the floor in a handful of authoritative strides and kneeled in front of the girls. Her sharp features were tight with concern. "Are you two alright?"

"More or less." Adora's shoulder pinched angrily as she shrugged. "All things considered."

"All things indeed." Chief Hope's brows furrowed. "I trust you don't need me to tell you how unbelievably wreckless this was."

"You pronounced 'efficient' wrong," Catra quipped, snarky despite the way her voice wavered with exhaustion.

“I wish you had come to me. We could have worked together,” Chief Hope said. Catra scoffed and Adora shook her head.

“Did it work?” Adora asked. “Did you see the footage?”

“I’d say half of Etheria saw the footage,” a soft, melodic voice answered from the doorway.

Adora’s head shot up. Had she not already been sitting down, she likely would have fallen to her knees.

“Angella!” she cried as the former Chief of EPD made her way across the floor. Angella’s arm was wrapped around Glimmer, who clung to her mother’s side, her eyes red with tears. Bow beamed as he followed behind them. Catra’s mouth hung open, speechless.

Chief Hope stood aside so Angella could take her place. Without a word, Angella threw her arms around Adora and Catra’s shoulders and held them in a warm embrace.

“I am so proud of you,” she said as she pulled back. She glanced back at her daughter and Bow. “Of all of you. Together, you did what I never could. And you two—” she gathered Adora and Catra’s hands in hers “—opened my eyes. I can never thank you enough.”

Catra shook her head as if she were trying to shake off a dream. “I don’t understand. Where have you been?”

Though Angella smiled, her expression seemed heavy and sad. “I needed to know just how deep the Horde’s influence went in this city. I needed to experience the world that you and Adora and so many others have had to live in for myself.” She reached up and gently brushed some of Catra’s hair off her face. For a split-second, Catra tensed under her touch before sinking into the touch. “I needed to understand what’s been happening so I could figure out how to help fix things.”

A sea of questions flooded Adora's mind. She wanted to know everything — who Angella had met, what she had seen. But those could wait. Right now, only one question seemed to matter.

"So, how *do* we fix things?"

"I won't pretend to have all of the answers," Angella admitted. "But I have some ideas. It's going to be a big job, and it's going to take some time, but I think now's the time to try."

"How can we help?" Catra asked. Her question seemed to take everyone by surprise. Everyone, that is, except Adora, who gazed at Catra with so much love and pride that it brought tears to her eyes.

"One step at a time," Chief Hope chimed in. "First we need to do our due diligence and investigate what happened here today. My detectives from First City will need to interview all of you, and anyone else who helped you."

Adora's stomach dropped. She wrapped her arm around Catra and pulled her close, feeling protective. "Are we in trouble?"

Chief Hope exchanged a quick, knowing glance with Angella before answering. "My official, on the record answer is that I cannot comment on the outcome of this investigation at this time." She paused. Her lips quirked upward ever so slightly. "Off the record? You kids are heroes, and I'll do everything in my power to protect you."

It wasn't a perfect answer, but Adora had come to understand that justice was rarely that. She and the others had known the risks when they devised this plan. All that mattered was that Prime couldn't hurt anyone ever again, and the Horde's days were numbered. Regardless of what happened next, Adora believed wholeheartedly that it would be worth it.

"You are going to be okay, I promise," Angella said, looking both Adora and Catra in the eyes in turn. "And that is a promise I am determined to keep."

Wordlessly, Adora and Catra looked at one another. Neither of them trusted her promise completely. How could they? Lifetimes of broken promises and disappointment gave them more than enough reason to be skeptical. But this time they had something they hadn't before: hope.

Maybe, just maybe, this time would be different.

"We should clear out of here," Chief Hope said, breaking the silence. "I'm sure CSI is eager to start processing the scene."

"Good idea," Angella agreed. She got to her feet and immediately pulled her daughter into her arms. Adora and Catra rose and followed the others, lingering behind with their fingers laced together. Just as they reached the door, Catra stopped and tugged Adora gently back.

Turning, Adora looked Catra over with concern. "Are you okay?"

"I almost lost you," Catra replied, her voice catching and her mismatched eyes brimming with tears.

Adora's mouth worked silently, trying to find the right words to say.

Catra continued. "Don't you ever fucking scare me like that again!"

This time, Adora laughed. She pulled Catra closer and cradled her beautiful face between her hands. "I won't, I promise." Adora leaned forward and touched her forehead to Catra's. "Thanks for saving my life, by the way."

Catra scoffed. "You idiot." She grabbed the front of Adora's shirt in both of her fists, pulled against her, and pressed a deep kiss to Adora's lips. A thrill erupted in Adora's core, chasing away the pain and everything else. The kiss lingered; they took their time.

"I love you, Adora," Catra murmured against Adora's lips.

Adora's heart soared. It was amazing how three little words could change absolutely everything. She kissed Catra again, and then grinned. "I love you too, Catra."

They fell into an embrace and held each other like they were the only two people left in the world. Adora marveled at the warmth of Catra's body against hers and the way Catra's breath on her neck sent goosebumps racing across her skin.

"So this is it," Catra whispered. "Shadow Weaver, Prime… they're really gone."

A twinge of grief pulled at Adora's insides as she remembered the way Shadow Weaver had saved them both. It may well have been the only good thing that miserable old woman ever did in her entire life. Adora wasn't ready to explore the conflicting emotions that Shadow Weaver's sacrifice stirred up. Besides, there would be time enough to process those feelings now.

There'd be time enough for everything.

And so, Adora nodded. "It's finally over."

"Hey." Bow's voice pulled Adora and Catra from their shared reverie. They lifted their heads and found him and Glimmer waiting in the doorway.

Glimmer held out her hand. "Are you guys coming?"

Adora looked at Catra, who smiled back at her.

"Yes, please," Catra said, dragging Adora along with her. "Let's get the hell out of this place."

As she took in a deep breath, Adora could already tell that things were different. Even the quality of the air felt lighter and full of promise.

She and Catra linked arms with Glimmer and Bow, and together they strode out of the ruins of the past and into the brave new

world.


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Epilogue

Warm afternoon sunshine filtered through the window, bathing the pages of Adora's journal in golden light. Her pen cast dancing shadows as she scribbled down her thoughts. She always enjoyed this quiet hour after her weekly therapy session, when she'd decompress through writing while she waited for Catra to finish her own session. Sometimes, when a session left her thoughts and emotions running wild, this practice of pouring it all out onto paper helped her find a bit of calm in the storm.

But today's entry was a happy one; she'd spent most of her session talking about how she'd finally received her GED. The world had never felt more open, and now she was excitedly filling line after line with her plans for a future that once felt completely unattainable.

From behind the office door came the sounds of chairs scraping the floor and muffled voices raising back up from the low murmur of therapy-speak to normal conversation. Adora pulled out her phone to check the time — Catra's session was wrapping up. She smiled at her lockscreen photo of her and Catra, their grinning faces pushed close together as they mugged for the camera. Her camera roll was full of pictures just like it.

The door opened and Catra stepped out, their therapist following behind her. As much as they loved working with Perfuma, they all agreed that their enduring friendship presented a conflict of interest (especially after Perfuma and Scorpia started dating). It had taken a while, but eventually they'd found a new therapist they both liked. They'd been working with him for over a year, and sometimes Adora wondered how they'd ever gotten by without him.

"Thanks again," Catra said. She gave Melog, who rode perched across her shoulders nearly everywhere she went, a scratch behind his ear. "I'll give that guided meditation a try this week and let you know how it goes."

Their therapist nodded. “Sounds like a plan! You ladies have a great week; I’ll see you next Friday.”

Adora tossed her journal and pen into her bag and waved goodbye to their therapist before taking Catra’s hand. They walked down the stairs side by side and made their way outside.

“How’re you feeling?” Adora asked. “Was it a good session?”

Catra had to lean her head forward a bit so she could see around Melog. She smiled — a contented, genuine smile. “Yup. We mostly talked about ways to expand my mindfulness practice. He suggested a video channel I should check out.”

“Cool! Maybe we can do one of them together.”

The therapist’s office was only a handful of blocks away from the modest one bedroom apartment Adora and Catra shared. While the bus would have been faster, they liked walking to and from their appointments, especially when the days were as beautiful as this one. They didn’t live in the fanciest part of town — their neighborhood was tired and a little out of the way, made up of mostly shabby low-rise apartment buildings, bodegas, and laundromats. But to the girls, it was home.

A text tone sounded from Catra’s back pocket. She fished out her phone and read the message with a quiet hum.

“Scorpia wants to know if we want to hang out with her and Perfuma tonight,” she said.

“That sounds fun,” Adora replied. “Do they have anything in mind?”

“Takeout and game night. She says they can come to our place so we don’t have to go downtown.”

Adora let out a grateful sigh. Without a vehicle, it took them forever to get around the city. She appreciated that their friends always kept that in mind when making plans. Sometimes she

secretly wished that Catra still had her old motorcycle, but she knew it was for the best that it had been repossessed back during the trial. It would have haunted them both if they'd kept it; a ghost forever linking them to the disgraced former-mayor and the control he'd wielded over their lives.

As if she could read Adora's mind, Catra let out a frustrated huff. "I should really get my license. I'm sure I could find a used bike for cheap. It would be way easier."

"One thing at a time," Adora said, giving her a playful nudge with her elbow. "You've kinda got your hands full at the moment, Ms. Super-Important-Consultant-Lady."

Catra rolled her eyes and tried to hide a bashful smile behind Melog's fluff. The truth was they'd both been busy since the investigation into the Horde and resulting trials wrapped up. While Adora had poured herself into her education and fast-tracking her way to getting her GED in record time, Catra had gone straight to work. Her first order of business had been helping Angella Brightmoon campaign in Etheria's first mayoral election post-Prime. And now that Mayor Brightmoon was officially in office, Catra had accepted a brand new role as a social programs consultant at City Hall. Angella had worked hard to earn back Etheria's trust, and a big part of that work had been putting everything she'd learned about corruption and the city's vulnerable populations to good use. She'd campaigned on the changes that needed to happen, and she fulfilled her first campaign promise as soon as she stepped into office: hiring people with lived experience and knowledge to help her build programs and make changes that would make a real difference in the lives of her constituents.

It was a perfect role for Catra, who had both the experiences the role required and a burning desire to make amends for her transgressions. Within the first few months on the job she was already leading the charge to decriminalize sex work, and she was working with Entrapta to develop harm reduction initiatives to help support those impacted by drugs like Runestone and Robots.

“That reminds me,” Catra mused. “We’re presenting our reform proposal to the Foster Families Association next week. Can I practice my pitch on you tomorrow?”

Heart swelling with pride, Adora gave Catra’s hand a squeeze. “Of course! Anything I can do to help.” Catra thanked her with a quick kiss on the cheek that left Adora buzzing for more.

Their apartment building came into view. At the sight of home, Melog hopped down from Catra’s shoulders and strutted ahead of them like the marshal of the world’s smallest parade. Relieved of her adorable load, Catra rolled her shoulders and let out a contented sigh.

“So,” she said, cutting a glance at Adora, “have you talked to Sparkles or Bow yet?”

Adora knew what she was really asking and shook her head in response. “Nah, they’re busy with exams right now and I don’t want to distract them.” She thought about Glimmer and Bow, who were wrapping up the semester at First City University, and her heart ached fondly. She missed them so much, but she was buoyed by the knowledge that they’d be moving back to Etheria the following week. “I’ll tell them when they get back for the summer.”

Catra snorted. “How can someone so smart be so dumb at the same time? They’re your friends; they’d want to know that you passed your GED! You *know* Sparkles will be pissed when she finds out you waited to tell her.”

Laughing, Adora opened the building door and let Melog and Catra in ahead of her. “It’s honestly not that big of a deal.”

This made Catra, who was already a couple of steps up the stairs, stop mid-stride. She whirled around and loomed above Adora with her hands on her hips and a deadly look on her face. “Not a big deal? It’s a *huge* deal, Adora!”

"If you insist." Adora shrugged. "I just don't think it's worth interrupting our friends' studying to announce."

For a split second it looked like Catra wanted to keep arguing. But her phone chimed again, distracting her. Catra stole a quick peek at the screen and shook her head. Before Adora could ask her what the message said, Catra took Adora's face between her palms and pulled her in for a long, passionate kiss. She kissed her like they were already upstairs in the privacy of their apartment, her tongue sliding invitingly across Adora's while her mouth hungrily worked Adora's lips. Heat bloomed under where Catra's hands trailed across Adora's neck, fingers teasing along the soft fuzz of her undercut. She let Catra pin their bodies together, thrilling at the feeling of her soft breasts and toned muscles pressing into her own until her head spun with want.

"What's it gonna take for you to realize how worthy you are?" Catra murmured against Adora's lips.

"Don't know," Adora mumbled back. "Probably more of this." She was sliding her fingers under the hem of Catra's tank top when Melog let out an impatient yowl from the landing above them. The spell was broken and Catra pulled back. She stepped backwards up a step and left Adora gasping for more.

"Yeah, well, you're not getting anymore of *this* until you tell our friends your good news." Catra pressed the tip of her index finger to Adora's forehead and winked "Sucker."

"Hey! That's not fair!" Adora cried, but Catra was already dashing up the stairs with that squeaky laugh of hers. Flustered, Adora chased after her. By the time she reached the landing, Catra had already unlocked their apartment door and was dashing inside.

"Yeah, you'd better run," Adora exclaimed as she burst into the apartment after her, "because I'm going to tickle the hell out of—"

"SURPRISE!!"

The cacophony of voices was so loud and unexpected that it nearly knocked Adora off her feet. She gaped in breathless shock at the crowd of people crammed into the living room of the tiny apartment. Catra stood, beaming between Glimmer and Bow. They were joined by so many of Adora's favorite people; Perfuma with her arm looped around Scorpia's, Mayor Brightmoon and her sister-in-law Castaspella, Entrapta with her little rat Emily peeking out of her pocket. Even Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle—whom Adora and Catra had reconnected with in the months after the trial—were there. They were all surrounded by brightly colored balloons and streamers that hung from every corner. A sting ladened with glittering gold letters proclaimed CONGRATULATIONS on the wall above their heads.

"What— why—" Adora's mind spun in place, unable to form a coherent thought.

"Congrats!" Glimmer shrieked as she threw her arms around Adora's neck. "I can't believe you were going to wait to tell us you got your GED!"

Bow joined the hug with tears in his eyes. "We're so proud of you, Adora!"

Over their shoulders, Adora spotted Catra wearing an *I-told-you-so* grin. "What are you doing here?" Adora asked. "I thought you weren't finished with finals until next week?"

Glimmer flapped her hand dismissively. "Nah, we finished a couple days ago. We just told you we'd be home next week so we could surprise you."

"And celebrate with you!" Bow exclaimed, stepping aside to reveal an elaborate cake decorated to look like a graduate's cap.

The hot prickle of tears made Adora's vision blur as she gazed around the room, taking in the smiling faces of her friends. "You guys did all this for me? But, why?"

Angella stepped forward and pressed a gentle kiss to Adora's forehead. Adora didn't realize that she was crying until Angella brushed a tear from her cheek. "Because we love you, darling."

Scorpia let out a joyful whoop, which signaled to the others that it was time to join the group hug. Adora laughed through her tears as she was jostled and crushed in the loving embrace of her friends until finally Casta shouted "who wants cake?" over the flurry of voices and everyone cheered.

Pictures were taken and the cake was cut. Perfuma popped a bottle of champagne and someone turned on some music. The room vibrated with so much love and joy that Adora eventually had to step out onto the small balcony just to catch her breath.

"Is it too much?"

Adora turned to find Catra slipping out to join her. She slid the balcony door shut, muffling the raucous sounds of the party inside. At that moment, it felt like they were the only two people left in the world. Adora smiled and reached out to her girlfriend. "It's perfect."

Catra slid her arms around Adora's waist and nuzzled her face into her neck. "Good," she purred. "You deserve it. And before you try to argue with me: yes, I insist!"

"Okay, fine! I believe you!" Adora chuckled. It wasn't quite true, but given that the apartment was currently full of people who had come to celebrate her, Adora had to admit that Catra might be right about this whole "being worthy" thing. They stood for a while in contemplative silence, staring out at their neighborhood. It was an unremarkable view of an unremarkable part of town, but it was theirs. "It kind of feels like a dream, doesn't it?" Adora said quietly.

In her arms, Catra shrugged. "Of course it does. For the longest time that's all this could be."

“Can you imagine if we could go back in time and tell our younger selves that this is how our lives would turn out?” Adora mused, thinking back to that dingy old warehouse and the threadbare mattress on the floor that they’d shared. “Do you think they’d believe us?”

“I think little Catra would have a hard time believing that we’d ever be out of the Horde. Or have our own place and jobs…” Catra tipped her head back so she could look into Adora’s eyes. “But I know she would have been excited to know that we’re, like, *together* together.”

Lifting an eyebrow, Adora smirked. “Damn. How long have you been in love with me?”

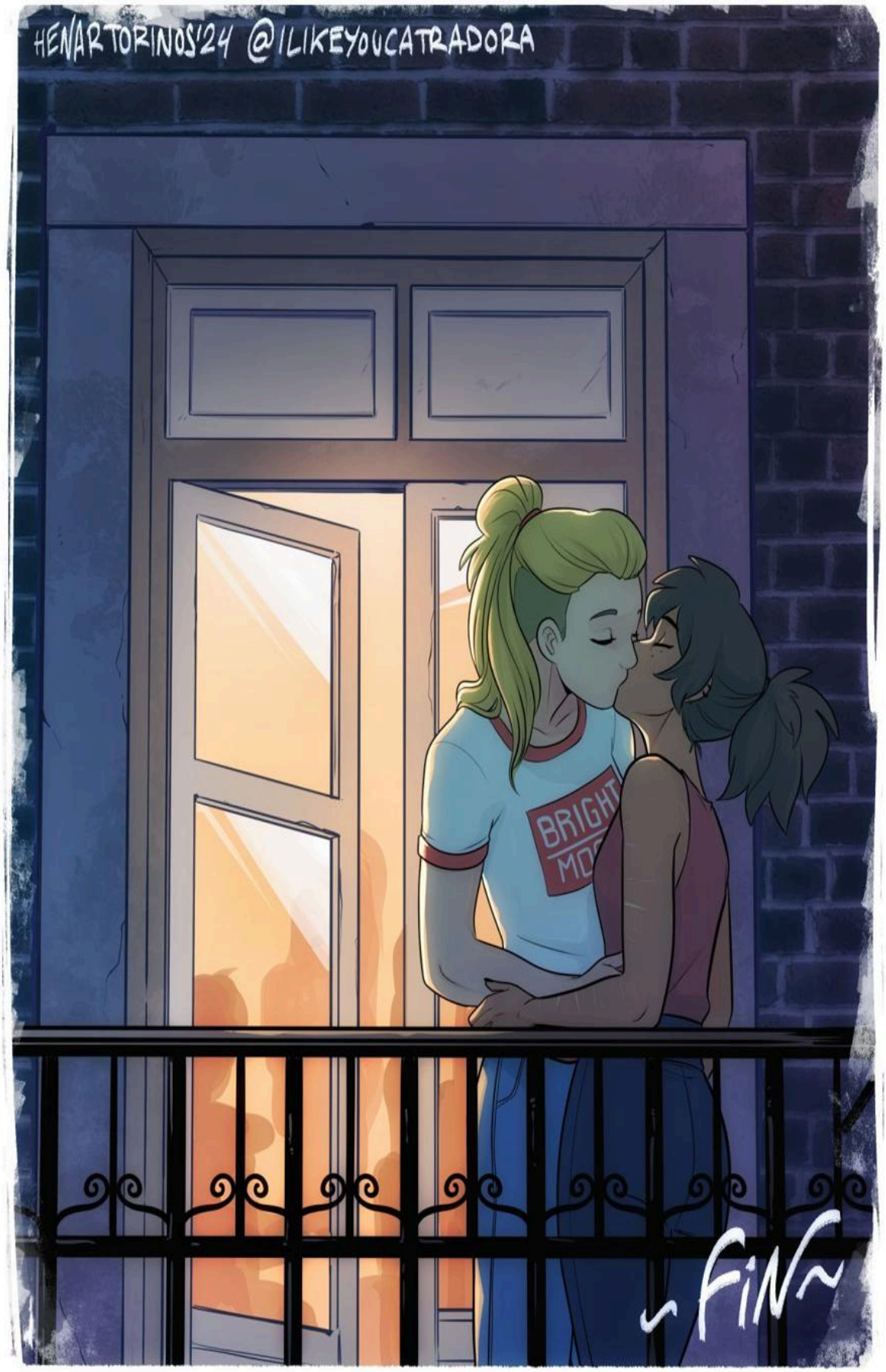
Catra scoffed. “You’re such an idiot.”

“I’m serious!”

For a quiet moment, Catra didn’t speak. Her eyes searched Adora’s, and Adora wondered what she saw reflected back at her. Was it the love she had for her? Her hopes and dreams for their future together? With a soft smile, Catra reached up and traced her fingertips lightly down Adora cheek.

“Always,” Catra whispered. “I always have, and I always will.”

With her heart soaring, Adora closed the distance between them and kissed the love of her life deeply, safe in the unshakable truth that the future she once only dared dream of would be right there in her arms, always.


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~FIN~

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